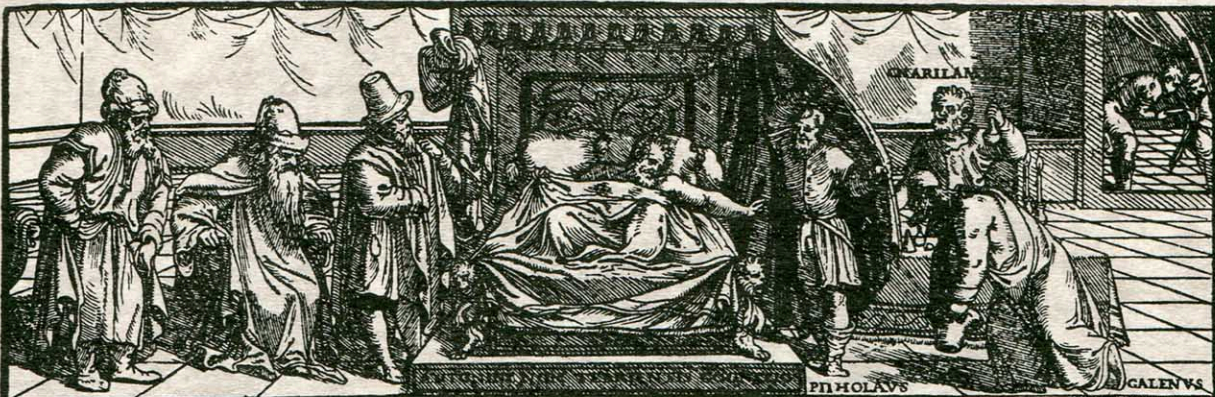




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Darwin Ortiz

STRONG

MAGIC



Creative Showmanship
For The Close-Up Magician



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Why is it that some magicians get great audience reaction while others who are just as skillful leave audiences cold? The answers are in **STRONG MAGIC**, the first-ever book on showmanship specifically for the close-up magician.

As a successful professional magician for almost twenty years, Darwin Ortiz has appeared before thousands of audiences of all kinds. During that time he has studied what it takes to really move an audience. In **STRONG MAGIC** he presents the results of those years of study and experience in a way that every magician can benefit from.

Do you want applause, gasps, and praise? Do you want your performances to be talked about and remembered? **STRONG MAGIC** tells you how. You already own countless books on card and coin manipulation. Here is a book on something far more important: *audience manipulation*. Not a dry, boring treatise, it's funny, fascinating, exciting reading. Not a book of vague theory, it's loaded with countless examples and concrete techniques that you can put to use right away to give your magic more impact. These are the real secrets of close-up magic—and they're all in **STRONG MAGIC**.



Darwin Ortiz is known throughout the magic world as one of the world's leading sleight-of-hand performers with cards. He is a professional close-up magician specializing in the college and corporate markets. Darwin has appeared on numerous television programs including *The CBS Morning Program*, *The Dick Cavett Show*, *The Tom Snyder Show*, *The Paul Daniels Show* (BBC-TV), and on HBO and CNN as well as national television shows in France and Argentina.

Darwin is also recognized as the world's leading expert on crooked gambling methods. In this capacity he has served as a consultant to gambling casinos in Las Vegas, Atlantic City, and throughout the world. Darwin's book *Gambling Scams* is widely hailed as the definitive work on the subject; it is presently being used as a reference and training tool by casinos in over a dozen countries.

In his roles as an entertainer and consultant, Darwin has performed in fifteen countries spanning six continents (all except Antarctica). When not globe-trotting, he lives in Washington, DC.

Also by Darwin Ortiz

Gambling Scams

(1984)

Darwin Ortiz on Casino Gambling

(1986)

Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table

(1988)

The Annotated Erdnase

(1991)

Strong Magic

(1994)

Cardshark

(1995)

STRONG MAGIC

CREATIVE SHOWMANSHIP FOR THE CLOSE-UP MAGICIAN

DARWIN ORTIZ

Edited
by
Richard Kaufman, Matthew Field, and Mark Phillips

Published
by



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For Maureen, the best thing that ever happened to me

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“Someone creates a trick, many people perfect it, but its final success in front of an audience depends on the person who presents it.”

René Lavand

“All magic is mental.”

Tony Shiels

A Hand of Cards—A Game—A Book (Juan Tamariz)

Darwin begins the game by dealing himself a spectacular poker hand of four aces: the Argentinean René Lavand, the Englishman Alfred Hitchcock, the American Tex Avery, and the Spaniard Ascanio.

These aces, and various others that Darwin pulls out of his sleeve in the course of the book, come, not coincidentally, from the passions that he and I share: literature, fantasy, film, magic.

Now Darwin checks and rechecks his winning cards. He analyzes and extracts from them the maximum artistic common denominator. (Why are they aces?)

The game reaches its climactic moment. Darwin plays with the tremendous advantage provided by his personal experience as a magician, as a lecturer, as a profound student and academic (remember *The Annotated Erdnase!*), as a tireless and curious reader of everything dealing with the artistic themes (what a personal library he has!), as an interesting conversationalist (he talks . . . and listens!), as an analytical and methodical thinker, as an experienced and extremely lucid writer.

In this way he manages to attack the game from the most diverse points of view, discovering winning strategies for understanding how to achieve stronger and more fascinating magic. The hands, because of their quantity, seem overwhelming (what a table of contents!), because of their subject matter, perhaps obscure or difficult reading

Stop right there! Wait. Relax. Don't be alarmed dear reader: the book is readable, it's extremely clear, it's meaty, it's thrilling in its intellectual adventure. And it's also, clearly, enormously practical.

It makes you think. It enriches you as an artist (and therefore as a human being). It pushes you to wager (and heavily) for a better and more artistic magic.

It gambles against mediocrity, conformity, and misunderstood commercialism. It's now the showdown, the moment of revealing the poker hands: That initial hand of four aces has been transformed (and we haven't detected a single false move) into a Royal Flush: the five cards are the time, the intelligence, the effort, the energy, and the love that, I believe I know well, Darwin has employed in this book, in this final hand. It doesn't matter what cards are held by the opponent, Miss Vulgarly. Darwin has won the game. And our beloved art of magic has won with him.

We have all won by betting with you. Thank you, Darwin Ortiz.

Juan Tamariz
May, 1994

Introduction:

Showmanship As Technique

Most writing on magic presentation falls into one of two categories. The first is the “wear a clean shirt, smile a lot, and be yourself” school. Certainly, this sort of advice isn't wrong. But it's so elementary and superficial that anybody who has gotten beyond the kindergarten stage of showmanship must sense that there has to be more to the subject.

The other category is the sermonizing school. These are the magazine articles that exhort magicians to be more entertaining, think more about their audiences, etc. Like a preacher in the pulpit on Sunday morning, the author berates the reader for his sins and warns him to become more entertaining before he's smitten by the hand of God. The only thing the author doesn't do is tell the reader *how* to make his magic more entertaining. (Cynic that I am, I always suspect it's because the author has no idea how.)

I figure that any magician who isn't entertaining either is totally oblivious to the impact he has on audiences, in which case he is beyond hope, or wants to improve but doesn't know how. In this book you won't find any sermons or diatribes, just a nuts-and-bolts approach that will tell you how.

I expect that most magicians will label this book a work on magic theory. I don't see it that way. *Our Magic* is an example of a book on magic theory and a brilliant one. This is a book on technique; I know that when magicians speak of technique they mean sleight-of-hand moves. But there is another body of technique at least as important to your success as an entertainer: the theatrical and psychological techniques you employ to elicit the kind of reaction you want from an audience. In this sense, this book is analogous to a book on art technique, film technique, acting technique, or writing

technique.

If you want to paint, you had better understand the rules of perspective and composition. In film, a lap dissolve will have one effect on an audience, a match dissolve will have another, a fade will have still a different effect. If you're going to direct a film and want to make sure the audience feels what you want them to feel when to want them to feel it, you'd better know the difference. Then it's up to you to decide which one to use when. It's the same with magic.

Technique comes, in part, from an understanding of underlying principles. For that reason, we will start our study of presentation with a brief discussion of "theory." Just keep in mind that this is simply to establish a foundation for understanding what this book is really about: providing you with a set of concrete, practical tools you can use in different situations to affect the audience the way you want to affect them. Once you understand what these tools are what they do, how they work, and how to apply them, it'll be your job as an artist to decide which ones to use for which jobs.

As we proceed, you'll find there will be situations where you'll need considerable ingenuity and creativity to find ways to incorporate various techniques into a trick in order to achieve the effect you want to have on the audience. Good presentation, in fact, requires a great deal of creativity.

In magic, creativity in fashioning presentations has never been as recognized and valued as creativity in devising effects and methods. I believe this is because most magicians are hobbyists who perform mainly for other magicians. Magician audiences are, of course, notorious for responding more strongly to effect and method than to presentation. However, if you perform for laypeople, you'll find that presentation offers as fertile and challenging an outlet for creativity as effects and methods, and one that is at least as rewarding.

Prologue: A Little Theory

“Our task is amazement, not amusement. Always amazement first.”

René Lavand

1. Magic As Mystery

“A conjuror is nothing if he only amuses and fails to inspire wonder.”

Thomas Frost, *The Lives of the Conjurors*

“Entertainment is broader than amusement. Shakespeare's Comedy of Errors is amusing; his Hamlet is not. Nevertheless, the fact that Hamlet is far more popular than the Comedy of Errors proves that it is also far more entertaining.”

Henning Nelms, *Magic and Showmanship*

Memorable Magic

Witnessing a close-up magic performance can be an experience so memorable that the spectator will literally remember it for the rest of his life. If you think that's a ridiculous claim, consider this. Have you ever been at a social gathering where people learn that you're a magician, and immediately someone comes up to you and says, “You know I saw a magician one time who did [then follows a vivid, although perhaps inaccurate description of some magic trick]. I'll never forget that!”

I think most of us have had this experience many times. Often the performance that person describes is something he witnessed ten or

fifteen years ago or even further back. Yet it made such a strong impression that the moment he heard the word “magician” the experience popped into his head and he was impelled to tell you about it.

Whenever I pick up a deck of cards to perform, my goal is to make such a strong impression on each spectator that whenever the subject of card tricks or card cheating comes up in the future—indeed, virtually any time he sees a deck of cards—he'll think of me. And I know that if I do my job right, that is exactly what will happen.

I believe every close-up magician should set similar goals for himself. To do that, you have to focus on making your magic as strong as possible. Of the several fundamental premises that underlie this book, the most basic one is this: The magician's primary job is to entertain his audience with magic. Not merely to entertain his audience while doing magic, but to entertain them *with* magic. The most important source of entertainment should be the magic itself.

Unfortunately, many magicians don't seem to believe that magic in itself can be entertaining to laypeople. They feel that, in order to hold their audience's attention, they have to lard their performances with bad jokes that would shame any Borscht-Belt comic. They think the term “commercial magic” has to mean a string of lightweight ten-second gag/tricks relying on cuteness rather than mystery, but justifying their existence because they elicit a momentary chuckle (or groan) from the spectator. The result is a performance that is like watching old TV reruns of *The Dukes of Hazzard*—mindless entertainment that momentarily diverts but is forgotten almost the instant it's over.

The Magical Experience

This sort of magic results from what I call “Fitzkee's fallacy,” the belief that magic has no inherent entertainment value. In *Showmanship for Magicians*, Dariel Fitzkee's prescription for making magic entertaining is to introduce music, dance, comedy, and sex appeal into the magic performance. In his view, magic is some sort of bitter pill that you have to sugar-coat in order to get the audience to swallow. I don't want you to think I'm suggesting

there is anything wrong with employing such elements to add to the appeal of a magic performance. But thinking that this is all there is to making magic entertaining overlooks the most obvious, and the most important, way you can make magic more entertaining: by making the magic itself more entertaining.

If you don't believe that magic itself can be entertaining, if you don't believe that experiencing apparent impossibilities can be strong, unique, and memorable entertainment for an audience. I won't argue the point with you. I'll only suggest that you give up magic. If you really think that magic is of no value except as a peg on which to hang music, dance, comedy, and sex appeal, you should become a musician, dancer, comedian, or stripper and forget about magic.

I believe that not only can magic, in itself, be highly entertaining, but that magic offers an entertainment experience that is qualitatively different from what an audience can get from music, dance, comedy, or any other form of entertainment—not necessarily better, but different. That unique entertainment experience comes from mystery, the experience of the impossible. Frankly, if you don't strongly want to give your audiences that *particular* entertainment experience you don't belong in magic.

Once you accept the premise that entertaining *with magic* is your main priority, you'll find it has some important implications. It doesn't mean that you turn your back on the possibilities of using comedy, storytelling, music, or other elements to enhance your magic. It does mean that, your first priority is making your magic as powerful and memorable as possible. It means that you use elements like comedy primarily to make your magic stronger. If a gag strengthens the magic, it goes in; if a gag weakens the magic, it goes out.

You must never lose sight of your primary goal: to make your audience experience mystery. If magic has any claim to being an art it lies in its unique ability to make a spectator confront the impossible, along with the exhilarating feeling this entails as a trapdoor opens under everything he thinks he knows about, reality and his mind goes into freefall.

Even viewed purely as entertainment, this feeling—the magical

experience—is not only the most unique, but also the strongest entertainment experience you as a magician can give your audience. But before you can start working on affecting the audience's state of mind, you may have to change your own attitudes.

The Challenge Attitude

There are many people in this world who hate bad magic. (I'm one of them.) But there are also some people who hate good magic. Magic, to them, means that if you fool them, they lose and you win. If they catch you, they win and you lose. Fortunately, such people are few and far between.

Of more concern is the fact that virtually any audience may fall into the mindset of viewing a magic performance as a win-lose situation if you encourage them to. It's your job to make them see it as a win-win situation. If the magician wins, everyone wins—you get the satisfaction of entertaining them and they get the pleasure of being entertained. If you lose, everyone loses—what could have been an enjoyable experience becomes a waste of time. A good magic performance is a cooperative venture, not a competitive one. The audience should actually be your allies in fooling them.

A key to achieving this partnership with the audience is avoiding any sense of challenge in your presentation. The late Fred Robinson was fond of quoting Fred Kaps to the effect that, “There is no place for challenge in professional magic.” I would go further and say that there is no place for challenge in good magic. The performer who challenges his audience to figure out how the tricks are done is reinforcing the win-lose model.

A problem arises when trying to get magicians to see the self-defeating nature of challenge magic, and it's one that I think I had best deal with head-on. The problem is the fact that some of the most legendary figures in magic have used the challenge approach.

In an interview in the English magic magazine *Opus*, Scottish cardman Gordon Bruce quite rightly advises novice magicians to avoid the challenge approach. He then goes on to say, “Slydini does it all the time but only gets away with it because he is a master.”

The fact is that Slydini only got away with it because he spent his

entire life performing for other magicians. I don't believe Slydini could have sustained a career performing for laypeople without drastically altering his challenge style of presentation. The fact that he never succeeded in having such a career may indicate as much. Slydini's career consisted of performing for and lecturing to other magicians and, particularly, giving lessons to other magicians. As such, his presentational style should not provide a model for anyone interested in entertaining the public.

Slydini was a genius whose thinking on misdirection revolutionized dose-up magic and who also contributed numerous seminal techniques to the table-worker's armory. However, his challenge approach is so well-known to magicians and represents such a perfect example of what *not* to do, that I feel it necessary to analyze this negative feature of his work further.

After fooling a spectator several times with the same effect, Slydini would ask him, "You know why you no see? Because you no watch!"

Translation: "You know why you didn't catch me? Because you're stupid!" After fooling another spectator with several repetitions of the Coins Through the Table, he would reassure him with the statement, "I do it again and this time you catch!" When Slydini did it again and the spectator still didn't catch, it was reasonable for him to wonder if there was something wrong with him. Presumably, other people usually caught on at this point.

Even worse, the spectator would have to feel that he had failed in his mission. Slydini's comments made it clear that the spectator's job was to catch the magician. So far he had lost and the magician had won. He could only hope that next time he would win and the magician would lose.

One of the most harmful aspects of the challenge approach is that it undermines the illusion of magic. Every time Slydini chided a spectator for not catching him, he reminded the audience that there was something to catch—that it wasn't really magic. Every time John Ramsay faked a palm, then showed his hand empty, he reminded the viewer that he was just watching "tricks" that depended on things like palming. Such an approach is not likely to give an audience a sense of wonder at having seen an impossibility.

It's more likely to leave them with a sense of frustration at having been outwitted.

The challenge approach relates to the puzzle mentality we'll be discussing in a moment. Puzzles have solutions. We may not know what the solution is, but we know there is one. Magic on the other hand, is, by definition, an eternal mystery for which there is no possible solution. Therefore, it doesn't make any sense to challenge the audience to find a solution.

I suspect there may be something about performing for other magicians that tends to promote a challenge style. Is it just a coincidence that John Ramsay, another of the legendary close-up magicians of this century, also built his style around the challenge approach, relying on the constant use of feints and sucker moves to rub his audience's noses in the fact that he was fooling them? Ramsay would even taunt spectators by following a coin vanish with the comment, "You don't know where the coin is, do you, laddie?"

Of course, Ramsay made his living running a grocery store. If you want to pattern your performing approach after one of this century's legendary magicians, I suggest that a better model is Fred Kaps, a magician who made his living performing for the public. You'll recall his advice was, "There is no place for challenge in professional magic."

I want to make it clear that what I am advising against is a challenging *attitude* on the part of the performer. There is, for example, nothing wrong with presenting an effect under challenge conditions. You must, however, make it clear by your attitude that *you're challenging yourself to succeed under impossible conditions; you're not challenging the audience to catch you.*

Similarly, any apparent impossibility poses an implicit challenge to an audience to find a natural explanation. In magic, effects that involve repetition, such as the "Ambitious Card," a one-at-a-time ace assembly, or a repeat "Oil and Water" routine, particularly pose a challenge to the audience to figure them out. With each new repetition they consider new theories and are forced to reject them.

This process of implicitly making the audience consider every possible explanation until they finally have to accept that there is no

explanation can be an extremely effective way of leading them to embrace the impossible just what magic should be all about. (Juan Tamariz explores this concept in *The Magic Way*.) Just make sure the challenge comes from the impossibility you present, not from your own attitude. Your attitude should be that there is no explanation to be sought; it's just magic.

The Puzzle Mentality

"I've never dealt with whodunits. They're simply clever puzzles, aren't they? They're intellectual rather than emotional, and emotion is the only thing that keeps my audiences interested."

Alfred Hitchcock

When I was about nine years old, I got a children's magic set. Along with paddle tricks and all the other slum magic that form the standard magic-set fare, it also included about a half-dozen wire puzzles. I remember wondering what these were doing in the set since I knew that puzzles and magic weren't, the same thing. This simple truth that any nine year old instinctively knows is one that many magicians fail to realize. A magical effect may be very puzzling, but it's not a puzzle. A puzzle admits of a possible solution, at least in theory. True magic admits of no possible solution; it's an eternal mystery. Even more important, a puzzle is strictly an intellectual challenge with no emotional element—unless you count the frustration. Emotionless intellect is precisely what we want to avoid in magic. (As we've just seen, challenge is another good thing to avoid in magic.) The only satisfaction of a puzzle comes from solving it; the satisfaction of magic for the spectator must come in part from not solving it.

A sign of the prevalence of this puzzle mentality in magic is the habit some cardmen have of referring to every plot for a trick as a "card problem" and every effect employing that plot as a "solution" to the problem. Constructing a magical effect usually involves solving many problems, just as writing a novel may require solving many problems of plot, characterization, and style. Yet, no writer would ever refer to his plot as a problem and the finished novel as the solution. The very problem/solution terminology suggests a desire to reduce the creative process to an intellectual exercise. The

artistic process, whether in creating effects or presentations is much more complex than that.

The failure to clearly distinguish between magic and puzzles is one of the most pernicious, as well as one of the most pervasive trends in magic. My own field of card magic is particularly plagued by this problem. In *Ibidem* No. 21, Norm Houghton speaks of “amateur mathematicians who have somehow acquired the quaint delusion that their hobby is magic.” Unfortunately, the accusation is only too true.

The problem stems in part from the fact that many magicians are also puzzle fans. In fact, during the short history of close-up magic, a number of well-known practitioners have also been prominent puzzle experts. Many magic magazines also publish puzzles from time to time. With this dual love in the bosoms of so many magicians, it's little wonder they sometimes get the two confused.

It also makes it difficult for them to recognize that most people don't like puzzles. In fact, many people hate them. I'm not very fond of puzzles myself. (It probably goes back to getting gypped on that magic set.) I think that as a magician I'm fortunate in this regard. This attitude brings me closer to the viewpoint of most laypeople, something that every magician should strive for.

If you're one of those magicians who likes puzzles, you're going to have to be particularly alert to the danger of allowing your magic to degenerate into mere puzzles. Strive to give your audiences impossibilities rather than puzzles. Let them experience wonder rather than frustration.

The Illusion Of Impossibility

“There is a world of difference between a spectator's not knowing how something's done versus his knowing that it can't be done.”

Simon Aronson, *The Aronson Approach*

An interesting difference between performing for magicians and performing for laypeople is that, if a magician succeeds in figuring out ninety percent of a trick but can't figure out the other ten percent, he will feel that the trick fooled him; if a layperson

succeeds in figuring out ten percent of a trick but can't figure out the other ninety percent of the trick, he will feel that it didn't fool him. The magician will think, "I know how he controlled my card to the top of the deck and I saw him palm the card. But I don't know how he got it between those two plastic sheets that were taped together on all sides. He really fooled me." The layperson will think, "He didn't fool me; I saw him palm the card."

This attitude on the part of lay audiences frustrates some magicians who are inclined to respond. "Yeah, but how did I locate your card in the first place, and how did I get it between the plastic sheets?" The layperson's response will be something like, "Oh, you got it in there somehow. But you didn't fool me; I saw the card in your hand."

Which attitude is correct, that of magician audiences or lay audiences? It depends on whether you feel that magic is supposed to be a puzzle or an apparent impossibility. Suppose a person is putting together a 100-piece jigsaw puzzle. He gets ninety pieces into place, but can't get the last ten pieces to fit. He will feel that he failed to solve the puzzle.

Suppose you're watching something that is allegedly achieved by supernatural means. You spot some wires that are obviously being manipulated from offstage. You may not know exactly what those wires have to do with what you're seeing, but you know they must have something to do with it. You also know that supernatural phenomena don't require wires. You weren't fooled; you saw the wires.

The question in the magician-spectator's mind is, "What is the explanation?" The question in the lay-spectator's mind is, "Is there an explanation?" Therefore, to move a layperson, you must do something far more difficult than fooling him, you must create an illusion of impossibility. I would go so far as to say that *the illusion of impossibility* is as good a definition of what constitutes magic as I can imagine.

Of course, creating an illusion is far more difficult than merely puzzling someone. A magical illusion is the most fragile thing in the world. It's like a delicate soap bubble that can be burst by sharp

objects, sudden jostling, or even a gust of wind. Since most magicians will always choose the easiest path rather than the most effective, you can expect that most of your magician friends will settle for doing puzzles. If you choose the path of self-discipline rather than, self-indulgence you'll have to work very hard to master the techniques taught in this book in order to nurture the illusion of impossibility.

2. Reaching The Emotions

“One may disbelieve with his mind yet still believe with his blood.”

Edward Wagenknecht

Probably the key reason why many magicians lack faith in magic as entertainment is the feeling that magic has lost its hold over modern audiences because people no longer believe in magic as a literal reality. Let's examine this matter of belief more closely since it's fundamental to understanding the role of showmanship in magic.

It's become fashionable among those few magicians who even bother to discuss showmanship to talk about getting audiences to “willingly suspend their disbelief.” This phrase was first coined by Samuel Taylor Coleridge to refer to the attitude required of theater audiences. While quite apt in that context, it's not really appropriate to magic.

To understand why, let's contrast the attitude of a theater—going audience to that of a spectator watching close-up magic. A person goes to a performance of J.M. Barrie's play *Peter Pan*. He knows that people can't fly and he knows that the actor portraying Peter Pan is not really flying through the air. In order to enjoy the play, however he is going to have to pretend that a person can fly, and forget he is watching an actor suspended by wires. Since the wires are visible to anyone who looks hard enough, the spectator must do this willingly or the play won't work for him.

By contrast, consider a spectator watching a magician make a dollar bill float through the air. The spectator could willingly suspend his disbelief and pretend that dollar bills can float. If he did that, it

wouldn't matter if he saw the thread attached to the bill, anymore than it matters that he can see the wires attached to Peter Pan. However, if he took that attitude, the magic wouldn't have much impact on him. The floating bill is strong magic precisely because the spectator will not *willingly* believe that bills can float. It's the fact that his intellect doesn't want to believe, yet his senses force him to, that gives the magic its power.

Yet, it's also true that in order for close-up magic to be effective, the spectator must become a co-conspirator with the performer in pulling off the scam. Here we come to a paradox that is central to understanding the power of magic as entertainment. Most people have an intellectual resistance to believing in the impossible while at the same time having an emotional desire to believe in the impossible. It is this tension at the heart of the human spirit that strong magic evokes. The result is the wonder and awe that good magic always generates. So forget about creating willing suspension of disbelief. Get your audience to actually *believe in magic*.

Intellectual Vs. Emotional Belief

It sounds like an impossible goal, doesn't it? How can you make a sophisticated, modern audience believe in magic? You can't, if you're talking about intellectual belief. I'm talking about *emotional belief*. An anecdote from the nineteenth century perfectly captures the difference between intellectual belief and emotional belief. Madam De Duffand was asked whether she believed in ghosts. She responded, "No. But I am afraid of them."

The impact of a magic effect is directly proportional to the degree to which it engages the emotions of the spectator. The reaction to strong magic is always emotional. Poker expert Mike Caro once said, "Losers exaggerate [how much money they lost]."

That's because they're not trying to convey *what really happened* so much as *how bad they feel*." This is also why laypeople often exaggerate a magic effect when they describe it to another. They're not really trying to communicate what happened. They're trying to convey the emotion they felt when they witnessed it.

If the impact of magic is on the emotions, it follows that your

presentations have to be designed to reach the emotions. The problem is that the intellect always attempts to protect the emotions. It's like a guard standing before a set of iron gates. When you show someone an apparent impossibility, before he can get emotionally excited, his intellect will say, "Wait a minute. I can figure this out. There has to be a rational explanation." It's only when his intellect surrenders and admits that there is no explanation that the gates swing open and you can reach his emotions. (If an effect is properly structured, that whole process may take a split second.) Therefore, if you want to reach the spectator's emotions, you first have to literally *baffle* his intellect — leave it without any possible explanation.

Certainly, you will never achieve intellectual belief with an audience. They will always know in the backs of their minds that there's really no such thing as magic. However, when you succeed in baffling their intellects by creating strong conviction, you will achieve emotional belief. On a gut level, they will react as if the magic is real. Remember Madam De Duffand? She knew intellectually that ghosts don't exist. But that didn't prevent her from reacting on an emotional level as if they did.

3. Narrative Art

Unlike static art forms like painting, sculpture, and photography and purely expressive art forms like music and dance, magic is a narrative art form. This simply means that magic tells a story. I'm not here referring to the fact that some magical presentations use a story to accompany the effect. I mean that every effect is itself a story regardless of the presentation accompanying it. Like any story, it has a beginning, a middle, and an end. As with any narrative art, the audience watches because it wants to find out what will happen next. When a spectator watches a magic trick, he is witnessing, and sometimes participating in, a story: the story of what happens in the magic trick.

This means that part of magic presentation technique is narrative technique. It is concerned with considerations of theme, characterization, conflict, plotting, story line, clarity, atmosphere, and dramatic structure. These are the same considerations that are

central to all narrative arts: film, theater, fiction, and storytelling.

I stress this because, as obvious as the point is, it has received very little attention in magic literature. Therefore, this way of thinking is likely to strike many readers as strange. In developing the concepts explored in this book I'll often employ analogies to other narrative arts and cite principles that are accepted as axiomatic in all other narrative arts, yet hardly recognized in magic. I think that as we go along you'll come to appreciate that the better you understand the principles of narrative art generally the more effective you'll be as a magical entertainer.

While every magic trick tells a story, it's important to realize that the prime goal of magic is not to tell a story but to *create a sensation*. I mention this because, in addition to Fitzkee's fallacy, another common error is what I call "the theatrical fallacy." Some of the magicians and magical writers most concerned with presentation make the mistake of thinking that the point of a magic effect is to support a dramatic premise, much like theatrical effects or film special effects do. (This, for example, is a flaw in Henning Nelms' otherwise outstanding *Magic and Showmanship*. Not surprisingly, Nelms' background was in theater.)

If, however, our fundamental premise is correct that the unique strength of magic is that it gives the audience the experience of confronting the impossible, it follows that the point of a dramatic presentation is to enhance the magic. The magic is not there to validate a dramatic premise, the dramatic premise is used to add impact to the magic, to make the experience of the impossible that much more powerful.

With these thoughts in the backs of our minds, I think we're ready to leave theory, roll up our sleeves, and plunge into technique.

Part One: The Effect

“True success and satisfaction go only to those who really comprehend the underlying principles of why a trick succeeds or fails.”

Greer Marechal

CHAPTER ONE: CLARITY

“To those who question whether clarity is all that important, I can only say that it is the most important quality in the making of a film.”

François Truffaut

The Goal Of Clarity

Dai Vernon often said that confusion is not magic. One might, go so far as to say that confusion is the antithesis of magic. One of my personal pet peeves is the habit many magicians have of stating in their patter that they will do this or that “to further confuse the issue.” I used to think that perhaps I was overreacting to what is, after all, only a minor verbal infelicity. However, I felt vindicated when one day in a conversation with David Roth, he expressed the same annoyance.

The patter line itself is not important, but the mentality it indicates is. You'll never succeed in presenting really strong magic until you come to appreciate this simple point: At the end of an effect, your audience must not be the least bit confused as to what just happened. They must be absolutely clear on what just happened. Only then can they really appreciate that what just happened is totally impossible.

Much has been said about the desirability of performing simple effects. While simple effects can be very powerful, effects with more substance can also be very powerful. Which type you gravitate toward will probably be determined more by your temperament than any other factor. What is really essential for strong magic is not simplicity of effect but *clarity* of effect. One of the most

fundamental essentials in achieving strong magic is conveying to the audience a clear picture of what is supposed to have happened.

Much of the confusion between simplicity and clarity stems from the fact that a person of limited presentational skills may find that he can only present an effect clearly if it's a simple one. Consequently, he associates clarity with simplicity. However, with proper attention to presentation and routining, more complex effects can also be clearly conveyed to an audience.

Choosing to perform simple or complex effects is a matter of artistic judgment; achieving clarity of effect in either case is a matter of technique. In this section we'll discuss techniques for achieving clarity which can be applied to whatever kind of effect you choose to present.

Before an effect can be clear in your audience's mind it first has to be clear in your own. Many performers go wrong at this very first step. They become so fascinated with the details of an effect—the moves, the twists and turns, the individual phases—they never step back and try to see the big picture.

I once heard one of our most legendary cardmen describe another of our most legendary cardmen by saying: "He is a great magician. He just doesn't know what an *effect* is." Judging from the literature of close-up magic, many magicians don't know what an effect is. This is particularly evident in some of the effects that have resulted from the current tendency toward combining different plots in the same effect and borrowing elements from one effect to incorporate in a completely different effect. I'm not criticizing this trend since it has resulted in some very strong magic. However, as with any concept, when applied unthinkingly, the results can be dismal. Some tricks of this kind one sees recall the Frankenstein monster, a grotesque creature made up of parts from different bodies sewn together.

As a first step toward achieving clarity in your magic, I recommend the following extremely effective exercise. Briefly summarize every trick in your repertoire. Don't just think about this. Actually get a piece of paper and a pen. Have your repertoire list at hand. Now write a summary of each effect in three sentences or less. Once

you've finished, perform each effect, then look at the summary you wrote. You may want to revise it or alter it in some way. Keep working on these summaries until you're completely satisfied that you've captured the essence of each trick in a couple of sentences.

Once you've finalized your summaries, you're now ready to work on communicating your concept of each effect to your audiences. Don't think this will happen automatically.

The most extreme example I ever encountered of a magician failing to convey his concept of the effect to his audience occurred many years ago when I was first getting into serious card magic. I met another cardman at Tannen's Magic Shop. We started talking about the bluff pass. That's the move where you apparently lift off half the deck and have a selection replaced on the lower half. Actually you only lift off one card so the selection ends up second from the top of the deck.

The other cardman mentioned that he was familiar with another version of this move. (I later learned that this variation involves simulating cutting off half the deck while actually taking no card at all. Consequently, when the "half deck" is replaced the selected card ends up on top. However, I was not aware of this at the time.)

The magician offered to perform the move for me. He had me pick a card. Then he removed his right hand from the deck and held it in a very cramped, awkward position as he told me to replace my card on top of the cards in his left hand. (Apparently, I was supposed to believe his empty hand held half the deck.) I wondered about the strange way he held his right hand but I was afraid to ask about it, not wanting to draw attention to what might be a degenerative joint disease. I certainly had no idea that I was supposed to think there were cards in his hand.

After I replaced my card he slapped his right hand on the deck and announced, "Your card is lost in the middle of the deck." I thought I had really been fooled since I had no idea how the card could be in the middle. I thought the effect was a reverse Ambitious Card: a card starts on top of the deck; you slap the deck and the card immediately jumps to the middle.

I said, "That's wonderful! How did you get my card to the middle?"

He said, “No, no. Your card isn't in the middle. It's on top!” He then turned over the top card to prove his claim.

After puzzling over this for a few moments, I said, “Would you do that for me again? I think I missed something.” We went through the identical procedure again. Once more he slapped the deck and announced that the card was now in the middle. “That's great,” I said. “I can't understand how you get it to the middle.”

“No!” he shouted. “The card is really on top!” More confused than ever, I asked him to do it one more time. Suffice it to say that we went through this Abbott and Costello-type routine several times more without either of us ever realizing what was going on in the other's mind.

This particular failure to properly convey the effect was a result of incredible technical incompetence on the performer's part. However, even when an effect is executed perfectly from a method standpoint, there can be a considerable gulf between what the performer feels he is presenting and what the audience perceives is happening.

In order to write out your effect summaries you had to engage in two activities, *interpretation* and *selection*. These are the same two things you have to do in order to convey an effect to an audience with clarity.

Interpretation

Few effects are so unequivocal as to speak for themselves without patter interpretation by the performer. Suppose you place a red-backed card on the table. Then you have a spectator select a card from a blue-backed deck. When the red-backed card is turned over, it proves to be identical to the selected card.

Did you foresee the future or did you control the spectator's will to cause him to choose the card you wished? Perhaps you were demonstrating an extraordinary coincidence, or perhaps you and the spectator were joined in some psychic, sympathetic link that led you both to be attracted to the same card. Which is it? You have to decide. Once you decide how you want the effect to be interpreted, you must incorporate that interpretation in your patter.

Selection

Interpretation is necessary to avoid ambiguity of effect. Selection is necessary to avoid confusion of effect, the more common problem among magicians. When you wrote your brief descriptions of the various effects in your repertoire you had to be selective in what you mentioned. If you had described every step and detail that occurs in performance you could never have limited yourself to three sentences or less. Clarity of effect demands similar selectivity in your presentation. By what you choose to emphasize, you communicate to the audience what is really important: worth noting, and worth remembering about the effect.

You can achieve emphasis by either positive techniques or negative techniques. Positive techniques are those that expand upon the matters to be emphasized. Whatever you treat as important the audience will perceive as important. If you tell them that something is important, they will believe it's important. If you pay particular attention to something, they will believe it's important. If you spend more time on something, they will believe it's important.

In a pick-a-card trick, you may spend a great deal of time in having the card lost in the deck and little time in locating it, or you may spend little time in having the card lost in the deck and a great deal of time in locating it. In either case, you're telling the spectator what is the important part of the trick. Either approach might be justified in a particular trick. In one effect, the impact might depend almost entirely on the spectator appreciating the utter impossibility of your keeping track of his card; thus, you should emphasize the procedures for losing the card in the deck. In another effect, the "Card to Wallet" for example, the manner in which you find the card is all that matters.

You can also achieve emphasis by negative techniques. By this I mean that you can underscore one point by deleting other points. As F. Cowles Strickland writes in *The Technique of Acting*, "As soon as some details are removed, those which remain will have greater emphasis, merely because there are no other details competing for the attention of the audience."

This is why one of the most important aspects of effective

presentation is a ruthless removal of all non-essentials. Every word, every gesture, every action must be evaluated on the basis of whether it contributes to the overall effect you're attempting to achieve. If it doesn't contribute, you should eliminate it.

All of us who have a serious interest in magic have had the experience many times of seeing excruciatingly bad performances. Some were due to technical inadequacies on the part of the performer and some were due to presentational inadequacies. If you think back to those which were due to poor presentation, I think you'll recall many instances of the following flaws. The performer may have continually taken three sentences to say what could have been said in one, at the end of which you still didn't know what he was trying to say. He may have had some irritating gesture or other habit—continually shifting his weight from foot to foot, riffling the cards for no reason, or constantly saying “okay”—which acted as a distraction from the magic he was presenting. He may have complicated each effect with the introduction of conditions such as having cards signed, wrapping rubber bands around the deck, and other matters that seemed to have no point except in his mind. The end result was a cluttered effect, the most common presentational problem. In magic, as in housekeeping, the solution to clutter is to throw out what you don't need.

Your effect summaries have provided you with a clear picture of the essential features of each effect. Using these effect summaries, I recommend that you review the presentation of each effect, eliminating every patter line, every action, every procedure, and every condition that does not demonstrably contribute to conveying the essential effect you wish to create. The result will be clear, streamlined presentations that will maximize the impact of each trick.

With time this kind of thinking will become automatic whenever you work on a new effect. Initially, however, this exercise in conducting housecleaning on your presentations will pay immediate dividends as well as starting you thinking in the correct terms.

Easing The Audience's Burden

One of the most important lessons to learn about presenting magic

is that audiences are easily confused, easily distracted, and easily fatigued. Anything in your presentation that overburdens the spectator will hurt the clarity of the effect by overwhelming him with more than he can comfortably handle. For this reason, *the audience must never be made to work*. And the toughest kind of work is mental work. Therefore, you can't afford to put the audience in a position where they have to concentrate unduly. Henning Nelms said it perfectly: "One of the dramatist's most important jobs is to relieve the audience of all mental effort."

In effects like "Three-Card Monte" and the "Shell Game" the audience has to try to keep track of the winning card or the pea. For the effect to be successful, the shifting of the cards or shells must be kept to such a minimum that the audience can keep track with virtually no effort. If you were to shift the props around so rapidly or so extensively that it required real concentration to keep track, the effect would certainly fail.

A couple of years ago an effect was marketed that revolved around a con game premise. The performer and a spectator played a game in which the performer always won. The game involved a group of spot cards laid out on the table. The performer and spectator took turns pointing to cards and totaling their values. The first person who surpassed a certain total lost.

As it happens, I bought the manuscript for this effect at the Gambler's Book Club while in Las Vegas. After reading the manuscript in my hotel room I went down to the casino to play some blackjack. I was struck by how long it took many of the other players to add up their hands. A player might be holding a fourteen and draw a card. When he received a nine he would stare at his cards for an interminable period before turning them face up. It took him that long to realize he'd gone over twenty-one! This observation made me appreciate how trying an experience it would be for such a person to watch the effect I had just bought.

I am not speaking here only of uneducated people. Many well-educated, intelligent people are inept at simple arithmetic. Educators even have a name for the problem; they call it innumeracy, the mathematical equivalent of illiteracy. The invention of pocket calculators has only made the problem worse.

Many other people who are intellectually capable of doing arithmetic nevertheless have such an aversion to mathematics that they view even simple addition as an unpleasant task. (There's a name for this too: it's called math anxiety.) A trick that requires the audience to continually add up numbers simply requires too much concentration to be entertaining to most people.

This same effect involved a presentation in which the spectator was encouraged (i.e., challenged) to try to figure out the secret. Normally, in a magic performance, the spectator can devote just as much energy as he wishes to trying to figure out the tricks and no more. When he is challenged by the performer to come up with an explanation, he may feel pressed to do more mental work than he really cares to.

Just as arithmetic carries unpleasant connotations of dreary school days for many people, so does memorization. Any effect that taxes the audience's memory will be perceived by most people as work, the antithesis of entertainment. You should never ask one person to remember two selected cards. Similarly, you should never ask the same person to remember one selected card after another. Spread the burden by having different people pick cards in different tricks.

Of course, almost every effect requires that the audience remember something, even if it's only under which cup you just placed the ball. The point is that the effect should be structured in such a way that such remembering occurs without conscious effort. We can put this in the form of a general rule, one of Darwin's Laws: *Make it easier for the audience to remember what you want them to remember than it would be to forget it.*

While on the subject of avoiding schoolroom drudgery, let me add that the audience should never be made to take a test. In "McDonald Aces," the cards are mixed face up and face down at the outset and a spectator is then asked whether the aces are face up or face down. This is a classic example of meaningless clutter, in this case used as a ruse to cover a switch of the aces. There are many other examples of presentations where the performer cross-examines the spectator at some point.

Most people didn't like school. They didn't like the concentration;

they didn't like the arithmetic; they didn't like the memorization; but, most of all, they didn't like the tests! Don't cast yourself in the role of a schoolmaster with your audience as your students. This kind of aggravation is what people have to deal with at work every day. It's precisely what they look to entertainment to allow them to escape from. They quite rightly expect you to do the work while they sit back and relax.

Taxing a person's concentration or memory not only interferes with their enjoyment of the performance, it tends to confuse the effect for them as they miss key points of the trick while they struggle with whatever mental task you have foisted on them. Eliminate all such features from every effect and you'll have taken a step toward clarifying your magic.

Clarifying Techniques

Let's examine some of the major techniques you can use to clarify an effect. Each is a tool to help the spectator properly conceptualize the effect. Keep in mind, however, that these techniques are not necessarily called for in every effect and an effect that incorporates one or more of them is not necessarily better than one that doesn't. Whether a particular effect would benefit from any of these techniques is a question you must answer based on your artistic judgment and the audience reaction you're getting which may or may not indicate the need for greater clarity. However, if you sense that one of your effects is coming across muddled, the following should function as a handy checklist of possible methods to help correct the problem.

(1) *Use fewer props.* This is the most extreme of clarifying techniques, sometimes a very effective one. At one time, the "Linking Rings" was commonly performed with ten or more rings. Cardini introduced, and Dai Vernon popularized, the use of six rings. Jack Miller used only four rings. Today, many performers find they can attain the best audience reaction with a three-ring routine. Certainly the use of only three rings allows for the clearest possible picture for the audience of what is happening.

The classic ace assembly employs sixteen cards: the four aces plus twelve indifferent cards. However, one of the strongest of ace

assemblies is Peter Kane's "Jazz Aces" which employs only eight cards: four aces and four indifferent cards. Part of the reason for the trick's strength is certainly the exceptional clarity of effect achieved by reducing the number of cards.

In the Cups and Balls, many performers who have trouble selling a routine using three cups and three balls find they can get excellent reaction from a routine using only one cup and one ball. To take an extreme example, Slydini's "One-Coin Routine" is certainly one of the most crystal clear of all coin effects primarily because it uses only *one* coin.

Card magic provides several examples of a potential drawback of reducing the number of props—namely, the danger of reducing the scope and, hence, the impact of the effect. One of the major card magic trends of recent years has been the proliferation of packet tricks. Such classic plots as "All Backs," "Triumph," "Out of This World," and the "Color-Changing Deck" are often performed these days with a small packet of cards rather than a full deck.

Sometimes the result is a stronger effect due to greater clarity. Sometimes the result is a weaker effect due to diminished scope. Changing the backs of four cards is not as great an achievement as changing the backs of fifty-two cards.

Reducing the number of props is a case of achieving clarity through a simplification of effect. The other clarifying techniques we will look at work without altering the effect itself.

(2) *Use a memory hook.* Sometimes all you need is to provide the audience with some simple visual or verbal mnemonic aid to help them conceptualize a particular effect clearly. In John Mendoza's book *Close-Up Presentation* he discusses Pressley Guitar's "Copper, Brass, and Silver" effect. In this trick a half-dollar in one of the performer's hands transposes with a Chinese coin and a Mexican coin in the other. The original version of this effect was "Two Copper and One Silver" in which the half-dollar changed places with an English penny and a Mexican centavo.

Mendoza says he prefers the original version because it's less confusing. This is because of the similarity between the English coin and the Mexican coin; both are copper. This enables the audience to

mentally group those two coins together and see the transposition as occurring between two entities, the coppers in one hand and the silver in the other. With the use of three totally dissimilar coins, the audience has too many different concepts to juggle.

However, Mendoza then goes on to suggest an excellent way of achieving the same clarity in the “Copper, Brass, and Silver” effect. Instead of talking about the English coin and the Chinese coin, Mendoza refers to them merely as “the foreign coins.” Now the spectator can again view the transposition as occurring between two entities, the foreign coins vs. the American coin. Just compare the following two lines of patter and consider which is easier to grasp. 1- “Remember, the copper English penny and the brass Chinese coin go in this hand while the silver half-dollar goes in this hand.” 2- “Remember, the foreign coins go in this hand while the American coin goes in this hand.”

Of course, you can achieve the same result by reducing the number of props as suggested earlier. Just perform the transposition with only two coins as in the standard “Copper-Silver” effect. This will weaken the effect, however, by diminishing its scope. The Mendoza memory hook of classifying the coins into two categories, foreign and domestic, offers the best of both worlds. The spectators can appreciate the added impossibility of one coin changing places with two, while still easily grasping the effect.

(3) *Visually clarify the props.* What makes the “Copper, Brass, and Silver” effect amazing and also potentially confusing is that it is an asymmetrical transposition. One coin changes places with two rather than one with one or two with two. This same issue arises in “Slick Aces,” an effect from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* in which the ace of spades changes places with the other three aces. If the effect were performed with four selected cards, it would be the same effect in theory but it would be at least slightly harder for an audience to conceptualize. The use of the aces provides an easier picture to grasp. The three aces with small pips change places with the one ace that has a large pip. The three small-pip aces form a convenient group to contrast against the one large-pip ace.

Vernon's “Twisting the Aces” is an acknowledged classic. One at a time, each of the four aces turns over in the packet. However, in

order for the spectator to appreciate that every ace turns over he must *remember* at every point which aces have already turned over and which have not. Brother Hamman introduced the idea of doing the trick with the ace, two, three, and four of one suit. The cards turn over in numerical order, making it almost automatic for the audience to realize at each point which cards are yet to go. (Remember one of our goals: make it easier for them to remember what you want them to remember than it would be to forget it.)

I once read a card effect in which a group of four blue-backed kings transposed one at a time with four red-backed queens. The added condition of using cards with two different back colors made the trick seem more impossible but also more difficult for the spectators to follow. They now had to remember which cards had which color backs.

The problem could easily be solved by using four red spot cards with red backs and four black spot cards with blue backs. Now each card is practically the same color on both sides and remembering which is which becomes virtually automatic. The different backs now actually makes it easier for the audience to follow the effect since they can easily see which cards are where whether they're face down or face up.

The performer can go even further by referring to the red-backed, red spot cards as simply the “red cards,” and referring to the blue-backed, black spot cards as the “black and blue” cards. The common phrase “black and blue” acts as a memory hook of the kind discussed a moment ago.

This example is quite different from an effect such as Lin Searles' “Ultimate Aces,” an ace assembly in which the aces have red backs and the indifferent cards have blue backs. Here the different color backs are used to emphasize the important cards (the important aces have a bright-colored back while the unimportant cards have a more subdued-color back). Thus, the two different backs help clarify the effect rather than potentially muddle it as in the previous case.

In my gambling lecture I demonstrate bottom dealing techniques. When demonstrating a face-down bottom deal, the picture can be kept, very clear. Four aces are openly placed on the bottom. Then

the poker hands are dealt face down and one hand is turned face up to show that it contains the aces. When demonstrating a stud bottom deal, however, all the cards are dealt face up which can make for a cluttered picture.

That's why, in the latter case. I first openly place a group of black spot cards on top of the deck and a royal flush in hearts on the bottom. The red picture cards make a strong visual contrast to the black spot cards. The audience can now easily distinguish between those cards that must have come from the bottom and those that must have come from the top—between the important cards and the unimportant cards.

This same idea can be applied to an ace assembly by using four kings instead of four aces and twelve black spot, cards as the indifferent cards. In a very simple, straightforward ace assembly, this might be superfluous. In a more complex assembly plot, this step might be useful in clarifying matters. As with all the clarification techniques, visual clarification of props is only an option; it's your job to decide when it's called for.

(4) *Visually clarify the layout.* In the theater, a standard technique employed by directors in staging a play is what is sometimes called picturization. Carl Allensworth's *The Complete Play Production Handbook* defines picturization as, “the visual representation, without movement or dialogue, of the character relationships, the story developments, and the emotional content of the scene. It is the visual interpretation of the meaning inherent in the lines of the play.”

In other words, the positioning of the actors and the scenery in relation to each other and in relation to the boundaries of the stage is used as one of the tools to communicate the play's content to the audience. Although these elements are constantly shifting, at any given moment, this positioning provides the viewer with a particular picture. In Rod Stewart's words, “Every picture tells a story.” It's part of the director's job to ensure that each picture is accurately telling the story he wants to convey

Close-up magic provides countless opportunities to utilize this concept in the positioning of props on the table. One very common

example is Vernon's T-formation often used in ace assemblies. With the cards laid out in this pattern, it's instantly clear to every viewer which of the four packets is the focal point of the effect. The spectator doesn't have to make an effort to remember which is the important packet; he could hardly forget if he wanted to.

Eddie Fechter used to perform an effect in which six quarters traveled from one hand to the other one at a time. After each coin traveled he would spread out the coins from his left hand in a row on the left side of the table, then spread the right-hand coins in a similar row on the right side of the table. As the one row continually got shorter and the other continually got longer, even the most dense or inebriated spectator could hardly fail to follow the flow of the effect.

Suppose you're going to perform an effect with two groups of cards, one more important than the other. When first displaying the cards you could subtly underscore this point by laying out the unimportant cards in a tight spread while the important ones are laid out in a wide fan. If a prop plays a central role in the effect, place it at the center of the close-up mat; if it plays only a peripheral role, place it somewhat to the side (at the *periphery* of your mat). Of course, none of this should look contrived or calculated, any more than the placement of the actors in a well-directed play looks contrived. Remember, adequate rehearsal is what makes things look unrehearsed.

There are countless more examples I could cite, but the concept is simple once you start to think about it. That, of course, is the key. As obvious as the idea may seem, you won't find yourself applying it—at least, at first—unless you think about it. Once you start thinking in visual terms, it'll soon become second nature.

Naturally, there is another consideration in the arrangement of props besides clarity, namely the demands of method. For example, if you intend to lap something it may be necessary to place it near the table edge. There is nothing wrong with this, as long as the arrangement doesn't send a visual message that contradicts the effect you're trying to convey.

I recently read an effect, in which three cards selected by three

spectators are matched by three prediction cards from another deck. The switch of the spectators' cards which was the key to the method required that the selections be dealt in a row in front of the performer while his predictions were dealt in a row in front of the spectators. The performer's cards were in front of the spectators; the spectators' cards were in front of the performer.

The effect was an outstanding one. Nevertheless, it struck a false note at this point. There is something subtly wrong with placing the performer's cards on the spectators' side of the table while the spectators' cards are placed on the performer's side of the table. Of course, since there is no such thing as real magic, all magic tricks involve compromising the ideal. Each performer reading that effect will have to decide whether this compromise is worth making.

(5) *Make the hidden visible*. It's easier to remember where something is if it's in plain sight. The “McDonald Aces” offers greater clarity than most ace assemblies because each ace remains *face up* on the table until it transposes. In general, a version of an effect where the props are visible throughout most of the effect will be clearer than one in which the props spend much of their time hidden (face down, in the performer's closed hand, or covered by other props).

This is one reason why the “Ambitious Card” is a clearer effect than the “Elevator Cards.” The ambitious card is constantly being turned face up; it's only face down at intervals. By contrast, each of the elevator cards must remain face down on the table until after it travels.

(6) *Eliminate time lags*. The longer the spectators have to wait for something to happen, either because of the performer's use of time-consuming procedures or because of excessive patter, the more likely they are to become unclear about what is supposed to be happening. Later we'll be talking about the problem of fading emotional memory. Time lags can also cause *intellectual* memory to fade, concentration to flag, attention to wander, and one's ability to grasp the overall picture to weaken.

Remember, the spectators are not as familiar with the trick you're doing as you are. Don't make it harder for them to put the

individual pieces together in their minds by having long stretches of dead time between those pieces.

(7) *Eliminate interruptions.* Imagine you're performing an effect and, right at the most critical moment of the trick, another entertainer interrupts you to do a bit from his act. Perhaps a comedian comes over and tells one of his best jokes. Or perhaps a juggler elbows you aside and does a little juggling bit. It might even be another magician who stands in front of you and does a quicky effect in the middle of your trick.

Obviously, that interruption may make it difficult or even impossible for the audience to follow the thread of your effect. It doesn't matter that the joke might be quite funny, the juggling bit quite impressive, or the quicky effect quite startling. In fact, it might be all the more likely to sabotage your trick because of how effective it is. The bit's effectiveness makes the interruption that much more of a distraction from the effect you're trying to present.

Fortunately, what I've just described isn't likely to ever happen to you. If it did, I'm sure you'd be furious with the jerk who interrupted you. But, amazingly, many performers will interrupt themselves at a critical moment in an effect to tell a joke, do a flourish, or throw in another quicky effect.

In Juan Tamariz' *The Magic Way*, he mentions a term coined by Arturo de Ascanio in his writings on magic theory. The term is "anti-contrasting parenthesis." This strange phrase makes me think something must have been lost in translation. But I like the fact that it's a curious phrase because it makes it easier to remember. And the concept it represents is very much worth remembering. Tamariz defines it as "an action or phrase that distracts from the trick, makes the spectators forget the situation that the magician wants them to remember ([for example,] the colour of a handkerchief that is about to change), or keeps them from focusing on a fact or action that the magician wants them to see clearly."

I'm not for a moment arguing against using humor, flourishes, or quick magical bits in your performances. But the positioning of such digressions is critical. Any such bit at the wrong moment can distract the audience precisely when you most want them to focus

on some key element of the effect you're performing.

Throwing in a gag as you're having a card selected won't do any harm and may do some good, both for the laugh it gets and by filling in a moment of dead time. Throwing in a gag as you're revealing the selected card may kill the whole impact of the trick if, for example, it distracts the audience from appreciating that the card was, not just in your wallet, but in the zippered compartment of the wallet.

Recently, I saw a magician perform a beautiful version of the Cards to Pocket. Just as the last card was about to travel to his pocket he threw in a very funny visual gag. Unfortunately, the gag was so funny that it completely distracted the audience from the vanish of the last card and its production from the pocket—what should have been the high point of the effect. If the gag had been used earlier, on one of the previous cards, it would have been just as funny and it wouldn't have killed the climax of the trick. (As John Carney has written, “Humor should never be at the expense of the effect and the mystery.”)

This can be a tough pitfall to resist because the audience is rewarding your mistake. They laugh at the joke or smile in admiration of the flourish. However, as Jesse Jackson would say, you've got to keep your eyes on the prize. In this case, the prize you're after is the gasp of astonishment at the climax of the effect. Anything that threatens that goal just isn't worth the momentary gratification.

Sometimes the anti-contrasting parenthesis is actually built right into the structure of the effect. Fred Braue is credited with the following variation of “Triumph.” As in the original, a selected card is lost in the deck, and the deck is shuffled, face-up cards and face-down cards being mixed together. After a magical gesture, the cards are spread on the table and every card is now face-down except for one face-up card in the middle. However, unlike the original, the face-up card is not the selected card. Instead, it is a ten-spot. The performer then counts over ten cards from the ten-spot; the card at that point is turned over and proves to be the selected card.

This is an example of the kind of bad magic that often results when magicians embellish tricks to make them more appealing to

audiences of other magicians. In this case, the ten-spot creates an anti-contrasting parenthesis. Normally, when you spread out the cards at the climax of Triumph, the spectator thinks, “My God, they're all face down except for my card!” In the Braue version, the spectator thinks, “My God, they're all—wait a minute! What's the story with that ten of spades?”

The face-up ten-spot, which doesn't make any sense to the spectator when it appears, distracts him from appreciating the utter impossibility of the other cards all being face down. Just as the spectator's mind is about to explode, you let all the air out. It's like having the phone ring just as you're having an orgasm. Even if it's good news, it's just not good timing,

This is a good place to introduce another of Darwin's Laws: *Audiences are not easily fooled, but they are easily confused*. If you add Vernon's dictum that confusion is not magic you should see why it's important to avoid *magicus interruptus*.

(8) *Procedural directness*. Nothing kills clarity in magic more surely than using indirect procedures and excessive handling. If you spread the cards and have somebody remove one, everyone can understand that a card has been chosen. If you ask a spectator to name a number between ten and twenty, count off that many cards, add the digits of the named number, count off that many cards from the previously counted-off packet, and remember the card at that number, you should not be surprised if some people have trouble realizing that what has “happened” is that a card has been chosen.

Many methods in card magic require that the performer continually cut, shuffle, deal, deal down and under, count cards, recount the same cards, and reshow cards that were just shown a moment ago. Many methods in close-up magic require that the performer pick up props just to place them down again in order to pick them up a moment later to no apparent purpose. Many methods in all kinds of magic require that you go about doing something in just about the most roundabout way humanly possible. Because such procedures clutter the landscape that the spectators are viewing, they get in the way of their seeing the big picture. That big picture is otherwise known as the effect.

Magicians like to pretend that method, effect, and presentation are unrelated subjects. There is no better example of the relevance of the method to the effect that is perceived by the audience, and consequently to presentation, than the way in which indirect procedures and overhandling can clutter an effect to the point where the audience doesn't know what is supposed to have happened.

Remember the example I gave earlier of gathering the cards at the beginning of the “McDonald Aces,” mixing them face up and face down, then dealing them out again. This pointless procedure is used to switch the regular aces for the double-faced aces. There are far more direct methods of doing the switch, but they demand more skill so they will be ignored by those lazy magicians who tell themselves that the audience doesn't care about the method. They may not care about the method, but they do care about whether or not they can follow what is supposed to be happening, and that is often affected by what method you use.

To make clear what I mean by directness, I'll delineate the difference between directness and simplicity. One so often hears an effect described as “simple and direct” that there is a tendency to assume the two things are the same. (To add to the confusion, there are those magicians who say “simple” when they actually mean “easy.” This is typical of the muddled thinking that predominates in magic.)

A trick may be simple without being direct or direct without being simple. “The Twenty-One Card Trick” is simple but not direct. The plot of having someone think of a card and then divining it is as simple as one could hope for. However, the procedure of continually dealing the cards in rows and cross-examining the spectator about the whereabouts of his card is the height of indirection.

By contrast, David Roth's “Portable Hole” is very direct, but the plot of coins emerging from a bagless purse, disappearing into a two-dimensional hole, and materializing under the hole is hardly simple. Finally, the Ambitious Card is an example of an effect which, in the best versions, is both simple and direct. Simplicity is an aspect of plot. Directness is an aspect of procedure which in turn is a function of method. (Whew!)

Simplicity in magic is strictly a matter of personal preference. Directness, however, is an absolute essential. Earlier I said that you don't have to try to incorporate all the various clarifying techniques into every effect. It's something you have to determine on a trick-by-trick basis. However, directness in procedure and handling is a goal you must strive for in every effect. It's not only essential to clarity, its necessary if your magic is to really look like magic.

In sleight-of-hand effects, indirect procedures are often referred to as overhandling. But it's important to realize that this problem doesn't just arise in sleight-of-hand magic. Consider two versions of the same general effect that I recently read. Both are essentially self-working. One is “Britlandeck” by David Britland.

In this version, the performer shows a joker on top of the deck. He writes a prediction on the back of the joker and hides the writing from view by turning the deck face up. He then asks the spectator to name any card he wishes. The spectator may, for example, name the four of hearts. The performer then spreads through the deck, finds the four of hearts, and drops it on the table in front of the spectator. Finally, he turns the deck face down to show that what he previously wrote on the back of the joker is “the four of hearts.”

Compare that to the following trick I ran across in a book on mentalism. The performer brings out two decks of cards, one red-backed, the other blue-backed. The spectator is asked to select one. The performer then picks up the other deck and removes a card from it. This card is not shown but is slipped inside an envelope which is placed aside. The remainder of this deck is handed to the spectator with the instruction that he place it in his pocket.

The performer then spreads the other deck, faces toward the spectator, and asks him to name any card he sees. (Let's again assume that the four of hearts is named.) The performer then removes this card from the deck and places it inside the envelope with the other card. The spectator is then asked to remove the other deck from his pocket. (This is the deck from which the performer previously removed a card, not the deck from which the spectator thought of a card. With me so far?) He is instructed to count through the face-up deck and stop when he sees the card that he thought of.

The spectator finds there are only fifty-one cards in the deck and his thought-of card is not among them. He is then instructed to remove the two cards from within the envelope and turn them over. They both prove to be fours of hearts.

In a strictly intellectual sense, the effect is identical in both cases. The performer proves that he predicted what card the spectator would think of. However, any good performer should be able to present the first version clearly; only a very accomplished showman could succeed in clearly conveying the effect of the second version to an audience. Even then, the impact would not be the same. The trick is simply not clear enough because the procedure is so absurdly indirect. The first version is nearly self-working; the second version is completely self-working. So you see, the problem of indirect procedures is not limited to sleight of hand.

There are four reasons why magicians so often fall into the trap of littering their magic with overhandling or other indirect procedures. First, they fall so in love with the ingenuity of a particular method that they use that method even when it doesn't fit and may actually harm the effect. A small example of this can be found in the second version of the prediction effect I described a moment ago, the one that uses two decks. In that trick, the performer begins by giving the spectator a choice of the two decks. He really uses a magician's choice to ensure that the prediction card is taken from the deck that is gaffed for that purpose and that the "thought-of" card comes from the deck that is gaffed for that purpose.

The performer could simply have handed the spectator the deck he wanted him to use. In so doing he would have removed one small distraction from the effect. I can only assume that he likes doing the magician's choice so much that it prevented him from realizing that it doesn't add anything to this particular effect.

By now you realize that I don't subscribe to the method- doesn't-matter school of thought. I do, however, believe that *method matters only in regard to how it affects the effect*. The fact that you do a particular move very well is no reason to do it at every opportunity. The fact that a particular stratagem intrigues you is no reason to use it in an effect where it contributes nothing.

The second reason for indirect procedures is that many magicians are concerned only with performing for other magicians. This leads them to load up their effects with complicated procedures in the hope that other magicians will get lost in the maze and be unable to reconstruct the effect.

A variation of this is the magician who has spent so much time around other magicians that he has lost all touch with how laypeople think. Even when he is routining his magic for laymen, he attributes to them the thinking habits of magicians. He continually throws in ploys designed to convince the laymen that he isn't doing things that never would have occurred to them in the first place. (In this connection, we will later be discussing subtleties and conditions—which ones matter to laypeople and which ones don't.)

Always keep in mind that devious procedures to make it impossible for other *magicians* to follow the *method* may also make it impossible for *laymen* to follow the *effect*. (Besides, I'll let you in on a secret, although you probably won't believe me. The average “magician” is just a layman with a bunny rabbit on his business card. Routine your magic to fool and entertain laypeople and you'll be surprised at how many magicians you'll also fool along the way.)

The third reason for indirect procedures is that they often make an effect much easier to perform. Unfortunately, they may also make the effect no longer worth performing. This is an uncomfortable fact that many magicians refuse to face. I recently read an article on presentation in a magic magazine. Along with some generally good advice, the author makes this statement: “Forget complicated magical methods, and seek the easiest way to accomplish the trick.” The problem is that very often the complicated method is the easiest way to accomplish the trick.

An example of this is the ace switch in the “McDonald Aces” that I described earlier. Another illustration is Larry Jennings' “Open Travellers.” In his version, the aces are palmed across, so the packets never touch. Magicians who are afraid of palming devised versions in which the aces had to be continually gathered up only to be dealt out again for no good reason. The magician's job became easier, but the effect became less clear. Remember, *your job is to make things as easy as possible for your audience, not to make*

things as easy as possible for yourself.

The fourth and final reason magicians use indirect procedure is that sometimes they are the only way a particular effect can be achieved. If the indirect approach is the only way an effect can be achieved, do a different effect.

Admittedly, the above discussion assumes an ideal that can't be completely attained in the real world. Because we can't do real magic, we'll always have to engage in a certain amount of indirection in our approach. It's a question of degree. Here is a test to help you decide if a particular handling is too indirect. Ask yourself, "What would this effect look like if I could do it through real magic?" Then consider how far the method and handling depart from this ideal.

Real magic would always involve the most direct procedures possible. If you could really read minds, you would simply ask someone to think of a word, then you would immediately tell him what that word is. Since you probably can't really read minds, you're going to have to introduce one or two detours. This is permissible if they're kept to a minimum and if you can convincingly justify each one.

I think it would be permissible to have the spectator choose the word from a book "to ensure a large enough selection." It might even be permissible to have the spectator write the word down on a piece of paper "so that later we'll have proof for the rest of the audience of the success or failure of the experiment."

But if the spectator has to roll three dice and add the numbers on the opposite sides to arrive at a page number; then he has to add the digits of the page number to count down to a line; finally, he has to write the word down and seal it inside three envelopes; you shouldn't be surprised if the audience fails to realize that the effect was that someone thought of a word and you read his mind.

Since directness is a matter of degree, it will always involve personal judgment. The "real magic" test won't give you an automatic answer; you still have to make the final decision. However, the "real magic" test will at least keep your attention focused on the big picture, otherwise known as the effect.

CHAPTER TWO: CONVICTION

1. The Dynamics Of Conviction

The Expository Phase

Virtually all close-up magic tricks can be divided into two parts which I'll term the expository phase and the magical phase. Robert-Houdin said that before you change an apple into an orange you should make sure the audience knows it's an apple. Changing the apple into an orange is the magical phase. Making sure first that they know it's an apple is the expository phase.

The expository phase always comes first, for example: having a card selected and returned to the deck; placing four coins on the table under four playing cards; having the four aces signed and buried in different parts of the deck; or dealing the aces in a T-formation and dealing three cards on top of each one. Then comes the magical phase: making the selected card rise from the deck; making the coins travel from card to card; producing the aces from four different pockets; or making the aces gather together in one packet.

At first glance, some tricks might seem like they don't fit this format. For example, does producing a coin at the fingertips have any expository phase?' Isn't it all magic? Admittedly, this is a case where the exposition is so brief, it almost seems nonexistent. Still, the production of a coin at your fingertips won't have much impact unless something has gone before to lead the audience to believe you don't have a coin in your hand.

Multi-phase effects like “Oil and Water” or the “Ambitious Card” may also seem like exceptions. The fact that they're not becomes clear when you realize that a multi-phase effect is a series of discrete

magical effects combined. Therefore, each phase of the trick has its own expository phase and magical phase. In “Oil and Water,” each phase begins with the performer alternating the colors (exposition) and ends with the colors separating (magic). In the “Ambitious Card,” every time you insert the card in the middle of the deck you're engaging in the expository phase; every time it rises to the top you're engaging in the magical phase. In any case, there's no need to debate about the few seeming exceptions since almost all effects divide very easily and naturally into these two phases.

One might almost term these two phases of a trick the boring part and the interesting part. This isn't really accurate since the expository phase can and should be interesting to your audience too. (Indeed, if you can't make the expository phase interesting, your magic is bound to fail since the audience won't be paying any attention by the time the magical phase arrives.) Nevertheless, it is true that the magical phase is inherently interesting while the expository phase is not *inherently* interesting.

This leads many magicians to treat the expository phase as a nuisance to be gotten out of the way as soon as possible. They act as if the exposition is of no importance. A typical example is the magician who says, “It doesn't matter how you control the selected card. The audience doesn't care how you control the card. They're only interested in how you reveal it.”

The fallacy of this attitude becomes obvious when you realize that the expository phase and the magical phase in magic are exactly analogous to the setup and the punchline in a joke. It's the punchline that gets the laugh, but it's not the punchline that's funny; it's the entire joke that's funny.

To put it another way, the setup determines how funny the punchline will be. Imagine a comic who stood before an audience and only recited punchlines. Do you really think he'd set lots of laughs? Do you think it doesn't matter what he says during the setup because the audience is only interested in the punchline? Not only is the setup necessary, the setup must be done just a certain way for the joke to work. Any professional comic will tell you that if a gag isn't set up properly it will die.

In the same way, the expository phase of a magic trick is not merely a necessary evil, it's a pivotal element, of the effect. In fact, it's only a slight exaggeration to say that the expository phase is what determines how strongly the effect as a whole will play. Admittedly, it's important to make the expository phase as interesting as possible. We'll talk about that later in the sections on Substantive Meaning, Situational Meaning, and Pacing. Right now I want to talk about perhaps the single most important consideration in creating strong magic: *making the expository phase as convincing as possible.*

Degrees Of Conviction

One of the most important factors that will determine how strongly your magic registers with an audience is the *degree* of conviction you achieve in their minds. The more strongly the audience believes that the coin is in your hand, the more amazed they'll be when you show that it's gone. Stated baldly this way the point seems obvious, but I think that many magicians don't really believe there are degrees of conviction. They think that either the audience believes or they don't and that, therefore, spending time trying to strengthen conviction is just something to do if you're working for other magicians.

To test this position, let's take as an example the "Color- Changing Deck" effect. There are some versions of this effect that are very convincing (Larry Jennings' "Transmutation" and my own "Greek Poker," for example) because a great deal happens before the blue deck changes to red, and during all this preliminary matter the spectators are seeing what appear to be a great many different blue-backed cards.

There are other versions where proving that the deck is blue consists of little more than performing a couple of face-up Hindu shuffles, flashing the bottom card occasionally. Some magicians would argue this is enough, because once the audience believes the deck is blue all else is gilding the lily. But let's take this further.

Suppose you were to take a red deck and place a single blue card on top of it, then place the deck in a blue case. If you removed this deck from the case and held it face-down in your hand, everyone would

believe that the deck is blue. Do you really think, however, that if you were to immediately lap the one blue card and spread the deck to show that it's red, there would be gasps of amazement?

Let's go further still. You don't even need the blue cover card. Laypeople believe that blue cardcases contain blue decks. Just put a red deck in a blue case. During your performance, remove the deck from the case face up. Everyone will believe that the deck is blue since it came from a blue case. Now turn the deck face down and spread it on the table. Will this be met with a round of applause? Of course not. The audience will simply reconsider its previous assumption that the deck was blue and conclude, quite rightly, that you put a red deck in a blue case.

In both examples the audience initially believed you had a blue deck. However, in both cases the conviction was so shallow that, when matters proved different, the audience was able to revise its assumption without difficulty.

Now let's assume you hand a deck to a spectator and have him shuffle it, spread it between his hands, and assure himself that the deck is blue-backed. Let's assume further that you take the deck back, turn it face up for an instant, then immediately turn it face down and spread it across the table. It's now red-backed. Can you doubt that the spectator would be speechless with astonishment? Unfortunately, I don't have a method for this version, but I know that if I did it would play strongly. The reason is that such a high degree of conviction had been achieved that having that conviction overturned would be a very unsettling experience for the spectator.

Degrees of conviction is one reason why magical methods are not really interchangeable and why one version of a trick may be far more powerful than another. It's also a major reason why visual magic is so strong. A person will never be more convinced that a card is the ace of spades than when he is staring right at its face. Let's take a look at the factors that affect conviction.

Emotional Memory

In achieving conviction in a spectator's mind it's important to remember that both rational and irrational elements can bear on

the matter. Consider the factor I call *emotional memory*. Try this experiment. Perform a simple coin vanish for some laypeople. Just pretend to put the coin in your hand but don't. Patter for about ten seconds, then open your hand to show the coin gone. On another occasion do the same thing, only this time patter for about a minute before opening your hand to show the coin gone. If you try this teat repeatedly, you will find that you'll consistently get a stronger reaction when you wait only ten seconds before revealing the vanish. What's going on here? Presumably you performed the move just as deceptively in each case. Yet when you patter longer it almost seems as if the audience has half-forgotten that they saw you put the coin in your hand. In a sense, they have. Of course, in a strictly intellectual sense they still remember they saw the coin placed in the hand; if questioned on the point, they will certainly verify that they saw you place it there.

Yet, while the intellectual memory hasn't faded, the emotional conviction that came from apparently seeing the coin placed in the hand has partially faded. The more time that elapses between closing the hand around the coin and opening the hand to show the coin gone, the less strongly the audience feels in their gut that it must be there. That's one reason why Slydini's "One-Coin Routine" is so strong. Each vanish of the coin follows right on the heels of the audience seeing the coin in the hand.

I recall two different performances I've seen that vividly underscored this point. In one case the magician was performing a "Coins Through the Table" routine in which four half-dollars penetrated one at a time. He placed the four coins in his hand then, while keeping the hand in a closed fist, he asked a spectator to point out the "soft spot" in the table. When she did so, he rapped the spot a couple of times with his fist and questioned its softness. He asked the spectator if she wanted to change her mind. When she declined, he insured that she change her mind. After a new soft spot was chosen, he asked the other spectators if they would prefer that he use a different spot on the table. When a soft spot had been selected by plebiscite, he finally brought his fist down on the table and opened it to reveal only three coins while his other hand emerged from under the table with the fourth coin. This ordeal was repeated with each of the remaining half-dollars.

This performer received no audience reaction to any of the penetrations. I think the reason was clear. After each interminable period of meaningless prattle about soft spots, people could hardly remember how many coins he had placed in his fist at the outset. Again, in a strictly intellectual sense they could recall the number, but the *visceral experience* of seeing the coins go into the hand had faded to the point where it carried no conviction.

(This is also a good example of why a performer should not play up meaningless conditions. Did this magician really think people were going to walk out of the performance saying, “Not only did he make the coin go through the table, the most amazing thing is that he let *me* pick what spot on the table it would penetrate!” If he had asked me to point to the soft spot, I would've pointed between his ears.)

The second example involved a far more talented magician, but he allowed the same error to ruin a classic effect. The performer was working a trade show. The effect in question was “Triumph.” He had a card selected and returned to the deck. He then turned half the deck face up and shuffled the two halves together.

Then came the fatal error. He placed the deck aside and launched into an extended pitch about the product he was representing. When he finally spread out the cards to show that they were all face down except for the selected card it had virtually no impact. He had allowed the emotional memory of seeing face-up cards and face-down cards pushed into each other to dissipate.

There is no denying that pitching the product is a vital part of a trade show performer's job. However, if instead of holding the climax of the trick hostage to make his audience stay for the commercial, he had finished the effect and then done his pitch, I'm certain everyone would have stayed and listened if only so they could see another miracle like the one they'd just witnessed.

Yet another good example of what I mean was passed on to me by my friend Pat Cook. He once told me that he had just witnessed something in magic that he previously thought impossible. I expected that he was about to describe some card or coin miracle. Instead he told me about seeing a magician fail to get any audience reaction whatever when he produced a giant load at the end of a

chop cup routine.

“Was he working for magicians?” I asked. He informed me that it was a paying audience of laypeople. I said, “Well, he must have flashed.” But Pat told me he was quite sure the audience had been fooled by the load.

He went on to explain that after the magician executed the load perfectly he left the loaded cup on the table and launched into a long stream of patter. “He talked so much,” said Pat, “that by the time he lifted the cup to show the load, the audience didn't care.” I would say rather that by the time he revealed the load, the audience didn't remember having seen the cup empty—at least, they didn't remember *emotionally*.

Sometimes the problem of fading emotional memory is built into the very structure of an effect. A good example is found in many versions of the “Elevator Cards.” The performer deals, for example, an ace, two, three, and four of hearts in a face-down row. One-by-one each card is placed in one position in the deck and made to travel to a different position. By the time the performer gets to the four of hearts, a good deal of time has elapsed since the face of that card was last shown. Consequently, each phase is a little weaker than the one that preceded it just the opposite of what good routining demands.

Remember Houdin's advice that before you change an apple into an orange you should make sure people realize it's an apple? He might have added that *you shouldn't allow too much time to elapse between the audience's last glimpse of the apple and their first glimpse of the orange*.

Admittedly, there are other factors besides emotional memory to consider in gauging the optimal elapsed time between showing the original state and revealing the changed state. One is the possibility of building suspense before the revelation. We'll discuss this at length later. (But note that the “soft spot” gambit did nothing to build suspense. The time to build suspense in “Coins Through the Table” is after the hand has been slammed down on the table. A brief pause before lifting the hand to show the remaining coins can heighten anticipation.)

Another factor to consider is that of deceptiveness. Too short a time lapse might make it easy for the audience to backtrack and figure out what must have happened. If you show that a coin has vanished the instant you drop it in your hand, it won't be difficult for the spectators to figure out that you must have retained the coin in the other hand. If you do a double turnover to show a card, turn the card face down on the deck, then immediately show that the top card is now different, most people will realize that the card you showed originally is still on top of the deck even if they don't grasp the mechanics of a double lift. It's far more deceptive to take the face-down card off the deck and rub it on the table for a few moments before revealing the change. Just don't keep rubbing for five minutes—and don't ask the audience to pick what spot on the table you should rub the card on!

Deteriorating Conviction

A difficult problem that arises in many effects is that, although the performer may succeed in creating a high degree of conviction at the outset, the very progress of the effect serves to undermine that conviction. Consequently, each subsequent phase of the effect becomes weaker rather than stronger.

Consider the typical ace assembly. The performer apparently deals the four aces in a T-formation. Actually, the three aces in the follower positions have been switched for indifferent cards; however, due to the deceptiveness of the switch, the spectator is certain that all four cards on the table are aces.

When the first ace travels to join the leader, the spectator is amazed. When the second ace joins the leader, the spectator begins to wonder whether all the cards laid out at the beginning really were aces. By the time the last ace travels across, the spectator is certain that all the aces weren't on the table to begin with. Although he doesn't know-how the switch occurred, his initial conviction as to the positions of the aces has eroded to the point where the last phase of the trick is the least powerful rather than the most powerful as dramatic theory demands.

Another example is provided by "Follow the Leader." In this effect, ten red cards are dealt in one face-down pile and ten black cards are

dealt in another pile. Each pile is assigned a leader card of the same color. But when the leader cards are transposed, the face- down cards appear to follow; red cards are dealt from what had been the black pile and vice versa. This transposing of the leader cards with cards of matching color then being dealt from the face- down piles is repeated until the two piles have been exhausted.

The first time the leaders are transposed, the effect is very strong because the spectator was certain he knew where the red cards were and where the black cards were. By the time the trick is halfway through, the progress of the effect has forced the spectator to conclude that the two packets didn't really consist of all reds and all blacks as he had thought. The performer thinks that the message of each repetition is, "The face-down cards follow the leaders no matter how many times they are switched around." Unfortunately, the real message to the spectator is, "You were wrong when you thought that each packet of cards consisted of only one color at the beginning."

Although the spectator may not understand how he was fooled at the outset, having recognized that all there is to the trick was this initial deception, his interest wanes; the illusion of magic has been destroyed. (This again illustrates the difference between the perspective of magicians and that of laymen. For the magician, puzzling over how he could have been fooled during the initial laying out of the red cards and black cards is enough to fascinate him. For the layman, the realization that there is nothing more to the "magic" than that initial deception transforms the trick into a mere puzzle and he loses interest.)

Still another illustration of the problem occurs in "The Ambitious Card." The first couple of times you make the card jump from the middle to the top, there is no doubt in the spectator's mind that the card really is in the middle. By the fourth time you do it, the spectator may be asking to see the face of the card just before you insert it in the center.

The "Elevator Cards" effect we talked about earlier also suffers from deteriorating conviction as well as straining emotional memory. I could give many other examples of this same dynamic at work in other effects. However, you can probably think of further examples

yourself. In fact, most tricks that involve repetition are potentially vulnerable to this problem.

This is not to say that there is no solution or that repetitive effects should be avoided. The really effective versions of these tricks, however, are those that somehow reinforce conviction as the effect progresses. Let's go back to our example of the ace assembly. In the "McDonald Aces" all four aces are laid out on the table face up. No matter how amazing the vanish of each ace may be, the spectator cannot doubt the location of the remaining aces since they're staring him in the face.

In the "Jazz Aces," only eight cards are used, four aces and four black cards. Each time an ace joins the leader, the performer shows that the four cards in his hand are all black, thus indirectly proving that the four cards on the table must all be aces. In Vernon's "Slow-Motion Four Aces," the performer shows the face of the fourth ace just before the last phase, thus making the ending of the trick the strongest part rather than the weakest.

Similarly, Bill Miesel has published a version of "Follow the Leader" where halfway through the trick the performer shows that the cards remaining in the two follower packets are all red and all black respectively; yet he immediately continues with the transpositions. Also, numerous "Ambitious Card" handlings have been devised which allow the performer to show the face of the card as he inserts it into the deck. The wise performer saves these handlings for later in the routine when he has to counteract deteriorating conviction.

The specific means that will work best depend on the specific trick. What each of these examples shows, though, is the value of maintaining a high level of conviction throughout a repetitive effect either by means of some condition (such as laying out the aces on the table face up) or some convincer (such as flashing the face of the ambitious card as it is buried in the deck). Let's take a closer look at how conditions and convincers work.

2. Conditions

If conviction is a key factor determining the impact of a magic effect, the most important factor determining how much conviction an

effect achieves is the strictness of the conditions under which it's performed. By conditions I mean such things as whether the deck is shuffled by a spectator, whether a selected card is signed, whether the aces congregated while the spectator had her hand on the leader packet whether certain key procedures are performed by the magician or by a spectator, whether the spectator is allowed to think of any card or is limited to only certain choices, whether the magic happens without the performer touching the props, or whether you do the effect with borrowed objects or your own.

Many magicians will tell you that laypeople can't appreciate stringent conditions, that those things matter only to other magicians. This position gains weight from the fact that many magicians who perform only for other magicians become obsessed with the conditions of an effect to the exclusion of all other factors. Furthermore, when such a magician does perform for laypeople, it often becomes obvious that the conditional elements so dear to his heart don't matter at all to the audience.

Does this mean that laypeople don't care about conditions? Actually, the issue of conditions is every bit as important to lay audiences as magician audiences. However, the specific conditions that impress laymen are often totally different from those that impress other magicians. Magicians' reactions to conditions are shaped by their knowledge of how such effects are *actually* done, laypeople's reactions to conditions are shaped by how they, sometimes naively, *think* such an effect might be done.

Suppose you perform "The Card to Envelope/Wallet" for a mixed audience of both magicians and laymen. After the signed selection has been replaced in the deck, you very fairly show your hand empty, then reach in your jacket pocket and remove your wallet. You unzip it and take out an envelope. You show that not only is the flap of the envelope glued shut but it is also sealed with a blob of wax.

The magicians in the audience will be very impressed by the fact that you showed your hand empty before removing the wallet since they know this isn't possible in the standard method of performing this effect. Laypeople will be much less affected by this condition since, if the card was convincingly lost in the deck, it won't occur to them that it could be hidden in your hand. Furthermore, they would

set no way that a palmed card could be instantly introduced into a sealed envelope. Therefore, they will believe the hand is empty even if it's not shown. (By contrast, the magicians will believe the hand is *not* empty unless it is shown.)

The laypeople will be very impressed, however, by the fact that the envelope is sealed with wax since this appears to make it even more impossible to get the card into the envelope than just gluing the flap shut. Magicians will not be at all impressed by this condition since they know that the card is not inserted into the envelope through the flap opening anyway.

Thus both the magicians and the laypeople will be impressed by the conditions under which the “Card to Envelope/Wallet” was performed, but each group will be impressed by different conditions.

I'll give you another example from my own work. Whenever I perform for laypeople I always roll up my sleeves. I've found through experience that this condition makes the performance much more memorable for them; it eliminates a possible explanation (cards hidden in my sleeves) which they would otherwise suspect. Of course, this condition doesn't impress other magicians at all since they know that the notion of magicians having cards up their sleeves is a myth.

Incidentally, you shouldn't condescendingly assume that this layman fixation with sleeves is a sign of their stupidity. Let's look at it from their standpoint. An audience sees me perform “Darwin's Wild Card,” for example, in which eight black deuces change into red nines in a totally incomprehensible manner. It's only logical for them to wonder where the nines came from and where the deuces went to.

Since my hands were undeniably empty at the outset, are undeniably empty at the end, and have not approached any possible place of concealment, it's perfectly rational to suspect the one place of concealment that is always near my hands. From the standpoint of the information the layperson has to work with, suspecting the sleeves is an intelligent—indeed, an unavoidable—conclusion.

However, when you roll up your sleeves, you remove the last possible refuge of logic. The spectator's intellect can no longer

protect his emotions from reacting with awe to what he sees. I believe anyone who performs visual card magic can increase the impact of his magic on laypeople by fifty percent simply by rolling up his sleeves.

Indeed, long experience has taught me that there are three explanations that are always on the tip of a layperson's tongue when he watches card magic: cards in the sleeve, marked cards, and duplicates. If you transform one card into another, they will suspect that the card was exchanged for one in your sleeve. If you identify a selected card, they will suspect that the deck is marked. If you make a card travel from one place to another, they will suspect that the card that arrived at point B is only a duplicate of the one that started at point A.

Therefore, you can greatly strengthen such effects by imposing conditions that eliminate those theories. I've already recommended performing with sleeves rolled up. If you're going to identify a card selected by a spectator, it'll be more effective if you have the card selected in such a way that you never get to see its back. For example, you might have the spectator select the card while your back is turned or have him peek at the card rather than remove it from the deck.

If you're going to make a card travel to some impossible location, you must take steps to eliminate the possibility of a duplicate. Generally, the best solution is to have the card signed. (Ironically, magicians seldom suspect sleeved cards, marked decks, or duplicates which often makes it possible to fool them badly with precisely those methods that would have little chance of getting past laypeople.)

This raises an important point. We magicians are often spectators of magic as well as performers of magic. That's why it can be difficult for us to distinguish between those conditions that impress us when we watch a trick and those conditions that would impress laypeople when we perform a trick.

Recently I read a magic book that contained a Named Triumph effect. This is a version of "Triumph" in which the spectator does not pick a card, he merely names any card he wishes. The cards are

then mixed face up and face down. At the end, the named card is the only face-up card in the deck. This effect received particularly high praise from the publisher in the flap copy of the book.

I'm sure this version of "Triumph" would be much stronger for magicians than the standard version. I'm also sure that it would be much *weaker* for laypeople than the standard version. I've had enough experience performing for lay audiences to predict with some confidence what a layman's reaction to this effect would be. When you proudly displayed the climactic layout of the cards at the end of your technical tour de force, he'd look at you completely unimpressed and say, "Well, sure, I told you what my card was!"

If you watch laypeople closely when you have them pick a card you'll notice that they're almost paranoid about hiding its face from you. If you ask them to show the card to others, they will do so in a very guarded way to make sure there is no chance of your catching a peek. If anything occurs as the card is returned to the deck that makes them think you might have seen it they will immediately yell, "You saw it! Let me pick another one."

I once saw a prominent bar magician ask a spectator to name her card for the benefit of the audience at the end of the trick just before he revealed it. She refused to do it. This resulted in a battle of wills between them which almost led to the performer having her ejected from his bar. I too have sometimes encountered resistance when asking a spectator to name her card at the end of the trick. If laypeople are reluctant to name their selection at the end of a trick, imagine how unimpressed they would be with a trick in which they had to name their card at the very beginning!

From a layperson's perspective, the whole point of a pick-a-card trick is that you don't know what card they picked. This makes perfect sense from their viewpoint. The only way a layman could ever find a card in the deck is if he knew what card he was looking for. It's natural that he would assume the same applies to you.

By contrast, magicians know that most pick-a-card tricks depend on controlling the *location* of the card in the deck, not on knowing its *identity*. They would be impressed by a version of "Triumph" in which they could name any card in a shuffled deck since this would

preclude all the standard controls. Laypeople don't know about any of those controls. For them a version of "Triumph" in which their card is buried in the deck, its identity unknown to you, is much stronger than one where they have to tell you the name of the card.

This effect provides a good example of how you can fool yourself into believing that laypeople can't appreciate fine points and that one method is as good as another as far as lay audiences are concerned. You perform your super-technical Named Triumph and, to your dismay, it's greeted with yawns. Your reaction might be, "Laymen don't know what good magic is. You may as well just do the slop shuffle for them."

If instead you realize that laypeople's appreciation of conditions is molded by their naive notions of how they think magic must be done, you might take the following approach that I've christened "Nameless Triumph." Have the deck shuffled by a spectator, then have the spectator peek at a card. Secretly glimpse the selection and immediately hand the deck out for another shuffle. As far as your lay audience is concerned, you can't know either the *identity* or the *location* of the card in the deck. (They are, of course, only half right) Now perform the "Named Triumph" handling using your secret knowledge of the card's identity.

Having the spectator shuffle immediately after your glimpse can even be tied into the theme of your presentation. When the spectator returns the deck, say, "Thank goodness you shuffled like a normal person. The last time I did this trick, the guy shuffled like this." Now you go into your face-up/face-down shuffles. This is a powerful version of "Triumph" that should flabbergast any audience, whether laymen or magicians.

Hopefully, you're starting to realize that conditions are a matter of audience perception. Perception, in turn, is shaped by your point of view, and a lay audience's point of view is very different from that of a magician audience. This point is important enough to rise to the level of a basic principle: *how impressive a condition is depends on your audience's perceptions, not on the reality of the situation.*

This is a powerful secret. It means that you can often make an effect stronger without making it any harder. You do this by incorporating

a condition that seems important even though it doesn't affect the working of the trick at all.

We've already seen one good example of this in the idea of working with sleeves rolled up. Another good illustration is a handling for the climax of Vernon's "Twisting the Aces" I worked out years ago. I call it "Twisting the Case." In order to keep the description brief, I'll assume that you're familiar with the original effect.

Proceed with the original Vernon handling up to the point where the first three aces have turned over and the last ace (the ace of spades) is face up in the middle of the packet unknown to the audience. As in the original, perform an Elmsley count to apparently show all four cards face down. (The last card of the count should go to the bottom, leaving the ace of spades face up third from the top.)

Insert the packet into the cardcase and close the case. Place the case on the table. While it rests on the table, turn it clockwise 180 degrees with your fingertips. This echoes the twisting flourish you used to make the first three aces turn face up.

Open the case and tip the packet onto the table face down. (With a little practice, you'll find you can easily do this without the cards spreading.) Let the audience see there is nothing left inside the case. Using only one fingertip, spread the tabled packet very slowly and dramatically. There, face up in the middle, is the ace of spades.

This handling does not make the effect any more difficult. It won't impress magicians; they'll realize that all the work was done before the packet was placed in the cardcase. However, laypeople will believe that you turned the ace over while the packet was enclosed in the case, a very impressive condition. Try this and you'll find that you will get twice as much audience reaction as with the original simply because you've taken into account the audience's point of view.

Mind you, there are some conditions that impress both magicians and laymen, although many magicians won't admit it. Here, as in so many areas of presentation, some magicians refuse to give laypeople credit for much intelligence. Magicians love Paul Gertner's version of the "Cups and Balls" in which he uses steel ball bearings. They

appreciate that sneaking these balls in and out of the cup noiselessly is a tremendous technical challenge. Yet I've often heard magicians praise this effect, only to follow up by observing condescendingly, "Of course, it's only good for magicians." Presumably they feel that only someone with years of experience and study in magic would realize that a steel ball hitting a metal cup will make noise.

Paul, being an experienced and accomplished professional magician, knows better and uses the routine in his laymen performances. Of course, he doesn't take any chances; he starts the effect by pointing out how much harder it is to do with steel balls. (He also points this out when performing for magicians, probably realizing that they'd be more likely to miss the point than laypeople. They'd be too busy trying to catch the next move.)

The inability of most magicians to understand which conditions matter to laypeople and which don't is a prime reason why so much of what is published in magic is irrelevant to performing in the real world.

Countless versions of "The Spectator Cuts to the Aces" have been published by cardmen. Michael Skinner once showed me a very elementary version which he said was the strongest one for laypeople he'd ever found. What this version had that almost all others lack was that the method allowed for having the spectator himself turn over the top card of each packet to reveal the aces. Most methods involve a switch at this point and therefore require that the performer turn the cards over.

The key to making "The Spectator Cuts to the Aces" a strong trick is convincing the spectator that he is really the one who locates the aces. There is no better way of achieving that conviction than allowing him to do the turning over as well as the cutting. My own experience with this effect has convinced me that Michael was absolutely correct. Because almost all the many versions of this trick that have flooded the magical literature lack this vital condition they represent pointless exercises. Tremendous ingenuity has been brought to bear in some of these versions, but that ingenuity has focused on those elements that matter least to an audience.

If you still doubt that conditions are a vital factor in determining

audience impact, try to see Daryl perform his “Ambitious Card” routine for laypeople. This is the version which ends with the deck being tied with a piece of rope. Despite this condition, the signed card is cleanly inserted in the middle and immediately shown to have arrived on top. This ending destroys lay audiences. Yet, the only difference between the first phase of Daryl's routine and the last phase is the condition under which it's performed.

Identifying Important Conditions

The question then isn't whether the conditions of an effect are important to lay audiences, but rather which conditions matter to them and which don't. Here are some techniques to help you answer that question for any given effect.

First, try as an exercise to pretend you don't know anything about magic. Take the effect in question and try to figure out how it might be done. Use all your native intelligence but don't use any of your technical knowledge of magicians' methods.

Once you've developed some theories, you can be reasonably sure that any conditions which seem to disprove those theories will have impact on a lay audience. As I stressed earlier, the conditions that matter to magician audiences are those that relate to the way they *know* a particular affect is usually done. The conditions that matter to laypeople are those that relate to the way they *guess* a particular affect could be done.

Second, try to remember back to when you were a layman. I've found this a particularly useful practice in gaining insights into how laypeople think. After all, we all started out as laymen. When you first became interested in magic, chances are you saw many effects performed in your first few visits to the magic shop or magic club meetings. Try to remember the ones that made the greatest impression on you and, most importantly, why they affected you so strongly. The conditions that impressed you then are the ones that will impress your audiences now.

Third, and most important, listen to your audiences. There are many ways in which they'll tell you what they consider important. The first is how strongly they react. If you've tried doing different

versions of the same trick and one gets a stronger reaction than others, check to see if the stronger one contains a condition particularly impressive to laymen.

Audiences will also tell you what they think is important through direct comments to you or to other laypeople that you may overhear during or after a performance. I can't tell you how many times I've heard a layman say in disbelief after one of my effects, "And he did it with his sleeves rolled up!"

Another instructive time to listen to laypeople is when they're describing to someone else an effect you performed (or describing to you an effect they saw another magician perform.) Inevitably they'll leave out many details. The points they choose to include in the description are the ones they consider important. If they mention a condition, it's because it's important to them.

You may be surprised at how perceptive laypeople can be. An old man, a complete layman, once told me of a wonderful magician he had seen in his youth. Although he couldn't remember the magician's name, from the description it was obvious he was talking about Cardini. The point that impressed him most and which he mentioned repeatedly was how the magician was able to perform those intricate manipulations while wearing gloves. This is a condition many magicians would think would surely be lost on laypeople.

The Must-Believe Test

Finally, here is a simple technique I've found very useful in identifying important conditions. I call it the must-believe test. Simply ask yourself this question: what is the one false premise the audience *must believe* if they are to view the effect as a miracle?

For example, in the "Torn and Restored Card," the one false premise they must believe is that the card you show restored at the end is the same one you tore up at the beginning. In "Triumph," they must believe that face-up and face-down cards are really mixed together at the end of the shuffle. In the "Ambitious Card," they must believe that the card that appears on top of the deck is the same one you buried in the middle. In a typical ace assembly, they

must believe that the four aces begin in four different packets. As these examples show, once you ask the must-believe question, the answer in most cases is obvious. The trick is to ask the question in the first place.

Once you've identified what the audience must believe, you'll know that any conditions that strengthen that belief will make the trick stronger. Conditions that relate to other issues will matter little.

For example, I wanted to create an ace location in the miracle class. I realized that to achieve it I had to convince the audience that I had no idea of the location of the aces in the deck at the beginning of the trick. That was the false premise they must believe. Therefore, I knew that's where I should concentrate my efforts.

To achieve the necessary conviction I introduced three conditions. I will only perform the trick with a borrowed deck; I have the deck shuffled by a spectator before I start; and I have a spectator cover my eyes with her hands as I locate the aces. The borrowed deck convinces them that the aces can't be shaved, marked, or prepared in any way that might allow me to feel their location. The spectator shuffle ensures that I can't know the locations of any of the cards in the deck. The fact that my eyes are covered means that I can't catch a glimpse of an ace as I shuffle and cut the deck. (The resulting effect, "Blind Aces," appears in my upcoming book *Cardshark*.)

Occasionally, the one thing the audience must believe to view the trick as a miracle is actually a *true* premise. For instance, in the "Card to Wallet," what they must believe is that the card that is found in the wallet is the same one that was lost in the deck. Of course, it really is the same card. Yet you still have to introduce a condition, such as having the card signed, to achieve the necessary conviction or the trick will fail. The fact that something is true doesn't mean the audience will assume it's true.

Also, occasionally, there may be two or, in rare cases, three false premises the audience must believe. In the "Card to Envelope" they must believe that the card in the envelope is the same one that was lost in the deck, but they must also believe that the envelope is completely sealed. In any case, the basic principles of applying the must-believe test remain the same.

You'll find the must-believe test is more useful in analyzing some effects than others. But in many cases it can help you distinguish between important conditions and unimportant ones. It can also help you in comparing different versions of the same effect to determine which one will play more strongly. Once you identify the one false premise the audience must believe, you'll know that whichever version is more convincing on that point will get the stronger reaction.

What all the exercises I've just given will help you achieve is to *see the effect from the audience's point of view*. This is something you must always strive for, yet which most magicians fail to do.

Al Baker has often been quoted as saying that many good tricks have been killed by improvements, yet Baker's own books are filled with his improved versions of standard effects. Clearly, he didn't believe that all efforts at improving tricks were bad. What's the key difference between those efforts at improvement that succeed and those that only succeed in killing a good trick? I believe that failing to understand what conditions in a trick matter to an audience is the source of most lethal "improvements."

An improvement that strengthens an important condition will always make for a stronger effect. Unfortunately, many "improved" versions actually eliminate important conditions in order to make the trick easier to perform. In order to make a trick more convenient to do, the magician destroys the one feature that made the effect worth doing. There are many elements of your magic that an audience may care about, but your personal convenience is not one of them. Keep that in mind as you read the following discussion.

The No-Contact Condition

There is one condition that relates to so many different effects, is so important in the minds of lay audiences, and is so frequently violated by magicians that I feel it deserves separate discussion. That is what I term the no-contact condition. Simply stated, if an effect involves an object traveling from point A to point B, the effect will be substantially stronger if point A and point B never come in contact with each other.

If the effect consists of a coin traveling from the right fist to the left fist, the impact will lessen if the two fists touch, even for only a moment. If the effect consists of a selected card traveling from the deck to your wallet, the impact will lessen if the wallet is rested on the deck when you first remove it from your pocket.

Mind you, if you asked the spectator how the coin could travel from hand to hand even if they did touch, as long as the fists remained closed, he wouldn't be able to tell you. Neither could he tell you how the card could get inside the wallet just because the wallet rested momentarily on the deck. Nevertheless, instinctively people sense that the task becomes a little easier if the two points touch—and, of course, they're right!

Because this condition registers on an instinctive level, the spectator himself may not consciously realize that the reason a trick leaves him cold is that it violates the no-contact condition. This doesn't for a moment, mean it isn't important. (As a matter of fact, all the most important factors that determine an effect's impact on an audience function partly on an unconscious level.) Despite the unconscious aspect of the no-contact condition, spectators will often reveal the importance they attach to that factor in their comments; to the perceptive magician, spectators' comments often reveal more than they themselves realize.

The no-contact condition can also be violated by openly conveying some object from point A to point B before the invisible transfer of another object. In Alex Elmsley's "Between Your Palms," the performer begins by placing aside a card sight unseen. Later this card proves to be the same card the spectator selected from the deck and signed *after* the unknown card was set aside. It would be difficult to imagine a more amazing plot. Yet this trick which intrigues magicians leaves laypeople cold.

The problem is not with the plot but with the procedure, which violates the no-contact condition. Before the identity of the unknown card is revealed it is brought in contact with two other selected cards—cards which were removed from the deck after the signed selection was buried in the deck.

There are other versions of this effect in which the set-aside card is

instead sandwiched between two cards or four of a kind but none of these address the central problem. Only Ed Brown's version achieves a degree of isolation by placing the set-aside card in one compartment of a wallet while the other selections go into a different compartment. (However, see "The Dream Card" in *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* and "The Psychotronic Card" in *Cardshark* for examples of this type of effect that do observe the no-contact condition.)

Any survey of magical literature or any extended exposure to close-up magic will yield many more effects in which the no-contact condition is violated. In certain ace assemblies one of the follower packets must touch the leader packet. In some tricks in which the selected card is removed from the cardcase the case must first touch the deck. In some Cards Across effects the two packets must first be brought together.

My convictions about the importance of the no-contact condition to audiences are the result of very extensive performing experience and observation. I believe that anyone who experiments with different versions of the same effect will come to the same conclusion. Nevertheless, I realize my argument will meet strong resistance from many magicians.

The problem is that, when audiences think that lack of contact between point A and point B makes the trick harder to do, they're absolutely right. That's why so many versions of these effects do involve bringing points A and B together. While the inventors of these tricks presumably would argue that the no-contact feature doesn't matter to audiences, they will usually try to structure the effect so that points A and B touch for the least amount of time possible. For example, in a Cards Across effect, the two packets may only brush across each other for an instant. Implicitly this recognizes that the less time the two points are in contact, the stronger the effect will be. Yet that same logic should make it clear that if they don't come in contact at all, the effect will be stronger still.

The bulk of what is published in magic books and magazines will always reflect what is easiest to invent, not what is most effective to perform. The bulk of what most magicians perform will always

reflect what is easiest to do, not what has the strongest impact on an audience. For example, since most magicians are scared to death of palming a card, non-palming card-to-wallet tricks will continue to be popular and that will usually mean bringing the wallet in contact with the deck or openly inserting extraneous cards into the wallet or your pocket prior to removing the signed selection. These versions may lack the conviction, and sometimes the clarity and directness, achieved by the palming approaches, but they're a heck of a lot easier to do. You'll have to decide for yourself where your priorities lie.

Dramatizing Conditions

I trust that by now you appreciate the vital role conditions play in maximizing audience impact. However, conditions will only affect an audience if you make sure the audience notices them and appreciates their implications. They must appreciate them not only intellectually but also on an emotional level. The key to giving conditions emotional impact is dramatizing.

The best place to see creative examples of such dramatizing is in television commercials. Advertising companies first determine what feature of a product they want the audience to appreciate. Then they figure out a way to communicate that feature to an audience in a dramatic fashion. They don't just tell people about the feature, they show them in some memorable way.

Practically every commercial you see illustrates this approach. If they want you to appreciate that a car provides a smooth ride, they have a diamond cutter cut an expensive diamond in the backseat of the car while driving over a bumpy road. If they want you to appreciate how securely a plastic food storage bag seals, they fill the bag with angry bees. If they want you to see how powerful a vacuum cleaner is, they show it sucking up steel nuts and bolts.

You have to learn to sell the conditions of your effects the way Madison Avenue sells the features of its products—in ways that reach the viewer's gut, not just his intellect.

Don't try to dramatize every condition of the effect or you'll just dissipate the impact of this technique. The must-believe test will

help you here. The conditions that relate to what the audience must believe in order for the trick to be a miracle are the ones to dramatize.

Through Actions: Consider the “Ultra-Mental Deck” effect where the performer shows that he predicted a freely thought-of card by previously reversing that card in the deck. The impact of this trick depends entirely on the audience being convinced that the performer couldn't possibly have foreseen the spectator's choice. Mentalist Chet Miller would dramatize this point by having a spectator randomly selected from the audience, then sending that person to a pay phone with instructions to telephone any acquaintance within a one-hundred mile radius to ask him to name a card. How could audiences fail to appreciate the impossibility of his foreseeing this distant stranger's choice? (The one-hundred mile limitation is a clever example of the illogical convincer concept we'll be discussing later.)

In presenting this same effect, Al Koran would have a spectator think of any card. He would then tell him to forget that card and think of another one. He would then tell him to forget this second card and think of yet another one. It was this third thought-of card that Koran would show he had predicted. As he would point out in his patter, how could he possibly have foreseen what card a spectator would arrive at after changing his mind twice? This kind of thinking means nothing to the magician concerned only with methods, but it can make all the difference in the world to the performer who wants maximum audience impact.

Let's consider one more example of dramatizing the free choice angle in an effect. In the 14/15 force, the deck is set up in such a way that any two adjoining cards will add up to either fourteen or fifteen. The usual way to handle this force is to tell a spectator to cut the deck and take the two cards at the point he cut to.

Suppose instead you spread the deck face down on the table and hand the spectator the joker. You tell him to insert the joker face up at any point he wishes in the spread. Now you tell him that you need two cards for the effect. You may use the two cards directly above the joker or the two cards directly below the joker. Alternatively, you may use the card directly above the joker plus the one directly

below it. The choice is his.

The net result of this is exactly the same as if you had just told the spectator to cut the deck and take the two cards at the point he cut to. However, this way of handling the force dramatizes the variety of choices open to the spectator. It underscores the totally random and uncontrolled nature of the two cards arrived at. Both handlings are logically the same, but their psychological impact is quite different.

Don Alan is fond of using dramatizations after the climax of an effect to drive home its impossibility. The best-known example is when, after producing a giant steel nut or ball bearing, he lifts it several inches above the table and lets it drop with a loud thud. Similarly, after producing two large balls in his “Chop Cup” routine he will place them both in the cup and mime trying to pound them back in to drive home the fact that they won't both fit at the same time. At the conclusion of Brother Hamman's “Micro Macro” he will hand the regular-size deck and the miniature cardcase to a spectator and ask him, tongue in cheek, to place the cards back in the box; there is no better way to dramatize the impossibility of what has just happened. Alan uses a similar touch at the conclusion of “Ring Flight,” the effect where a spectator's borrowed ring vanishes from the performer's hand and appears hooked onto his keycase. At the conclusion of the trick, he hands the keycase to the spectator and tells her to remove her ring. Invariably, it takes her a long period of fumbling before she succeeds. Then, for the benefit of the slower members of the audience, Alan drives home the point with a patter line: “If you think it's hard to get off of there, you should try to get the damned thing on there!”

One of the most beautifully creative ideas for dramatizing a condition I've run across is a presentation for the “Coin In Bottle” published in the *Phoenix*, credited to Franklin Taylor. Taylor would take out a dime and a quarter and ask a spectator which would be easier to fit into the bottle. Naturally, the spectator would say the dime. Taylor would then hand him the dime and the bottle and tell him to try. The spectator would discover that the dime was too large to fit through the neck of the bottle. You can imagine, then, how much more impressed the spectator now was when Taylor proceeded to put the *quarter* inside the bottle. If even a dime

wouldn't fit, getting a quarter inside was a true miracle.

In some card effects, it's important that the audience appreciate the fact that the cards were shuffled by a spectator at the outset. A simple but effective way to dramatize this is to ask three different spectators to shuffle consecutively.

Harry Houdini was a master of dramatizing conditions. In his "Milk Can Escape," the most important condition was the fact that he was under water: he couldn't breathe until he escaped. To dramatize this, he would begin by asking how many people in the audience thought they could hold their breaths for one minute. After a show of hands, he would ask everyone to hold their breaths while he timed them. Spectator after spectator would eventually give up, desperately gasping for breath.

Later, when Houdini was struggling to escape, a large clock would count off the seconds. With the memory of their own experience fresh in their minds, the audience's alarm would grow as the time went far past the point where they had been able to hold their breaths. No other presentational approach could ever have gotten them to feel what Houdini must be going through the way thus one did.

When Houdini did the escape from seventy-five feet, of rope he would have an assistant time how long it took the audience volunteers to tie him up. Then he would announce that he would escape from the ropes in less time than it had taken them to restrain him. If he had simply announced that he would escape in, say, four minutes, it would have meant little to the audience. His ploy reduced that abstract fact to terms they could understand.

Through Audience Participation: One of the generally most versatile and effective methods of dramatizing a condition is to have the audience enforce that condition. How many times have you heard a layperson finish a glowing description of an effect he's witnessed with a comment such as, "And I shuffled the cards myself," or, "And it was Joe's deck of cards!"

One of the things that makes the "McDonald Aces" the most powerful of all ace assemblies is the fact that the performer never touches the leader packet until the very end. You could dramatize

this condition by placing a paperweight on the leader packet at the start of the trick. The paperweight would not be removed until the end. Alternatively, you could dramatize the condition by having a spectator place her hand on the packet, warning her not to lift her hand for even an instant until you ask her to at the end of the trick. Logically, both methods are just as good at proving that you don't tamper with the packet during the trick. Yet, emotionally, having the spectator place her hand on the cards will be much more convincing.

There are many ways this concept can be applied. For example, some performers very effectively sell the no-contact condition—the fact that their hands never come near each other during a “Copper-Silver Transposition” or “Coins Across”—by having one spectator hold the performer's left wrist while another spectator holds his right wrist.

Suppose you want to sell the fact that you never touch a certain prop throughout the effect. You can single out one member of the audience to watch that prop throughout the effect. Just before the climax you can have her affirm that she never took her eyes off the item in question and that you positively never went near it. This is an idea I've used for years with great results.

An extremely effective item I always perform when I have the opportunity to work with a borrowed deck is the “Blind Aces” effect I mentioned earlier. After the borrowed deck has been shuffled by a spectator I take it and proceed to cut to the four aces. I do this while blindfolded. Only I don't use a blindfold.

Instead, as I'm sitting at the table, I have a female spectator stand behind me and cover my eyes with her hands. This offers an advantage in pacing since it takes far less time than most blindfolds require to put on and take off. It also eliminates the time-consuming process of having a blindfold tested by audience members before the start of the trick to prove that it's not gimmicked; the spectator's hands are above suspicion.

My main reason for taking this approach, however, is that having an audience member “enforce” my blindness is the strongest way I can dramatize the sightless condition under which the effect is

performed. If you think it makes no difference if the trick is done with a cloth blindfold or a “human” blindfold you still haven't grasped the central fact that strong magic is about emotion, not logic. If you do appreciate the difference, start looking for ways to dramatize key conditions of an effect by having the audience “police” those conditions themselves. You'll start hearing laypeople glowingly recount your effects to others, ending with comments like, “And I never took my eyes off that box,” or, “And they never let go of his wrists,” or, “And she covered his eyes the whole time!”

Through Images: Never underestimate the power of mere words to forcefully drive home a point. For best effect these words should evoke *concrete images* in a spectator's mind. The abstract speaks to the intellect; the concrete image speaks to the emotions and instincts.

That's why a charity will select an annual poster child. They know they can cite statistics about thousands of children suffering and it won't move most people to action because statistics appeal only to the intellect. Yet a photograph of a single child in need will get people to donate because it's a concrete image that cuts directly to the emotions. That's what you have to achieve with your words.

Peter Duffie published an effect in which two cards selected by a spectator are torn in half. One half of each card is then burned. Then an envelope that had been handed to the spectator before he selected his cards is opened; inside are the two halves which a moment earlier were unmistakably destroyed.

For this effect to register strongly, the spectators *must believe* that these are the same two halves that they saw burned. The proof is that their torn edges perfectly match those of the two undestroyed halves. That is the vital condition, the one they have to appreciate in their gut.

When I would perform this trick, as I tore the two cards, I delivered the following patter: “*Did you ever see one of those old spy movies where the secret agent is given half of a torn dollar bill? Later, when he meets his contact, the contact produces the other half of the bill and they compare them to be sure they match. That way the hero knows that his contact isn't an impostor. This is because*

any time you tear any piece of paper you create a jagged edge that is as unique as a fingerprint. You could sit in a room tearing playing cards eight hours a day for ten years and never succeed in getting two with identical edges.”

During this brief patter, which hardly runs longer than it takes to tear the two cards, I drive the key condition home by means of three separate concrete images. First, I invoke an old movie cliché that everyone has witnessed—a scene whose whole point is the validity of the condition you want to stress. Second, I make an analogy to fingerprints, something that is virtually synonymous with uniqueness as a means of identification. Finally, I conjure up the ridiculous image of a person sitting in a room tearing playing cards day after day in an effort to come up with two identical tears. Even as the spectator visualizes this scene, he realizes the futility of such an endeavor. Later, when I match up the two torn halves of each card, the spectator will vividly appreciate that these must really be the same halves he saw destroyed by fire.

The technique of dramatizing through words is very similar to those used by poets. The poet employs metaphors, similes, and evocative imagery to go beyond communicating with the reader's intellect and reach his emotions. The creative showman will do the same to make

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The technique of dramatizing through words is very similar to those used by poets. The poet employs metaphors, similes, and evocative imagery to go beyond communicating with the reader's intellect and reach his emotions. The creative showman will do the same to make the spectator appreciate the key conditions of an effect in his gut as well as in his brain.

An appreciation for, and use of, presentational angles of this kind is one of the features that most distinguishes professional performers from amateurs. When two professional close-up workers have a session, they're more likely to trade the kind of presentational bits I've been describing than new moves or effects.

In fact, I've found it a quick and reliable way of sizing up other

magicians. If I describe to a magician a dramatizing ploy that I know to be strong and his eyes light up, I know I'm talking to a performer. If, instead, he stares at me blankly, or gives me a puzzled look as if trying to figure out just what my point is, I know I'm dealing with a hobbyist who does most of his performing for other magicians.

Once you start thinking in terms of dramatizing conditions many ideas will occur to you. Opportunities for dramatizing the conditions of an effect are limited only by your imagination. This area as much as any indicates why presentation offers as much room for creativity as inventing new moves or effects.

3. Convincers

A technique at the other extreme from the dramatization of conditions but which aids in the same ultimate goal is the use of convincers. I first ran across the term “convincers” in the writings of Harry Lorayne. Many people use the word “subtleties” to refer to the same thing, but I prefer the term *convincer* because it underscores the purpose of the technique, which is to strengthen conviction.

Where dramatizing is a big production, convincers are a small touch. Where dramatizing is clearly conscious and deliberate, convincers are off-handed, seemingly uncalculated. That is, in fact, their greatest strength.

Convincers may be divided into two types: *accidental convincers* and *incidental convincers*. The distinction is a subtle one worth making for analytical purposes and for helping to understand the dynamics of this technique.

Accidental Convincers

One reason why convincers are stronger if they're not stressed is that many convincers are convincing only because the audience believes they're accidental.

A very subtle use of the accidental convincer is provided by Juan Tamariz in a book test taught in his *The Fire Points in Magic*. He

wishes to force the seventh word on page 106. Having forced the page he tells the spectator to add the digits of the page number to arrive at one word on the page. Since one, zero, and six add up to eight, he tells her, she should look at the eighth word.

Naturally, someone in the audience is bound to point out that one, zero, and six add up to seven, not eight. The performer responds by saying, "Of course, you are right . . . excuse me! It does not matter: the seventh word." Through a cleverly staged accident, the performer has convinced the audience that he could just as easily have divined the eighth word or, by implication, any other word in the book.

Another good example of the accidental convincer is provided by the German mentalist Punx. In one effect in his book *Fourth Dimensional Mysteries* he opens a billet and reads to the audience something a spectator has written on it. When he unfolds the paper, he first gives it a 180 degree turn before reading the writing. The clear implication is that the writing was upside down when he first opened the paper.

In reality there is no writing on the paper at all. The performer has previously switched the spectator's billet for a blank dummy. When he pretends to read from the blank, he is actually reciting from memory the spectator's writing which he previously glimpsed. The subtle touch of revolving the paper unconsciously strengthens the audience's belief that it does have writing.

Incidental Convincers

By an incidental convincer I mean adding conviction to a certain feature of an effect "unconsciously" in the act of drawing attention to some other feature. As with the accidental convincer, this allows you to allay suspicion in ways that might actually arouse suspicion if they were performed overtly.

One effect I do involves inserting the ace of hearts into the middle of the deck. As I push the ace in, I turn my hands over and say to the spectators, "Notice that it's going in at least half-way down in the deck." As I do this, the audience can see the face of the ace before it's completely inserted. Actually, the card isn't the ace of hearts at

all. I've previously switched the ace for the three of hearts.

It resembles the ace because the bottom pip of the three is hidden in the deck and the top pip is hidden behind my fingers as I push the card in.

Passing off a three as an ace is, of course, a standard ploy. How many times have you seen a magician do an ace assembly where at one point he picks up one of the follower packets and shows the bottom card, apparently an ace, actually a three with the two end pips covered by his fingers? This is usually accompanied by a comment like, "Remember, this packet contains the ace of hearts." This kind of thing is much more likely to make the spectators wonder whether the ace is really there than to convince them it is. They quite understandably ask themselves, "If he wants to show me the ace, why is he covering most of it with his fingers?"

Compare this with the handling I described before. I'm not turning over my hands to show them that the card is the ace. I'm doing it to show them that the card is really going half-way down in the deck. Since I'm not concerned with exhibiting the face of the ace, it's not suspicious that my fingers might happen to be covering part of it. Yet while I'm drawing attention to where I'm inserting the card, the audience is bound to notice, almost subliminally, that the card really is the ace of hearts. That's what I mean by an incidental convincer. The contrast between the two situations described above should make clear why it's such a psychologically potent technique.

Why Convincers Work

No challenge: What both accidental convincers and incidental convincers have in common is that they're both seemingly unintentional. The "unintentional" approach is always best using convincers because convincers provide *indirect* proof that something is so. If this is overtly presented with the intention of convincing the audience, they're likely to wonder why, if you really want to convince them of your claim, you don't provide *direct* proof. However, if they interpret your actions as unintentional, this question doesn't arise.

No skepticism: Another important strength of the unintentional

approach is that, if the audience interprets an action as unintentional or accidental, they will attribute to it a sincerity and honesty that people are understandably reluctant to grant to the actions of a magician in most cases.

Let me illustrate this by discussing in detail a ploy often used in the “Torn and Restored Card.” The performer tears a corner off the selected card, secretly switches it for a duplicate corner, and gives it to a spectator. Later when that corner is fitted to the restored card it “proves” that it must be the same card. The torn-corner “receipt” is one of the conditions of the trick, but not a very effective one because it underestimates the audience's intelligence. The concept of switching corners is not a difficult one for a perceptive layman to hit upon.

This fact was brought home to me by a story told by my friend Bob Kohler. He often does the “Bill to Lemon” and always has the bill signed with a Sharpie pen. (This is a pen with non-water- soluble ink so the signature won't run when it gets soaked with lemon juice.) The effect involves no duplicate; the signed bill is actually loaded into the lemon.

One evening when Bob was performing this trick he reached in his pocket and found that his Sharpie pen was missing. Improvising, he tore a corner off the bill and gave it to a spectator for identification and continued with the effect. Remember, there was no switch of either the corner or the bill. The bill in the lemon really was the same one he initially borrowed. After the show, several laypeople came up and accused Bob of switching the torn corner. Since then he's been careful to always have a Sharpie pen in his pocket.

What does all this have to do with convincers? In his excellent book *A New Look at Some Classic Close-Up*, Bill Okal has a great version of the “Torn and Restored Card” that, uses the torn corner swindle. Recognizing the problem I've discussed above, he handles it differently. He tears the card and “accidentally” lets one corner drop to the table. He fails to notice this until a spectator calls it to his attention after the other pieces have been vanished.

Initially upset by the mistake, Bill eventually brushes the matter off, telling the spectator to keep the piece as a souvenir. Later when the

restored card is produced minus one corner, the spectator herself remembers the other piece and, without any prompting, invariably fits it in to discover that it matches.

I don't doubt that, as Bill states, this is a very convincing bit as long as the performer succeeds through his acting in really making the audience believe that the dropped piece was an accident. Thus, a ploy that fails miserably as a condition succeeds brilliantly as an accidental convincer, simply because the audience will attribute to an accident a sincerity they won't attribute to an obviously deliberate action.

No logical scrutiny: Another advantage of the unintentional approach is that very often its effect on an audience is almost subliminal. The spectators barely notice the convincer on a conscious level but register it subconsciously. This is particularly desirable since it achieves conviction on the deepest level. An interesting benefit of this approach is that it bypasses the critical intellect. Consequently, a subliminal convincer need not even make sense to serve its purpose. Many of the best convincers don't make sense logically, but do make sense psychologically.

For example, in almost any case where a duplicate is later going to be switched in for one of the props used in an effect, you can employ a subliminal convincer to decrease the chances of the audience suspecting a switch. You do this by making the prop appear unique through incorporating some imperfection.

A medallion may bear a scratch which you've carefully duplicated on the other medallion to be switched in later. If you write something on an envelope, you may "accidentally" make a small error that must be crossed out or necessitate writing over a letter. Or perhaps your pen slips and leaves a mark after the writing. Naturally, you've previously incorporated that same "mistake" in the duplicate. In a trick with a Himber wallet, you may place a photograph in one side of the wallet. That photograph has a crease in it. On the other side of the wallet you have a duplicate photograph creased in exactly the same way.

Since every one of these imperfections is extremely easy to recreate on any number of duplicates, their presence doesn't really prove

anything. But because the convincer works subliminally, the spectator simply won't, think to ask himself, "Could he have obtained an identical photograph and creased it the same way?"

Another good example of an illogical convincer is what Tony Raven has christened the virgin state principle. When using a common item that has been prepared in some way, you can discourage suspicion about its gaffed nature by dressing up the item so it looks like it just came from the store.

For example, suppose you're going to use a gaffed envelope. After gaffing it, put it together with a dozen other envelopes and wrap them together with a paper strip, the way they're usually found in stationery stores. Finally, place a price sticker on the strip. All these things subtly say to the audience, "These are ordinary envelopes, just as you might buy in any store." Most importantly, because they say it subliminally, they say it far more convincingly than if you were to include the above sentence in your patter.

An illogical convincer that mentalists use all the time is to incorporate a small error in the course of their accurate predictions or divinations. People seem to feel this proves the psychic must be genuine. If he were using trickery, he would have gotten everything right. It doesn't make sense, but it does convince people.

A classic example of the illogical convincer in a non-magical context is provided by an episode from the early career of the legendary con man, Yellow Kid Weill. At the time, the Kid was working a horse race scam. After gaining the mark's confidence, he would explain that he was privy to information about a fixed horse race. He wanted to let his new-found friend benefit from this information. Unfortunately, he'd promised that he wouldn't reveal the name of the winning horse to anyone. The only way around this prohibition would be for the mark to give his money to the Yellow Kid who would bet it for him and later give him his winnings. Needless to say, once the Kid left with the money he never returned.

On one occasion, the mark got cold feet at the last second. Just as he was about to hand over the money he froze. The Kid pointed out that post time was fast approaching; if he didn't get the bet down soon it would be too late. Still the mark hesitated. Undoubtedly, at

the moment of decision he started wondering if he'd ever see the Kid again after he forked over the money.

Sensing he was on the verge of losing his sucker, the Kid desperately searched his mind for some ploy to gain psychological leverage. As it happens, he was wearing an expensive, attractive coat that the mark had complimented him on earlier. The Kid tore off his coat and handed it to the mark saying, "It's so late I'm going to have to run to reach the ticket window in time. Hold my coat till I get back." No sooner did he give him the coat than the mark handed over the money. On some subconscious level, the sucker had concluded, "He wouldn't leave his coat behind if he weren't planning to return."

Suppose the Yellow Kid had actually said, "As a sign of good faith, I'll leave you my coat." You can be sure the mark would have responded, "That's ridiculous! Who would accept a one thousand dollar coat as collateral for a ten thousand dollar loan?" However, as long as the logic was unstated it remained unexamined. Consequently, what was logically absurd proved psychologically convincing.

Does Anyone Notice?

"Audiences are far from being as dumb as some performers seem to think."

Ted Annemann

Many magicians will tell you that the sorts of things we've been discussing in this section are a waste of time when working for laymen. People just don't notice all those fine points. Magicians often make the claim that laypeople are easy to fool—that they aren't very observant, intelligent, perceptive, etc. Frankly, I believe it's simply an excuse for laziness. If laypeople aren't very smart, then we don't have to work very hard to fool them. Countless magical duffers have justified their incompetence with the claim, "Laymen never notice."

The point these magicians fail to grasp is that laymen are not a homogenous group. Some are smart, some are stupid. Some are moderately observant, some are extremely observant. That's why any experienced performer can cite examples from his experiences

to support any generalization he wants. If he wants to argue that laymen are unobservant, he tells you about the time he accidentally switched a blue deck for a red one and no one noticed. If he wants to argue that laymen are observant, he tells you about the times spectators have pointed out very small discrepancies, the kind that magic books always dismiss with the comment, “Don't worry, no one will notice.”

In my own work, I'm continually impressed by how difficult it is to fool people, at least, if you want to fool *everyone*. I've often been amazed by spectators who have spotted the smallest discrepancies or even slight thematic inconsistencies. Such experiences always inspire me to work harder and be more subtle. Those same spectators are the ones who would notice—and be convinced by—convincers.

I once had a magician say to me, “Audiences don't notice those fine points. Heck, I'm lucky if I can get them to remember their card.” If a magician tells me he has trouble getting people to pay close attention to his magic, I'm willing to take him at his word. But I wonder if such magicians ever consider that their failure to make their magic deeply convincing might be one of the reasons their audiences can hardly be bothered to even remember the selected card.

This leads me to another one of Darwin's Rules, based on extensive personal experience and observation: *The better you are, the closer they watch*. If you really baffle people with a couple of effects, you'll find they pay very close attention indeed. The opposite is also true.

Most card men know the Tilt move in which a card is apparently placed in the middle of the deck from the rear. Instead it's actually inserted second from the top because there is a gap at the back between the top card and the rest of the deck. I use Howard Schwarzman's well-known subtlety in connection with this move. When I first attempt to insert the card in the middle, the card “accidentally” butts against the deck, pushing a couple of cards out slightly. On the second try, the card is successfully inserted into the deck.

On one occasion I was scheduled to do a magic lecture and before I

started I noted that the only woman in the audience was the club president's wife. I asked him if he thought she'd mind if I asked her to help. His answer was, "Go ahead if you want. But I have to warn you; she hates card tricks."

I did use her and she reacted as warmly and enthusiastically to my tricks as I could possibly have hoped. (This was a lesson in itself. How many magicians are convinced their wives hate magic, when in fact they only hate bad magic, the only kind they've ever seen?)

During the lecture I performed a trick using the Tilt move. Later when I taught the trick I explained the Tilt move but did not bother mentioning the subtlety of first butting out a couple of cards from the middle as if failing on the insertion.

As soon as I explained the Tilt move, my assistant, the club president's wife, said, almost indignantly, "That's not what you did before! You really put it in the middle."

Taken aback, I asked, "Why do you say that?"

She answered, "Because when you did it, I saw some cards stick out at the front."

Here was a layperson with no special interest in card tricks (in fact, an antipathy toward them, according to her husband). Yet not only had she noticed a tiny subtlety, she'd been so convinced by it that even when I explained the true method she initially refused to believe it. It would be difficult to imagine a deeper level of conviction. It may be that ninety-five percent of all laypeople would not have even noticed the subtlety. But given the fact that it takes almost no time or effort to do it, I'll continue to include it for people like her.

Weighing Pros And Cons

Let me repeat: the above convincer takes almost no time or effort. Therefore, there's no reason not to include it. Some convincers, however, do extract a price. They may slow down the trick, they may require more work on your part, or they may turn an impromptu trick into one that requires preparation. In such cases, you'll simply have to decide whether the price is worth paying. It's your job as an

artist to make those kinds of decisions.

Furthermore, it can certainly be a waste of time and energy to work hard to convince people of something it would never occur to them to question in the first place. This sort of thing is often justly condemned as “overproving.” Just watch the contortions most magicians go through in order to correct the “wrong” packet in “Out of this World,” when all you really have to do is turn the wrong packet face up and spread it on the table. Everyone will marvel at the fact that the colors are separated and no one will notice that the packet is “wrong.”

Spending a great deal of time and effort to prove something that isn't even in contention in the audience's mind is one thing. Doing everything you can to convince the audience of some element that it at the very heart of what makes the trick impossible is another. The latter is always worth the effort. Keep in mind, however, that this means providing the most convincing proof, not necessarily the greatest quantity of proof. It doesn't mean using every move you know to prove something; it means using the most convincing one.

Finally, it's also true that there is such a thing as achieving one hundred percent conviction on a particular point. Once you've achieved that, any further proving is wasted effort. If they're one hundred percent convinced that the four cards on the table are the aces, then there's no point in belaboring the matter. The question, of course, is, “Are they really one hundred percent convinced?” Only experience performing the effect in question can answer that for you. However, whenever you feel greater conviction can still be achieved, you now have an arsenal of techniques to achieve it.

CHAPTER THREE: SUGGESTION

“Beliefs not only affect judgments and behavior, but can even distort what we see.”

David Levis, *The Secret Language of Success*

“We see with our mind as much as with our eyes.”

S.H. Sharpe

What Is Suggestion?

Dr. John Booth once defined showmanship as “convincing exaggeration.” While I think this is too restrictive a definition for the vast subject of showmanship, I think it's a perfect description of suggestion. Suggestion is simply psychological manipulation designed to make the audience see more than really happens.

Suggestion can greatly enhance an effect. For example, I've often seen David Roth perform a self-levitation effect for laymen in which he rises from the ground two to three inches. Yet, due to suggestion, those same lay people usually swear he rose anywhere from six to ten inches off the ground.

Suggestion can even constitute the sole method for a magic effect. Table tilting and the pendulum effect are two examples. A hypnotist/mentalist friend of mine once told me, “Hypnotism is the ultimate kind of magic. You create magical effects in people's minds using nothing but suggestion.” In fact, a good way of getting a working knowledge of what suggestion is all about is to read Ormond McGill's great book, *The Encyclopedia of Genuine Stage Hypnotism*.

The key to understanding suggestion is realizing that, as S.H.

Sharpe wrote, “We see with our minds as much as with our eyes.” To an extent, every magic effect involves suggestion since it depends in part on creating a false frame of reference. That frame of reference is created through suggestion: you tell the spectator how he should interpret what he sees.

The essence of suggestion is expectation. Right now, I'm going to pass on to you one of the greatest secrets in magic. The longer you're in magic, the more you'll appreciate how true and how important this secret is. *People see what they expect to see; they experience what they expect to experience.*

I once went to see a double feature at the movies, a comedy and a drama. When the first film started it was the drama, but the audience had been led to believe the comedy would be screened first. People laughed during the first couple of minutes of the film until they realized the error.

Unfortunately, this sort of expectation can sometimes work against you. Because people expect trickery from magicians, they will sometimes see it even when it's not there. Remember that the next time a spectator accuses you of having just done a move when you know you haven't done anything.

However, if you know how, you can make expectation work for you in your magic. Presently there is a Sunday-morning televangelist show where the preacher is continually advising his viewers, “Expect a miracle.” This ought to be every magician's motto. To create that expectation you have to understand the five key factors in suggestion: prestige, atmosphere, reinforcement, desire, and planted suggestions. In practice, these elements intertwine; they're almost impossible to separate from each other. For analytical purposes, however, it's best to look at each one individually.

Prestige

As a child I loved *Aesop's Fables*. As an adult I find they still have a lot of wisdom to offer. Take, for example, the tale of “The Buffoon and the Countryman.” It's short enough to quote in full (from *The Fables of Aesop*, edited by Joseph Jacobs):

At a country fair there was a Buffoon who made all the

people laugh by imitating the cries of various animals. He finished off by squeaking so like a pig that the spectators thought that he had a porker concealed about him. But a Countryman who stood by said: 'Call that a pig's squeak! Nothing like it. You give me till to-morrow and I will show you what it's like.' The audience laughed, but next day, sure enough, the Countryman appeared on the stage, and putting his head down squealed so hideously that the spectators hissed and threw stones at him to make him stop. 'You fools!' he cried, 'See what you have been hissing,' and held up a little pig whose ear he had been pinching to make him utter the squeals.

Aesop gives the moral of this story as: “Men often applaud as imitation, and hiss the real thing.” Anyone familiar with either the art world or show business knows the truth of that statement. For the magician, however, the story has an even more important moral: An audience's reaction is largely determined by the performer's prestige. The buffoon was a professional animal-sounds imitator, so people expected him to be good. When he performed they were impressed. They didn't expect the countryman to be expert at animal imitations, so they were unimpressed even when he produced the real thing.

My friend Bob Elliott once had an experience that's a real-life analog to this fable. He was sitting in a crowded bar one evening watching *The Tonight Show* on TV with the other patrons. Uri Geller was one of the guests. He proceeded to bend a couple of keys by means of his “psychic powers.” This amazed everyone at the bar.

Bob said, “I can do that.” When challenged, he proved his claim by bending a couple of keys using exactly the same method Geller did. The bar guys were unimpressed, “You just bent them when we weren't looking,” they said. It wouldn't, have mattered if Bob had actually used psychic powers instead of the same sleight of hand Geller did. The bar patrons were just not about to believe that some guy in a bar could do what this world-renowned, scientist-tested psychic on national television could. All the prestige was on Geller's side, none of it on Bob's side.

I once witnessed this same phenomenon during a magic convention.

A few of us went over to a Denny's about 2 o'clock in the morning. One of the group, a topnotch magician, insisted on doing a trick for the waitress. The trick was a true miracle in which a rubber ball penetrated the bottom of a drinking glass he'd borrowed from her. She looked at him skeptically and said, "Do that again." (As we've discussed, this is not a compliment. It's just the spectator's way of saying, "The only reason you fooled me is that I wasn't paying attention.") He did it again. She scowled and said, "You're throwing it in the glass somehow." End of discussion.

I'm sure that if he'd done the same trick in a professional performance where people knew he was being paid a great deal of money to appear, the reaction would have been tremendous. But, to the waitress, he was just some clown at Denny's. As far as laymen are concerned, great magicians don't hang out at Denny's at 2 A.M. (If they only knew!)

So, how do you go about building prestige both before and during your performance so your audiences don't think you're just some clown at Denny's?

Professional Secrets: In the case of professionals, the process of prestige-building can and should start even before the performance begins. It's customary to send strong promotional literature to a potential client who's considering hiring you. I often send such material to a client even after he's already committed to hiring me. If you can get the client tired up about your upcoming performance, he will often become your best press agent, talking you up to others who will be attending the function.

Restaurant magicians sometimes have table tents printed up and displayed at each table. If the card has a couple of glowing endorsements of the performer from prestigious sources (newspapers, TV shows, etc.), it will not only result in his working more tables it will also make his performance more effective because he'll be starting with greater prestige.

I'm fortunate that in many of the shows I do I receive an introduction at the start of each performance. This is uncommon in the realm of close-up shows. (I'm speaking here of shows for laypeople; such introductions are standard at magic conventions

and magicians' lectures.) Even at private parties, I've had clients insist on stopping the party to address the crowd and let them know who I was before I started working. I expect they want to boast about having hired someone so "important."

I always provide the person who is going to introduce me with a typed set of credits he can use. These introductions are tremendously helpful in building prestige. Even before I start performing, the audience thinks so highly of me I can't lose.

If you're an amateur you don't have these advantages. But, if you're really good, you may find that your friends become enthusiastic press agents for you, telling others who haven't seen you work just how great you are. This will make your job much easier when you perform for those who haven't seen you before but know your reputation.

Give Yourself a Plug: During your performances, you should work diligently, hut subtly, to build your own prestige. The way to do this is self-promotional patter. This is a technique used by all the best professionals to a greater or lesser extent.

If you think about it, you may find you have some credentials that will build your image. Have you ever won a close-up contest at a magic convention? (It doesn't matter how small the convention: laymen don't know the difference.) Did you ever do magic on a local TV show or news broadcast? Have you taken lessons from a famous magician? (It doesn't matter if your friends have never heard of that magician; if you tell them he's famous, they'll believe you.) All of these things will seem terribly romantic and prestigious to laypeople. But they won't know about them unless you tell them.

The trick is to tell them without seeming to be blowing your own horn. You have to work these revelations into your patter in a natural and unobtrusive way. For example, you might, introduce an effect by saying, "This next trick is one that I'm particularly fond of because it's the trick that won me first place in close-up magic at the annual Warlords of Magic Convention a couple of years ago."

Don't for a moment think this won't affect the way the audience responds to the effect. There's a false cut I often demonstrate at magic sessions. Sometimes I introduce it by saying, "Here's a move

that was taught to me years ago by a card cheat from Boston.” Other times I introduce it by saying “Here’s a move I found in an old magic magazine.” Actually, both statements are true. The move was taught to me by a card cheat and, a couple of years later, I ran across the same move in an old magic magazine.

Clearly, the inherent merits of the move have nothing to do with where I learned it. But magicians are always far more eager to learn the move when I tell them it was taught to me by a card cheat; that’s a far more prestigious source. Although this story concerns other magicians, the same holds true for lay people. You’ll receive a far stronger response to a trick if you start by saying, “Here’s a trick I once performed on the Tonight Show,” (as long as they believe you) than if you start by saying, “Here’s a trick I bought for twelve bucks in a magic shop”—even if it’s the same trick.

Remember my friend at Denny’s? Instead of doing his trick “cold,” he might have started by explaining to the waitress that he was in town attending a national convention of professional magicians. (I know that ninety-nine percent of magic-convention attendees are amateurs. So tell a white lie. Who’s it going to hurt?) He could then explain that the next day he was going to debut an original magic illusion. Because she was such a great waitress he wanted to do it for her even before the other magicians got a chance to see it. I guarantee her response would have been infinitely more enthusiastic.

I don’t want to produce a bunch of blowhards with this advice, but I’d be doing you a disservice if I didn’t share this powerful technique with you. The best way to see how this sort of thing ought to be done is to watch the most successful pros perform. Once you’re attuned to it, you’ll see many examples of this technique at work.

Hobbyists will try to tell you that this attitude is terribly immodest. That’s the sort of thinking you can expect from hobbyists. If you went around bragging to boost your ego, that would be immodest. What we’re talking about here is the conscious use of a theatrical technique, not in order to stroke your own ego, but in order to strengthen your performance. The fact is you’re doing this for the audience’s benefit. They want to love your magic; you just have to give them permission to do so.

Prestige From Your Magic: Finally, you should realize that the strongest prestige-builder is your own magic. The stronger each effect is, the more your prestige builds as the performance progresses. Each effect you perform acts as an advertisement for the one you're going to do next. Consequently, your prestige should climb steadily from the start of the performance to the end. This is why it's unwise to do a really miraculous effect too early in the show; it just won't get the reaction it deserves.

You can prove this to yourself with an experiment. Select one of the most amazing effects in your repertoire. Then use it as the opening effect in a fifteen or twenty-minute set. On another occasion, use it to close that same set. I guarantee it will get a much stronger reaction as a closer. When you do it as an opener, people just aren't ready to give you credit for being a miracle man yet. They will convince themselves that they just blinked at the wrong time or that they missed something obvious. It's not that you're great; it's just that you caught them napping. But when you use it as a closer, the previous effects will have gradually built your prestige to the point where they're finally ready to give you credit for being a miracle worker.

This is also why the time to do a gaffed card trick is after you've staggered the audience with several impromptu effects. Your prestige is sky high and they're convinced you don't need trick cards to perform miracles. If you do the gaffed card trick before laying the groundwork in terms of prestige-building, trick cards are the first thing they'll suspect. How else could some clown at Denny's do a card miracle?

Atmosphere

"The generation of atmosphere, the aura of the uncanny, is one of the most important secrets of magic. It contributes to the willing suspension of disbelief, the feeling that, within the magic circle, or in the presence of the magical shrine, anything may happen."

Doreen Valiente, *An ABC of Witchcraft*

"Atmosphere is the all-important thing, for the final criterion of authenticity is not the dovetailing of a plot but the creation of a

given sensation."

H.P. Lovecraft, *Supernatural Horror in Fiction*

One of the most important elements in making suggestion work is atmosphere. In a certain atmosphere things may seem possible that would strike us as absurd in a different atmosphere. The classic example is ghost stories. Told at the beach on a sunny day, a story about someone seeing a ghostly apparition might seem absurd. Told by a fireside in a chilly, dimly lit room at night during a thunderstorm, the same tale might seem disturbingly plausible.

In Carlos Clarens' *An Illustrated History of the Horror Film* there is a great story about Carl Dreyer who directed *Vampyr*, one of the all-time classic horror films:

To his crew, Dreyer described the film-to-be. 'Imagine that we are sitting in an ordinary room. Suddenly we are told that there is a corpse behind the door. In an instant the room we are sitting in is completely altered; everything in it has taken on another look; the light, the atmosphere have changed, though they are physically the same. This is because we have changed and the objects are as we conceive them.'

What Dreyer's example makes clear is that atmosphere is, in the final analysis, a state of mind. In trying to create a certain atmosphere you are using externals to produce a mental state that will lead the audience to perceive your magic the way you want them to.

It's like the man who prepares for a seduction by dimming the lights, putting on romantic music, preparing a candlelit dinner, and chilling some champagne. He knows this atmosphere might produce a frame of mind that could lead to activities more unlikely in a different atmosphere.

As a magician, you must first determine what kind of atmosphere will best seduce your audience—what kind of atmosphere will make your magic most effective. It may be a fairy-tale atmosphere like the one David Roth generates. Through the use of whimsical props like plastic rainbows, cloth holes, and bagless purses, and fantasy

themes like pouring sound into a glass and pulling reflections off a mirror, he creates a fairy-tale world almost like that of the castle in Cocteau's *Beauty and the Beast*. In this enchanted world it's easy to believe that one could drop coins into a two-dimensional hole and find a pot of gold at the end of a rainbow.

Alternatively, your magic might benefit more from an atmosphere of the occult where unseen forces really can affect human affairs. What about a *Twilight Zone* atmosphere where the laws of reality might become skewed at any moment and the most familiar matters take on an alien dimension? Perhaps you want to create a *Sting-like* atmosphere where card sharks with superhuman skill gather to bend the laws of chance to their will and fleece the unwary in the process. Only you can decide what atmosphere your magic will best thrive in. And you can only decide after studying your own magic carefully.

Once you've determined your goal, you have a variety of tools to help you reach it. One of the most effective is the props you use. Every prop has certain connotations: comical, whimsical, glamorous, exotic, mysterious, threatening, etc. The simplest way to determine those connotations is to ask yourself the question: what kind of person would be likely to employ this prop? (If the answer is no sane person except a magician would ever use it, it's probably best to eliminate it.)

An even more important tool is your words. They can generate (or destroy) atmosphere in two ways. First, the language itself may carry connotations. Are you using technical terms associated with a certain profession or field of study? The other important aspect of words is that they can create imagery through metaphors, descriptions, or allusions. Your words can create pictures in your audience's mind. Make them pictures that produce the atmosphere you want.

The themes you choose for your effects can also contribute strongly to the atmosphere. Many effects can be cloaked in a variety of different themes according to your preference. Themes dealing with ESP, poltergeist, dreams, gambling, etc. are very evocative and can set a certain tone for the entire performance.

Finally, setting is one of the most important elements in creating atmosphere. Unfortunately, as a close-up magician, you'll seldom have much control over the setting in which you're performing. However, through the use of story patter you can evoke whatever setting is most favorable to the atmosphere you want to create. I won't go into detail on this topic since we'll be exploring it later in the discussion on story presentations. For the present, just keep in the back of your mind the realization that you can transport your audience to any setting you wish on the face of this earth (or elsewhere) by means of a good story effect.

Reinforcement

The fairy tale of “The Emperor's New Clothes” is a classic example of suggestion through reinforcement. Although the emperor was naked, each person saw him as splendidly dressed simply because everyone else seemed to. In any group, the perceptions of the others around us will tend to shape our own perceptions. More specifically, their reactions *reinforce* our tendency to see things a certain way.

This is why it's desirable to use audience assistants who are highly expressive, ones who scream, jump, and otherwise display their emotions without inhibition. Their enthusiasm will become infectious and strengthen the reactions of the others. When performing for a small group, it's always easy to spot, during the first couple of tricks, who those highly expressive spectators are. If you use them for subsequent effects involving strong audience participation, their reactions will amplify those of the crowd as a whole.

Another situation in which you'll see the reinforcement phenomenon at work is when two or more spectators who have seen you work on separate occasions get together and discuss your magic. Their enthusiastic descriptions will tend to reinforce each other and you can see the enthusiasm (and unconscious exaggerations) grow as the conversation progresses.

David Roth exploited this phenomenon very shrewdly in the self-levitation effect I mentioned earlier. He would only perform it for one spectator at a time. At a party, he would take one spectator into another room and do the levitation. She would come out and

describe what she'd seen to everyone in glowing terms. Naturally, others would ask to see this miracle also. Eventually, he would reluctantly agree to take someone else into the other room to see him float.

In the course of the evening, he might levitate for five or six people, but always one at a time. As the number of witnesses grew, their descriptions would reinforce each other, becoming more and more inaccurate but more and more wonderful. By the time the last couple of people were led into the other room to see the phenomenon their lever-pitch expectation guaranteed a successful performance. They went in *expecting to see a miracle*, so invariably they did.

Desire

“What we wish, that we readily believe.”

Demosthenes

In the fairy tale of “The Emperor's New Clothes,” the con men tell everyone that only intelligent people can see the new royal garments. Since everyone likes to think of himself as intelligent, everyone now *wants* to see the clothes; doing so will prove just how intelligent they are. This is, in fact, the most important key to effective suggestion. *People tend to see what they want to see and experience what they want to experience.* That's why medical quacks are so successful. Their victims are desperate with desire to believe that there is some miraculous cure, that they won't have to die. That's also why spirit mediums often succeed in fooling their victims with even the crudest methods. These are people who are heartsick with loss. They want to believe their loved ones are not lost to them forever.

We magicians can exploit this factor by selecting magical themes that appeal to people's innermost desires. That will make it that much more likely that they will enter into the illusion. This point should become clearer when we discuss substantive meaning in the next section.

For now, I'll just give you an example of how *not* to do it. One old card effect is known as the “I.Q. Test.” The implication is that if the

spectator fails to follow where the various cards are at any given moment he's mentally deficient. This is hardly a theme likely to make the audience want to be fooled. Imagine if the emperor's tailors had said only stupid people could see the emperor's new clothes. How much chance would the scam have had of working then?

Another way to exploit the desire element in suggestion is to work to establish a strong bond with the audience. The old cliché that if they like you they'll like your magic is a little simple-minded. If they like you, they may just feel that much more embarrassed for you when you perform terrible magic. It is true, however, that if they like you they will *want* to like your magic. They will unconsciously work harder to come under the spell of the illusion.

For example, I find that if I've built up enough prestige and audience rapport, people will simply refuse to believe that I can make a mistake. If something does go wrong, as long as I can come up with any half-way credible “out,” they will cheerfully conclude that it was “all part of the act.”

Planting Suggestions

All of the above elements will help ensure that your suggestions will land on fertile soil. But to get the full benefit of all the “groundwork” you have to plant your suggestions artfully. In a planted suggestion, you *tell* the audience, either directly or indirectly, what to expect. If your prestige, the atmosphere, reinforcement, and their own innate desires have properly softened them up, they will expect what you tell them to. And they will see and experience what they expect to. Let's consider some examples.

In performing Larry Jennings' “The Open Travellers” I found that occasionally people would claim that they had actually seen the ace fall from my empty palm to the table. Since this is exactly the illusion I'm trying to create, I decided to strengthen this notion with a planted suggestion. At one point, I turn my palm up and say, “You can't see the card while it's palmed.” Then I “place” the ace on the table as I say, “But you can see it as it drops out of my hand.” The number of people who report doing so is now much higher because I've created the expectation that, they will see it.

In the floating effect, David Roth would start by asking the spectator to watch his feet closely so that later he could tell David just how far off the ground he had floated. As he said this, David would gesture with his hands held six or seven inches apart. In fact, he would only rise a couple of inches off the ground. But his casual gesture created an expectation on the spectator's part that he would float six or seven inches. Therefore, after the effect he would usually report to David that he had, in fact, risen some half-dozen inches off the ground.

Uri Geller would place a secretly-bent key in someone's hand and warn him that he might feel the key move in his hand as he concentrated. Later, the person would often swear that he'd actually felt the key bending inside his fist.

In many cases, it pays to describe the effect in advance to the audience to help ensure that they see what you intend for them to see. My effect "Jumping Gemini" from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* is a trick done with four cards. At they end, these cards apparently change to four kings. Actually, there are only two kings in the packet: I show them as four kings by means of Brother Hamman's Gemini Count. The Gemini Count in theory contains an element of risk because the same two kings are each shown twice. In my trick, however, experience has shown me that there is not the slightest risk because the illusion is created as much by suggestion as by Hamman's move.

Just before performing the Gemini Count I announce that the four cards are now the four kings. Throughout the effect the audience has seen these four cards repeatedly change in inexplicable ways. Therefore, my prestige on this effect is at a high point when I make that announcement. The audience is ready to believe they're kings even before the first king is revealed. Consequently, during the Gemini Count they see exactly what they expect to see, four different kings, not two kings shown twice. If I simply performed the Gemini Count without first telling people what to expect, the move would be much riskier.

Don't forget, however, that planted suggestions depend for their success on properly developing the other elements of suggestion. For example, atmosphere puts the audience in the proper state of

mind to accept that your planted suggestions might be true. Prestige is particularly important. Since you're the one telling them what to expect, your credibility at that stage determines how much weight your suggestion will carry.

If you want a deeper understanding of the use of suggestion in creating illusion, I suggest you read some books on the history of spiritualism. It's a study that will reward you greatly. Suggestion has probably never been used to greater effect in deception.

Negative Suggestions

Understanding how suggestion works is important, not only so that you can use it to strengthen your magic, but also to ensure you don't unwittingly use it to undermine your magic. Magicians often make off-handed comments that carry suggestions that hurt their magic. The classic example is the performer who says, "I have here an ordinary, unprepared drinking glass." Until he made that comment it had never occurred to anyone in the audience that the glass might be anything other than that or that it might even be possible to prepare a drinking glass in some special way. But the magician's statement has now planted the suggestion in their minds.

I once saw a magician do a series of amazing coin tricks for a young lady. Glowing with admiration, she said, "That must take a tremendous amount of practice." He responded by saying, "Actually, I hardly ever practice any more."

At that moment I saw all the enthusiasm drain out of her face. He didn't seem to notice and went on to do several more tricks. He also did not appear to notice that these tricks produced almost no reaction from the spectator. His casual, ill-conceived comment had carried the suggestion: What I'm doing for you is really trivial. And that's just how she perceived everything he did from then on.

Almost everything you say and do before an audience carries messages beyond the surface text. Make sure those messages are ones that will create the expectations in their mind you want to create.

CHAPTER FOUR: SUBSTANTIVE MEANING

I'm sure you've had the experience countless times of having someone who has just learned that you do magic say to you, "So, you're a magician! Can you make my wife disappear?" And if you're a restaurant magician, you've undoubtedly had the experience even more times of having a patron say to you, "So, you're a magician! Can you make the check disappear?"

These gags get tiresome so quickly that it's easy to ignore them without realizing that, beneath the corny humor, the layperson is telling you something very important. He is saying, "If you're really a magician, why don't you do something useful?" Why so many men seem to feel that making their wives disappear would be a useful thing is a question we'll have to leave to the daytime talk shows. ("Men who want to make their wives disappear on the next *Donahue!*")

What matters is that people tend to immediately react to the knowledge that you're a magician by suggesting, in however hackneyed a manner, that you should do something of practical value with your powers. That's certainly what they would do if they had magical powers. This tells you something very important about how to make your magic strong and memorable. Do things that seem significant and meaningful in terms of your audience's real-world experiences. After all, when was the last time a layperson said to you, "So, you're a magician! Can you put a cigarette through a quarter?"

Magic that has real-world significance I will term "magic with meaning." In this regard I'm following the lead of Henning Nelms who, in his wonderful book *Magic and Showmanship*, first coined both the term and the concept. Let's look at some of the most

effective sources of meaning you can invoke in your magical presentations.

Gambling

This is a source of meaning that I exploit in a great deal of my work. Indeed, anyone who does a lot of card magic will find it difficult to avoid coming to grips with this issue. When laymen see a deck of cards, the first thing that pops into their minds is not ace assemblies and oil-and-water routines. What they naturally think of first is card games since, of course, that's what cards were invented for—a fact that we magicians need to be reminded of from time to time. And the most important (i.e., meaningful) kinds of card games are the ones on which money is wagered. If you want to show an audience something meaningful with a deck of cards you can do no better than to show them how it's possible to win money in card games.

Additionally, opportunities can arise to exploit gambling meaning in effects using props other than cards. “The Three-Shell Game,” the “Endless Chain,” and coin guessing games are a few examples. Some creative thinking might produce other examples. I think this is a very under-explored area in magic.

Today, virtually everyone in our culture gambles in some way. For some, it's all-expenses-paid high roller junkets to Las Vegas; for others it's a couple of bucks on a lottery ticket. It may be penny-appoint gin rummy at the country club, Friday-night poker with the guys, or church bingo with the ladies, but very few people completely resist the lure of gambling. What's more, even those few souls who've never gambled are intrigued by the subject because gambling, and the large sums that can be won or lost at it, is so often played up in the media.

The public's fascination with gambling can be exploited two ways in magic, through gambling routines and through magical effects with a gambling theme. This distinction is one that many magicians fail to grasp but audiences understand instinctively. In a gambling routine you're offering a serious demonstration of how it's possible to win at gambling; the keynote here is a sense of authenticity. One good way to achieve it is to actually do “the real work.” At the same tune, there is nothing wrong with doing a pseudo-demonstration as

long as it possesses a feeling of authenticity. In other words, it doesn't have to be authentic, but it does have to *seem* authentic or the audience will sense they are being conned and react adversely.

What this means is that a gambling routine must have a gambling feel rather than a magic feel. You don't want to pull out a magic wand in order to change your four aces into a royal flush. (I've seen magicians do things almost that ridiculous in gambling routines.) The best way to avoid this problem is to acquire some background knowledge on gambling so your routines will incorporate proper gambling procedure and gambling terminology.

A magic effect with a gambling theme is another matter. Derek Dingle's "Roll-Over Aces" is a good example. No layperson is going to think that this is a demonstration of exactly how cheats operate in a game. Yet, the fact that the trick has a gambling connection through the production of, first, the four aces, then four royal flushes, will give the effect more impact.

Suppose that, at the end of the effect, you were to spread the four packets and, instead of four royal flushes, you were to show four six-card packets running from nine to ace in suit sequence. This would actually be harder than producing the royal flushes. You would have produced twenty-four cards in sequence rather than twenty cards in sequence. Yet the trick would have less impact because the climax would have less meaning. It's the fact that royal flushes are significant in poker that gives the trick's climax power.

When using a gambling theme for a magic effect, the presentation can even be completely tongue-in-cheek and still be effective as long as the audience realizes that you don't expect them to take you too seriously. Irv Weiner's "Soft Dice" is a good example. Irv talks about playing craps in his apartment and having the downstairs neighbors complain of the noise of the dice rolling across the floor. He then shows the audience the solution he came up with: dice made of sponge rubber. He now launches into a spongeball routine with these "dice" in which each magical effect somehow relates to his misadventures as a craps shooter.

No one in the audience seriously thinks Irv or anyone else has ever wagered major sums of money on spotted cubes of sponge.

Nevertheless, the presentation gives the effect a meaning missing from most spongeball routines. There is now a point to everything that happens; the audience can relate what's happening to their own experiences.

Let's return to the matter of actual gambling routines. I could write a book just on how to properly present this kind of material. (I won't; I don't intend to create professional competition for myself.) However, I've seen so many magicians make really fundamental errors in this area that I think a couple of basic observations are in order.

First, although I've spoken of the need for the performer to have background knowledge, it's important to remember that not all audience members possess a great deal of knowledge about gambling. One key to success in this kind of work is to structure your routines so that they'll captivate knowledgeable gamblers, yet still be easy to understand even for complete non-gamblers. They should not require any technical knowledge on the audience's part.

Even people who've never played cards in their lives know that four aces or a royal flush are good poker hands. Stick to those kinds of hands. If you're going to demonstrate cheating at bridge, don't deal yourself a perfect no-trump hand. Only a bridge player will know that's a good hand. Deal yourself all thirteen spades in numerical order. Even a non-card player will instinctively appreciate that this is an awesome achievement, while the bridge players will still be bowled over.

If a routine does require some background knowledge on the audience's part, be sure you provide that information in your patter. When you come up with a routine that is equally riveting to a group of nuns or a group of Las Vegas pitbosses you know you've got a winner. (See the Card Table Artifice section of *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* for some good examples.)

Second, always remember that the great strength of a gambling routine is that it's relevant to the audience's experience. Don't do anything that distances the presentation from their experience. The classic example of this mistake is the magician who decides to present a gambling act and immediately runs out to buy a

Mississippi riverboat gambler outfit. All that a period costume will accomplish is to tell your audience that they shouldn't take you or what you're doing seriously. It's all just make-believe.

The spectators know that they've never played cards with anyone dressed in a bowler hat, string tie, and garters on his sleeves; therefore, what you're going to show them has nothing to do with their lives. They know that people don't dress that way in the real world today. Therefore, what you're going to show them must not have anything to do with the real world today. If you're thinking of wearing period costume for a gambling act, save your money and just hang a sign around your neck saying, "Don't take me seriously."

Third, the better you understand the psychology of gambling routines, the better you'll be able to sell them. Gambling routines are unique in that they exploit the audience's fears and their wishful fantasies at the same time. The spectator will think, "My God, imagine if I ever found myself sitting across the table from someone like him in a game. I'd never know what hit me." At the same time, he'll be thinking, "If only I could do the things he can. I'd be on the next plane to Las Vegas. My money worries would be over. And wouldn't it be great to teach a lesson to that loudmouthed buddy of mine who always gloats whenever he beats me at poker!" The better you understand this dual psychology, the better you can exploit it in your presentations.

Finally, for the same reason, you should understand that there is a deep-seated mystical, as well as financial, appeal to gambling routines. In *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I expressed the concept in these terms: "Ever since they were first invented, cards and dice have been used for divination since it was felt that only the powers of the supernatural could influence the turn of a card or the roll of a die. To control a game of chance is akin to controlling fate. Consider the implications of the term 'wheel of fortune.' To the public, any mortal who can do these things must be quite special."

I know that some magicians object to displays of skill of the kind involved in gambling routines because they feel they detract from a sense of magic. This is, of course, an issue every performer must decide for himself. However, if you really understand the point I've made in the previous paragraph, you can appreciate that, in the

public's mind, the “cardshark” is the closest thing today to the true magician of olden times: a man with the power to control the forces of fate, chance, and nature for his own practical gain.

Grifting

Since this area is closely related to the one we've just covered I'll only discuss it briefly. It is, however, worth realizing that some of the appeals we've just discussed can be exploited in non-gambling contexts. Grifting is the underworld term for crimes that rely on skill and cleverness rather than force. These include con games, Shortchanging, pickpocketing, shoplifting, forgery and check kiting, pool hustling, and running crooked carnival games, as well as crooked gambling.

While no one approves of crime, most people save their real disapproval for violent crimes. They tend to have a grudging admiration for criminals who beat the system through their wits. This explains the popularity over the years of fictional characters like Arsene Lupin, A.J. Raffles. Boston Blackie, The Lone Wolf, John “The Cat” Robie (played by Cary Grant in Hitchcock's *To Catch a Thief*), and T.H.E. Cat and the appeal of “caper” movies in which the audience is encouraged to identify with the criminals.

Furthermore, everyone has a fascination with anything that is secret. And the techniques of the various forms of grifting are a complete secret to members of “square” society. That's why they'll jump at the opportunity to learn about, these subjects in a non- threatening environment.

This is an underexplored area just waiting for some imaginative magicians to develop. There are some routines in print that point the way. Dai Vernon, George Starke, Bert Allerton, and Ray Grismer have all had excellent shortchanging routines in print. In volume one of *The Collected Works of Alex Elmsley*, he has a signature transfer card effect built around a presentation about the techniques of forgers.

In *Pasteboard Presentations*, Terry LaGerould has an effect in which a thought-of card vanishes from a packet of cards. There doesn't seem anything special about that until you learn that the

packet of cards is in the spectator's wallet inside his pocket at the time the vanish occurs. This, of course, allows for a presentation on a pickpocketing theme. LaGerould's idea has a lot of potential. In fact, I've already devised a very strong effect of my own inspired by LaGerould's which will appear in *Cardshark* under the title "Pickup on South Street."

Meanwhile, here is another application. What about doing a traditional "Cards Across" effect but instead of placing the two packets of cards into envelopes held by spectators, you insert them into the two spectators' wallets which they then pocket? Needless to say, the mechanics could be identical; yet the effect could be made far more meaningful by incorporating a pickpocket theme in the presentation.

The point about the importance of background knowledge I made earlier is just as valid here as in gambling routines. Indeed, you'll find that your knowledge of the subject in question will fascinate people almost as much as the effect itself. Any effect along these lines is likely to spur questions and comments from the spectators that will quickly reveal any ignorance on your part.

The interesting thing is that people can usually tell whether you know what you're talking about even if they don't know anything about the subject themselves. In *Magic and Showmanship*, Henning Nelms wisely observes that, "Esoteric knowledge always impresses people." However, he goes on to make the even more important observation that, "This sort, of knowledge cannot be faked."

The point about an atmosphere of authenticity also applies as much here as to gambling routines. Remember, it doesn't necessarily have to be real, but it must seem real unless the presentation is clearly intended as tongue in cheek. The idea is to capture the audience's imagination, not insult their intelligence.

ESP

Mentalism is the most successful branch of professional magic, yet the most maligned branch of magic among amateurs. This says something about the nature of magic and even more about the

nature of amateurs. Mentalism is so powerful because it's the most meaningful form of magic for laypeople. This is so for two reasons: because it deals with such a potent subject, our innermost thoughts, and because it's the one form of magic that may actually be real (from a layman's perspective). Any kind of magic that is real must by definition be more meaningful than any kind of magic that's only make-believe.

This latter point helps explain why so many magicians find mentalism boring. Mentalism is boring as trickery, but fascinating as authentic phenomena. A good example is Uri Geller's signature effect of bending a key. As a magic trick, it's silly, pointless, and far less amazing than many other effects one might do instead. However, as evidence of some hitherto unsuspected faculty of the human mind, it's endlessly fascinating.

This means that a mentalist's success with his audience is largely determined by how good he is at convincing them he really is psychic or, at the very least, making them entertain the possibility. (Forget about disclaimers. Every mentalist who uses one hopes the audience won't understand it or will just ignore it.) This means that his success with an audience of magicians will always be zero since, no matter how amazing his effects, he has no chance of ever convincing them that they're witnessing real psychic phenomena.

This is why the few mentalists who go over well at magic conventions are often the ones who would enjoy the least success with the general public. Magicians like those mentalists who cut the B.S. (i.e., trying to convince you they are really psychic) and get on with the effect. For a lay audience, this would translate as failing to develop the meaning and concentrating instead on the puzzle.

Because the meaning of mentalism is so strong when the performer is good at inspiring true belief, it overshadows all other considerations of showmanship. Magicians love to complain about what lousy showmen Geller and Kreskin are. What they mean by this is that they don't indulge in corny puns or insult humor and lack the Urbanity and suaveness they imagine is necessary for a polished Performer. Actually, both these men are masters of a deeper kind of showmanship most magicians don't even suspect exists.

I stress all this because it's important for you to understand even if you plan to perform just one or two mental effects. You must keep in mind two paramount points. Number one, aim to inspire belief. You must perform each effect with sincerity rather than a let's-pretend-I'm-psyhic attitude.

Number two, you must remember that every mental effect you do, whatever its text, exists first and foremost to sell the subtext that you can manipulate thoughts. Mentalism is not—or at least, should not be—about slips of paper, slates, colored poker chips, or playing cards. True mentalism is about thoughts—your audience's thoughts. Keep the focus there and just use the props as a means to that end.

The Occult

People are fascinated by the occult. It keeps cropping up in now guises—the latest is the “New Age”—but its appeal is timeless and immune to technological advances.

A comparison of theatrical magic and occult magic shows exactly why so much theatrical magic fails to move audiences and also how occult themes can strengthen theatrical magic. Occult magic doesn't concern itself with changing red handkerchiefs into green handkerchiefs or making one steel ring penetrate another. It deals with healing and hurting, winning love, gaining wealth, and exerting power over other people, the kinds of things that people really care about—the kinds of things we magicians would be dealing with if we could really do magic.

Well, we can't really do magic. But we can cloak our magic with themes that invoke the emotion-drenched concerns of occult magic. Even linking two steel rings together can become very moving if it seems somehow to imply that the performer is dealing with occult powers that he could, if he chose, turn to more sinister purposes.

Considering the obvious connection between occult magic and theatrical magic—one evolved from the other—it's surprising how little occult themes have been exploited in magic until recently. In the last few years this has changed some, primarily through the influence of *The New Invocation*, a magazine devoted to occult-theme magic, and its chief contributors. However, as others have

observed, “bizarre magic,” as its advocates call it, is a field of magic that is written about far more than it's performed.

One reason for this is that most published bizarre magic effects have presentations that require a type of persona that few amateur magicians can sustain. Your friends know that you're not a warlock who has sold his soul to Satan or studied occult doctrine for decades in some remote monastery in the Carpathians.

Yet, with some thought it is possible to find occult presentations credible for the average performer. The occult can touch anyone's life. How might it have touched yours? Did you happen on an unusual amulet in an antique shop or inherit a strange occult book from a dead uncle? Did you decide on a whim to enter an occult book store or research some esoteric subject and end up learning more than you'd bargained for? Give it some thought and you may find a number of ways you can exploit this rich presentational field in one of more effects.

I'm sure I don't have to point out that the same concerns of apparent authenticity, background knowledge, and sincerity in presentation that I've stressed before are just as important in occult effects. So I won't.

Magic

Believe it or not, most people have a certain curiosity about magic. I don't mean that they want to become magicians, but rather that, given the opportunity, they'd like to learn a little more about the subject. This is because magic has one thing in common with some of the other subjects we've discussed so far. Like crooked gambling, grifting, and the occult, it is a secret art. And anything that is secret holds a certain fascination for people.

Most people have never been close enough to a magician to ask him questions that may be on their minds. You know the ones, the questions you get all the time from laypeople: How did you first get interested in magic? How did you learn to be a magician? How much do you have to practice? Furthermore, even spectators who've never had any curiosity about magic or magicians before will find themselves intrigued with the subject after you've astonished them

with a couple of really strong tricks.

It has always surprised me that more magicians don't take advantage of this natural audience curiosity about what they do for a living or as a hobby to build presentations around. Generally, people are interested in how the tricks are done, how you learn to do them, and how you magic guys interact generally. Here are some examples from the repertoires of top magicians that exploit this strong source of meaning.

Michael Skinner explains to his audience that magicians often get together at conventions and also in private groups called “sessions.” At these sessions, they perform, tricks for each other. But these tricks are a little different from the ones they do for the general public. They tend to be more challenging, more difficult to perform, and more difficult to figure out. They're specially designed by magicians to baffle their fellow magicians. Michael then offers to perform one of his favorite “session” tricks. You can be sure his audience's curiosity and interest is at a high pitch by the time he starts the trick. If you're wondering what trick Michael performs, you're imaging the point. You can perform any effect you want after that introduction, as long as it's one that's impressive enough to live up to the buildup.

Arturo de Ascanio tells people about the time, many years ago, when he first, auditioned for membership in the Madrid Magic Circle. He had to prepare a trick for performance before the membership committee. With so much riding on one trick, he worked very hard to perfect it. It's still one of his favorites, and he would like to perform it for them now. You can be sure that when he goes on to perform one of his beautiful ace assemblies, the audience is particularly appreciative.

Each of these presentations makes the audience feel privileged to be allowed to witness the effect being presented. As long as they don't find out how easy it really is to get accepted into most magic clubs or how bad most of the magic performed at sessions is, these presentations will continue to work. Yes, they do present a romanticized view of the magic world but, after all, our job is to provide the public with illusions.

These presentations also exploit the audience's curiosity about the hidden world of the magician. On one of his videotapes, Eugene Burger exploits this curiosity by presenting an effect that he calls his “warm-up ritual.” This, he explains, is the exercise he performs in private to prepare for each performance. Once again, this introduction exploits the mystique of magic to make the effect seem something special, significant, more than just a card trick.

Since people are always interested in how you first got into magic, a presentation about the first magic trick you ever learned would be effective. Al Koran made the “Torn and Restored Cigarette Paper” into a special effect by describing it as the first magic trick he ever saw, the one that led to his career choice.

Magicians often use presentations in which they offer to teach the audience how a trick is done. In theory, such presentations have the kind of meaning we're talking about here. In practice, the audience usually realizes from the outset that it's all a put on. A more credible approach would be to offer to demonstrate some psychological secret of magic such as suggestion or misdirection. For example, after briefly explaining the principle of misdirection, you might place a card aside and explain that sometime in the course of the trick you will switch it for a different card. But if you do it correctly, no one will see it happen because you will cover it with misdirection. This presentation would work well for Brother Hamman's “The Signed Card,” for example.

It is true that magicians sometimes do tricks that are nominally based on the themes I've suggested. But they are usually so blatantly phony they carry no conviction and therefore arouse no audience interest. There is all the difference in the world between Ascanio's sincere presentation of his “audition trick,” Mike Skinner revealing his favorite “session trick”, or Eugene Burger demonstrating his “warm-up ritual” on the one hand and some magic bozo prattling on about the “rules of the magicians' union” on the other hand. Similarly, there is no comparison between presenting an effect as a seemingly serious demonstration of the role of misdirection in magic and a magician telling the audience that the secret to his tricks is that he has a trapdoor in his hand.

The difference in each case is, to borrow a phrase from Eugene

Burger, sincerity of purpose. That's not to say that the things you tell the audience must be true, only that they should seem to be true, at least within the dramatic reality you create. As a magician, you should take seriously the old gag that the secret to success is sincerity; once you learn to fake that, you've got it made.

Money

In one of Bob Nelson's books on psychic readings he states that people's three main concerns in life are money, sex, and health. You can find support for Nelson's claim in any copy of *Reader's Digest*, the most popular magazine in the world. Every issue I've ever seen contained at least one article on each of those three subjects.

In fact, each of those subjects also has several magazines devoted entirely to it. One of those magazines is called *Money*. It should also come as no surprise that “money” appears in Barbara Leeds' book *Power Speak* in her list of “the twelve most persuasive words in the English language.” In our culture few subjects have a more firm and Universal hold on the public consciousness.

Money has such a deep attraction that performing “Card Warp” with a hundred dollar bill, floating a dollar bill, or using crumpled bills for an impromptu Cups and Balls routine will attract greater initial audience attention than using other props for the same effect. These effects actually have nothing to do with money, but the use of money will tend to draw the eyes of the spectators in the same way that a bikini-clad girl will draw the eyes of most men to a billboard advertisement.

However, to achieve real moaning for an effect from money, it must be used as the theme of the effect, not just as a prop. The trick must not only use money, it must be *about* money. People have only two concerns when it comes to money, getting more money and holding on to the money they already have. These are the only themes that will have meaning for them in a money trick.

If you perform the “Hundred Dollar Bill Switch” by borrowing a one-dollar bill and changing it into a hundred, the effect will have strong meaning because you will have achieved every spectator's dream, making his money grow. If you perform the same trick by

borrowing a one-hundred dollar bill, changing it to a single, and then returning it to the spectator, it will have strong meaning because of the humor of the spectator having failed in the goal of holding on to his money. Torn and Restored Bill tricks also have strong meaning for the latter reason. Indeed, this effect provides a dramatic example of the power of meaning in magic. The larger the denomination of the bill you borrow, the more impact the effect will have, even though the magic remains the same.

Pseudo-demonstrations of shortchanging exploit monetary meaning from both ends: the hustler's ability to gain money and the victim's inability to hold on to it. Depending on your performing persona, you may choose to present such an effect by identifying yourself with the shortchange artist or with the victim. (Either approach can be highly effective, but they carry two different messages about the performer.) In John Carney's book *Carney Knowledge* he has a wonderful effect called "The Logical Bill Trick." The performer takes a dollar bill, folds it over, and produces a half dollar from the folds. He repeats this to produce a second coin. Finally, he folds the bill into a small packet and a third half dollar slides out of the packet. What makes the effect great is the kicker. When the dollar bill is unfolded it is seen to have changed to a twenty-dollar bill. This is what gives it strong meaning.

It seems to me this could also be extremely effective worked in reverse. Borrow a twenty-dollar bill from a spectator. Proceed to produce the three half dollars, dropping each in his hand. Comment that since the coins came from his bill they belong to him. He may object to keeping them, but you insist that they are now his. Return the folded bill along with the halves and proceed to your next effect. This may, for example, involve asking another spectator to select a card; in any case, you completely turn your attention away from the spectator who lent you the bill.

When the spectator unfolds the bill to return it to his wallet he discovers that it is now a one-dollar bill. He will attempt to bring this to your attention, but you try to ignore him and continue with your next trick. Undoubtedly, he won't be easily dissuaded. This should make for a very humorous situation for the rest of the audience; milk it for all it's worth. Finally, take the dollar bill back

from the spectator and change it to a twenty by means of the “Hundred Dollar Bill Switch.” (You already had your thumbtip loaded with another twenty.) Offer to trade the twenty for the spectator's three half dollars. Naturally, he will accept the offer and thereby bring the effect full circle.

The trick will be even stronger if you can borrow a one- hundred dollar bill from a spectator, but you won't always be able to get it. If you want to try for the hundred, have two thumbtips loaded, one with a hundred and one with a twenty. If you can't get someone to lend you a hundred dollar bill, settle for a twenty. Just don't get your thumbtips confused.

Keep in mind that *most magic with substantive meaning is essentially wish-fulfillment magic*. People wish to make money appear, not disappear. This is why Himber's “Polaroid Money” trick, or any effect in which the performer appears to be able to print money, is a natural.

One of the most effective of all close-up tricks with money is Pat Page's effect in which blank pieces of paper change into dollar bills. I once saw a magician perform this effect in reverse. He started with dollar bills and changed them to blank paper. Although his patter made this approach logical it could never be as emotionally powerful as the original approach. The ability to change ordinary paper into money is a very desirable talent: the ability to change money into worthless paper isn't a highly marketable skill.

When I talk about money magic having strong meaning I'm speaking strictly of tricks with paper currency, not coin effects. The appeal of money is often cited as one of the advantages of coin magic, but I think this is misguided. The problem is inflation. Coins today simply don't have enough buying power for coin tricks to have the kind of meaning we're discussing here. Even street beggars will look at you contemptuously if you only offer them a couple of quarters or a half-dollar.

Undoubtedly, in T. Nelson Downs' day it was different. When he plucked coins out of the air, he was realizing not only “The Miser's Dream” but the dream of every person in his audience. Today, pulling coins out of the ether is not a cost-efficient way of spending

your time. Any skilled professional can earn more on an hourly basis by plying his trade than by walking around with a pail in one hand while combing the aerial mint with the other. However, there are a couple of stage manipulators who have kept up with the times by employing sleights normally used in card manipulation to apparently pluck paper money out of the air.

None of this is meant to suggest that coin magic is not capable of being very strong. I only want to stress that if a coin trick is to have strong meaning it's going to have to come from something other than the mere fact that coins are used.

Sex

Remember the other two items on Bob Nelson's list of universal concerns? Health and sex. I don't think that health has much potential as a theme for magical presentations (although some creative performer may prove me wrong). However, sex does have such potential if carefully approached.

Sex in magical presentations (and in most other contexts) is like atomic energy. It has great potential for good, but if you're not careful it'll blow up in your face. Utilizing the tremendous appeal and meaning of sex in a presentation without offending or alienating people takes a great deal of judgment and cleverness, but it can be done.

The dangers to avoid in using sex in a presentation are any hint of vulgarity, overfamiliarity with the audience, sexism, and placing people in embarrassing situations. Such presentations also virtually demand the use of humor to defuse the explosive potential of the subject. It's also a good rule generally to use even the most innocuous sexual presentations only with audiences in your own general age group. If the audience is much younger, they're more likely to be embarrassed; if they're much older, you may appear disrespectful.

Knowing your audience is also critical. Bob Sheets has proven in countless performances that the much reviled "Bra Trick" can be a killer for a singles bar crowd. In Bob's presentation, he drops any pretense about silks traveling from place to place. Instead, he

presents the effect as a test of how “hot” the female subject is. In other words, he makes the trick explicitly about sex. For a group of people who already have sex on their minds anyway, it's very effective.

Part of the key to Bob's success with this trick is that he has—I'm sure he'll forgive me for saying this—a totally sexually non-threatening persona as a performer. In the hands of someone else, it could be every bit as offensive as the “Bra Trick” usually is.

Exploiting sex in magical presentations most definitely is not for everyone. And it most definitely is not for every situation. If you have any doubts in your mind, forget I ever brought the matter up and concentrate on the many other strong sources of substantive meaning in this section.

Me

Do you know what all people consider to be the single most important and interesting subject in the world? Themselves. It's the one subject no one ever tires of. Why not make your magic more fascinating by tying it in with the spectator's own fascination with himself? There are a great many ways to do this. Here are some of the most effective and adaptable.

Readings: The power “psychic” or psychological readings have over people's imaginations was forcefully brought home to me for the first time by an experience I had in college. At the time I was working part-time in the New York Public Library. I was interested in getting to know better a certain attractive co-worker. One day while we were talking, I spotted on her desk a note she'd written. To impress her, I picked it up and proceeded to analyze her handwriting. I simply made the whole thing up as I went along. Fortunately, I had once read a book on graphology; this gave me enough background information to make everything sound plausible.

I never did get a date with the girl. She was so impressed by the character reading, however, that she mentioned it to all the other employees. During the next week, every single person who worked in that library came up to me and asked me to analyze their

handwriting. Each of them left deeply impressed by the result.

Here's the amazing thing. These were people with whom I'd been working for months. Under the guise of interpreting their handwriting, I simply described their characters as I had come to know them through our association. Yet, if I had simply said, "After observing you for months, I would say you're the kind of person who, . . ." no one would have cared about my opinion. But, because my observations were supposedly based on abstruse deductions from their handwriting, they hung on every word. Each observation took on a special significance. So captivated were they by the notion that their handwriting was providing a key to their souls that they completely overlooked the obvious fact that I was just describing people whom I knew as I knew them to be.

Because there are so many different props used by psychics and students of the occult to pick up people's "vibrations" or foretell the future, the opportunities for incorporating readings into magic effects are extensive. Playing cards are a natural for any such presentations since cards are associated with fortune telling in most people's minds.

Consider this presentation I've used with success for an "Ultra-Mental Deck" prediction. You hand a deck of cards to a young lady. While she is holding it, you ask her to name any card that comes into her mind. She names, for example, the two of hearts.

Explaining that in fortune telling each playing card has a special meaning, you discuss the kind of person who would be drawn to the two of hearts. Based on the symbolism of that card, you provide the young lady with a brief character reading, and conclude with a prediction of an event she can expect in the near future.

Finally, you explain that when you arose this morning you had a strong impression that you would meet just such a person today. To prove your claim, you retrieve the deck of cards she's been holding remove it from the box, and spread the cards between your hands. There is one card reversed in the deck. It proves to be the two of hearts.

Notice how this presentation expands the meaning of the effect. The trick is no longer about cards; it's about the spectator. The only

importance of the cards is that they serve to reveal insights about the spectator, and also to confirm your visionary powers in foreseeing that you would meet such a person. The two phenomena strengthen each other. The accuracy of the reading seems to prove that the card prediction was more than just a trick; the success of the card prediction seems to prove that the reading was more than just smooth-sounding baloney. (I wish I'd worked this presentation out while I was still working at the library; I might not have struck out with that girl.)

Another popular form of character reading is numerology. Certainly there are many close-up effects that involve numbers. To provide just one example, let's take another card effect, Larry Jennings' "Stabbed Coincidence" or Allan Ackerman's "Quick Coincidence." With my presentation, it would appear this way.

You spread through the deck looking for a card you feel would properly symbolize the spectator based on the vibrations you're receiving from her. You place this card aside without showing it. The spectator then selects a card and inserts it face down in the middle of the deck so it's protruding about half-way. You turn this card face up so all can see that it is, for example, a six.

You suggest that it's important that the spectator was attracted to a six. You then proceed to give the spectator a brief reading based on the numerological significance of the number six. Next, you turn over the card you had set aside earlier to symbolize the spectator, and it proves to be another six. Lest the spectator think that her choice of the number six was a mere coincidence, you conclude by showing that the spectator inserted her six in the deck between the other two sixes.

As in the previous example, you've shifted the focus of the effect from the cards to the person for whom the card effect is being performed. Yet the effect is not diminished but enhanced. Instead of a puzzling but meaningless coincidence, we now have a coincidence with cosmic significance—one that suggests that there is some hidden harmony at work beneath the surface of things that guides our destiny. A card trick with implications like that is one people will remember.

A particularly creative application of cold reading to magic can be found in Lee Earle's published effect "Aura Cards." I won't bother to detail Earle's effect but rather focus on the principle it embodies, which is the more important point. There are many effects in close-up magic where the performer either divines or predicts the color of a poker chip, colored card, or other trinket chosen by a spectator. Typically, such effects are the epitome of meaningless puzzles. ("I don't know how the performer knew which one I chose, but why should I really care?") Earle's idea is to present such an effect in the context of an aura reading.

Most people today are generally familiar with the occult theory that all living things are surrounded by a multi-colored aura that is invisible to all but the psychically gifted. Kirlian photography has revived this old doctrine. Mystics believe that the colors in a person's aura provide insights into his character and mental and physical states. Using this as background, you can give the spectator a brief cold reading supposedly based on his affinity for the particular color he chose. Now, it seems to really matter which poker chip the spectator selected.

Not only cards, numbers, and colors, but also symbols, birth dates, tarot cards, handwriting, names (through numerology), ink blots, and even doodles may be used for such effects. Many years ago, Howard Albright published a great presentation for Annemann's "Pseudo Psychometry" using doodles. This was later used by Al Koran, a man who really knew what constitutes strong magic, so you know the idea is good.

Indeed, "Pseudo Psychometry" is such a great effect in all its variations—Bill Larsen, Sr. once called it the greatest effect in magic—precisely because the subject of the effect is the audience itself. You could hardly find a subject more certain to hold their undivided attention. T.A. Waters has made the very important point, however, that some performers seem to think that the effect of "Pseudo Psychometry" is simply to match objects and spectators. Of course, the important effect is the analysis of the spectator's character. Your ability to match the spectator and the object only serves to validate your claim of picking up vibrations from the object and thereby prove that there really is something to this

psychometry business.

Mention of psychometry brings to mind the fact that literally any small object may be used as the focus for a reading if it belongs to a spectator. Basil Horwitz has published a card effect that he ties in with psychometry. After the spectator has selected a card and it's been lost in the deck, the performer spreads the deck on the table. He then borrows some personal possession of the spectator. Holding this in his fist, he runs his hand back and forth along the spread. Eventually he stops at one card. This proves to be the selected card. Apparently, the spectator's personal vibrations radiating from his possession have led the performer to the one card that has similar vibrations still clinging to it.

This presentation could be further enhanced if the performer gave the spectator a brief cold reading from the psychometrized object before locating the card. Once again, the divination of the card would seem to indicate that there was more to the reading than just hokum.

Points to Keep in Mind: A little imagination and a bit of occult research should suggest many other ideas for incorporating readings into your close-up. Notice, however, that each example I gave involved a prediction, divination, or coincidence effect. The presentation should always fit the effect. A *presentation* with occult overtones should only be used for an *effect* with occult overtones. Generally, predictions, divinations, and coincidence effects are the ones that fit this description. To do a reading based on a spectator's selected card, then conclude by pulling the card out of your shoe would be a little jarring.

Note that I'm concerned here with the use of cold reading to help magicians, not with the use of magic to help cold readers. That's why in each example I've kept the focus on the magic. For instance, in each case I've suggested giving the reading before you reach the climax of the effect. To do the reading after the magic happens would be anti-climactic and would waste the opportunity of using the reading to build anticipation for, and appreciation of, the magic. Basic dramatic theory dictates that the most important thing should always happen last; for us, this means the magic happens last. Also, I've recommended *brief* readings because, since the point is the

magic, you don't want the tail wagging the dog.

Keep in mind that a reading will be most fascinating to the person receiving it. Therefore, if performing for a group, it's particularly important to keep an individual reading short. If performing for just one person, you can allow the reading to run longer if you wish as long as you can see that the person is interested in hearing more.

The literature of cold reading has grown tremendously in the last few of years, so you should have no trouble finding strong material from which to compose brief readings. Two particularly good sources of readings that are short but powerful are “Tarot Telepathy” and “Lecture for Annemann's Pseudo Psychometry,” both found in *The Mental Mysteries and Other Writings of William W. Larsen, Sr.*

Names and Signatures: There is nothing so sweet to our ears as our own names. Conjuring with a person's name always adds interest to an effect. There are many tricks where the performer locates a selected card by spelling to it. Some shrewd performers instead locate a selected card by spelling the name of the person who chose the card.

A fine example of using a person's name to add meaning to an effect is Ed Marlo's trick “Female.” A deck of cards is spread face up and a woman is asked to name any card. The one she designates is placed aside face up. The deck is then turned face down to show that each card has a different first name written on the back: Joe, Bill, Steve, etc.

The performer points out that each of these is a man's name. “Since one particular card was designated by the spectator, a woman, wouldn't it be amazing if that one card bore a woman's name on it?” the performer asks. When the card is turned face down, not only does it have a woman's name written on it, it has the *spectator's* name written on it.

If conjuring with a person's name is potent, even more potent is conjuring with the most personal embodiment of that name, his signature. Consider the significance of one's signature in our culture. Signatures are the way business people approve decisions. It's the way we authorize transfers of personal funds, the way we grant

others the legal power to act in our behalf, the way we attest to the truth of written statements, the way we pledge our commitment to legal contracts, the way we validate wills, the way we authenticate documents, the way we close correspondence, and one of the ways in which we prove our identity to others. A signature has almost sacred implications. If you want to sell your soul to the devil, what do you have to do? Sign on the dotted line! And once you've signed there is no turning back.

Graphologists will also tell you that our signatures represent abstract self-portraits. Nothing could be more symbolic of our individual identities; nothing could be more unique to ourselves. Two different people may have the same name, but they won't have the same signature.

To show someone that you can conjure with his signature is not only impressive, it's a little unsettling. It brings to mind the primitive's fear of having his soul stolen in a mirror or photograph.

I first came to appreciate the power of conjuring with a person's signature when I began performing "The Dream Card," an effect from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. In it, I begin by mentioning a dream I had the previous night, in which the spectator (whom, I've never met before) figured. I mention that a playing card played an important role in the dream. This led me to remove that particular card from an old deck and place it in my wallet. As I speak, I show the card to be red-backed, but do not reveal its face. The dream card is replaced in the wallet and the wallet replaced in my pocket.

The spectator then selects a card from a blue deck and signs it on the face. Let's assume it's the four of hearts. After this card is returned to the deck, I again remove the red-backed dream card from my wallet. Not only does it prove to be the four of hearts, it bears the spectator's signature on its face.

This trick has an uncanny effect on an audience, one unlike any other I've ever performed. The important point to note for our purposes is how the spectator becomes not only an assistant in the effect, but the very subject of the effect. This fact is underscored at the very outset when I explain that the reason I chose her to help me is that I recognized her from my dream.

Remember, people are more interested in people than in anything else; this guarantees that they will pay close attention to this effect. The spectator is more interested in herself than in anything else; this guarantees that she will pay rapt attention to this effect. People place special significance in signatures; this guarantees they won't soon forget the climax of this effect.

The potential for powerful magic in the realm of signatures is still underexplored. Another strong effect of this kind will appear in my book *Cardshark* under the title "Signature Effect" in which a spectator's signature is transferred from one card to another. At a final illustration of the possibilities, I'll briefly describe another signature transfer effect I've devised, an unpublished effect which is based on a great idea from the David Williamson book, *Williamson's Wonders*.

I begin by removing the joker from the deck and placing it in my pocket. The spectator then selects a card and signs it on the back. I now visibly peel the spectator's signature off the card, the ink coming off in a ribbon. I knead this ribbon into a small ball and drop it in my pocket, the one that contains the joker. After patting my pocket a couple of times to flatten out signature, I remove the joker. There on the back of the joker is the spectator's signature.

Imagine if you really could transfer people's signatures from one place to another. The power this would give you would be enormous, the potential for creating mischief truly awesome. No one would be safe. The implications are frightening.

Then have also been a number of effects published in which the signatures on the backs of two playing cards transpose. These are all good example of card effects that become far more than just card effects because they deal with *people* as well as pasteboards.

Finally, it should be noted that conjuring with signatures can also be tied in with the concept of character reading discussed before. I've already commented on the fascination handwriting analysis holds for people. An effect that requires a spectator to sign a card could begin with the performer giving the spectator a brief cold reading based on his analysis of that signature. I don't recommend using this idea indiscriminately. It would be a little out of place in a

standard Carlo to Wallet effect, for example. However, if such an interlude is in keeping with the mood and theme of the effect, it could considerably enhance the presentation.

Other Ideas: There are many other effects and presentations that score strongly because they make the spectator the focus of the trick. In Paul Curry's "Lie Detective" you locate a selected card by unerringly detecting when a spectator is lying by his tone of voice.

In Al Baker's "Eyes of a Poker Player" you locate a selected card while toasting the spectator's ability to maintain a poker face. In each case, the subject matter is not the cards but the person; the cards merely act as the medium for the test.

"Out of The World" has such strong meaning because it deals, not merely with ESP, but with the *spectator's* ESP. There are many other fine mental effects that also purport to test the spectator's psychic powers. Furthermore, many psychic effects can easily be reworked to make the spectator's powers the central issue rather than the performer's. The Eddie Fields biography *A Life Among Secrets* contains an amusing anecdote about how Field took several standard prediction effects and twisted them around to convince a friend that he was reading Fields' mind.

Mental effects such as billet reading and question answering in which the performer evidences a knowledge of intimate details of a person's private life draw their meaning almost as much from this "me" angle as from the ESP angle. I once saw a mentalist do a billet test in which a woman wrote the name Herman on the slip of paper. When the mentalist said to her, "Who is Herman?" she started shaking as she explained that Herman was her late husband's name.

I asked myself the question how did he know what was written on the billet? However, it was obvious from the audience's astonished reaction that they were asking themselves the question: how could he know that her late husband was named Herman? Of course, he didn't. He had no idea who Herman was until she told him. But to the audience the effect was not about knowing what was written on a piece of paper. It was about knowing an emotion- charged secret about this woman's past life.

Don't think that because this sort of thing involves only one

spectator that the rest of the audience will feel left out. They will identify with that spectator as their representative. Furthermore, they will also be fascinated by that spectator's reactions. Remember, people care about people more than anything else.

Universal Experience

Universal experience is a unique source of meaning for magic. Unlike the previous examples, it derives its power not from the fact that it deals with something important but from the fact that it deals with something which may be trivial but with which everyone can identify. Comedian George Carlin has defined the concept as, "Little universal moments that we share separately, the things that make us the same."

The concept is one very frequently used in comedy. Consider the example of *Snigglets* and *More Snigglets*, two very popular humor books by comedian Rich Hall. The premise for these books is to provide the English language with words that don't already exist but for which there is a crying need. For example, "Cinomuck: the sticky substance that invariably coats the floors of movie theaters." Or "lactomangulation: bending the spout on a milk container so badly out of shape that it is no longer usable."

I don't know whether you find theme definitions funny, but I do and so do many other people judging from the sales figures for these books. But, the question arises, why are they funny? Each of these definitions focuses attention on some widespread foible or common irritation of everyday life. Their humor stems from the shock of recognition, the amusement, and sometimes relief, that comes of realizing that everybody else has the same experiences.

For example, when I read the definition of flugging ("The dangerous practice of using your fingers to guide an electric plug into the socket when plugging in something in the dark"), I was relieved to discover that I wasn't the only one with this dumb habit. The appeal to universal experience also explains the popularity of the Andy Rooney segments on the TV show *Sixty Minutes* and the writings of columnist Erma Bombeck.

Many comedians get a good laugh by doing nothing more than

pointing to a puzzling universal experience. For example, comedian Larry Miller says: “How does the phone cord always get so tangled? How? All I ever do is pick up the receiver, talk, and hang up. I don't pick it up, do a cartwheel followed by a somersault, and then hang it up.”

Other standup comics use universal experiences as only the starting point of a routine. Comedian Jerry Seinfeld asks his audience “Ever notice how you will go to the laundromat with evenly matched pairs of socks, yet when you come back you'll have one unmatched sock left over? Where do those odd socks go?” His audience laughs because every one of them can relate to the experience he has just described.

He then goes further, however, by providing an answer to his own question. Socks, he explains, are the most adventurous of all clothing. They get tired of being cooped up in your drawer. They see a trip to the laundromat as their one chance to escape. Ever take your laundry out of the dryer and notice a sock tucked away in a corner after all the other clothes were removed? It was hiding, hoping you wouldn't notice, so it could make a getaway later. Ever take something out of the dryer and spot a sock clinging inconspicuously to one side? It was tagging along so it could drop off and make a break for it as soon as you neared the door. Of course, it's a tough world out there for a sock on its own. Ever walk down the street and see a dirty, rumpled sock on the sidewalk? That was a fugitive that didn't make it.

While this brief summary doesn't do justice to Seinfeld's clever routine, it's enough for analytical purposes. First, Seinfeld invokes a universal human experience: missing socks. This shared experience immediately creates a bond among the audience members and between the audience and the performer and creates audience interest in what he is going to say next.

Then he exploits the humorous potential in the topic by offering an absurd explanation for the experience. In fact, he identifies four different universal experiences: socks missing after doing laundry, socks hiding in the dryer, socks clinging to other clothing, dirty socks on the sidewalk. He then offers one explanation for all four experiences. The humor of the routine derives from the fact that

such a ludicrous theory can so neatly explain so many different common, everyday happenings.

This is an example of what might be termed the *Bizarre Explanation Formula* for exploiting universal human experiences. It consists of invoking a trivial but universal human experience, then following up by providing some skewed insight or theory about it. This approach is a staple of standup comedy. It may constitute an elaborate routine as in the above example or the entire formula may be condensed into one brief gag. I recall one comedian who was talking about when he once worked for an appliance firm. He explained, "I was the guy who used to put that device inside hairdryers that makes you think you hear the phone ringing as soon as you turn it on."

The Bizarre Explanation Formula can be applied intact to certain magic effects. Perfect examples are provided by two prominent comedy magicians, Tom Ogden and Mike Caveney. When Tom Ogden performs the "Cannibal Cards" effect wherein playing cards placed between two kings disappear, he doesn't indulge in some corny story about cannibals and missionaries. (How many people could relate that to their own experiences?) Instead, he asks his audience, "Ever take out an old deck to play cards only to find that there are one or two cards missing from the pack?" You can be sure that almost everyone in his audience can answer yes to that question.

Tom then goes on to explain the reason. Certain cards in each deck are cannibals. They actually devour other cards. That's why the longer you own a deck the more cards will disappear from it Tom then identifies the black kings as being the cannibals in the particular deck he has and proceeds to demonstrate their anthropophagous tendencies.

When Mike Caveney does the "Linking Coat Hangers" he poses this question to his audience: "Ever go to the closet to hang up a coat and find that all the wire coat hangers are tangled together? No matter what you do, it's impossible to get them apart." Again, everyone in the audience can answer that one affirmatively. Mike has an explanation. Coat hangers are sexually insatiable. Leave them together in a dark closet for a few minutes and they

immediately start to copulate. Mike then takes out a few coat hangers and proceeds to demonstrate their mating habits.

In these routines, Tom Ogden and Mike Caveney are doing exactly the same thing Jerry Seinfeld did in his comedy routine. First, they invoke a universal human experience: finding that socks are missing after doing the laundry; being unable to play cards because of a short deck; being unable to untangle coat hangers in the closet. Then they offer an absurd and inherently amusing explanation: the socks escape; the playing cards get eaten by other playing cards; the coat hangers copulate.

However, as magicians, they can then go on to do something that the comedian can't. They can actually "prove" their bizarre theories by demonstrating how cards vanish as soon as they're placed between the kings or how coat hangers link up as soon as they're allowed near each other.

In addition to the Bizarre Explanation Formula, comedians also exploit universal human experiences with another approach I term the *Bizarre Solution Formula*. The comic identifies a problem that virtually everyone in his audience has experienced at some time. Then he offers an amusing solution to the problem.

The solution is amusing because, although absurd, it makes a strange kind of sense. For example, I once heard a standup comic talking about the deplorable state of emergency medical services. He observed that the average response time for ambulances in medical emergencies is forty minutes. His solution: Put ambulance attendants in pizza delivery trucks. They get there in *thirty* minutes and, if they don't, it's free.

This formula is easily adaptable to magic. Instead of offering a bizarre solution to a universal problem, the magician can offer a magical solution. A perfect illustration is the presentation for "The Gypsy Thread" devised by Lonnie Chevie and popularized by Charles Green. The performer talks about dental floss and how, whenever the roll runs out, one is invariably left with a piece that is too small to use.

Rather than let this go to waste, his solution is to save all these little pieces and magically weld them together into one piece that is

long enough to use. The performer illustrates this explanation, taking a long piece of dental floss, breaking it into little pieces, then magically fusing them back into one long piece.

Many other magic tricks are adaptable to presentations as magical solutions to common problems. Consider the plot used by many coin men where a large-denomination coin is transformed into smaller coins that add up to the same amount, for example, a half-dollar transformed into two quarters. This could be presented as a magical solution to the common predicament of driving into the exact-change lane of a toll booth only to discover that you don't have the exact change you thought you had.

An indication of the strength of invoking universal experiences in a presentation is the fact that, often, when a standup comic describes a universal human experience in setting up a gag, the audience will start to laugh even before he gets to the punchline. Erma Bombeck can draw a smile from readers just by asking, "Why does the bread always land on the floor jelly side down?" Calling to mind the experience is itself entertaining. If you can add comedy or magic, or both, to that starting point you'll have an unbeatable combination.

All this talk about comedians should not lead you to assume that universal experience is only of value to the comedy magician. While the humorous potential of this approach shouldn't be overlooked, our prime concern is the fact that universal experience can lend meaning to an effect. Universal experience is, by definition, *shared* experience, and shared experiences bring people together. This type of presentation helps draw the audience together and deeper into the performance. By providing the audience with a means of relating what you're doing to their own lives, you can make them care about what you're doing.

Let me give you an example of a non-comedy use of universal experience in presentation. It's a presentation devised by Jay Sankey for Al Baker's "Pack That Cuts Itself," better known as "The Haunted Pack." Jay asks if anyone has ever tried building a card castle. This is, in fact, something that almost everyone has done at one time or another. He then goes on to warn of unforeseen dangers in this pastime. Everyone has heard of haunted castles. Well, even card castles can become haunted.

Jay once built a card castle that became haunted and, even though he took the castle apart, the deck remains haunted to this day. To prove his claim, Jay performs the Al Baker effect. This is not a comedy presentation—"charming" would be a more apt description—but it certainly gives the effect more of a point by relating it to the audience's own experiences.

Finally, here's an example of how universal experience can be used in an effect that already has another source of meaning to amplify that meaning. In my gambling lecture I demonstrate the second deal. I introduce the demonstration by saying, "How many times have you played blackjack and realized that if you'd gotten the card the player after you got you wouldn't have busted, or that if you had received the card the player before you got you would have had a blackjack?"

Blackjack is one of the most popular card games in the country. Even high school and college students play it. Therefore, it's certain that virtually everyone in the audience will be able to recall instances of the common but frustrating blackjack playing experience I've described. In fact, whenever I ask the question I always see several heads in the audience nodding.

I then go on to explain how a cheat could use a second deal to give himself the card the player after him should have gotten or the card the player before him should have gotten. (Instead of a bizarre solution or a magical solution, we have here a crooked solution to a common problem.) Now the second deal becomes important, not only because it is a means of cheating at cards, but because it is a means of cheating that would have come in handy in many situations the spectator can readily think of from his own experience.

Invoking universal human experiences, like the other sources of meaning we've discussed, provides the thinking magician with one more tool he can use to answer the question that is implicitly posed by every audience: "So you're going to do a trick; why should I care?"

Surrealism

Surrealism as a category of magical meaning is difficult to define. In fact, I'm not sure that "surrealism" is the most accurate name for what I have in mind here. But since I can't think of a better one, it'll have to do. Rather than worry about terminology, I'll concentrate on clarifying the concept through examples and analysis.

What I have in mind is a popular concept in modern close-up. The common thread that ties all such effects together is the tendency to play with the very nature of reality. I think the best way to explain what I mean is through examples. There are two themes that recur in surrealist effects. The first is the suggestion that symbols are interchangeable with reality. The second is the notion that reality itself is malleable.

Symbol vs. Reality: In David Roth's "Stamp Trick" he takes out a rubber stamp, an ink pad, and a piece of paper. The rubber stamp reproduces life-size images of a half-dollar. After stamping three half-dollar images on the piece of paper, the performer folds the paper in half and tips it over. Out roll three real half-dollars. When the paper is unfolded it is now blank.

Replacing the half-dollars within the folds of the paper, the paper is unfolded to reveal that the half-dollars are gone but the three stamped images are back. The images become reality, then reality again becomes the image. Jerry Andrus uses a similar idea in "Mylar Mystery," a trick where a picture of a yellow ball on an acetate sheet turns into a real ball when the sheet is rolled into a cone.

Another slant on the symbol and reality interchange is provided by a quick card trick performed by Rafael Benatar of Spain. He shows a six of spades and asks the audience what you get if you turn a six upside-down. Naturally, the answer is a nine. He now turns the six of spades upside-down; as he does so, it visibly changes to the nine of spades. The Arabic numeral six is, after all, only a symbol for a particular reality, specifically, a particular quantity. But in the world of magic, when you change the symbol by inverting it, the actual quantity—in this case, the quantity of pips on a card—also changes.

Paul Gertner has a card effect in which a spectator selects the three of hearts. When the performer attempts to locate the card, he produces instead the two of hearts. On being informed of his error, he introduces a small red self-adhesive sticker in the shape of a heart. He attaches this to the center of the deuce, making it look like a three of hearts. However, when the card is handed to the spectator, he finds that it really *is* the three of hearts.

If desired, the Gertner trick could be brought full circle like the Roth trick. The performer could take the three of hearts back from the spectator and peel off the center heart, being left once more with the heart adhesive sticker and the two of hearts. Symbol becomes reality, then reality reverts to symbol. Yet another example of this concept is the "Twilight" coin trick in which a coin's reflection (symbol) becomes a real coin, then reverts back to a reflection.

A slightly different approach is taken in Roth's "Portable Hole." In this case, a round piece of black felt is introduced and called a portable hole. Clearly, this is not really a hole but only a two-dimensional representation of a hole, not unlike using a drawing of a hole. Yet when things are dropped into the felt "hole" they disappear just as they would if they had been dropped into a real hole. Here the symbol of the object does not turn into the real object as in the "Stamp Trick"; rather the symbol functions just as if it were the real object.

The same is true of Dick Koornwinder's "Crazy Cannon." After having had a card selected and lost in the deck, the performer draws a small cannon on a pad of paper. Aiming the drawing at the deck of cards, he "fires" the cannon. A loud explosion is heard. On spreading through the deck, the selected card is now found to have a hole shot through it. Once again, the symbol of the object functions exactly the way the real object would have.

In David Harkey's "Pop Art," the paper with the drawing of the cannon is rolled into a tube. The cannon is then fired, causing smoke to pour out of the tube. When the paper is unrolled, the drawing is seen to have changed; the mouth of the cannon has actually been blown off by the explosion. Thus, the interchange between symbol and reality has been taken one step further.

Those familiar with Dr. Sawa's "Piano Trick" will see the same basic concept at work there; a set of fake piano keys produces music just as if it were a real piano. In his "Slot Machine" trick, the performer's fist is used to symbolize a slot machine and eventually produces a stream of coins like a real slot machine.

Manipulating Reality: In Dr. Boris Zola's "Extraction of Silver," the spectator is handed a half-dollar. While the coin is held in his closed fist, the performer extracts the silver from it in the form of a silver nugget. Left in the spectator's hand is a clear plastic replica of a half-dollar, suggesting that, through magic, form can be separated from substance. It's almost as if the coin's body has been separated from its soul.

David Roth does an effect with a small, orange rubber ball and a half-dollar. He makes the two transpose several times. Finally, he slaps the coin and the ball together; when he opens his hands, he is holding a half-dollar made of orange rubber. The form of one of the objects has merged with the substance of the other.

A possible twist on this idea would be to perform several transpositions of the coin and ball as Roth does. On the last attempted transposition something seems to go wrong. The performer opens his hands and is seen to have a silver ball in one hand and an orange rubber half-dollar in the other. The forms have transposed while the substances have not.

Just as the above effects separate form from substance, certain tricks separate objects from one of their properties. In David Roth's "Tuning Fork," the sounds produced by an object are separated from the object and stored independently.

Surreal effects represent a different way of looking at the world. By playing off such a skewed view of reality, they represent what may well be conceptually the most sophisticated kind of magic. Yet, as we'll see in a moment, it's also the most innocent.

The Cartoon Connection: Anyone who wants inspiration for creating surrealistic magic effects should study the silent films of French magician and film pioneer George Méliès. Another great source of inspiration would be the cartoons of Max Fleischer such as those featuring Betty Boop or Koko the Clown.

For example, any fan of these cartoons will recognize that the “Moving Pip Card” has a Fleischeresque quality to it as do all effects where the performer draws something and the drawing then comes to life. Consider David Williamson's effect where, after a spectator signs a card, the performer pulls the signature off, the writing coming away like a black thread being pulled free of the card. This concept is right out of Fleischer's “Out of the Inkwell” cartoon series.

David Roth's “Portable Hole” is another idea straight out of cartoons. For example, there is the 1955 Warner Bros. cartoon “The Hole Idea” about a scientist who produces a revolutionary invention, “portable holes.” (Yes, that's really what they're called in the cartoon.) He carries the floppy black discs in a briefcase until a thief steals them and uses one to break into Fort Knox. (He just places a hole against the wall and walks through it.)

If you need further proof, check out the cartoon-movie *Who Framed Roger Rabbit?* One live-action scene takes place in a warehouse used for storing cartoon props. One of the storage boxes is labeled “portable holes.”

Not only do these items share the same name as the prop in David Roth's effect, they function exactly the same way. When one of the characters removes a portable hole from the box it proves to be a flat, black, circular piece of fabric similar to the Roth prop. Yet when he throws the portable hole against a wall, it sticks there and he is able to put his arm through it.

The concept of a *moveable* hole that can be dragged from place to place, as in Alex Elmsley's “Puncture,” has also been used in countless cartoons. (See, for example, *The Magical Mystery Tour*.) Or, consider the cartoons of the legendary Tex Avery. In “Deputy Droopy,” one character screams into a milk bottle. No sound is heard until he carries the bottle outside and pours out the sound. This is exactly like David Roth's “Tuning Fork” in which sound is trapped in a glass and later poured out.

In Avery's “Drag-A-Long Droopy,” cowboy Droopy shoots a nickel out of the air. Down come five pennies, each with a bullet hole through it. You'll recall that Dr. Sawa does essentially the same thing without the use of a firearm. I once saw a cartoon in which a

man was wearing a polkadot tie. Another man came along and slapped him on the back, causing all the polkadots to sink to the bottom of the tie. (Remember Tommy Wonder's effect with the falling playing card pips?)

The relation between cartoons and certain magic plots has not escaped the notice of some magicians. Jay Sankey once published a magic problem titled “Bugs Bunny Baseball” because it was inspired by a gag in a Bugs Bunny cartoon. David Harkey describes one of the effects in his book *Simply Harkey* as a “three-dimensional cartoon.” Similarly, French cardman Bernard Bilis once told me that Swedish cardman Lennart Greene's magic reminded him of the cartoons of Tex Avery. In fact, Sylvester the Jester has built a highly novel act entirely around cartoon humor.

This cartoon connection provides a key to the appeal and meaning of surrealistic magic. Cartoons have always had a special appeal to children. Their logic seems to make particular sense to children. Magic, at its best, awakens childlike wonder in audiences. Surrealistic effects do this by seemingly validating the child's view of the world.

Does the surrealism angle in magic really constitute substantive meaning? The concept behind substantive meaning is that an effect will be more powerful if it deals with a subject that is important. Surrealistic effects deal with the very nature of reality. Can you think of anything more important?

Subtext

Subtext is a concept that arises often in film criticism. It refers to the hidden message that a film conveys to an audience beneath the surface of the story it is telling (the “text”). The subtext is literally the “underlying message.”

For example, most of the current crop of slasher horror movies carry a Puritan subtext: teenagers shouldn't have sex. (That's usually when the madman sneaks up and hacks them to pieces.) In the 1950s, many science fiction horror films dealt with outer space invasions in which the aliens took over the bodies of normal people and used them to infiltrate the Earth. This carried a strong

xenophobic subtext. The message was: “Don't trust foreigners. They may look just like you and me, but inside they're different—and dangerous!”

In terms of the presentation of magic, subtext forms another dimension of the subject of meaning. It differs from the overt meaning derived from the text of the trick only in that subtext is a subliminal message that works without the awareness of the audience—and often without the awareness of the magician! Yet it can be a potent source of meaning for an effect.

No form of magic relies more heavily on subtext than mentalism. Consider Al Baker's “Chickenfeed,” a standard opening effect used by many mentalists. The performer has a member of the audience stand. He then writes a prediction on a notepad. The spectator now counts the loose change in his pocket. It comes to, let us say, a dollar and thirty-seven cents. The performer has someone read his prediction. It says, “\$1.37.” The text of the effect is, “The performer knows how much change a person has in his pocket.”

If this overt text were the only message the trick carried, it would be a trivial exercise. After all, of what good is it to know how much change strangers are carrying around? If that were as far as the matter went, the performer would be demonstrating a strange but pointless talent, rather like being able to wiggle one's ears.

However, the subtext of the effect says much more. In the spectator's mind, someone who knows that he has a dollar thirty-seven in his right hip pocket probably knows that he has a comb with three broken teeth in his jacket pocket, a shopping list from his wife in his shirt pocket, and a key to his mistress' apartment in his left hip pocket. Now things start to get interesting. The subtext of this effect is, as Johnny Carson says, “The great Karnak sees all, knows all.” You just can't keep any secrets from this guy.

Emotionally there is not much distance from conceding that a man can know what's in my pockets to conceding that he can know what's in my diary, and from there to conceding that he can know what's in my soul. A tongue-in-cheek patter line I sometimes use in my performances is, “The implications are frightening.” This line actually sums up an important element of my approach to

presentation and also conveys the essence of what subtext is all about: implications.

A comparison of several seemingly similar effects provides a good illustration of the importance of subtext. Card predictions may be divided into three categories: (1) the performer predicts a card that the spectator thinks of (for example, by means of an “Ultra- Mental Deck”); (2) the performer predicts a card that the spectator physically selects (for example, by means of a forcing deck); (3) the performer predicts a card arrived at “randomly.” (For example: “Name a number between ten and twenty. Fourteen? Okay, count off fourteen cards. Fourteen is composed of a one and a four. One and four add up to five, so count down to the fifth card.”)

Many performers will see these effects as very similar. (You know the type. The guy who says, “The methods are different but the effect is the same, and laymen don't care about method.”) But the fact is that the second version will play stronger than the third and the first version will play stronger than the second.

This is partially because laymen intuitively sense that the more physical procedure involved in arriving at the card, the more opportunity is created for the performer to influence the process. But it's also because each version carries a slightly different subtext. The third version says that the performer can control random processes—impressive! The second version says that the performer can control my actions—disturbing! The first version says that the performer can control my thoughts—frightening!

An excellent insight into the subtext of escape effects was provided by James Randi in a recent magic magazine article: “Escapology has one thing going for it that probably made Harry Houdini such a superstar in his day and a legend in the present. Everyone wants to escape from something. Taxes, contracts, illness, work, the multitude of burdens that we all chafe under are shadows from which we want to escape.”

In other words, in terms of subtext, Houdini was more than a guy who was good with locks; he was a man who was truly *free* and therefore someone to be admired and envied. Little wonder that he is the most famous magician of modern history.

The most common example of subtext at work in magic is one that every close-up magician has experienced. The performer has a spectator pick a card, loses the card in the deck, then finds it. Neither the plot nor the presentation of the effect has anything to do with gambling, card games, or card cheating. Yet, the spectator responds by saying, "I'd sure hate to play cards with you!"

Magicians are usually amused and somewhat puzzled by this comment. They know that most close-up magicians, even those who specialize in card magic, would pose no threat in a game. It's understandable that a gambling routine might elicit such an audience response, but why a pick-a-card trick? To most magicians, this reaction is just not logical. This is further proof that the prime impact of strong magic is emotional rather than logical. For laypeople the subtext of many card tricks is: this guy would be a dangerous opponent in a card game. Without this subtext, most pick-a-card tricks would be meaningless puzzles.

As the above example indicates, magicians often benefit from a trick's subtext without even being aware of it. Nevertheless, it's very useful to appreciate subtext on a conscious level and recognize it in action for two reasons. First, it will enable you to avoid *negative* subtexts. Later, when we discuss characterization and constructing an act, we will see that a trick, while effective in itself, may convey a message that undermines what you're trying to achieve in your overall performance.

To take another example, in most stage magic acts, the only role played by women is to act as servants for the male performer and to meekly submit to being sawed, stabbed, or otherwise mutilated by him for the amusement of the audience. This anti- feminist subtext may well offend many modern women, even if only

on a subconscious level, and may partially account for the relative lack of popularity of stage magic among women.

Creating a Subtext: Secondly, a conscious awareness of how subtext works will often allow you to create a positive subtext or strengthen an existing positive subtext through patter or routining changes. A perfect example of giving meaning to an effect by creating a subtext can be seen in Martin Nash's performance of "Colors on the March"

from his book *Any Second Now*.

This is an effect in which the performer demonstrates his ability to deal red cards and black cards in any pattern: alternating, two of one color followed by two of the other color, or in groups of three. The original of this effect is the aptly named “Scarne Puzzle.” Bill Simon later elaborated the effect to create his “Call to the Colors.” Although he made the trick longer, Simon did nothing to lift it out of the puzzle class.

Nash's routine is almost identical to the Simon version, but his presentation is very different. He begins by stating that he will show how a card cheat can deal himself any hand he wants in a game. Since not everyone in the audience will be familiar with any one particular card game and what constitutes a good hand in that game, he will use something that everyone can understand, the colors red and black. He then launches into the Simon routine. About halfway through the effect, he again reminds the audience that instead of dealing reds and blacks he could just as easily deal full houses, royal flushes, or grand slam bridge hands.

The spectator's eyes see red cards and black cards, but his mind's eye sees an endless stream of unbeatable gambling hands. A couple of deftly placed comments have transformed a puzzle into an emotionally meaningful effect by creating a strong gambling subtext.

René Lavand performs the same effect using a very different presentation. He begins by explaining that this is one effect he himself doesn't understand—an effect he sometimes performs for himself to help preserve his own sense of wonder. As the effect progresses, he stresses that he does absolutely nothing to the cards; they just rearrange themselves into different color patterns. He wonders aloud how this can be. The only answer he can find is that playing cards are “ritualistic, ancient, and mysterious.”

Thus, in this presentation, the red/black patterns of the cards are only an outward manifestation of an inner soul, an inner life, that the cards themselves possess. At the core of the effect is the impenetrable mystery of a deck of cards.

In one sense, the Martin Nash presentation and the René Lavand presentation are at opposite extremes. While Nash stresses his total

control of the deck, Lavand stresses his total lack of control; the cards just do it themselves. However, the two presentations both draw their strength from the implication that the effect the audience sees is just the tip of the iceberg. In each case, the effect implies much more than it shows and thus uses subtext to transform a puzzle into a meaningful effect, in one case an impressive demonstration of skill and in the other a mystical mystery.

Strengthening a Subtext: Let's look at a couple of examples of strengthening a subtext that is already inherent in an effect. We've seen that mental effects generally carry a subtext implying that whatever psychic power is being displayed actually extends far beyond the boundaries of the demonstration being performed. Consider an elementary example of underscoring this concept through patter.

“Out of this World” is one of the strongest effects in card magic and one of my favorite tricks. At the conclusion of it I always turn to the person who has just successfully sorted the reds and blacks and comment that, if she has any tips on the stock market, the rest of us would be very interested to hear them. This line gets a chuckle but, more importantly, it communicates the notion that this card effect has uncovered a power within the spectator that may have ramifications far beyond the sorting out of cards.

Finally, I'll give you an example where considerable thought and analysis were required before I finally identified the subtext at work in an effect I was performing. This then allowed me to further strengthen that subtext.

The multiple card location effect of the type popularized by Eddie Fechter had never particularly appealed to me. It always seemed to me that the quickie-type location in which the spectator chooses a card and the performer finds it by means of some snappy flourish was a boring effect. I figured that repeating the effect eight times in a row would be eight times as boring.

But after seeing Michael Skinner receive a very strong reaction with an effect of this kind I decided to experiment with the plot. I put together the “Nine-Card Location” which appears in *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. I quickly found that the effect had an enormous

impact on an audience. I finally had to recognize that having nine cards selected, then finding them in rapid-fire succession, had a psychological effect on an audience far different from performing nine separate pick-a-card tricks in a row.

In part, I think this stems from the fact that the audience correctly senses that the problem of controlling the cards becomes far more difficult in a multiple location. With the deck being shuffled and cut in the course of locating each card, there would seem to be a great danger of losing track of the later selections in the process of finding the earlier selections.

However, another important element in the success of the trick is the subtext. The structure of the effect is that all nine cards are selected and lost, then all nine cards are located one after the other. The selection process and the location process are separated by a time interval. Once the effect really gets going, what the audience sees is that someone names a card and you instantly cut to it; a second spectator names a card and you instantly cut to it, too; yet another spectator names a card and you instantly cut to that one. Psychologically, it begins to appear as if anyone could name any card and you could instantly cut to it.

Thus, the subtext conveys far more than the actual text of the trick. After all, if you could actually have any person name any card, then take a shuffled deck and instantly cut to the named card, it would be an awesome effect. Here is an excellent example of how, through subtext, one can imply an effect that would be quite impossible to achieve literally. Having once become aware of the subliminal message of this effect I was then able to underscore that message through several small patter changes.

Discovering Subtexts: As with every other aspect of magical presentation, when analyzing subtext it is vital that you listen to what laymen say to you. Unfortunately, many magicians find themselves puzzled by many laymen comments and dismiss them without thought. They will jokingly repeat these comments to other magicians with the condescending air of a parent quoting his child's latest cute statement. Their attitude is one of, "Those goofy laymen; what will they come up with next?"

Remember, laymen comments often convey more than the spectator himself realizes. The effect of a trick is what happens in the audience's mind and those comments tell you what is going on in the audience's mind. I've often had people come up to me after a show and say, "You're actually keeping track of all fifty-two cards all the time during the whole show aren't you?" (Naturally, I always answer, "Yes") That is the subtext of the "Nine-Card Location" as well as of many of the other effects I feature in my performances. Little wonder the trick has such a powerful impact. The implications are quite frightening.

The Inherent Meaningfulness Of Magic

After all this talk about the importance of substantive meaning, it may surprise you to learn that I don't believe it's essential for an effect to have substantive meaning (or situational meaning, which we'll soon be discussing) to be powerful. The fact is that magic is inherently meaningful. If you do something that is truly impossible, even something as trivial as levitating a toothpick, it has tremendous meaning. That's because, while the achievement itself may be trivial, the implications are not. If it's truly impossible, it brings into question everything we think we know about how the universe works.

That's why baffling magic always evokes an emotional response. If you see something that all your instincts tell you is impossible, it has to be meaningful to you. The implication is that from this point on you can never be certain of anything.

This assumes, of course, that the effect appears truly impossible and not merely puzzling. We saw how to achieve that impression when we discussed clarity, conviction, and suggestion.

However, as a practical matter, you can always use all the help you can get when it comes to grabbing an audience and moving them emotionally. Whenever you can add substantive meaning of the kind we've been discussing to the inherent meaningfulness of magic it can only help you in your goals of getting the audience to pay attention in the first place and giving them an experience they'll never forget.

Credibility

Finally, I want to stress an important point in connection with magical presentations that many magicians fail to grasp. It's not what you say that matters; it's what the audience believes that matters. To put it differently, a substantively meaningful presentation will only work if it's credible within the context of the trick you're doing.

Some of the presentations we've discussed are intended to be believed literally by an audience. For example, this is the case with most gambling exposé and mentalism presentations. Others, such as the occult presentations, may only succeed in leaving your audience uncertain as to whether what they've seen should be taken literally. Still others are fanciful; the audience knows they can't literally be true, yet their eyes tell them that they are. The signature transfer effect I described is a good example of this. Yet other presentations are clearly tongue in cheek, for example, the sex patter for the Clock Trick. Yet all of these presentations have one thing in common. They will only succeed if the audience feels that, at least on some level, they are credible,

This will partially depend on your own attitude. In some cases, as I pointed out earlier, it will also depend on whether the audience feels that you really know what you're talking about. However, credibility will depend, more than anything else, on how appropriate the presentation is to the effect.

External Credibility: In order for a presentational theme to be credible, the claims you make in developing that theme must not contradict what the audience knows about the real world.

I remember reading one card effect whose presentation revolved around a performance of the Marx Brothers. The patter included the line, "The Marx Brothers were actually quick-change artists, not comedians." Indeed, the entire presentation was predicated on this strange claim. Since everyone on earth knows that the Marx Brothers were *not* quick-change artists, but comedians, the presentation lost all credibility from that point on.

Another card effect I recall reading dealt with the subject of how

one trains to be a Las Vegas blackjack dealer. Since the world of Las Vegas casinos is one that fascinates most people, this theme is bound to grab an audience's attention. Unfortunately, the premise of the effect is that, in order to qualify for a casino job, a blackjack dealer must demonstrate his ability to cut to four of a kind.

Any audience member with an ounce of sense will realize that Las Vegas casinos are not going to require card cheating ability as a prerequisite for a dealing job. Furthermore, if they know how to play cards, they'll know that four of a kind is a good hand at poker, not blackjack. Consequently, this presentation will detract from the effect rather than add to it.

You can't achieve credibility if the presentation insults the audience's intelligence. In your presentations, don't blithely make claims about the real world that your audience knows to be false.

Internal Credibility: A presentational theme must not only be consistent with what the audience knows of the real world, it must also be consistent with what happens in the effect. In other words, the effect must flow logically from the premise.

As soon as you use the word logic in connection with a magic effect some magicians will respond that magic, by its very nature, is illogical. Such people don't understand what the word logic means. Actually, magic is a violation of physics, not logic. Logic is concerned only with drawing conclusions from premises. The premises may or may not conform to physical reality. Either way, once the premises are established, certain conclusions flow unavoidably from them.

You can see this at work in any good fantasy story, whether it takes place in an imaginary world filled with magic like Tolkein's *The Lord of the Rings* or is set in the real world with just one limited intrusion of magic as was typical of most *Twilight Zone* episodes. The writer knows that, having established his magical premise, everything that happens must be logically consistent with it or the story will lack credibility. It's all right to tell readers that Superman's body is impervious to any kind of injury, that he can swim through molten lava and knives just bounce off his body. But then you have to explain how he cuts his hair and fingernails.

Wouldn't the scissors just break? You made the rules; you've got to live by them. (As any DC Comics fan knows, Superman's hair and nails don't grow in Earth's atmosphere.)

Similarly, you can tell an audience that the selected cards are disappearing because they're being swallowed by the four cannibalistic kings. But you can't conclude the trick by then pulling the selected cards out of your pocket. To reproduce the selections by making the kings regurgitate them would be internally consistent, to reproduce them from a sealed envelope in your wallet would not.

Flaws of this kind, which we might term thematic discrepancies, are bad because they remind the audience that they're not seeing real magic—it's only a trick—in the same way that an anachronism in a film reminds the audience that “it's only a movie.” Both interfere with emotional belief.

Matching Presentation and Effect: It really isn't all that difficult to come up with a strong presentational theme. However, coming up with a strong presentational theme that *fits* the effect in question is another matter. Credibility problems generally arise from a mismatch between presentation and effect. If you really want to reproduce the vanished cards from an envelope in your wallet, then the cannibal theme is simply not the most appropriate presentation. There is nothing wrong with cutting to four of a kind, just don't talk about Las Vegas blackjack dealers when you do it. If the Marx Brothers theme doesn't fit the effect, change either the effect or the theme, don't make absurd claims about the career of the Marx Brothers.

In one of Don Albrecht's great cartoons poking fun at magicians, he shows a bearded, turbaned conjuror presenting the Sponge Bunnies trick using occult patter. We've already seen that occult presentations can be great. But in this case nobody's going to buy it. Remember, what you say in your patter doesn't have to be true, but it does have to be believable. (Sort of like the policy followed by the Nixon administration.)

Always seek to fashion a presentation that is not only substantively meaningful, but that also fits the effect like a glove. Then develop that presentation logically throughout the effect, don't abandon the

presentation halfway through the trick. What the audience sees and what it hears must seem completely compatible. This isn't easy to achieve. It requires hard thinking and creativity. But it's essential if the presentation is to enhance the effect rather than just seem irrelevant or silly and embarrassing.

CHAPTER FIVE: SITUATIONAL MEANING

Roald Dahl wrote a riveting short story called “The Man From the South” which has been adapted for television several times. It concerns the question of whether or not a cigarette lighter will ignite repeatedly without missing. How could such a trivial matter hold a TV audience's attention? The answer lies in the context in which the question is raised.

A young man is trying to impress a woman in a restaurant. He lights her cigarette and comments in passing that his lighter never misses. An older man overhears the boast and proposes a wager. If the young man's lighter can light ten times in a row, he will win the older man's luxury automobile.

Unfortunately, the young man has nothing of comparable value to wager. The older man has a solution. He will accept the young man's little finger as his part of the wager. If the lighter works, the young man gets the car. If the lighter fails, the old man gets to cut off the little finger.

The young man craves the car and fears appearing like a blowhard coward in front of the woman he's been trying to impress. He agrees to the wager. His hand is tied to a table. The old man pulls out a sharp pocket knife and holds it above the young man's finger.

With his free hand the young man tries the lighter. It lights. A second time it lights. A third, fourth, fifth, sixth, seventh and eighth time it lights. It lights again on the ninth try. With an almost lustful look on his face, the old man grips the knife above the young man's finger, fighting to restrain himself.

Do you really care what happens on the tenth try? If you do, it's because an essentially meaningless event has been couched within a

compelling situation. It's the human drama that makes the event meaningful. You can make your magic more meaningful by doing the same.

This is the concept I've labeled situational meaning. It's a concept I developed when I considered the fact that there are some effects that are totally devoid of meaning in the Henning Nelms sense, yet are very compelling to audiences because of the human context the performer places them in.

The key to understanding situational meaning is Dariel Fitzkee's observation that, "People are more interested in people than in any other single thing." As you study the various forms of situational meaning, you'll note the common thread is that they all involve people (the performer, spectators, or the performer and spectators) in situations that make the audience care how those people will react.

I couldn't possibly do justice to the great climax of Roald Dahl's story in a brief synopsis, so I suggest you track down the original. In the meanwhile, let's look at techniques for creating situational meaning.

Conflict Against Spectator

The essence of the Roald Dahl story is a sharply defined conflict. There is nothing more dramatically riveting than conflict. In fact, conflict is the essence of all drama. This is why so many people will stop to watch a street fight even though they may not know either participant and therefore have no reason to care who wins.

Generally speaking, the simplest way to inject conflict into a magical presentation is to arrange a game or contest of some kind between the performer and a spectator. There are many gambling routines that follow this format. This is natural since interpersonal conflict is the essence of gambling. Effects like the "Ten-Card Poker Deal," the "Three-Shell Game," the "Endless Chain," some "Three-Card Monte" routines, and certain poker and blackjack routines work off this premise. Del Ray not only presents a poker deal and blackjack deal in which he gambles with spectators, he also does an outstanding dice routine along the same lines.

The premise, however, is not limited to gambling routines. Many effects are built around a contest or invented game between the performer and a spectator. Some of these effects can be very powerful. Others are too contrived to be really effective. Nevertheless, the principle is sound. Those effects of this kind that fail do so because the magic is weak, not because the presentation is unsound. Such games may pit the performer against one or more spectators in a battle of luck or skill. “Seven Keys to Baldpate” is an example of the former while Paul Harris' “Reflex” and Max Malini's “Coin Game” are examples of the latter.

Some magicians argue that such an approach is likely to antagonize an audience or embarrass the spectator involved. The fact that successful professional magicians such as Del Ray, Eddie Tullock, Mike Rogers, myself, and many others have used this approach consistently with great success proves otherwise. Nevertheless, it's true that you can antagonize or embarrass a spectator if you *misuse* this technique.

First, it's important to avoid making this a personal matter. This means that you don't denigrate or ridicule the spectator when he loses. And you don't gloat when you win.

Instead, you may, for example, express surprise at your own success. Or you may confess to having an unfair advantage due to your years of practice. The important thing is that you don't encourage the spectator to allow his ego to get involved in the contest. If the average person plays chess with Anatoly Karpov he doesn't expect to win and he won't be upset if he loses. But he also doesn't want Karpov to ridicule him for his poor play or do a little victory dance at the end of the game.

Furthermore, you don't want it to look like you're stacking the odds against the spectator. Whatever the game or contest, you must make it appear that your opponent has all the advantages. Otherwise, you'll look like a bully picking on a defenseless spectator. Make it look like you're bending over backward to give the spectator every chance to win; make yourself the underdog. When the spectator does lose, be a gracious winner.

If you follow these simple rules you won't run any risk of alienating

the audience. On the contrary, you'll have them riveted to their seats as they await the outcome of the conflict. You'll also have them applauding when you conquer overwhelming odds to win.

Conflict Against Machine

Ever since John Henry won a wager by pounding railroad spikes into the ground faster than a steam drill, mankind has been fascinated by the battle between man and machine. Beginning with the Industrial Revolution, machines have been proving that they can perform physical tasks faster and better than humans. With the advent of the computer revolution it appears they're also destined to perform mental tasks better than us. Deep down most of us find this notion a little disquieting. That's why in a contest between man and machine, we'll always root for the man. It brings out the Luddite in all of us.

Traditionally, lightning calculators have demonstrated their skills by performing complicated mathematical calculations mentally before an audience member could perform the same calculations using an adding machine. I don't know whether anyone has updated this sort of demonstration to show his ability to beat a pocket calculator, but if anyone does it should make for a memorable performance.

A couple of years ago a Russian mentalist performed a very impressive demonstration of muscle reading on television. He succeeded in locating an object hidden in the studio. What made it particularly impressive was that an electronic homing device had been attached to the object. At the same time that the mentalist began searching for the object through "mindreading," a team of technicians began searching for it using the latest electronic equipment. The mentalist succeeded in finding the object before the technicians did.

At this point I can't even remember what the hidden object was. But I do remember that the mentalist beat the machine. This perfectly illustrates my point. I don't remember the details of the task, which was essentially meaningless, but I do remember the situation of a man triumphing over technology. That was very meaningful.

The concept of man vs. machine has gone virtually undeveloped in close-up magic. The above two examples provide some idea of the possibilities. If you hit on the right application of this concept, it could make you a legend. It worked for John Henry.

Conflict Against Imaginary Character

“The art of the storyteller and the art of the magician have much in common. With both the appeal is to the imagination.”

Jean Hugard

An intriguing illustration of the power of presentation is provided by the fact that it is possible to captivate an audience with a completely fabricated conflict between the performer and an imaginary character whose presence is conjured up purely through showmanship. When I speak of a conflict with an imaginary character I am entering the realm of what is usually termed story patter.

Before proceeding I think I should clarify that term since it's commonly used to refer to two very different kinds of presentations. The first kind is what I call allegorical magic. This is where magic props are used to symbolize characters and events in a story. Well-known examples are the “Thieves and Sheep” in which coins represent the title characters and “The Hotel Mystery” in which the kings and queens from a pack of cards represent traveling men and ladies of the night. This strange kind of presentation has always struck me as a sort of secular version of gospel magic.

This is not at all what I mean when I speak of story patter. I'm talking about effects where the performer relates a story in which something magical occurred and, as he does so, recreates the magic which took place in that story. This typically involves acting out the story itself to a greater or lesser extent. A classic example is the “Magician vs. Gambler” plot in card magic.

The strength of story presentation was first brought home to me when, in my early twenties, I saw the movie *The Sting*. In one key scene, one of the heroes, played by Paul Newman, engages in a card game with the villain, played by Robert Shaw. Shaw tries to cheat Newman by switching in a cold deck. However, Newman outsmarts

him by switching his own poker hand and winning the pot.

When I saw the film in a movie theater, the audience actually broke out into a loud cheer when Newman revealed his winning hand. This was a reaction that any performer would be glad to receive from a gambling routine—and Newman hadn't even done any moves!

The audience wasn't impressed by Paul Newman's sleight of hand which, of course, never actually occurred. They were, however, captivated by the dramatic elements of the scene. It struck me that the scene I had just witnessed was really nothing but a film version of the “Magician vs. Gambler” effect. If I could present a gambling routine that dazzled the audience with my skill and, at the same time, incorporated dramatic elements similar to those in that movie scene, the result would have to be very potent.

Story presentations have a bad reputation in some circles. This is partly because they're associated in most magicians' minds with children's magic, a field where the concept is done to death. It's also partly because they're often used by people who don't understand the dynamics of this technique and therefore fall into traps that produce deadly boring presentations. We're going to be talking about those traps and how to avoid them. First, however, let's consider the dynamics of the story patter approach and the advantages it offers.

Essential Elements

The essential elements in a story presentation are the same ones that are essential to any story: a protagonist (hero), an antagonist (villain), a conflict, and a resolution. The single most important requirement for fashioning a fictional conflict that will grab an audience is a sympathetic protagonist.

The Protagonist: Although in the title of this section I spoke of the performer vs. a fictional character, it's not strictly necessary for the performer to be the hero of the story. The protagonist may be as imaginary as the antagonist. As a practical matter, however, the audience will tend to identify you with the protagonist of the tale. It's in your interest to try to strengthen this identification. If the

protagonist is fictional, his role will nonetheless be played by you. Therefore, a fictional protagonist should always be someone you want to be identified with and someone the audience will have no trouble identifying you with.

When most magicians perform the “Magician vs. Gambler,” they cast the magician as the hero. This is logical; since the performer is a magician, the fictional magician is the character the audience will tend to identify him with. When Martin Nash, who bills himself as “The Charming Cheat,” does the effect, he follows the standard plot but casts the gambler in the role of protagonist.

When I do the effect, I want to accent the gambling context and remove any hint of a magical flavor so I tell the tale of a contest between two card sharks, one an arrogant youngster, the other a legendary old card shark. The audience enjoys seeing the old master put the obnoxious young upstart in his place. I don't yet qualify as an old man. Nevertheless, if I were twenty years younger I might cast the young card shark in the role of the hero. Of course, I would first rework the characters to make the young card shark sympathetic and the old one obnoxious.

A story presentation can always be made more effective by casting the performer in the role of protagonist or, failing that, fashioning the protagonist to serve as a surrogate for the performer. I've read many effects where the performer tells a story about a one-armed gambler; the gambler is the protagonist of the story. I do a similar effect (“The One-Handed Poker Deal” from *Cardshark*). However, I introduce it by talking about the time I met a gambler who, after witnessing my skill, said the only way he'd play cards with me is if I had one hand tied behind my back. That would mean I could only shuffle, cut, deal, or handle the cards with one hand. In effect, I've cast myself in the role of the one-armed gambler, keeping the focus where it belongs: on me.

In Peter Kane's “The Gypsy Curse,” he tells the story of how an old Gypsy woman outwitted a street gambler who tried to cheat her at a three-card monte type game. Is the audience going to identify the performer with the Gypsy woman, the protagonist of the tale? Not very likely. If anything, they'll identify him with the gambling cheat, the villain who is defeated in the end by the Gypsy's greater powers.

This is not the image you want to project.

In José Carroll's version of "The Gypsy Curse," he tells the story of the time *he* outwitted a street gambler who tried to cheat him. This simple twist immediately makes the tale work better for the magician. What Carroll and I have done in these two examples is something that should be raised to the level of a principle when using story patter: *when you tell a story, if possible, personalize it; make yourself the hero*. A story told in the first person will always be more powerful and immediate for an audience than one told in the third person.

Sometimes personalizing won't be practical for reasons of credibility or other considerations. For example, using José Carroll's presentation prevents you from employing the antique-style playing cards and period setting of the original Peter Kane version. If this element is important to you, you can retain it by using the alternative approach I mentioned earlier: create a protagonist who can serve as a surrogate for you.

You could tell the audience that magical skill runs in your family. For example, your great, great, great grandfather was also a magician. One family story tells of the time he foiled a street gambler who tried to cheat him in a game. You can now proceed to perform the effect exactly as in the Peter Kane original. As you tell the story, the audience will naturally identify you with your magician ancestor.

Harry Levine has a clever twist on this concept. He tells the audience a tongue-in-cheek tale about the time he went to a hypnotist and experienced a past-life regression. Now he can go on to perform a story effect in a period setting and still cast himself as the hero.

The Antagonist: Almost as important as a sympathetic hero is an unsympathetic villain, someone the audience will enjoy booing. In fiction, the antagonist need not be a person. It may be a force of nature, society in general, or even an aspect of the protagonist's own character that he must overcome. However, in the very elementary kind of storytelling that magic demands, a personal villain is usually best.

Not only should the antagonist be a person, it should be a three-dimensional person, a villain with a face. René Lavand is a master at fleshing out the antagonists in his story presentations. His book *Magic from the Soul* contains many story presentations about various gamblers and card cheats he has crossed swords with. In them, Lavand often tells us his antagonist's name or nickname, his nationality, his physical appearance, his favorite method of cheating, and other personal traits.

He doesn't provide every one of these details in every one of the stories; however, he does include enough telling details in each case to give us a picture of a real person. Compare this to the average magician's presentation of the “Magician vs. Gambler” where both characters remain faceless cardboard cutouts.

The ideal antagonist is both three-dimensional and formidable. It's been said that the key to a good story is a good villain. After all, the hero's stature is measured by the stature of the opponent he overcomes. Would Sherlock Holmes have looked as good if Professor Moriarty had been a moron instead of a genius? Would Robin Hood have seemed as impressive if the Sheriff of Nottingham had been a wimp?

One effective approach to producing a formidable opponent is what I call the Walter Mitty's Revenge Formula. The idea is to cast an unpopular authority figure as antagonist. Then build your story around an experience shared by most of your audience where they have felt helpless in dealing with this type of authority figure. Finally, turn the tables in the situation through magic. A couple of excellent examples of this strategy can be found in the outstanding book *Magical Adventures and Fairy Tales by Punx*.

One of these is a presentation for the “Monkey Bar,” the trick in which different-colored ribbons hanging from a bar magically change places. Punx tells of the time he was stopped by a traffic cop for driving through a red light. Punx accused the policemen of being color blind and apparently proved his claim by means of the “Monkey Bar,” thereby escaping a traffic ticket.

Certainly, traffic cops would be high on most people's lists of unpopular authority figures. Furthermore, almost every person in

the audience has had the experience of receiving a ticket from such a cop for some infraction. They may have tried to talk him out of issuing the ticket, but it's unlikely they succeeded. This is exactly the kind of universal experience that makes most people feel helpless. When the magician shows how he triumphed over the cop through magic, the audience will get a good deal of psychological satisfaction from the tale. (Admittedly, the "Monkey Bar" isn't a close-up trick. But this same presentation would work perfectly for "Hot Rod," a standard close-up item.)

Another effect in the Punx book is a version of the "Six-Card Repeat." In this presentation, the performer relates a dream he had in which a hated, sadistic math teacher from his youth came back from the dead to taunt him about his mathematical inadequacies, just as he had done so often when the magician had been his student. This time, however, the performer is able, by magic, to confound the teacher's mathematical theories, exorcising the spirit and sending it back to hell.

I suspect that most of us have, buried in our subconscious, memories of some math teacher, science teacher, or gym teacher who humiliated us as children, taking joy in rubbing our faces in our shortcomings. I wouldn't be at all surprised if some adults still have nightmares about this character.

Indeed, Punx's dream strikes me as psychoanalytically very sound. A painful specter from one's youth, long buried in the subconscious, rises again in a dream to arouse old feelings of inadequacy. He is then banished by an affirmation of the ego-building accomplishments of one's adulthood—in this case, the magical skills the performer has mastered. Even if you don't care to dig that deeply into the matter, I think you'll agree there is little doubt who the audience will be rooting for when Punx tells this tale.

A little thought will provide you with many more ideas for utilizing the Walter Mitty's Revenge Formula. How about a confrontation with an auto mechanic or TV repairman who kept your car/television set in the shop for ages, then presented you with an obviously inflated bill? What about a battle with an obnoxious sales clerk? Perhaps you used magic to survive an IRS audit. (It would be difficult to come up with a more unpopular authority figure than the

Internal Revenue Service or a common experience more likely to arouse feelings of helplessness than a tax audit.) You might recount a childhood encounter with a schoolyard bully where your magic saved you. Stories about besting a dishonest used car salesman also have potential.

All you need is some imagination combined with an understanding of psychology and contemporary social consciousness. For example, at one time a tale about outwitting a cop who was giving you a sobriety test might have been amusing. In today's social climate, it would be suicidal. Anything that reinforces sexual stereotypes (e.g., "how I got even with my mother-in-law") should also be avoided. With story patter as with any presentation it's important to study the subtext to make sure you're not sending out any unwelcome messages.

The Conflict: The greatest advantage of story patter is that it can achieve strong audience interest in the outcome of the effect as they're swept up in the imaginary conflict you create with your words. What gets the audience interested is the conflict at the heart of the story. For maximum audience involvement, it's best to make it a sharply drawn conflict, such as a direct challenge or a concrete threat which the villain presents to the hero.

For example, a gambling game, or any kind of wager, represents a very sharply defined, ritualized conflict situation. This is why poker deals, three-card monte routines, ace-cutting effects, and other gambling routines have so often been the subject of story presentations. Punx often uses the word "duel" in the titles of his story effects. This is an apt description. The best story presentations involve a duel of some sort between the protagonist and the antagonist.

Perhaps you feel I'm making too much of this matter of conflict. After all, the audience knows it's only a story. It's not "real," so how caught up can they get in the conflict?

Consider this. Every ventriloquist's act I've ever seen has been based on a conflict between the vent and his figure. It's this conflict that provides most of the humor and drives the entire act forward. Some vents even physically struggle with their figures; for example, the

ventriloquist may have to wrestle with the dummy to get it back into its box.

Every person in the audience knows that the conflict isn't "real." They know that there is really only one person on that stage; that he is doing both voices, that he is really only wrestling with himself. Yet, if the vent is good, that intellectual knowledge won't interfere for a moment with the audience losing itself in the dramatic reality of the conflict

This is just a specific application of one of the underlying premises of this book. What the audience knows intellectually need not interfere with what they feel emotionally. In fact, the analogy to magic is quite close. The vent must be sufficiently technically skilled to baffle the audience's intellect; the illusion of a conflict will never work if they can see his lips moving. (The spectator's brain may know better, but his gut tells him that, if the dummy's lips are moving and the ventriloquist's lips aren't, it must be the dummy who's talking.) He must also be a good enough showman to capture the audience's emotions in his presentation (the imaginary conflict). You must do the same thing if your story presentation is to work.

There are two conflict formats commonly found in story effects. I term these the challenge-response and the tennis match. The challenge-response is the more elementary approach. The antagonist challenges the performer in some way and the performer succeeds in meeting the challenge through magic. A good example is Vernon's original presentation for "Triumph." A difficult spectator challenges the performer's abilities by shuffling the cards face up and face down after his selection has been returned to the deck. The performer responds to the challenge by magically causing all the cards in the deck to turn face down except for the selected card.

In the tennis match format, the struggle between the performer and the antagonist goes back and forth several times before the performer finally emerges victorious. My presentation for Larry Jennings' "Homing Card" (given later) is an example of this approach. The challenge-response format is the one to use for a one-phase effect. The tennis match format is for multi-phase routines.

The Resolution: As to the matter of resolving the conflict, I have only one simple but important piece of advice: Let the hero win. The one exception is in comedy presentations where it's often effective for the performer/protagonist to suffer a comical or ironic defeat at the end of the tale. A good example is the late Fred Kaps' hilarious presentation for Fred Braue's "Homing Card" where the performer is defeated by a playing card with a will of its own. However, other than in comedy routines, the protagonist should emerge victorious. He is the one the audience is rooting for. *The audience wants to see the hero win*, and you're in the job of making the audience happy.

This advice is so obvious that it might seem superfluous were it not for the fact that it is sometimes violated even by performers who should know better. One of the classic effects in card magic is Dai Vernon's "Cutting the Aces" from the *Stars of Magic*. Vernon provides an intriguing patter story for this effect. It involves the time he met a one-armed gambler. The gambler offered to demonstrate his ability to cut to the aces. On his last try, the performer offered to bet a thousand dollars that the gambler would not succeed.

To ensure winning the bet, the performer attempted to cheat the gambler by palming the ace. But, the gambler outsmarted him by whipping out a knife and pinning the ace to the table, the knife going between the performer's fingers. The one-armed gambler ends by saying that's the way he himself lost his arm.

The performer narrates this tale as something that happened to him; thus the audience will view him as the protagonist. Yet, in the end he is both out-performed and outwitted by his antagonist, the one-armed gambler. He portrays himself as a petty cheat who tries to swindle a cripple out of a fairly won wager and also an incompetent cheat who gets nailed (almost literally) the moment he makes a move. The antagonist, the one-armed gambler, is the only one who displays any skill or class in this tale. Why any performer would wish to present himself in such an unflattering light is beyond me.

The story of the one-armed gambler is an intriguing one but, told as in the original version, it subverts what the performer should be striving to accomplish, namely, to gain audience empathy and

respect for himself. Yet a simple shift in point of view can gain for the performer the best of both worlds: the same strong story but with audience sympathy in his favor rather than against him.

Suppose the performer tells the story as an episode he once witnessed rather than one in which he participated. Now the one-armed gambler may be presented as the sympathetic protagonist and the other gambler who challenges him and then tries to cheat him can be painted an even blacker villain. Most importantly, the audience will psychologically identify the victorious one-armed gambler with the performer who is narrating the tale and also performing the sleight of hand he attributes to the one-armed gambler.

Before leaving this example I should note that in his book *Magical Adventures and Fairy Tales*, Punx argues that the great strength of the Vernon patter in “Cutting the Aces” is the fact that the audience doesn't know who they should root for, the performer whom they've grown to like during the performance or the one-armed gambler who shows himself to be the better man in this conflict.

To this I will only respond that in magical story patter you should be striving for entertainment not great literature. Moral ambiguity is fine if you are Ingmar Bergman. However, the films of Steven Spielberg gross a great deal more at the box office and nobody ever had any trouble figuring out who was the good guy and who was the bad guy in one of his movies. As a magical *entertainer* this is the kind of simple, gut-level entertainment you should be striving for. Give your protagonist a white hat; give your villain a black hat. Identify yourself with the good guy in the story and make sure that he wins.

Let me conclude this point by providing another example of how switching the perspective in a patter story can strengthen a presentation by making the protagonist the victor. *The Classic Magic of Larry Jennings* contains an outstanding effect called Larry Jennings' “Homing Card.” The performer holds four red cards and the ace of spades. He places the ace aside and shows the remaining four red cards. Yet a moment later, the ace has returned to the packet. The performer still holds only four cards, but one of them is now the ace. This sequence is repeated over and over. Each

time the ace is placed aside it returns to the packet. The packet gets smaller and smaller, but the ace is still there.

Eventually, the performer is down to only two cards, the ace of spades and one red card. He places the ace aside and holds onto the red card. A moment later, this lone card has changed to the ace of spades.

The book provides Michael Skinner's excellent patter story for this trick. It involves the time in the performer's childhood when his father offered to teach him a card trick. The trick involved the ace of spades but, because of a superstitious fear of the card, the performer kept placing it aside. Because the card was required in the trick, the father kept making it magically appear among the performer's cards.

While I found this patter story appealing I did not feel comfortable with casting myself in the role of a student and particularly did not like the idea of the performer losing a duel to someone else, even his own father. Once again, changing the point of view was the solution.

By changing the point of view I was able to preserve essentially the same conflict situation while resolving the conflict in favor of the performer. I'll give my patter exactly as I deliver it in this trick. I think that the action of the effect should be clear from the patter. Just remember the ace is continually placed aside. Yet every time the performer says the phrase "The Ace of Spades Trick," the ace is shown to have returned to the packet. (You'll note this is an example of the tennis match story format I mentioned earlier.)

Sometimes after a performance someone will come up to me and ask me to teach them a card trick. I always try to explain that the kinds of tricks I do take years of practice. You can't just teach someone how to do them in a few minutes. But then they sometimes say, "You must know one easy trick I could do for my friends." I never teach them. Not after what happened the last time I tried to teach someone a card trick.

I had said to the guy, "I'll teach you The Ace of Spades Trick. It uses one red card, two red cards, three red cards, four red cards, and the ace of spades." But I noticed that,

as soon as I handed him the cards, he got a little nervous. He said, "I don't mind using the four red cards. But I've heard that the ace of spades is a bad-luck card. If you don't mind, I'm going to just place the ace of spades aside and do the trick with just the four red cards. I'm sure no one will even notice that I'm using four cards instead of five."

I said, "No, for this trick you need the ace of spades." I palmed the ace of spades—invisibly. I tossed the ace of spades over to his cards and I said to him, "Will you let me teach you The Ace of Spades Trick?"

At this point the guy started to perspire. He said, "I'm part Gypsy. We Gypsies believe the ace of spades is the death card. If you don't mind I'd rather just place the ace of spades aside and do the trick with just three red cards. I'm sure it'll still be a good trick even with only three cards."

I said, "The trick won't work that way." I palmed the ace of spades—invisibly. I tossed the ace over to his cards and I said to him, "Now can I teach you The Ace of Spades Trick?"

He said, "I don't know how you're doing that. But it won't do you any good. I'm afraid of the ace of spades. I'm going to just place the ace of spades aside and do the trick with just two red cards. I'm willing to use this card and this card but not that card."

What could I do? I had to palm the ace of spades—invisibly. I tossed the ace over to his cards and I said to him, "Please let me teach you The Ace of Spades Trick."

At this point his hands started to shake. He said, "I don't mind using the nine of diamonds, but not the ace of spades. That's the death card."

I said, "They don't call this trick the Nine of Diamonds Trick. They call it The Ace of Spades Trick. I palmed the ace of spades—invisibly. I tossed the ace over to him. And

that's when the guy had a fatal heart attack.

Point of view is always a very important consideration in any form of fiction. In fashioning story presentations, you should always ask yourself if you've chosen the right point of view.

Optional Elements

Complications: There are a couple of other traditional storytelling elements you may choose to incorporate into your story pattern. One of these is complications. George M. Cohan once described his formula for a successful play as follows. Act one: get the hero up a tree. Act two: throw rocks at him. Act three: get him down. In more technical language, this might be paraphrased as: introduce the protagonist and lock the conflict. Introduce complications. Resolve the conflict. The rocks that are thrown at the hero are the complications.

Complications are unforeseen barriers that arise in the hero's path as he attempts to achieve his goal. Whether or not your story incorporates complications will be determined by the nature of the effect. However, the complications are usually what make a story interesting. Therefore, effects that involve seemingly unexpected barriers to achieving your goal are usually well-suited for story presentations.

Setting: Although every conflict must take place in some setting, it's up to you to decide whether you want to specify a particular setting in telling your story. Keep in mind, however, that a major advantage of story presentations is that they can generate powerful atmosphere through the use of evocative settings.

Choice of setting is one technique of the scenarist usually unavailable to the magician. A filmmaker may place a scene in whatever setting he feels will most effectively create the mood he wishes to achieve (within the limitations of budget and the demands of the plot). However, a close-up magician must perform his magic in whatever setting he happens to find his audience.

Most gambling routines would be more effective if performed at the baccarat table in the *salon privee* of the SBM Casino in Monte Carlo surrounded by tuxedoed croupiers. Arab playboys, and glamorous

women, or in the back room of a pool hall on a worn poker table under a naked lightbulb in a haze of cigar smoke. Most occult or supernatural effects would be more effective if performed by moonlight on a fallen tombstone in an ancient cemetery, or by candlelight on the bare floor of an abandoned house reputed to have been the sight of a ghastly murder, or by torchlight on the blood-stained altar of an ancient pagan temple in a remote South American jungle never before visited by civilized man. But, if you've been hired to perform in glaring sunlight on cheap lawn furniture beside the pool at a house party in the suburbs, that's where you're going to have to do the trick.

However, in a story presentation, through the power of your words you can transport your audience to any one of those settings or countless others that may be particularly conducive to your type of magic. Here again, the presentations of René Lavand as set out in his books are worth studying. Each tale unfolds in a well-defined setting: a casino in Marbella, Spain; a riverboat on the Mississippi; Tijuana, Mexico; even Elizabeth, New Jersey.

There is no tool more capable of generating strong atmosphere in magic than a story presentation with a strong sense of place. Not only will the atmosphere thus created strengthen that particular effect, but it will linger to color all the subsequent effects in that performance.

Avoiding Pitfalls

To effectively use story patter, it's important that you appreciate not only the strengths, but also the potential weaknesses of this approach. We've seen that story patter offers two advantages: first, the ability to generate strong emotional involvement on the part of the audience because of their interest in the outcome of the conflict that lies at the heart of the story; second, the ability to generate strong atmosphere.

It also contains two disadvantages. First, by their nature, story effects seldom provide any audience participation. After all, the spectators weren't there when the events of the story actually occurred, so how can they play a part in the recreation of those events? Consequently, story tricks typically cast the audience in the

role of witnesses rather than participants. Most story effects are what David Roth calls shut-up-and-watch tricks.

I'm not for a moment suggesting that an effect must contain audience participation to be strong. Some of the most powerful effects in close-up magic are of the shut-up-and-watch type. However, an overreliance on such effects places the audience in too passive a role and thus makes it harder to maintain a high level of audience involvement.

The second problem with story tricks is that they lack a sense of immediacy. In reality, of course, the audience is watching events that are happening now. Nevertheless, since the theme of these effects is the retelling of events that occurred some time in the past, these tricks contain a particularly predetermined quality as compared to most other close-up magic.

It's the difference in feel between watching a taped television program and watching a live news telecast of some exciting event as it is unfolding. The former can certainly be entertaining; however, the latter can be riveting. The sense of immediacy is one of the greatest strengths of live entertainment in general and close-up magic in particular, but it is this very sense of immediacy that suffers in story effects.

Once again this "canned" quality of story tricks only becomes a problem if you use too many such tricks in one performance. If you do only one or two story effects in the course of a full close-up show, the disadvantages are far outweighed by the advantages cited earlier, not to mention the variety that a good story trick can contribute to a performance. Nevertheless, I think it's worth examining techniques that may sometimes be successfully incorporated into story presentations to overcome the problems of audience passivity and lack of immediacy, thus achieving the best of both worlds.

Audience Participation: A moment ago I suggested that spectators can't play a role in a story trick because they weren't present when the story originally occurred. Actually, that doesn't necessarily follow. You can actively involve spectators in the story through the simple expedient of *casting* them in the roles of various participants in the original episode.

Dai Vernon's presentation for "Triumph" as published in the *Stars of Magic* is a patter story. Vernon tells of one particular occasion on which he was performing a pick-a-card trick. After the spectator had selected a card and returned it to the deck, Vernon handed him the pack to shuffle. To his amazement, the spectator shuffled face-up cards and face-down cards together, then handed back the deck with the challenge, "Find my card now!" Vernon triumphed over this unforeseen complication by causing all the cards to magically turn face down except for the selection.

When Vernon speaks of the spectator in the story having selected a card, he has a spectator in his audience select a card. When he says that the spectator returned the card to the deck, he has the spectator in the audience return the card to the deck. Thus, for the first part of the effect, Vernon has, in effect, cast an audience member to play the part of the spectator in the story.

Casting a spectator to play the part of a spectator must qualify as the ultimate in typecasting. It's the most obvious and most common application of the idea of having a spectator play an active part in a story trick. However, it's not the only way you can use this idea.

In my version of the "Magician vs. Gambler" I tell the story of a wager between an old card shark and a young card shark. The old man bet his entire bankroll and the young one bet the keys to his brand-new car. When I get to the point in the story where I mention the wagers I ask two of the spectators to act as stakeholders. I hand one of them my wallet and I hand the other my keycase. Although they don't know it yet, these two props will become very important later since a previously signed card will be found in each of them.

What I've done is to cast two spectators to play the parts of two of the original participants in the story I'm telling, thereby giving them an active role in the proceedings. This not only draws these two people more deeply into the effect, it draws in the rest of the audience since they will identify with their two representatives.

The standard approach in story effects is for the performer to play all the roles. However, it's actually only essential for him to play the role of the protagonist. When routining any story trick, consider whether any spectators can be cast in supporting roles. This is

particularly effective if the role calls for the spectator to make a choice or decision of some kind at some point in the effect. However, even if the spectator's functions will be perfunctory, it may be worth doing to achieve a sense of audience participation—as long as it fits the story and doesn't slow things down too much.

A point worth remembering is that, unlike in casting a movie, in a story effect a spectator may be effectively cast to play a certain role for only part of the story. For example, in Vernon's "Triumph" presentation, the audience member is only cast in the role of the difficult spectator for the first part of the story. He selects a card and returns it to the deck as the earlier spectator had done. However, when the performer speaks of the difficult spectator in the story having shuffled the deck face up and face down, he does the shuffling himself.

Immediacy and Failure: If you want to battle the problem of story tricks lacking immediacy, there are two techniques you can use. The first is the failure motif. It's often been said that the early days of live television had an excitement lacking today. This is because everyone participating and everyone watching knew that it was always possible for something to go wrong; even if it did, it would still go over the air. This is also true when you perform a story trick since you are "live," not on tape.

However, if you're really a smooth professional, the audience is likely to forget there is a possibility of something going wrong—unless something does go wrong. The moment they see you're in trouble, they think, "Oh-oh, that wasn't in the script. What's he going to do now?" They are riveted by what is happening, totally absorbed in the moment. They are suddenly very aware that what they are watching is happening *now*; it's not merely a replay of something that happened in the past.

In the "Magician vs. Gambler," you explain that the magician had to cut to four of a kind in order to win. You then proceed with the effect in such a way as to lead the audience to think that the magician effortlessly succeeded in doing just that. When, instead, you miss on the last card, the audience is shocked and so, apparently, are you. When you succeed in bringing the effect to a successful conclusion and it becomes apparent that the "miss" was

itself part of the story you were telling, you have succeeded in achieving the best of both worlds, a story trick with a feeling of immediacy.

This technique is not applicable to all story tricks, but please keep it in mind for those where it may be. The failure motif is so powerful that I'll give it separate attention later in this discussion of situational meaning. For now it is enough to note that it can be a powerful tool for counteracting that *rehearsed* feeling that can hamper story presentations.

Background Stories: The other technique for adding immediacy to story tricks is to use the story as *background* to the effect rather than as the plot of the effect. I can best explain this with an example. In Punx's book *Magical Adventures and Fairy Tales* he has a great presentation for the rotating key trick. This is the effect where a large, old-fashioned key turns mysteriously while balanced on your fingertip.

Punx tells the story of the night he spent in a reputedly haunted room in an old Scottish Inn. Unable to sleep, he stayed up by candlelight. The story itself is being told by candlelight. He mentions the room key which he left in the door when he went to bed, then produces that key from his pocket and balances it on his finger. He tells of seeing the key turn in the lock as if held by an invisible hand. As he describes this, the key on his fingertip starts to turn. He tells of how the key fell to the floor and the candle was suddenly extinguished. On cue, the key falls from his finger and he blows out the candle. (If you're wondering who the antagonist in this story is, it's the ghost; the key's movement would possess little menace were it not for the implication of a ghostly presence behind it.)

This is a beautiful presentation which cannot be faulted in any way. Suppose, however, you make the artistic judgment that you want to achieve greater immediacy in your presentation of this effect. You might proceed as follows. We'll assume you're attending a dinner party. After dinner the guests are sitting around talking. The conversation turns to the subject of the supernatural (because you've skillfully steered it in that direction). As always happens in such cases, various people recount uncanny experiences they've had.

Now it's your turn. You tell of your recent vacation to England and the night you spent in a Scottish Inn in a room rumored to be haunted. The story goes that a grisly murder was committed in that room a century ago. You didn't obtain any other details except that the crime occurred on the stroke of midnight.

When you first checked in, the thought of sleeping in a haunted room amused you. But as midnight approached you had second thoughts. As you lay in bed, you heard a distant clock strike twelve. A moment later you thought you heard a noise at the door. Looking in that direction you saw the key which you'd left in the keyhole turn slowly of its own accord. A moment later it fell to the floor.

What may have occurred in the room after that you'll never know because you were out of there in a flash and spent the rest of the night in your car. When you returned the next morning to collect your belongings, on an impulse you took the room key. (At this point you remove the key from your pocket.)

At first you tried to convince yourself that what you thought you'd seen was a case of your eyes playing tricks on you in the moonlight. However, since that trip you have on several occasions seen something unexplainable happen to that key, always exactly at midnight. Someone points out that it is almost midnight now. (You have, of course, carefully timed the start of your story. If the group is a little slow on the uptake, you yourself can "notice" that it's almost midnight.)

You look at your watch as the second hand approaches midnight. Just as it reaches twelve, you shift your attention to the key which is now balanced on your fingertip. Slowly, it is seen to rotate as if turned by a ghostly hand, then fall to the floor.

Feel free to employ this presentation if you wish. You don't even have to wait until midnight. Admittedly, the witching hour adds a strong atmospheric touch. However, as long as you perform the trick at night, you can always claim that the murder occurred five minutes after whatever time you start telling the story.

This presentation employs the same effect and essentially the same pattern story that Punx did. However, where Punx's performance was a reenactment of the story, my presentation uses the story only as a

prologue to the exhibition of a phenomenon which is happening now and which, therefore, no one can be certain will actually occur until the moment it does. (Study Henry Christ's "Dead Man's Hand" for another good example of using story patter as background.)

The previous presentation utilized what I call the Occult Formula, one that is very common in the field of bizarre magic: (1) The performer introduces an exotic prop. (2) He then tells some supernatural tale concerning that prop. (3) He uses the prop to produce a phenomenon that appears to validate the tale.

In the above case, I felt it would be dramatically more effective to tell the tale first, then introduce the prop. However, that's only a minor variation on the formula. It's a formula particularly well suited to effects with an occult or supernatural theme and one you'll encounter often if you read publications specializing in bizarre magic. It shouldn't be surprising that a branch of close-up magic that relies so heavily on the creation of atmosphere should make frequent use of story patter.

This background story technique is not only applicable to supernatural effects like "The Haunted Key," "The Dead Man's Hand," and bizarre magic effects. Here is an example from my own repertoire where I use the idea to present a straight card magic effect. I use this presentation for a two-card transposition effect where a card placed in my pocket changes places with another card held in my hand. The effect, called "Nulda's Revenge," will appear in *Cardshark*. However, there are several published "pocket transpositions" to which the patter could be applied equally well. Here is my exact patter:

In my book Gambling Scams I tell a story about a card cheat I know who specializes in holding out. This means that early in the game he palms a high card out of the deck and hides it in his pocket. Later, when it will do the most good, he switches that card for one of the cards he's been dealt.

On one occasion he went to the post office and bought some stamps. Later he was playing poker in a cardroom in Gardena, California. Forgetting that he had stamps in

his pocket, he pulled his scam of palming out a card and slipping it into his pocket. Later he switched that card for one of the ones he was dealt. It wasn't until he spread his hand on the table that he saw that the switched-in card had a postage stamp glued to the face. A little old lady in the game looked up at him and said, "So, someone mailed you an ace of diamonds?"

Some readers have questioned whether a card cheat could really switch a card in his hand for one in his pocket in a game without getting caught. Let's put the question to the test.

At this point, I perform the two-card transposition effect. The effect does not involve postage stamps and is in no way presented as a recreation of the story I've told. Rather, an amusing anecdote is used as a prelude to the effect, both for its inherent entertainment value and to add meaning to what would otherwise be an amazing but meaningless effect. (The anecdote is told as a spectator is signing the faces of the cards to be used in the effect, so the story also serves to fill in what would otherwise be dead time.)

Overshadowing the Magic: A final danger to avoid in story presentations is creating a situation where the tail (tale?) wags the dog. It's important not to lose sight of the fact that the story should support the magic, not the other way around. Unfortunately, the story patter approach tends to attract magicians who are more interested in talking than in doing magic. This is one of the biggest reasons the technique has fallen into disrepute with some magicians. Very few magicians have the storytelling skills to hold an audience's interest throughout a long story, yet too many are willing to try.

Even if you do possess such skill, it's still better for the sake of your magic to show restraint. René Lavand, perhaps the most effective exponent of story presentations in close-up magic, is acutely aware of the danger of allowing the story to overshadow the magic. He has often spoken of the need to achieve "equilibrium" between story and effect rather than "allowing the story to kill the magic or the magic to kill the story."

I've already praised Punx's book *Magical Adventures and Fairy*

Tales. However, one effect in that book provides a good example of what I advise against. Punx gives his presentation for the “Penetration Frame.” He observes that the effect itself takes only about a minute. Yet, he tells us that his story presentation for the effect takes six minutes. He goes on to say that often at the conclusion of this effect some audience members are in tears. I don't doubt that statement since the patter is quite touching. I'm sure, however, it's the story that is evoking this reaction, not the magic.

Punx boasts that no audience member has ever asked him after the show how he did the “Penetration Frame” effect. I suggest this is because the magic element has been eclipsed by the captivating tale. If they don't care how you did it, they haven't been sufficiently touched by the impossibility of what you did, and *confronting the impossible is the essence of magical entertainment*.

Storytelling is a form of entertainment in itself, one that is presently enjoying a revival. A skilled storyteller can bring an audience to tears without doing any magic. So can a talented playwright, filmmaker, actor, or singer. The one thing that magic can do that these other forms of entertainment cannot is to evoke awe by confronting the audience with the inexplicable. If you wish to entertain your audience with magic, evoking that reaction must be your prime goal; everything else must be secondary.

If your storytelling is so compelling that it overshadows the magic, you're succeeding as a raconteur but failing as a magician. There is nothing wrong with that if that's your goal, but don't call yourself a magician. Interestingly, Punx's introduction to his book begins with the words: “Don't call me just a magician or a conjuror; storyteller would be just right”

No doubt, many will argue that as long as the audience is entertained, that's all that matters. (This argument is most often put forward by people who couldn't entertain an audience if their lives depended on it.) However, entertainment can vary in nature as well as caliber; you have to decide the nature of the entertainment you want to give your audience.

The same issue arises in comedy magic. It's possible to generate a

great deal of laughter with magic, but it's also possible to generate a great deal of laughter without bothering to do any magic, as many standup comics have proven. Sometimes, a certain type of gag or a gag at the wrong moment may work to undercut the impact of the magic by acting as a distraction. This is all right for a comic who is using magic merely as a gimmick. But it's not acceptable for a true comedy magician. If he considers himself a magician he will do nothing to hurt his magic, even if it means eliminating a cherished gag.

Frankly, the above discussion is irrelevant to most magicians since they don't have the storytelling skills to hold an audience with a six-minute tale. For them, it's enough to note that you risk boring your audience if a patter story is too long and elaborate. I discuss this point at greater length in the section on Pacing under the title "Verbal Overkill." Therefore, for now, I'll only urge you to remember that in a story presentation the story should exist to enhance the magic. The magic should not exist as an excuse to tell the story. Your goal should be to have the story develop at the same rate that the action develops. That means no six-minute patter for a one-minute effect.

Am I being inconsistent in advising you to consider including details like the setting of your story and the characteristics of your antagonist, then telling you to keep it short? No, but I am being demanding. I realize it takes hard work to find just the few key, telling details to include that will flesh out a story without dragging it out. But, with enough thought you can do it. And it's vital to do it if you're going to achieve the right balance between narrative and magic. Like *Reader's Digest*, you've got to cut all the fat and make every word count.

This is particularly important to remember when using background stories as in my rotating key presentation since, in such a case, you often have to relate the entire story before the magic even begins. Keep the tale moving and get to the magical climax quickly.

Dramatic Reality: After all this talk about the potential problems of story presentations, it might be well to finish this discussion by focusing again on the great strength of this technique, its ability to give meaning to our magic by giving it implications beyond the

mere facts of the trick itself.

This is perfectly illustrated by the following example from my own repertoire, a version of the Torn and Restored Card which I call “The Marker.” (Yes, it will also be appearing in *Cardshark*.)

I begin by having a spectator select a card and sign it on the back. I then tell the audience of an experience I once had in a poker game. A player who lost to me didn't have enough cash to cover his losses, so I agreed to accept a “marker” (I.O.U.). The player didn't have any paper, so he wrote the marker on the back of one of the playing cards. As I say this, I'm writing something around the spectator's signature. I then have the spectator read aloud what is now written on the card: “I.O.U. \$5,000. Signed, [spectator's signature].” (This causes considerable amusement and is a good example of incorporating audience participation in a story presentation.)

I explain that the player tried to welch on his debt by palming the card out of the deck, leaving the table, and tearing up the marker. (As I say this, I tear up the spectator's signed, selected card.) When I discovered this, I gathered the pieces and restored the card to its original whole condition. (I illustrate this statement by restoring the spectator's card.) Thus, I was able to collect on the marker with a little help from magic . . . and a lot of help from my friend “Tony the Enforcer!”

Consider what this presentation accomplishes. Tearing up a playing card destroys the deck. Restoring the card saves you from having to spend two dollars and fifty cents to buy another pack, not exactly a matter of earthshaking import. However, destroying a negotiable instrument worth five thousand dollars is another matter. If you restore that, it really means something.

No doubt, some will respond that the audience knows that the story isn't true and that the card being torn and restored is not worth thousands of dollars. It's also true that when an audience sees an actor act out a death scene on stage they know that the play is not true and the actor isn't really dying. Nevertheless, such a scene may bring the audience to tears. This is because a good story well told creates a *dramatic reality* that has its effect on an audience despite the fact that they know it's not true.

The realization that the story is fiction is an *intellectual* one; the impact of the dramatic reality is an *emotional* one. Good story patter captures an audience's imagination, which is what all good magic should do.

As with any dramatic technique, proper use of story presentations requires care and a lot of thinking. You mustn't overdo it, either in the sense of using the technique too frequently or in the sense of over-elaborating the story to the point where it dwarfs the magic. However, when used skillfully, story presentation can be a very powerful tool in pursuing our goal of making the audience care about what we do.

Conflict Between Spectators

The idea of creating a conflict between two different spectators is one which you will not be able to use often. Although it's a less versatile situation than the others we've discussed, nevertheless, in certain tricks it can be exploited very effectively. Consider the "Endless Chain" effect. The performer forms a chain into a figure eight and demonstrates that if a finger is placed in one loop the chain catches, but if the finger is placed in the other loop the chain comes free. This is usually presented as a gambling game in which the spectator attempts to win by picking the loop that will catch. Needless to say, he always fails.

This standard presentation creates a conflict between the performer and the spectator and can be quite effective for that reason. However, here is an original presentation that places the emphasis on a conflict between two spectators.

The performer demonstrates how the game works and claims that it is an old-time swindle used by grifters. He explains that the con man's key to winning is his ability to judge character. He must succeed in picking as his opponent someone who is irresolute, easy to psyche out, and lacking in the courage of his convictions.

Turning to a woman in the audience he comments that he would never pick her as an opponent because he can tell that she is just the sort of strong-willed individual who would be impossible to beat. He then turns to the woman's husband or boyfriend and states that if

he were playing for money this is just the kind of weak-willed opponent he would want. (This line is delivered tongue-in-cheek so as not to offend.)

The performer allows the man to play and he loses. Forming another figure eight, he turns to the woman and allows her to choose a loop. She wins. The rest of the routine follows this pattern. Most of the time the game is played with the man and he loses every time. Occasionally, however, the performer turns to the woman and asks her to show her husband how it's done. Every time she plays she wins.

Throughout the routine the performer can generate considerable humor by commenting about the man's vacillation or his tendency to look to others for guidance as the reason for his losing. He tells the spectator that he must learn to think for himself and have faith in his judgment or he'll never win. This is the secret his wife has learned.

At one point, the performer can effectively use a clever bit from Jules Lenier's "Endless Chain" routine. The spectator places his finger in one loop. The performer points to the other loop and gives the spectator a knowing wink. If the spectator moves his finger to the loop indicated by the performer, he pulls the chain free and the spectator loses. The performer comments, "You think I'm going to help you? *She* never would have fallen for that." If the spectator keeps his finger in the original loop, the performer pulls the chain free and the spectator loses. The performer comments, "You can't say I didn't try to help!"

Finally, the performer forms the figure and has the man place one finger in each loop. He pulls the chain taut. Now comes the moment of truth. The spectator must remove one finger. Will he choose the correct one? The performer turns to the wife and asks her to advise her husband on which finger to remove.

At this point, the husband may choose to heed her advice or to ignore her. Of course, the performer has arranged things so that either way the man loses. If he has ignored her advice, he loses and the performer finishes by saying, "Someday maybe you'll learn to listen to her." If he has followed her advice, he loses and the

performer finishes by saying, "Someday maybe you'll learn to have faith in your own judgment."

Anyone familiar with the throws used in the "Endless Chain" will easily follow the method for the preceding routine. The important point is that the performer has fashioned a strong, meaningful presentation from a conflict he has generated between two spectators, one in which he seems to only play the part of a referee and friendly advisor.

In fact, the concept could be taken still further by abandoning the gambling con premise entirely and presenting the chain game as a new device now being used in marriage counseling. With enough creative thought this could make for an extremely funny routine with the performer playing the part of the counselor.

Note, incidentally, that the patter has been fashioned so as to foreshadow the climax regardless of whether or not the spectator follows his wife's advice. If he disregards her advice it is logical that he lose because it has been established that she is the only one who can beat the game. If he follows her advice it is logical that he lose because the performer has stressed that the spectator's fatal flaw is his willingness to be swayed by others. (For the record, I'll call the above presentation "The Lady or the Tiger?")

I'll provide you one more example of an effective spectator vs. spectator presentation for a standard trick. "The Spelling Lesson" is an old effect in which the performer removes all thirteen cards of one suit from the deck. He shuffles the packet then spells "ace," transferring one card from the top of the packet to the bottom for each letter. He then turns over the new top card of the packet and it is the ace. He repeats the process to produce the two and the three.

He then hands the packet to a spectator who is instructed to spell out "four." However, when the spectator finishes spelling and turns over the top card, it is the wrong card, perhaps a joker. The performer spells "four" and succeeds in arriving at the four. This pattern continues, the performer always arriving at the spelled card and the spectator always producing the joker when he tries, until all thirteen cards have been spelled out.

This effect also plays off a conflict between the performer and a

spectator, but not a very strong conflict because the effect doesn't really have much point. Who cares whether the cards come out in the right order or not?

Consider this alternative presentation designed for family audiences. The performer approaches a youngster in the audience who is perhaps ten or eleven years old. He asks the child if he is smart in school. He then asks how good he is at spelling. The performer explains that spelling is important in magic; if you misspell a word when writing out a magic formula or incantation the mistake could have disastrous results.

The performer then produces the packet of cards and has the child spell "ace" and turn over the top card. It is, of course, the ace. The youngster also succeeds in spelling and locating the two and the three. Now the performer hands the packet to the child's father and has him spell "four." Instead of the four, the joker turns up. The routine continues in this fashion. The child is always successful and the parent is always unsuccessful.

In effect, the child has been cast in the role which the performer plays in the standard presentation while the parent is cast in the role of the hapless spectator. The performer is once again only a referee who provides occasional pointed comments. ("And scientists claim that IQ is hereditary!" "Obviously, young man, you take after your mother." "Does your father ever help you with your homework? No? You're lucky.")

This presentation should produce considerable glee from the child, both at his success and at his parent's failure. This, in turn, will generate entertainment for the rest of the audience. Because the child will consider the whole enterprise important, it will become important to the audience.

Keep in mind that in order for a spectator vs. spectator conflict to be effective, the audience must be given *cause* to root for one over the other. Indeed, this is true of any conflict presentation. Many movies have failed with audiences because they were unable to generate any sympathy for the protagonist. Consequently, people simply didn't care whether the hero or villain triumphed.

In a presentation where the performer is cast as the protagonist in

the conflict, the audience will presumably root for him because he has previously established his character as appealing and sympathetic and has established a rapport with them. In the case of a spectator vs. spectator conflict, if you were simply to choose two spectators at random from the audience with whom to do the spelling trick, the presentation would have little impact.

The two examples I've just given work because they exploit built-in conflicts of family life: the inevitable conflicts between spouses and the inherent conflicts between parent and child. They provide emotional satisfaction for the audience by, in each case, casting the underdog in the conflict as the victor. (Our society is still sufficiently male-dominated that the wife or girlfriend will be viewed as the sympathetic underdog figure in the "Endless Chain" routine.) If you were to perform the "Endless Chain" with the wife as the loser and the husband as the winner it would be far less effective. If you were to reverse the roles of parent and child in the "Spelling Lesson," the results would be disastrous.

These two examples also draw strength from exploiting two standard clichés of television sitcoms and indeed of our society in general, the domineering wife or girlfriend paired with a weak-willed man and the crafty child who always outwits his parents. Let me repeat here the point I stressed in the discussion on story patter: In any conflict presentation the audience must have reason to root for one of the principals and they must be given the emotional satisfaction of seeing that principal win.

Other Conflicts

Before leaving the subject of conflict situations I want to point out that performer's conflicts need not involve other people or even machines. A clever performer can create audience interest even by becoming locked in combat with an inanimate object. If you ever saw Fred Kaps perform Braue's "The Homing Card" you know what I mean. Again and again Kaps was foiled by a black card that stubbornly insisted on returning to the packet of red cards in his hand. When performed by a master actor like Fred Kaps this became a real and very funny conflict.

The performer may even find himself in a conflict with fate itself.

This approach works best as a comedic theme for an entire act. Despite his best efforts, everything seems to go wrong for the performer. He just can't seem to get a break. The audience looks forward to each new effect to see what obstacles will arise in the hapless performer's path and how he will cope with them.

If you use some imagination, you'll find there are many opportunities to inject conflict into your effects. In so doing, you'll make those effects more gripping and more meaningful to the audience.

Risk

When I was a youngster, my father would watch boxing on television every Friday night. I always found these matches excruciatingly boring. I couldn't wait for them to be over so I could watch something on TV that I liked.

One Friday night my father proposed that we wager a quarter on the fight. I chose a boxer at random to bet on. That night I found the boxing match riveting.

Professional gamblers have long known that *any* event becomes more interesting if you've got a bet down on it. That's why whenever things get boring they find something to wager on. Whether it's which drop of rainwater will reach the bottom of a window pane first or which sugar cube a fly will decide to land on, such wagers turn boring waiting periods into interesting experiences.

Remember "The Man From the South"? The situation in that story was so compelling, not only because of the conflict, but also because the stakes were so high. The young man risked losing his little finger.

As a magician, you can sometimes make an effect far more compelling by raising the stakes. In other words, offer to risk something of value on the outcome of the trick. Presentations of this kind usually fall into two categories, financial risk and physical risk.

Performer's Financial Risk: Examples of financial risk presentations would include gambling routines in which the performer plays a game of cards with one or more spectators and offers to forfeit some sizable amount of money if he loses. A specific

example of this approach is “Beat the Dealer” from *Cardshark*.

Other illustrations of this presentation can be found in Del Ray's act.

Non-gambling examples of this approach include prediction effects where the performer backs up his prediction with a hundred-dollar bill as in John Thompson's version of Koran's “Five-Star Prediction.” Another is the classic “Bank Night” effect where several spectators are given a chance to win some of the performer's money if only they can guess correctly. Some performers use the same approach for Annemann's “Seven Keys to Baldpate” trick. The lock guards a substantial amount of cash which will go to whoever picks the right key.

There are a great many other effects to which this type of presentation could be adapted. Of course, it won't work for every effect. Offering to risk a hundred-dollar bill on the outcome of an ace assembly doesn't make much sense. What you need is a trick where you can state in advance what the desired effect will be and in which the chances of failure seem great. Indeed, for best results, the odds against success should seem overwhelming. Even a pick-a-card trick can be enhanced by offering to wager money on your success, but only if it's a pick-a-card trick that's performed under seemingly impossible conditions.

I need hardly add that it should also be a trick where there is actually no possibility of your failing. The audience would be embarrassed, not entertained, to see you fall flat on your face.

Some magicians fail to grasp this last point. They mistakenly feel that the appeal of such presentations is that the spectators have a chance to win something. If this were true, only the spectator who has an opportunity to win the money would be interested in the effect. The rest of the audience would be bored.

The real appeal of these presentations is not that the spectator might win something of value but that the performer might *lose* something of value. This doesn't mean that the audience wants to see the performer lose. They no more want to see you lose your money than they would want to see a tightrope walker fall as he is attempting to cross Niagara Falls. But it's the *possibility* that he might fall, combined with his willingness to face that risk, that

makes it interesting. Similarly, when you risk money on the outcome of a trick, it's the risk you're taking, the prospect that you *might* lose, and the question of how you'll react if you do, that give the situation drama.

Performer's Physical Risk: For that reason, even presentations where the audience does not stand to gain anything from the risk the performer is taking can be riveting. That's why effects where the performer risks his safety or physical well-being can achieve an almost hypnotic hold over an audience. The audience doesn't stand to gain anything from the outcome, but the performer stands to lose a great deal.

The field of escapology has used this form of situational meaning ever since the days of Houdini. Escaping from a straight jacket has no substantive meaning whatever for audiences since most of them have had no experience with straight jackets and don't foresee ever being restrained in one. However, suspend the straight jacketed performer upside down by a rope over a field of upturned spears and then set the rope on fire and the situation will provide the meaning that the substance lacks. Countless other examples could be cited from the escape field, from Houdini's underwater packing-case escape to David Copperfield's escape from a building set to be demolished in moments.

Mentalists have also utilized physical risk in their presentations. There is the "Russian Roulette" effect where the performer risks getting his brains blown out, the "Gallows Test" where he risks getting his neck stretched, and the "Acid Test" where he must drink from the glasses containing water and avoid the one containing deadly acid.

The concept of physical risk has been almost completely ignored in the field of close-up magic. However, with imagination it should be possible to find opportunities to incorporate the drama of physical risk into certain close-up effects.

Spectator's Risk: Not only can an effect become meaningful because the performer places something of value at risk, it can become meaningful because a *spectator* places something of value at risk.

Such presentations usually have a comedic as well as dramatic

element since the spectator is usually a reluctant participant.

The typical scenario is that a spectator lends the performer a large-denomination bill or a piece of expensive jewelry, only to discover after it's too late that the loaned item is going to be put in some kind of jeopardy. We've already discussed the "Bank Night" effect in which the performer puts some of his own money at risk. Terry Seabrooke's famous "Signed Note in Wallet" demonstrates that the same effect can become even more compelling, and certainly more funny, when it's a spectator whose money is put at risk.

Apparent Risk Only: This is a good point to remind ourselves that we are in the business of creating illusions. What I've been discussing in this section is how effects can be made meaningful by incorporating the *illusion* of risk. It would be irresponsible in the extreme to actually ever put someone else's property at risk. Similarly, it would be foolhardy to take chances with your safety just for the sake of a trick. In order for the presentation to be effective, the audience must be made to believe you're at risk; that doesn't mean you actually have to be at risk.

Finally, if you're going to wager money on an effect, it should be one where the chances of failure seem great but are actually nil. It must be one in which you are in control at all times and no spectator can do anything to screw you up, either unwittingly or wittingly. (Money brings out the worst in some people.) Not only would it be financially hurtful for you to fail, it would be a very uncomfortable experience for your audience to witness it. So make sure you pick a trick that is absolutely failsafe. If nothing else, the money you put up should provide you with incentive to practice.

Failure

One of the most effective, and versatile, ways of creating a meaningful situation during a trick is to appear to get into trouble during its performance. Most magicians realize this to a greater or lesser extent, but many don't really understand why. I've heard magicians say, "Audiences love to see a magician screw up." If this were true, most magicians would be very popular indeed with their audiences. Unless you've managed to alienate your audience, they won't want to see you screw up. Nevertheless, the spectacle of a

magician in trouble can exert an almost hypnotic control over an audience. They don't want to see you screw up, but they can't turn their eyes away if you do.

The key to this paradox lies in Dariel Fitzkee's brilliant insight that people are more interested in people than in anything else. Character fascinates people, and character is revealed under pressure. Most of the time you can maintain a facade in dealing with the world. But, when things go wrong, that's when the real you emerges.

People know this instinctively and are therefore always eager to see how another will respond to pressure. Audiences aren't attracted by the fact of your screwing up. It's the question of how you will react to the screw-up that holds them captive. Indeed, the more an audience likes you—the more they want to see you succeed—the more captivated they will be by the situation if you apparently fail.

If what interests people in a trick going wrong is how you react, just how do they want to see you react? Assuming they like you, it's pretty clear they would like to see you triumph over the problem. In this way, the magician-in-trouble premise offers the classic dramatic formula. The hero sets out to achieve a goal. Unforeseen problems threaten his success. In the end, he overcomes them and achieves his goal.

There are many effects that are structured to allow you to do just that. There are, in fact, too many to mention; I'm sure you could cite many examples yourself. If you've never experimented with such effects I strongly recommend you do so. You'll find that such effects can be among the most powerful you can perform.

The failure technique is often used by magicians, but seldom effectively. Too often when a magician tries this ploy, the audience simply thinks, “Oh, I get it. Now the magician is going to pretend he's in trouble.” In order for this technique to give meaning to an effect and generate emotion in the audience, they must believe you really are in trouble. This requires some convincing acting on your part. I recommend you read Henning Nelms' discussion of the “silent script” concept in *Magic and Showmanship* for help in this department.

Because credibility is central to the success of this technique, it's particularly effective in tricks that seem to require great skill or those that are performed under impossible conditions. In such cases, it's difficult for the audience to see how the effect could possibly work. Therefore, they'll find it easy to believe that it didn't work.

Some magicians avoid “sucker effects,” believing that audiences will resent being made suckers of when they discover that the performer was never really in trouble but was only conning them into believing he was. This thinking fails to grasp the proper psychology of this type of effect.

It is true, of course, that you're only pretending to be in trouble. It's also true that, in retrospect, the audience will realize intellectually that this was the case. However, if you sell the trick properly, people will react, not on the basis of their intellectual beliefs, but rather on the basis of their emotional beliefs. To put it differently, they will react to the dramatic reality rather than what they know to be the true reality.

It is, however, critical that you understand the effect you're trying to create. That effect is not that you fooled the audience into thinking you were in trouble. The effect should be that you really were in trouble but were able to extricate yourself through your magical powers. If you act your part in the drama with a clear view of the dramatic reality you're trying to create, you won't alienate your audience. You will, instead, create tremendous situational meaning. The effect will become important to the audience because they want to see how you deal with the situation that has unexpectedly arisen.

The failure of many magicians to understand the psychology of the magician-in-trouble ploy is indicated by the very term “sucker effect.” *For an audience to see you in trouble doesn't provide entertainment, it only creates the conditions for entertainment.* It generates audience interest. The next question is how you get yourself out of trouble. If you do it by applying your magical skills—by doing something ingenious or impossible—the audience will be pleased. And the more hopeless your situation seems, the more emotionally gratifying it is for the audience when you triumph.

If, however, your attitude reveals that you were playing the

audience for suckers, they may not be pleased. The failure technique should not be an opportunity for you to gloat or make people feel like suckers. Like the various substantive meaning topics we discussed, this situational meaning technique offers you an opportunity to show that your magical powers have practical applications—that they're useful. In this case they prove useful in getting you out of an embarrassing situation.

Magic Happening To The Spectator

One final situation that can give great meaning to an otherwise meaningless effect occurs when the magic actually happens to one of the spectators. I'm not speaking here merely of audience participation as such. Audience participation can offer many advantages, for example, in strengthening the conditions. If you shuffle the deck, you may cheat; if a spectator shuffles, everyone knows the cards are really mixed. Audience participation can also have disadvantages, for example, slowing down the pacing of an effect. It almost certainly will take the spectator longer to shuffle than it would take you to do so. However, there is a big difference between the spectator merely participating in an effect and being the subject of the effect. It's the latter case I want to consider now.

In the Hand: The most common—and one of the most effective—methods of having the magic happen to a spectator is causing it to occur in the spectator's hand. The best-known example is the “Sponge Balls.” Other effects include “Copper- Silver” in the spectator's hand, and Michael Skinner's brilliant ending for the “Coins Across” in which the last coin vanishes from the performer's hand and joins the other three coins in the spectator's closed fist.

Similarly, there are many card effects where one or more cards change while held by a spectator or while under a spectator's hand (for example, Annemann's “Card In Hand” and Fechter's “Be Honest, What is it?”). In *Cardshark*, I have an effect that takes the concept further. Four kings under a spectator's hand change places with the ace of spades; not only does the identity of the cards under the hand change, the quantity changes also. There are still other card effects in which a card either materializes in, or disappears from, a packet of cards under the spectator's hand.

In such effects, the magic does not just happen in the spectator's hand; in a sense, it happens *to* the spectator's hand. When I perform “McDonald Aces” I use the standard approach of having a young lady place her hand on the leader packet. Then as I vanish each ace I explain that the aces are actually changing places with the cards under the spectator's hand. At the end, she lifts her hand and discovers the four aces. Often at the end of the effect the spectator will stare at the palm of her hand in wonderment. This is the greatest strength of “McDonald Aces.” In most ace assemblies, the magic happens to the aces. In “McDonald Aces,” the magic happens to the spectator. The aces are merely the agency through which that magic happens.

With creativity it's possible to apply the in-the-hands formula to many effects that might not at first glance appear suitable. When Roger Klause does “Twisting the Aces,” the last ace turns face up while the cards are held by a spectator. Ed Marlo has published a handling for the “Ladies' Looking Glass” in which the last phase occurs while a spectator holds the deck. Similarly, in one phase of Daryl's “Ambitious Card” routine the card rises to the top while the spectator holds the deck. Johnny Benzais created a brilliant “Card Through the Table” effect, since adapted to coins, where the card penetrates and lands in a spectator's hand. Jeff McBride and Juan Tamariz have devised “Rising Card” effects that happen while the spectator holds the deck.

It will reward you greatly to give thought to what effects in your repertoire can be adapted to this approach. Invariably, the trick will become stronger. Remember, Uri Geller created a sensation by psychically bending keys; but it was his ability to bend keys held in *someone else's hand* that people talked about most.

Invasive Magic: There are also other highly effective ways of making the magic happen to the spectator. One is what I term “invasive magic.” In this case the magic happens on the spectator's person. For example, in my effect “Pickup on South Street” from *Cardshark*, a signed, selected card vanishes from within a spectator's wallet while the wallet is in his pocket. And it appears inside my wallet while my wallet is inside another spectator's pocket.

Another good example is Larry Grey's “Cards Across.” In this

version of the classic trick, the cards that travel across are not found in the packet the spectator is holding. After suitable milking of the magician-in-trouble premise, the cards are found to have landed in the spectator's *pocket*. Yet another good example of invasive magic is the wristwatch steal performed in the course of another effect. This was a standard item for Francis Carlyle, among others.

These effects, all slightly threatening in subtext, are memorable because they happen to the spectator in the sense of occurring within his personal zone. For that reason they create a very memorable situation. Invariably the spectator who experiences the effect reacts very strongly. Since the rest of the audience identifies with him, they do too.

Admittedly, creating such an effect poses a major technical challenge. For that reason there are very few examples in magical literature. However, if you rise to the challenge and devise such a routine you'll be amply rewarded in audience reaction.

The Spectator as Magician: Yet another way to have the magic happen to the spectator is to have the spectator actually perform the magic. The classic example is Paul Curry's "Out of this World." It's the fact that the spectator himself separates the cards into reds and blacks that makes this trick a miracle. If *you* were to sort the cards by color, even under impossible conditions, the effect would be nowhere near as strong.

Mindreading: Notice I didn't say mentalism; I said mindreading. As we've already discussed, mentalism in all its forms has very strong substantive meaning. But reading someone's thoughts (as opposed to all the other types of psi phenomena) also has strong situational meaning. It's actually the ultimate form of invasive magic. Having your wristwatch stolen is nothing compared to having your thoughts purloined.

Keep in mind, I'm speaking here of effects that really create an illusion of mindreading, not the "let's pretend I'm reading your mind" presentations one so often sees in magic. To take some examples from my own specialty, card magic, Annemann's "Thousand Dollar Test Card Location," David Hoy's "Tossed-Out Deck," and the "Paul Fox Miracle Gimmick" effect are good

examples of tricks that really leave the spectator, and the rest of the audience, feeling that you've penetrated his mind and read his thought.

T.V. Waters has argued that prediction effects can be difficult for a mentalist to sell because they're so amazing they lack credibility. He points out that, in some cases, the problem can be solved by presenting the effect, not as a prediction, but as a demonstration of psychic control. In the "Newspaper Test," for example, the performer can claim he will try to exert his will over the spectator to influence him to arrive at a certain word.

I bring this up because the "psychic control" approach also offers another advantage. It makes the spectator the subject of the trick. The effect becomes a great example of invasive magic as the performer proves he can penetrate the spectator's mind and subtly influence his will.

The Spectator's Possession: When you perform magic with an object with which a spectator strongly identifies, you can achieve some of the feeling of the magic happening to him. I don't, however, think that all borrowed-object tricks achieve this feeling. You have to do a trick with something a spectator identifies with intimately, for example, a piece of jewelry, and transform that object either temporarily or permanently.

A good example of what I have in mind is the "Linking Finger Rings." Similarly, in my tricks "Signature Effect" and the "Dream Card" I conjure with a spectator's signature. The complete ego identification each of us has with his signature makes these effects very much like doing magic to the person himself.

Regardless of which of the above approaches you use, when you make the magic happen to a spectator, you inject the human element into the trick. It's the human element that creates a *situation*—the kind of situation that will capture an audience's attention and make your magic important, which is what meaning in magic is all about.

CHAPTER SIX:

DRAMATIC STRUCTURE

1. Interest Catchers

Earlier we talked about how magic tricks could be divided into the boring part and the interesting part. An important aspect of showmanship is getting the audience to pay attention during the boring part so they can enjoy the interesting part. This may involve making the boring part as short as possible or having something interesting going on during the boring part. We'll explore both these concepts later in the chapter on Pacing.

Another effective technique is to do something at the very start of the trick that will intrigue the audience so much they'll want to sit through the boring part to see the interesting part. That's what we're going to talk about now.

The Intriguing Statement

I open one of my effects by telling the audience that I'm about to teach them how to win at blackjack. You can be sure this guarantees their undivided attention. Of course, all I'm doing here is making use of substantive meaning as we discussed earlier. But I'm introducing the subject as early as possible. Whenever you have an effect with strong meaning, get that meaning out on the table as soon as you can—if possible, in the first sentence. And make that sentence as striking and provocative as you can. If the effect gains its meaning from uncertainty, start by saying, “I'm not sure if this is going to work.” If the effect appears to involve physical danger, introduce it by saying, “I hope no one here is upset by the sight of blood.” They'll pay attention.

The Intriguing Question

This is the same idea except that, in this case, we frame that intriguing first sentence not as a statement but as a question. The advantage of questions is that they demand involvement. Listening to a declarative sentence is a passive process. But if I ask you a question you have to come up with a response, don't you? Even a rhetorical question leads the listener to frame an answer in his mind even if he doesn't articulate it. That's exactly why questions are used as a rhetorical device.

Questions also relate the subject under discussion directly to the listener in a personal way. Eugene Burger opens one mental effect by asking, "Do you believe in ESP?" Isn't that a lot better than just saying, "I'm going to show you a test of ESP?" Your silent response to such a statement might be, "So what?" But Burger's question demands that you think about your own feelings on the subject. It gets you immediately involved in the topic. You can make the question even more personal if you want. For example, asking a spectator, "Have you ever had a psychic experience?" is a great way to lead into a mental effect.

Remember, you want the question to be intriguing and provocative, "Would you like to pick a card?" is a question, but it's not exactly what we have in mind here. Suppose you're going to do an effect in which you apparently predict what card a spectator selects. You might turn to the young lady assisting you and say, "Do you think that it's possible for me to control your actions, make you do what I want, without your even being aware of it?" That'll get their attention.

If you do open by asking a spectator a question, please make sure that you acknowledge her answer. This doesn't mean that you engage in an extended dialogue and forget all about the effect you were going to do. It does mean that you actually listen to what she says. On a number of occasions I've seen performers ask a question and turn their attention away from the spectator before she even has a chance to answer. In such cases, it's painfully obvious to everyone that the question was just a ploy rather than a genuine attempt at communication. In most cases, these are yes-or-no questions, so it's easy for you to plan in advance what your response

will be in each case. Just make sure you actually respond to what the spectator says rather than to the answer you were expecting.

Don't underestimate the power of the intriguing question technique. Despite its simplicity, it's one of the most potent openings possible. Just watch Andy Rooney on *Sixty Minutes*. He's built a career on this technique. (Did you ever wonder why people watch Andy Rooney?)

The Spectator Question

People in my audiences are continually asking me questions. The intriguing thing is that they're always the same questions. Among other things, they want to know whether the casinos cheat and whether I'm allowed to play in Las Vegas. I think of these as "John questions." Prostitutes will tell you that all their customers ask the same questions. The most common one is: How did you get into this business? (Come to think of it, that's another one I get all the time.)

I've compiled a list of the twelve questions I'm most often asked by audience members. I have found this list immensely helpful in various ways in constructing presentations. I won't bother to include my list here because the questions I get are probably not the same ones you get. These things depend on the type of magic you do, your style, and, most of all, your persona. For example, if you're a mentalist you're probably used to being asked when you first discovered you possessed this gift.

I strongly recommend that you start compiling a list of the questions you most frequently get from audience members. They may be about magic in general, about your magic in particular, or about your involvement in magic. After you've been doing magic for laypeople for a while you'll be struck by how the exact same questions pop up over and over. As soon as you identify these recurring questions you'll have a very powerful tool at your disposal for making your magic more memorable.

The reason is that many of these questions are perfect springboards for effects. In other words, in many instances you can answer the question by performing an effect. Suppose someone asks you what your favorite trick is, or what is the most difficult trick you do, or

what was the first trick you ever learned? Isn't it natural to respond by performing the trick in question? (I hope I don't have to point out that your "favorite trick" is whatever trick you happen to want to perform at the moment, and that the "most difficult trick" you do doesn't have to be difficult at all as long as it looks difficult.

Similarly, the "first trick" you ever learned can be any trick that you think can be plausibly presented as such. Remember, this is show business, not a grand jury hearing.)

If you think about the questions you most often get from laypeople I think you'll find that most of them can be answered with an effect. The great thing about doing so is that you'll know that audience interest in the effect will be high since it relates directly to something that's on the spectator's mind. And since it's a question that you get all the time, its answer is bound to interest other people watching also, not just the person who happened to ask.

I'm not suggesting that you do tricks at inappropriate moments just because someone happened to ask you one of these common questions. Sometimes the best response to a question is a simple answer. However, in situations where you're already performing or where you judge that doing a trick is appropriate, there is no more effective way to open than to let the audience provide the interest-catcher in the form of a question they pose to you.

The Inverted Question

Using a spectator question as a springboard for a trick is such an effective interest-catcher that it's a pity to have to wait for a spectator to ask the question before you can do the trick. So don't wait. Suppose there's a question that laypeople often ask you about magic and you've fashioned an effect to answer that question. Since the question comes up frequently you know it's probably on people's minds even if they don't come up and ask. Why not introduce the effect by asking yourself the question, then answering it with the effect?

Perhaps you have a great trick you do whenever someone asks you what is the most difficult trick you do. If you feel like doing the trick and no one has asked the magic question, just introduce the effect

by saying, “People often ask me what is the most difficult trick I do.” Now, do the trick.

Mentalist Lee Earle opens one effect by saying, “People often ask me, ‘If you're so smart, why aren't you rich?’ ” This is a beautiful interest-catcher because practically everyone who sees a mentalist perform wonders how come, if he really is psychic, he doesn't use that power to pick winners at the racetrack or stocks on Wall Street. Earle doesn't wait for someone to bring it up. He beats them to the punch and, in so doing, ensures that everyone will pay close attention to the effect he performs to answer that question.

Similarly, I start one effect by saying, “People often ask me whether I'm allowed to play cards in Las Vegas.” I then perform an effect that demonstrates why I've been barred from the blackjack tables. Since the question was already on everyone's mind before I raised it, their interest in the effect is guaranteed.

Keep in mind that truth is absolutely essential for this technique to work. When you ask yourself a question that is on people's minds, they'll say to themselves, “Yeah, I was wondering that.” In fact, often when using the inverted question technique I'll see heads nodding in the audience as soon as I pose the question. That's proof that I've hit a nerve and they'll pay attention to the trick. However, if I were to introduce a rope trick by saying, “People often say to me, ‘Darwin, what's the best way to tie a shank knot?’” the audience reaction would be, “Huh?”

Remember, there's no great mystery to figuring out which inverted questions will work and which ones won't. Just listen to your audiences. The questions they ask you over and over are the ones that will catch their interest when you pose them to yourself.

The Intriguing Prop

So far, all the interest-catchers we've looked at involve patter. But sometimes you can capture the audience's imagination before you utter a word. You do this by pulling out a prop that fascinates the audience, a prop that makes them think, “What is that?” or, “What on earth is he planning to do with that?”

Bizarre magic is a field that makes constant use of this ploy. Almost

every effect seems to start with the performer introducing an amulet, talisman, statuette, ritual implement, or other occult tool. Stephen Minch once published a bizarre magic effect that begins with the performer taking out a jar containing a human eye floating in formaldehyde. There's an opening guaranteed to wake the audience.

Even if you don't conjure with body parts, you can still use this technique. When I perform "Card Warp" I use my "Card Warp Deck" idea from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. This means that I start by removing and displaying a deck in which every card has a different back: advertising cards, casino cards, souvenir cards, all mixed together. In "The Lucky Deck," also from the same book, I start by taking out and fanning a blank-faced deck. This may be a common sight to magicians, but not to laypeople. In each case, the strangeness of the deck makes the audience curious to see what I'm going to do with it. If you do Brother Hamman's "Micro Macro," you'll find the same thing happens as soon as you take out the miniature deck of cards.

Many years ago, Max Maven marketed an effect that used a pair of dice with no spots on them. If you do that effect, I suggest opening by rolling those dice out on the table before you say a word. One of the most common "intriguing props" in magic is the purse frame. Like blank playing cards and unspotted dice, a bagless purse is such an obviously useless concept that people will wonder what you plan to do with it.

Dr. Stanley Jaks made constant use of this method of capturing audience interest. In fact, his entire close-up act was built around attractive and unusual props, a new one being introduced at the start of each effect. Today, David Roth is a master of this technique. In addition to using a purse frame, he starts effects by pulling out cloth holes, tuning forks, plastic rainbows, or disembodied jacket sleeves. Even his coin box functions as an intriguing prop for laypeople since they've never seen anything like it before.

I don't recommend that you incorporate exotic props into effects where they serve no useful purpose. Sure, the audience will wonder, "What's he going to do with that?" But they'll be disappointed when they find out that the answer is, "Nothing much."

I do suggest that you look at your repertoire to see if there are some effects where you can effectively substitute something intriguing for a more mundane prop. (Keep in mind that the item must fit your persona. If your character is that of a card shark, an eye floating in a jar probably won't fit in. But a twenty-dollar gold piece might.) I also suggest that when using intriguing props that you routine the effect in such a way as to get the prop in view as early as possible. The sooner it's out there working to grab the audience, the better.

The Lead-In Effect

One last technique for grabbing an audience's interest at the start of an effect that works well with some tricks is to do a quickie effect that leads into the more elaborate effect. The most common example is a flash production of the four aces as a lead-in to an ace assembly. Similarly, Martin Nash does a long sandwich routine using the two red jacks as the sandwich cards. Instead of starting by spreading through the deck to remove the red jacks, he produces them in a flashy manner. This impressive, but very short, stunt is enough to make the audience realize that whatever he is planning to do with those jacks is probably going to be worth watching. This technique is only applicable to certain effects, but in the right spot it can be very effective.

In conclusion, I want to stress that you shouldn't feel you have to start every effect with an interest-catcher. Sometimes, the best possible opening for an effect is to say, "Pick a card." But, particularly in the early part of your performance, before you've really established yourself, it helps to give yourself every advantage in grabbing the audience. Interest-catching openings are one more tool for that purpose.

2. Progression

What Is Progression?

In *The Technique of Acting*, F. Cowles Strickland writes, "That which follows must always be made to seem more important and more interesting than that which has preceded. . . Even an attempt to maintain the same level of interest will not satisfy an audience."

In his great book, *Magic and Showmanship*, Henning Nelms talks about the same issue in terms of how the interest curve must continually rise in a performance. He writes, "The interest that an audience takes in anything never remains constant. If we do not increase it, it will slump. An audience is entertained only while interest is rising."

Those two statements are worth your closest study. The insight they contain is one of the most fundamental yet profound secrets of successful performing. The audience must feel a sense of progression throughout your entire performance and also within each effect. We'll be talking about progression in the overall performance in the section on The Act. Right now I want to talk about structuring an individual effect to achieve progression.

In an effect with a single climax, progression is usually not difficult to achieve. Things naturally tend to move toward the climax and the audience can sense that. It's in multi-phase effects that a lack of progression is most likely to destroy a good trick. By multi-phase effects I mean tricks like the "Ambitious Card," "Oil and Water," or a one-at-a-time "Coins Through the Table." In such tricks, you do the same sort of thing several times in a row.

Many tricks require a multi-phase approach. Some effects are over too fast for the audience to fully absorb. They feel that they were caught unprepared and want another chance to see the phenomenon. For example, I've never seen a performance of the "Ring on Wand" where the spectators didn't respond by saying, "Do it again."

Other effects are statistical. A single performance means nothing; they gain power only from repetition. If you and I cut for high card and I win, it doesn't prove much. The odds were only fifty-fifty; maybe I just got lucky. But if we do it six times in a row and I win each time, that's quite uncanny.

Yet this repetition, which may be the key to an effect's success, can also be its downfall if the audience senses that they are just seeing the same thing over and over. The moment they feel that the train is stuck in the station rather than moving forward, they lose interest.

It's your job to make sure the audience feels that every repetition is

more interesting than the last—the same, yet different.

Admittedly, there are some exceptions—effects where the phenomenon is so astonishing that even an exact repetition is enough to achieve a sense of progression. The exhibition of the phenomenon doesn't change, but the audience's appreciation grows with each repetition, creating that necessary sense of progression.

In such effects, three repetitions seems to be ideal. In the first one the audience thinks, “Did I see what I think I saw? I must have missed something.” In the second repetition, they think, “No, I really saw what I thought I saw, but it's impossible!” On the third repetition, they think, “It's hopeless. No matter how many times he does it, I'll never understand how it can be.”

A perfect example of this occurs in Larry Jennings' “Open Travellers,” an effect where you do the same thing three times, and the audience gets more excited each time. However, even with the most miraculous phenomenon, more than three identical repetitions will cause the interest curve to drop.

One effective approach is to introduce a more stringent condition after the third repetition. A perfect example occurs in the Edward Victor “Eleven-Card Trick.” The first three phases are identical. Each time the performer counts the cards he has one less than he should. If he were to repeat the same thing a fourth time, audience interest would drop. Instead, the performer introduces a new condition on the next phase. He has the spectator count the cards, yet there is still one less than there should be. This new wrinkle boosts audience interest in the rest of the routine.

If you can somehow make each repetition more impossible than the last, you may find you can effectively repeat many more times. Just watch Daryl perform the “Ambitious Card” sometime. He brings the card to the top over a dozen times, yet the interest curve never drops. But if he were to perform the exact same actions in exactly the same way, he would lose the audience by the fourth repetition, if not sooner.

Very few multi-phase effects are as strong in each individual repetition as the “Open Travellers.” Most will require that you give them a sense of progression by somehow making each phase more

interesting to the audience than the last. Here are the various ways you can do it.

Intrinsic Progressions

Through Strengthening Conditions: The most common and generally the most versatile way to build progression is to perform each phase under increasingly impossible conditions. “Mexican Poker” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* is an example of a statistical effect I play head-up poker with a spectator and win. To make it impressive, several repetitions are needed. Therefore we play five hands in a row. If I followed the game procedure on all five hands, the audience would eventually lose interest despite the astonishing fact that I win every hand under impossible conditions. Therefore, I've structured the routine so that the conditions become *more* impossible each time. With each repetition I give the spectator more and more control over how the cards are shuffled and distributed, yet I still win.

Another good example of progression through escalating conditions is Daryl's “Ambitious Card” routine. The first couple of times he inserts the card in the center and it rises to the top. Then he does the same thing with a small packet of cards. The audience sees this as a tougher condition since there seems less opportunity for concealing sleight of hand. Next he allows a spectator to hold the deck as he places the card in the center. Obviously, this restricts the possibilities for sleight of hand even further. Yet, the card jumps to the top even while the spectator is holding the deck. Finally, he ties the deck with a piece of rope. Clearly, this would seem to rule out any possibility whatever for manipulation of the cards. Yet, when he inserts the card in the middle, it still rises to the top. As with the previous example, the trick gets more and more impossible as it goes along.

One of the reasons why Larry Jennings' “Ambitious Classic” is such a great trick is that progression is built into the very premise of the trick. You start with a five-card packet and perform an Ambitious Card sequence. Then you discard a card and do it again. After each phase, you discard another card. The audience feels that with fewer and fewer cards, their chances of catching you should increase. Yet,

you fool them each time—even when you only have one card left. The game thing also happens in the Braue and Jennings versions of “The Homing Card.”

Creating progression by tightening the conditions is such a natural thing that audiences instinctively seek it if you don't provide it. You can prove this to yourself with a simple experiment. Perform a five-phase “Ambitious Card” routine for a group of laypeople. Make each phase look exactly like all the others, perhaps by using a pass each time. By the third phase you'll find that someone will ask if he can see the face of the card just before you insert it in the deck. If you accede to his request, the next time someone will ask if he can insert the card in the deck himself. Things will continue this way for the rest of the routine. With each phase, people will want to impose more and more stringent conditions on you.

Of course, other than as an experiment, you must never let this sort of situation develop. You can't let your audience take control of your performance. But if you don't provide progression, you may find that the audience will demand it, very possibly asking for conditions that you can't meet. The smart thing to do is to beat them to the punch. Structure your multi—phase effect in such a way that you impose increasingly stringent conditions on yourself as you go along before anyone else can think to request them.

Through Expanding the Scope: I once saw Pat Hazel perform a great version of Slydini's “Paper Balls Over the Head.” He did it about four or five times and held the audience riveted because he used a larger coin each time. By the last phase he was using a coin at least a foot in diameter. If he'd used the same coin each time, the amusement value of seeing the spectator fooled repeatedly by the same ploy would have quickly evaporated. The increasingly large coins provided progression by continually expanding the scope of the effect.

Yet, this hugely entertaining routine can be made monumentally boring by making just one small change: Reverse the order of the phases. If Hazel had started with the twelve-inch coin and then used a smaller one each time, he would have lost the audience long before the trick was over. As soon as they realized that the train was moving backwards, they would have gotten off at the next station.

In *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I have a very strong gambling routine called “The Ultimate Card Shark.” All told, it contains seven phases. It's a perfect example of expanding the scope of the effect as it unfolds. As I wrote in that book, the routine has “a very effective dramatic build that progresses logically from the control of a single playing card to the control of four cards, the control of twenty cards, and finally the control of all fifty–two cards.

Another good example of expanding the scope to create progression is Paul Gertner's “That's Ridiculous.” In it, he produces a series of coins. Each coin he produces is larger than the one before.

The difference between strengthening the conditions and expanding the scope is best illustrated with an analogy. Suppose I'm going to give an exhibition of weight lifting. I want to do three lifts, each more impressive than the one before. I might first clean and jerk three hundred pounds. Next I do a standing press of three hundred pounds. This is much harder since the weight has to be muscled up with no momentum. Finally, I do a one–armed press of three hundred pounds. I'm lifting the same amount of weight each time, but under increasingly tough conditions.

Suppose instead I do a clean and jerk of three hundred pounds. Then I do a clean and jerk of three hundred–fifty pounds. Finally, I do a clean and jerk of four hundred pounds. The conditions remain the same, but the scope of the task grows each time.

In magic, both approaches will succeed in holding the audience's interest. But some effects are more adaptable to the first approach while others are more suited to the second approach.

Artificial Progressions

Tightening conditions or expanding scope to raise the interest curve both depend on varying your method from phase to phase. Sometimes in a multi-phase routine you can't do that; you only have one good method, so you have to use it every time. Yet giving your audience a sense of progression is so essential that, if your method doesn't permit a true progression, you have to artificially manufacture one.

Through Conservation: In my “Oil and Water” routine, the second

phase is more impressive than the first because, the second time, I show the face of each card as I deal it into the combined red- and-black pile. Since I'm using the same method and handling in both phases I could show the faces during the first phase too, but I don't. By not revealing the full strength of the method the first time, I create the feeling that the second phase goes beyond the first one. I term this concept conservation because you're conserving your full strength until the end.

Juan Tamariz does the same thing in a three-phase location effect. The first time, he holds the deck in normal dealing grip as he has a spectator peek at a card. After locating the card, he offers to do it again. But, he points out, he will only hold the deck at the lower corner between one finger and thumb as the spectator peeks at the card. After finding this card also, he offers to do it one last time. This last time, he allows the spectator to hold the deck in his own hands as he peeks at a card.

Once again, since Tamariz is using the same method each time, he could have the spectator hold the deck in his own hand each of the three times he peeks at a card. All three locations would still be baffling, but they would be *equally* baffling. The audience would sense that the train was standing still.

If you can't make each subsequent phase stronger, you may have to work backwards and make each previous phase weaker. Look at the last phase and consider how you can lessen each previous phase slightly by holding back convincing features of the method. Reveal these convincing features step by step until, in the last phase, you hit them with the full power of the method. Be like a general who doesn't reveal his full troop strength in the first battle. Instead he holds some in reserve and adds them in stages as combat progresses until he overwhelms his opponent.

Through Increasing Stakes: A few years ago Peter Kane marketed a trick called "Kane's Variant." This is a fine effect in which you play a gambling game with the spectator and win. Since you can't lose, Kane recommends wagering a sum of money on the game to add interest. He also recommends playing the game three times with the spectator. This is necessary to prove it wasn't just luck. Unfortunately, each phase is just like the other two phases.

In this case, you can artificially generate a sense of progression by the simple expedient of wagering more money each time. For example, put up a twenty dollar bill on the first game. Then risk a fifty dollar bill on the second game. Finally, wager a hundred dollar bill on the last game. This gives the routine a sense of build. The *effect* remains the same each time, but the *situation* escalates; therefore, audience interest rises. You can apply this idea to any multi-phase effect involving risk.

Through Speed: Finally, a means of artificially creating a sense of progression that works effectively in some routines is a gradual change in tempo. If you perform each phase slightly faster than the one before the audience will get a feeling of making progress even though each phase is actually the same as all the others. This works best in multi-phase effects in which each phase is quite short.

Interestingly, it is also sometimes possible to create that necessary sense of progression by performing each phase slightly *slower* and more deliberately than the one before. In René Lavand's brilliant six-phase Oil and Water routine he achieves progression primarily from performing each phase more slowly than the one before, a fact that provides the effect with its patter theme.

3. Surprise And Suspense

“In other words, we're back to our usual alternatives: Do we want suspense or surprise?”

Alfred Hitchcock

To use terminology sometimes employed in connection with short stories, magic effects may be classified into two categories, revelatory and confirmational. The revelatory effect is one that ends in an unexpected way; the many versions of The Color-Changing Deck typify this category. The confirmational effect is one that ends exactly the way the audience expected; “Wild Card,” “The Homing Card,” and “Jazz Aces” are all well-known examples of this type. These two categories of effect reflect the two most powerful dramatic tools available to the performer: surprise and suspense.

A. Surprise

“This does not mean that there will be no dramatic surprises; it means simply that there must be no surprises which do not, as they unfold, make total sense to the audience.”

Nash & Oakey, *The Screenwriter's Handbook*

There are few things in magic as strong as a truly surprising climax. Anyone who does magic quickly discovers this fact to his delight. Consequently, the tendency is to utilize this weapon indiscriminately. In the following pages we'll consider the use and abuse of surprise as a dramatic tool.

There are two ways in which surprise may be incorporated into the climax of an effect. The first is to provide a surprise climax *instead* of the one the audience has been led to expect. The second is to provide a surprise climax *after* the one the audience has been led to expect.

Twist Endings

The Reverse One-Eighty: By a twist ending effect I mean one that ends completely differently from the way the audience expected. There are two common plays for achieving this result. The first I term the reverse one-eighty: at the last moment, the action of the effect makes a complete turn-around. A perfect example is “The O. Henry Aces” plot. The effect begins as a classic-style slow-motion ace assembly. The first ace travels to join the leader ace. Then the second ace travels to join the leader ace. Naturally, the audience expects that the third ace will do the same. Instead, the direction of the action suddenly reverses. The third ace remains stationary and the other aces travel from the leader packet to join it.

Similarly, in David Roth's Coin Box Routine, four half-dollars begin traveling one at a time from the performer's hand to the box. Just as the audience is ready for the fourth coin to travel to the box, the three in the box travel to join the one in the performer's hand.

Another example of this strategy familiar to most magicians is Paul Gertner's “Reverse Assembly.” Four coins begin in the four corners of an imaginary square. Each is covered by a playing card. The

second coin joins the first; then the third coin joins the first two. Just when the audience is ready for the fourth coin to join the first three, the rug is pulled out from under them. The coins that had gathered together return to their original positions so that everything is as it was at the start.

The Inversion: The other common approach used to achieve magical twist endings is what I term the inversion. This involves a role reversal of props. For example, at the end of “The O-Korto Coin Box” routine, at the end, the audience expects the coins to penetrate the hand, leaving the empty box sitting on the back of the hand. Instead, the *box* penetrates, leaving the four coins stacked on the back of the hand.

Along the same lines, I once saw a version of Vernon's “Travellers” in which the performer inserted the four aces into different parts of the deck. He then removed the first ace from one pocket, followed by removing the second ace from another pocket, and the third ace from yet a different pocket. However, when he reached into a fourth pocket, instead of emerging with the final ace as the audience expected, he brought out the entire deck. He then showed that the hand that a moment ago held the deck now contained only one card, the fourth ace. Throughout the effect, the roles of the props had been: the deck stays, the aces travel. But in the end, the ace stayed and the deck traveled.

Similarly, in James Louis' aptly named “Inversion,” the performer makes the spectator's card turn face-up in the deck. When he tries again, the entire deck turns face up except for the selected card. Along the same lines is my own favorite example of the inversion ploy, an original effect of mine I call “Through the Table.” I have a spectator select a card which is then lost in the deck. When the spectator presses down on the tabled deck, the selected card penetrates through the table. However, when I offer to repeat the effect, instead of the expected result, the entire deck penetrates through the table except for the selected card.

Criteria for Twist Endings: Effective tricks of this kind are hard to come by because the element of surprise alone is not enough to ensure success. Before such an effect can really work there are two criteria that have to be satisfied. First, the surprise ending must be

stronger than the ending the audience expects. This is really an obvious point when you think about it, but I've seen enough magicians violate the rule to realize that many don't think about it.

You're promising the audience one thing, then giving them something else instead. That something else had better be more satisfying than what you promised or you will have a disappointed audience on your hands. "The O. Henry Aces" fulfills this criterion because it promises that one ace will travel at the end but goes much further by making three aces travel instead. Similarly, in "Through the Table," making an entire pack penetrate through the table is more impressive than making just one card penetrate, which is what the audience expected.

Here again many magicians err by gearing their magic to the reactions of other magicians. Magician audiences are so bored by the standard magic plots they have seen countless times that they will react more strongly to any unexpected ending, even one that is actually weaker than the traditional ending. Fortunately, laymen don't suffer from this jaundiced attitude.

Actually, it's not difficult at all to surprise an audience if that's all you want to accomplish. All you have to do is do something that makes no sense. Since it makes no sense, no one could possibly have anticipated it. This often occurs in bad horror films that achieve shocks at the expense of logic. It also occurs in bad mystery stories where the author ensures that no one will guess who the murderer is by choosing as his culprit someone totally illogical who has no real reason for committing the crime. It also occurs quite frequently in bad magic.

This leads to our second criterion for effective twist endings: the ending, although unexpected, must seem logical, indeed almost inevitable, to the audience when they reflect back on it. Referring to the short story, Rust Hills calls this "the inevitability of retrospect." For the surprise to be *satisfying* to the audience they must respond to it by feeling: "I didn't see it coming but, of course, it makes perfect sense when you think about it." This means that the surprise ending, although different from what was promised, must relate logically to what was promised. It also means that the performer must carefully foreshadow the surprise ending. Yes, foreshadowing

is yet another technique of film and fiction that is important in close-up magic. Rust Hills describes foreshadowing in these terms: “What foreshadowing does is prepare in advance for events that will follow later in the story, often in ways that will not be fully understood by the reader until the story is completed.”

In *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I have a version of the “O. Henry Aces” called “Hitchcock Aces.” At the outset of the effect I turn to the spectator assisting me and say, “I am going to attempt to make these aces travel one at a time invisibly until we have all four aces in one packet. Mark my words, Mary, that's four aces in one packet and that's a promise.” This last statement is made very portentously which usually gets a chuckle but also ensures that the audience will remember the line. Later when I reveal the surprise climax I say, “If you'll lift your hand, Mary, you'll see that I kept my word, four aces in one packet.”

Kicker Endings

The other method of adding a surprise element to a magic effect is to provide a second, unexpected climax after the initial climax, usually referred to in magic as a kicker ending. The great popularity of kicker endings in magic today is largely a testament to the impact that Derek Dingle has had on the direction of close-up magic in the last twenty years. While Derek did not invent the kicker, he used the concept so frequently and with such devastating effect on other magicians that close-up magic has never been the same since.

As with so many trends in magic, it has ultimately been abused by those who are only capable of unthinking imitation. We see the result today in those magicians who seem incapable of ending a close-up trick without producing some large incongruous item, or ending a coin trick without producing a three-inch coin, or ending a card effect without making the deck change color. (Even packet tricks in which the deck plays no part at all sometimes end with the deck changing color!)

Criteria for Kicker Endings: Like anything else in magic, kickers are only effective when used intelligently. The two vital rules to keep in mind in evaluating the merit of a kicker ending are essentially the same as those pertaining to twist endings. First, the kicker climax

should be stronger than the basic climax of the effect. This is simply an application of the most fundamental rule of dramatic structure, that of progression, which we've already discussed. A kicker climax that is weaker than the climax that preceded it will only disappoint; it will detract from the effect rather than strengthen it. The technical term in drama for such a development is an anti-climax, something you must avoid at all costs in magic.

The second rule is that the kicker ending should be thematically related to the basic effect. It is a general principle that the audience must always be able to see a logical thread connecting what is happening with what has come before. Without this you won't amaze them, only disorient them. To be sure, your patter may be important in pointing out the linking thread that might otherwise have eluded the audience. But even a patter connection must be based on a real conceptual connection. A mere silly pun or weak gag won't suffice to connect an irrelevant kicker to an effect.

Without a thematic connection between effect and kicker the trick will lack unity. It's been observed that unity is an essential element of all art. I won't get into the thorny question now of whether magic is an art. It's sufficient to note that unity is something people instinctively crave in all forms of entertainment. When it's missing, the audience is left unsatisfied.

As Gary Provost points out in *Make Your Words Work*, the problem with life is that it's a disorganized mess. There is seemingly no rhyme or reason to it; it's just an arbitrary collection of experiences. But the human mind craves order. That's precisely why when we read a book, watch a play or movie, listen to a song or a joke, or watch a magic trick, we want it to have the one thing that's missing from real life. We want it to *make sense*. We want everything in it to relate to everything else in it in a logical way. In other words, we want it to have unity. As Anthony Storr writes in *Music and the Mind*, "Anything which lessens our distress at being surrounded by chaos gives us pleasure." This may sound like ivory tower theory, but the universal experience of performers and artists throughout history bears it out.

Too many kicker effects violate this necessary sense of unity. They look like the performer took pieces from a couple of different tricks

and threw them together haphazardly. (In fact, often that's exactly what he did.) A kicker will only work when it relates thematically to everything that has come before—when the whole trick, kicker and all, still has unity.

The technique of foreshadowing can be useful in this situation also. Another effect from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* is “Deja Vu Jokers,” an ace assembly-type effect with a kicker. In this case, after the four jokers assemble in the leader packet they are immediately shown to have returned to their original packets. As I begin this effect I explain that the real secret to my card tricks is that they are just psychological illusions, “In other words they never really happen at all, except in your mind.” This cryptic statement neatly foreshadows the climax.

As the assembly progresses I remind the audience occasionally that it is only an illusion; this provides further foreshadowing. Just before revealing the kicker, my patter is, “So you see the illusion is that all four jokers have gathered into one packet just as I promised.

Of course the reality is that none of this ever happened at all . . . except in your mind.” As the last line is delivered, the four packets are turned up to show that each contains one joker exactly as at the beginning.

Certainly, despite the foreshadowing, the audience does not for a moment anticipate the surprise climax that is coming. Yet, when it arrives it is apparent that, given the premise established at the outset, there could have been no other logical ending. That is the inevitability of retrospect.

Some Examples: To further clarify the two key principles pertaining to kickers, let's look at an example of an effect that fails because it violates these principles and then one that succeeds because it conforms to them. A couple of years ago I read a version of “The Open Travellers” in which the author's only contribution was the following kicker: When the magician finishes performing “The Open Travellers” with the four aces, he turns them face up to reveal that they have changed to the four kings. While changing four aces to four kings is a respectable magic effect, it pales in comparison to the effect of palming cards in such a way that they become invisible.

Thus the kicker offers only an anti-climax.

Furthermore, “The Open Travellers” is about palming cards and, in a broader sense, about cards traveling from place to place. What can changing the aces to the kings conceivably have to do with either of these themes? It doesn't take extensive audience testing to see that this mindless kicker will only weaken a classic effect. Anyone who finds that this kicker strengthens the trick for him must be doing something wrong in the performance of the basic effect. He must be bungling “The Open Travellers” so badly that the transformation of the aces is necessary to save the whole thing from complete oblivion.

By contrast, “Roll-Over Aces,” one of the tricks that started the kicker craze, is also one of the most effective. The effect is that the four aces are buried in the deck and the cards shuffled face up and face down. Four packets are then “rolled off” the deck and an ace is seen on the face of each packet. The rest of the cards are then shown to be straightened out, all face down. Finally, each of the packets having an ace on its face is shown to consist of a royal flush.

Derek Dingle taught me this effect some twenty years ago, not long after he devised it. I have been using it ever since, so I can testify from very extensive experience that few card effects will impress an audience more when skillfully performed.

I once witnessed a conversation between a young cardman and one of the living legends of magic. The young cardman, a friend of mine, was quite skillful with cards. When asked to perform something he chose to do “Roll-Over Aces.” No sooner had he finished than the legendary magician proceeded to berate the young man for performing such a “terrible trick.” The thrust of the criticism was that the effect should have ended with the production of the aces—that the “pure effect” of the ace revelation was ruined by the production of the royal flushes which had nothing to do with the main effect.

The often-heard criticism that the kicker in “Roll-Over Aces” is irrelevant to the main effect completely misses the point. The plot of the first part of “Roll-Over Aces” is that the performer demonstrates his ability to locate the four aces while shuffling the cards. This is a talent that has meaning only when viewed in the context of card

playing, particularly the game of poker. If the ability to locate four aces while shuffling would be a useful skill at poker, then the ability to locate four royal flushes while shuffling is a similar but even more useful poker skill. Of course, the performer should invoke the poker frame of reference early in his patter so as to foreshadow the kicker.

In a broader sense, the theme of “Roll-Over Aces” is the bringing of order out of chaos. The deck is thrown into a chaotic state by being shuffled face up and face down. Yet out of this chaos the performer is able to produce an amazing degree of order. The production of the four aces is the first level of order revealed. The fact that all the other cards are now face down reveals an even greater level of order. The fact that cards have been organized into royal flushes (suits segregated and cards in numerical order) demonstrates a still deeper—and quite astonishing—level of order.

Notice also that the kicker climax in “Roll-Over Aces” is stronger than the first climax thus satisfying our second criterion on kickers. Anyone who can't sell the production of four royal flushes as even more amazing than the production of four aces certainly does have presentational problems.

However, one point in the presentation requires careful handling. After the production of the aces and before the revelation of the royal flushes, the remaining cards are shown to have turned face down. This “Triumph” element is desirable from an esthetic standpoint. However, the “Triumph” revelation is not as strong as the dramatic rolling off of the aces. If presented as a major effect, the “Triumph” feature will register as an anti-climax. Instead, I reveal the straightening out of the cards quickly and casually without strong emphasis; in other words, I throw the climax away. Thus, the spreading out of the face-down cards registers as a touch rather than an additional climax. The aces and the royal flushes register as the only two climaxes, the second stronger than the first in orthodox theatrical manner.

An interesting trick to analyze in terms of the kicker being thematically related to the effect is what is probably both the oldest and the most popular kicker ending in all of close-up magic, the final load production in the Cups and Balls. That this ending is undeniably popular with audiences is indicated by the fact that it is

used by absolutely everyone who does the Cups and Balls; even those traditionalists who never tire of criticizing the modern tendency to “ruin” classic effects with kicker endings themselves always end this classic effect with a load production kicker.

Yet, on the face of it, the final load production seems to have nothing whatever to do with the plot of the Cups and Balls. The effect ends by producing props which have played no part in the basic effect. Even more to the point is the fact that the Cups and Balls is not a production effect. It is a translocation effect. The balls travel from place to place (from hand to cup or from one cup to another). In the main body of the effect, no balls are produced. The balls may move from one location to another but they never multiply. Yet in the kicker ending the translocation premise is completely abandoned in favor of a production plot and one in which the large balls produced have little resemblance to the small balls that have been used throughout the effect; indeed, in many routines the final loads are not balls at all but lemons or other incongruous items. (In fact, the strongest possible ending to the effect is the production of live chicks!)

I think that the success of the final load kicker may say something about the way audiences actually perceive the Cups and Balls effect—a perception that may surprise most magicians. Although the trick is presented as an effect of translocation and is nominally accepted by the audience on those terms, I suspect that, on an emotional level, the audience simply experiences it as a trick in which balls unexpectedly appear under cups.

If the trick is seen as basically just a matter of finding things under the cups that are not supposed to be there, then finding some even larger things under the cups that are *really* not supposed to be there may appear in the audience's eyes to be a surprising but logical conclusion to the trick.

Kickers and Magician Audiences: The whole subject of kicker endings is muddled by the fact that they are so effective when performing for other magicians. Indeed, the popularity of kicker endings is almost entirely due to the fact that they work so well for audiences of magicians. The amateur magic movement (i.e., magic for magicians) is the dominant force in magic today and is therefore

the cause of most of the trends we see in magic.

Magician audiences have been so extensively exposed to the classic effects that even a very fine performance of “Twisting the Aces,” “All Backs,” or the “Sympathetic Coins” may leave them unmoved. A common approach to revitalizing these classics for magician audiences is to throw in an unexpected kicker such as having the cards change color or the coins grow to three inches in diameter.

However, if you allow yourself to be guided by the reaction of magician audiences in this regard you may be misled in either of two ways. First, we've seen that to be effective the kicker must be stronger than the basic effect. However, with a magician audience a weak kicker may register as stronger than the basic effect because, through overexposure, magicians have become unable to appreciate just how strong the basic effect really is. If performed for a lay audience whose appreciation of the classic effect hasn't been blunted by repetition, the basic effect may register so strongly that, by comparison, the kicker is anti-climactic.

The second point to keep in mind is that a kicker ending should not be achieved at the expense of the basic effect. For example, in order to incorporate a color change of the deck at the end of “All Backs,” the handling of “All Backs” may have to be made less convincing. This may not matter with magician audiences because they aren't paying much attention to the “All Backs” phase anyway, having seen the trick so often; they only come alive when the color- change kicker arrives. With a lay audience, a weakening of the basic effect in order to achieve a kicker may be a poor tradeoff; often you'll achieve the strongest possible impact by performing the most convincing and effective version of the basic plot, even if this precludes use of some favorite kicker ending.

The moral here as elsewhere is that magicians generally are *less perceptive* audiences than laypeople and an unreliable guide as to what constitutes strong magic.

Handling the Second Climax: A final important point concerning kickers is one raised by Mike Rogers in his lecture notes *Opinions*. He states: “Effects having a second climax, or what we like to call 'kickers,' offend the viewer . . . The viewer watches, follows along,

and shows his appreciation at what he thinks has been the end of the effect. Then a second climax is sprung upon him, and he is made to feel foolish for thinking it was all over the first time.”

While I completely disagree with Rogers' conclusion, his comment does point out a potential problem that anyone performing a kicker effect should take into account. The same notion was touched on by Penn Jillette of Penn and Teller in a patter line I once heard him use. He was juggling several items, preparing for a very difficult juggling stunt. The preliminary juggling was itself impressive and the audience started to applaud. Penn responded by saying, “Don't applaud yet; you'll just feel stupid when the real trick happens!”

The problem in this case is not with kicker endings but with a presentation that leads people to conclude that the trick is over, then springs the kicker on them. The correct handling of this situation is to allow the basic climax to register with the audience; then, before they have a chance to applaud, hit them with the kicker. In small audience situations where people don't usually applaud, the principle still holds true. The kicker should be revealed after they have had time to absorb the first climax but before they start to lean back, relax, and think, “That was a great trick!” This is a timing matter on the performer's part that requires sensitivity to audience reaction and can only be developed with experience. However, if people are allowed to see what the entire effect is before they mentally conclude that the trick is over, you'll find no offensive element in kicker endings.

How Much Surprise?

“Surprise after surprise soon becomes . . . unsurprising.”

S.H. Sharpe

Having discussed the appropriateness of surprise endings in various situations, I'll conclude by addressing an equally important point how often you should use surprise endings. As I observed at the outset, surprise properly used can have a tremendous impact on an audience. There is a natural tendency to feel that, if something is very effective, you should use it at every possible opportunity.

Unfortunately, many theatrical devices are effective in inverse

proportion to how often they're used. Some magicians seem to feel they have to finish every effect with an unexpected ending. I've had numerous opportunities to see such performers work for laypeople. After a couple of tricks, the audience catches on to the pattern. They realize that every effect is going to have some twist or kicker at the end. From that point on, their sole concern becomes trying to anticipate each surprise ending. You can actually hear them whispering in the audience during each trick, speculating about how it's *really* going to end. The result is that they miss most of the magic as the whole performance degenerates into a game of the audience trying to second—guess the performer.

A surprise ending ceases to be a surprise as soon as people realize there is a surprise coming, even if they don't know exactly what the surprise will be. Like a strong seasoning, surprise endings in magic should be used sparingly for best results. Pick your spots carefully; a couple of well-thought out twist or kicker endings in the course of a twenty-minute performance can evoke tremendous emotional response. More than that can easily become self-defeating.

B. Suspense

“Suspense, which is the most powerful means of holding onto the viewer’s attention.”

Alfred Hitchcock

“The art of creating suspense is also the art of involving the audience.”

François Truffaut

What Is Suspense?

Whenever a reviewer describes a book as “impossible to put down” or one that “grips the reader from the first page to the last” he is invariably talking about a suspense novel. A good suspense novel or film grabs you and drags you along through the story without letting go until the very end. Clearly, this is an achievement that any magician would want to emulate.

Earlier I stated that one of the two primary goals of presentation is

to hold the audience's interest until the climax of the effect; there is no dramatic technique that can do this more effectively than the creation of suspense. Suspense is simply the most important dramatic element in magic.

I've summarized the essence of successful suspense in magic in Darwin's Suspense Formula: *make them care, then make them wait*. It's that simple; yet, to fully appreciate the concept and how to apply it will take considerable analysis.

I've never found a definition of suspense that serves well for theatrical purposes so I have fashioned my own: Suspense is the tension built up *over time* by *curiosity, uncertainty, or anticipation* concerning the attainment of a *desired result*. We can draw several lessons from this definition. First, you'll note that it indicates there are three types of suspense: curiosity, uncertainty, and anticipation. In this regard I have followed the lead of Rust Hills who analyzes suspense as follows: "First, there is *mystery*, which evokes *curiosity* as its effect on the reader. Second, there is *conflict*, which evokes *uncertainty* as to outcome. Third, and most effective, is *tension*, which evokes *anticipation*. The first is resolved by some sort of *explanation*; the second is resolved by some sort of *decision*; the third is resolved by some sort of *fulfillment*." Let's take a look at each of these forms of suspense as they may be applied to magic.

Mystery–Curiosity

Mystery novels of the 1930s typically created suspense by confronting the reader with a set of facts that appeared to describe an impossibility. For example, detective story writer and amateur magician Clayton Rawson specialized in novels where a man is found murdered in a room that was locked from the inside. Apparently there was no way the culprit could have escaped. The reader's curiosity hooks him into reading further to learn how this apparent impossibility could have occurred.

Instead of providing answers, the novel heaps new impossibilities, new puzzles, new mysteries on top of the original one. Thus the reader's curiosity increases. His desire for answers grows, which is another way of saying that the suspense grows. That's what keeps him turning the pages. Finally, in the last few pages the detective

gathers all the suspects in one room and explains, not only who done it, but also how he did it, neatly tying up all the loose ends. In a successful novel of this kind the solution should prove as ingenious as the mystery itself. If it's clever, it will leave the reader satisfied; if it's contrived and preposterous, it will leave him feeling cheated and manipulated.

This summary of the mystery-curiosity approach to suspense should make it clear why this is the trickiest form of suspense for the magician to use. In this type of suspense you begin with a mystery and climax with an explanation. In magic, you climax with the mystery and offer no explanations.

Yet there are many situations in which the magician can make effective use of the mystery–curiosity formula, that is in cases where the performer can arouse the audience's curiosity by presenting it with a mystery, then provide an explanation to that mystery which is itself an even *greater mystery*. Let's take an example. In both the “Solid Ghost” and “Glorpy” effects the performer shows an empty handkerchief, folds it over, and causes a solid, animated form to materialize within the handkerchief. Properly handled, this can create a great deal of curiosity on the part of the audience as to what could possibly be inside the handkerchief.

If you were to finish the effect by simply balling up the handkerchief and sticking it in your pocket the audience would be as irate as if they'd read a mystery novel only to find the last few pages missing. Instead, you do open the handkerchief to reveal what's inside—nothing at all. You've solved the mystery by offering an even greater mystery, magic for which there is no possible solution.

The Mysterious Prop: One effective way to create mystery- curiosity suspense is to introduce a prop and then invest it with mystery by keeping one of its features hidden. If properly handled, that feature will pique the audience's curiosity.

In the “Universal Card,” the performer takes out a card which he shows to be a joker. He brings this card in contact with a selected card and shows that the universal card has now changed to a duplicate of the selection. He repeats this with a second and third selection. Throughout this procedure the face of the universal card

is never shown except in contact with other cards. At all other times it's kept face down. The audience is bound to begin wondering what the universal card looks like when it's not in contact with another card. What does it *really* look like? Will it revert back to being a joker?

To place the card in your pocket at the end without giving people a final look at its face would be to cheat them and frustrate the suspense you've created. If instead you turn the card over and show that it is now blank you provide a satisfying and mystifying payoff to the suspense buildup.

A similar situation occurs in "The Dream Card" from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. The performer begins by removing a red-backed card from his wallet which bears his signature across the back. He explains in a tantalizingly vague but suggestive manner that this card figured in a dream he had the previous night. He does not, however, show the face of the card. Instead, he replaces the card in his wallet.

He then has a spectator select a card from a blue deck. The spectator signs the selection on the face. Throughout all this the audience is bound to be wondering about the face of the mysterious dream card. When the performer again removes the card from his wallet, holding it back outward as he patters about it, the curiosity-suspense should build to a high pitch. This helps guarantee a strong reaction when the red-backed dream card is turned around and shown to be the same card the spectator chose from the blue-backed deck, even bearing her signature on its face!

A favorite effect of mine is one in which nine cards are selected by as many spectators, then located by me in rapid-fire fashion. Before beginning the effect I place a small box in front of one of the spectators and instruct her not to take her eyes off it throughout the effect. As the trick unfolds, whenever that spectator starts watching the proceedings I admonish her with mock seriousness to ignore the trick and concentrate on watching the box. By the time the effect nears its end, you can be sure that the entire audience is very curious about what's inside that box.

The climax comes when, after locating the first eight selection, I

open the small box and, folded up inside, is the ninth spectator's signed selected card. The audience receives the long-awaited answer to its unstated question: What's inside the box? But the answer leaves them with a much greater mystery: How could it possibly have gotten inside the box despite the spectator's constant scrutiny?

In each of these examples, the spectator's curiosity is aroused by hiding one of the features of a key prop: the face of the card or the contents of the box. In each case, that feature is eventually revealed to create a far greater mystery.

Undercover Magic: As the Solid Ghost/Glorpy example suggested, almost any effect where magic occurs under cover offers similar potential. In fact, the performer may sometimes wish to keep something temporarily under cover even when the effect does not require it in order to build such suspense.

Eddie Fechter made good use of this idea in "The Open Travellers." The standard approach is for the performer to show his empty palm every time he carries an ace across. Fechter would go through the motions of palming the first ace. Still keeping his hand back outward, he would explain that the palming method he employed allowed free use of the hand. To prove his claim he would flex his hand and even close it into a fist. Yet when he placed his hand down on the table an uncreased ace would seemingly fall out. He would repeat the procedure a second time.

By now the audience was dying for a peek at his palm while it held the card to see how he could keep it undamaged through all that finger flexing. The last time, he satisfied their curiosity by turning his hand over to show an obviously empty palm; yet a moment later the last ace would come out of that hand. Once again, the answer to a mystery proved to be a deeper mystery.

All this talk of doing magic under cover may seem anachronistic in light of the current trend toward visual magic. While visual magic can be very powerful, you shouldn't fall into the trap of thinking that it's the only path to strong magic. This latter view, in my opinion totally erroneous, was argued in a magazine article by Jay Sankey. His position can be fairly summarized by the following quotation from that article: "Why *imply* a miracle when you should

be showing it unfolding itself in full view for all to marvel at? . . . the fewer . . . covers we employ, the more powerful, organic, and artistic our performances will be.” I don't know what Jay means by organic magic and I've left the thorny issue of magic as art for the end of the book. Therefore, I'll limit my observations to the prime concern of this book, making magic powerful.

The problem with Jays view is that he simply doesn't appreciate the power of mystery in magic. Certainly, one can cite bad magic effects that occur under cover, but one could also cite bad visual magic effects. This proves nothing. What a good undercover effect such as those I've described above accomplishes is to engage a viewer's curiosity and his imagination.

I've already pursued the benefits of exploiting curiosity to hold audience interest and to increase audience impact when that curiosity is finally satisfied. Beyond that, when you perform a miracle—something that is truly impossible—but you do it without revealing the entire process, the audience is forced to fill in the blanks with their own imagination. The advantage of engaging an audience's imagination is that whatever they imagine is bound to be more incredible than anything you could ever actually do.

When I was a kid, I would sometimes do a card trick for my little sister in which I would double lift to show the top card, then turn the double face down and deal the top card on the table. I would then rub the card back and forth on the table and, finally, turn it over to show that it had changed to another card.

Years later, my sister told me that she would stay up nights trying to imagine what was happening to the face of that card as it rubbed back and forth against the tablecloth. A color change would have been more visual, but it wouldn't have elicited that particular reaction. Of course, I'm speaking here of a child's viewpoint, but don't underestimate the power of strong magic to elicit a childlike response from adults.

This basic point has often been made in regard to horror films. Today, modern special effects and makeup techniques make it possible to display on the screen the most graphic gore and the most revolting monsters. Yet many of the most effective horror films of

all time are the older films which were forced by technical limitations to rely instead on implication and suggestion. The most advanced film technology cannot create the horror we can conjure up in our own minds under the proper psychological stimulus. As producer Val Lewton, famous for his suspenseful and atmospheric horror films, once said, "If you make the screen dark enough, the mind's eye will read anything into it you want!" The most terrifying monster is the one in the shadows that we can't quite make out. The most horrifying face is the one that waits concealed behind a mask. Sometimes the most amazing miracle is the one we *almost* see.

The old spirit mediums knew that no phantom they could ever produce in full light could match the impact of a piece of luminous gauze waved back and forth in a darkened room. In fact, a spiritualistic magic effect can serve to make the point. Max Maven originated the idea of using "Glorpy" for a spirit writing effect. A blank business card and a pencil are placed on a handkerchief and the corners are folded over to cover them. The performer explains that he will attempt to call upon a visitor from the spirit world to use these tools to provide a message.

Slowly the form of the pen is seen to rise within the handkerchief. It bobs up and down several times in a scribbling motion. Suddenly it drops down again. When the handkerchief is unfolded a message from "the other side" is found scrawled on the card.

Someday someone may succeed in devising a method whereby, in full light, the pen will actually be seen to rise on end and write without the need for the covering handkerchief. But I doubt that the reality of seeing the pen write will ever match the picture the spectators' own minds conjure up for them under Max's adroit psychological manipulation.

There is no real conflict between explicit effects and suggestive ones. As with all the techniques discussed in this book, each can be used effectively to achieve a certain effect on the audience. It's your job as a craftsman to learn *how* to employ each and your job as an artist to decide *when* to employ each.

I'm not for a moment criticizing visual magic. I'm only suggesting that we not lose sight of our real goal. The effect happens in the

spectator's mind. Our ultimate goal is to stimulate the audience's imaginations, not their eyes. The best way to achieve that is through a performance that combines visually explicit effects with other effects that rely more on implication and suggestion. In that way each approach reinforces the other.

In discussing mystery novels I mentioned that the solution must live up to the buildup. Otherwise the reader will feel cheated. This is just as important when mystery-curiosity is used to create suspense in magic. Every example I've given so far has fulfilled this criterion. Let's consider an example of undercover magic that fails to do so.

“The Daylight Séance” is the effect in which the performer holds a curtain in front of him with both hands. Behind the curtain objects levitate, bells ring, etc. As with other undercover effects, this one can create great audience curiosity as to what's happening behind the curtain. They want the performer to finish by tossing the curtain aside and letting them see.

Some performers do just that to show the audience that one of the hands on the curtain is actually a rubber fake; the manifestations were produced by the performer using his free hand. This ending gets the magician a cheap laugh but is bound to leave the audience feeling cheated and a little foolish at being deceived by such a simple means. A far more effective ending would be to whip the curtain away to show the materialization of an animal or other large object thereby answering a mystery with a greater mystery.

Strange Behavior: The final way to create mystery-curiosity suspense is to start a trick by doing something cryptic which you don't explain and which makes the audience wonder what you're up to. This approach is often used in films. Instead of opening with the credits, a movie will open with a pre-credit scene technically called a “teaser.” This first scene will show someone performing some intriguing, unexplained action. Curious to know what is going on, the viewer is hooked into watching what comes next. For example, the comedy *Where's Poppa?* opens with George Segal methodically donning a gorilla costume. This is not an everyday sight, so the audience's curiosity is aroused as to why he's doing it; consequently their attention is assured. (The viewer must wait until after the credits to learn that he's doing it to try to scare his senile old mother

to death.)

There are not many opportunities to apply this technique to magic, but occasionally it can be very useful. In “The Lazy Man's Card Trick,” the performer has the spectator pick a card and bury it in the deck. He then has the spectator cut the deck repeatedly. After three or four cuts, he has him turn the deck face up and start cutting again. He may instruct him to cut the deck eight or ten times or even more. All the while the audience is wondering where all this is leading; their curiosity is aroused and consequently their continued attention is guaranteed until the climax.

Suppose instead the performer announced at the outset that he's going to have the spectator cut several times to lose his card in the deck, then he'll find the card. After a couple of cuts, the audience would feel satisfied that the card was adequately lost and all the subsequent cuts would be boring to them. Since the method requires that the deck be cut many times, you would almost certainly lose the audience before you reached the climax. By keeping them in the dark as to your motives until the end you use their curiosity to keep them hooked. Furthermore, at the end of the trick they will, in retrospect, appreciate that the large number of cuts given the deck did make the outcome that much more impossible.

A popular effect that uses strange behavior to create suspense is Daryl's “Flapjacks.” The performer spends considerable time building a strange little architectural marvel out of a deck of cards, using packets of cards and coins as counterweights. He does this without explaining his purpose. As with the case of George Segal donning the gorilla costume, the audience wants to stick around to find out where this is all leading. When the payoff comes, they discover that it's all a Rube Goldberg-type device to reveal a four-card transformation. The humor is counterbalanced by the mystery of the four cards having changed.

Another good example of this technique is Jay Sankey's presentation of the “Card to Mouth.” Throughout the trick, he doesn't utter a word instead using title cards to give instructions to the spectators. Naturally, the audience is bound to wonder what the reason for the performer's strange silence is. That curiosity helps

ensure that they'll pay rapt attention right through to the end of the effect when they discover that the reason the performer can't talk is that he has the folded, signed, selected card in his mouth. (Intriguingly, this presentation implies that the card was in his mouth even before it was selected by the spectator!)

Some Parting Examples: As all these illustrations make dear, the key to mystery-curiosity suspense is to *create questions in the spectator's mind*. The opportunities for doing this are limited only by your own creativity.

One very creative use of this technique can be found in an effect from Juan Tamariz' *The Magic Way*. It employs a twist on the "mysterious prop" feature. In this case the prop is a slate. The key feature of the prop, the writing it contains, is hidden from the audience for only a couple of moments. Yet in that time tremendous suspense is generated.

Tamariz does a platform effect in which a drawing randomly selected from a magazine appears duplicated on a slate which has all the while been held by two spectators. Most performers would finish by immediately turning the slate toward the audience. Instead, Tamariz turns the slate so that only the two spectators on stage can see the drawing. Naturally, they react with amazement. The audience wonders what on earth they could be looking at that would evoke such a reaction (mystery-curiosity suspense). Consequently, when Tamariz finally turns the slate toward the audience their response is that much stronger. (This technique also has its film analog, the "reaction shot" showing a character responding with horror or amazement a moment before the audience is shown what the character is reacting to.)

I want you to realize that what we're discussing here is not some vague theory with little connection to reality. It is a series of concrete, practical techniques you can use to strengthen your magic and solve dramatic problems you may encounter in some effects. To make the point, I'll give you a specific example of such problem-solving. Vernon's "Travellers" is an effect in which the performer buries four signed aces in the deck. Instantly, he produces those aces from four different pockets. A couple of magicians have told me they have trouble holding the audience during this effect. By the

time the fourth card is produced from the pocket, the people's attention is wandering.

I don't know whether this is a weakness of the effect or of those individual performers. Either way, a little creativity can solve the problem through mystery-curiosity suspense. Suppose you present the effect this way. After the aces have been signed and lost in the deck, you announce that you'll make the aces travel to four different pockets. You riffle the deck, then reach in your pocket and pull out a card. You look at its face and announce that it is the ace of clubs, but you don't show it. Instead, you toss it face down on the table. You do the same thing with the other three aces, removing each one from a different pocket and naming it but not showing its face. Finally, you dramatically turn over each of the tabled cards to show that they are just what you claimed, the four signed aces.

All the time that you were producing the aces from your pockets, the audience would be thinking: "Is he serious? What kind of con is he trying to pull? Those cards can't really be the signed aces; they're lost in the deck, so what cards are those, and how does he intend to get himself out of this bluff?" This audience curiosity would guarantee their undivided attention when you finally turn over the aces for the climax. There would be no danger of the audience's interest waning before the end of the trick. And when the climax of the trick did come, the mystery of what the identity of those face-down cards really was would be replaced by the far deeper mystery of how those signed aces traveled to your pockets.

Yet another effective approach would be the following. The performer has the four aces signed, then leaves them face up in the center of the table. He then has four spectators each select a card and the four selections are lost in the deck. The tabled aces are turned face down and left in the center of the table. Immediately the performer starts pulling the signed aces from different pockets as in the original "Travellers." For the climax he turns over the four tabled cards to show that they are now the four previously-selected cards.

Once again, an unanswered question hooks the audience until the end of the effect. The aces are supposed to be face down in the center of the table. Therefore, when the performer starts pulling

those same aces from different pockets, the audience has to wonder: what are those cards on the table? They have to wait until the end of the effect to find out, their curiosity growing throughout; each time an ace is produced from the pocket the audience will be more eager to see the tabled cards turned face up. When they finally are, the answer to the mystery proves to be an even greater mystery: how did the four selected cards travel from the deck to the center of the table?

I'll close this discussion of mystery-curiosity with one last very creative example of its use, in this case employing the “mysterious prop” angle. In his book *Bizarre* Tony Shiels has a beautiful and quite frightening effect called “Jack-In-The-Box.” The performer places a small antique toy box on the table. The audience can't help noting that the box is held shut by a tiny padlock. This in itself is bound to arouse mystery-curiosity suspense about its contents.

The performer begins to explain the unusual way in which this Victorian era jack-in-the-box came into his possession. This explanation provides time for the suspense to build. As the performer continues talking, the spectators see the box tremble slightly, but the performer does not notice. This unsettling phenomenon occurs once or twice more. Finally, the performer produces a small key and unlocks the box. Can you doubt that by the time he opens the box, the audience's suspense will have reached a very high pitch? If you want to find out what finally emerges from the box, you will have to read Shiels' great book. For now, I'll leave you in suspense.

Conflict–Uncertainty

We've already discussed the concept of conflict extensively under Situational Meaning. All the types of conflicts described before can be exploited to create suspense as the audience waits to see who or what emerges victorious. However, in the context of suspense, the term conflict can be interpreted more broadly to include one of the classic conflict themes in literature: man against nature. In less pretentious terms, this simply means bucking the odds. In terms of magic, any effect where the performer undertakes a task that seems to carry great risk of failure either because of the great skill required

or because of the mathematical odds against the performer would constitute such a conflict.

An example of the first category is “The Twofer Shuffle” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*, an effect in which the performer attempts to stack a poker hand of four aces in only one riffle shuffle. I always preface this effect with the statement that it is so difficult that I only succeed on the average about four out of five times. This statement helps underscore the uncertainty of success in each performance. This illustrates an important point about such effects. In order to build suspense it's not enough that the effect actually be difficult; the audience must appreciate the fact that it's very difficult. This is the reasoning behind the old circus acrobats' practice of deliberately missing on the first couple of tries. In fact, the actual degree of difficulty involved is quite irrelevant. All that matters is the audience's perception. As always, the effect is what happens in the audience's mind.

Another strong suspense effect that relies on the difficulty angle to create uncertainty is Michael Ammar's presentation of “Roll-Over Aces” in which he pits himself against a stopwatch. The race-against-time technique Michael employs in this effect has long been a staple of suspense films. It can be traced from the old silent melodramas where the hero had to untie the heroine from the railroad tracks before the train reached them to the scene in *Goldfinger* where James Bond has to defuse the bomb he is handcuffed to before it detonates, all the while watching the timer as it relentlessly approaches zero hour. Undoubtedly, the concept has many more potential applications in dramatizing close-up effects.

A good example of an effect where conflict-uncertainty suspense can be built up due to the great mathematical odds against success is provided by any card prediction in which the method allows the performer to play up the spectator's total freedom of choice. Still another good example is the “Bank Night” effect.

In all these cases, the audience must know in advance what the performer is attempting. If you simply have someone pick a card, then remove a prediction from your pocket and have it read, this may come as a surprise but it won't be a source of suspense. Quite

simply, the audience won't realize until the end that a conflict was underway.

Suppose instead that you remove a prediction from your pocket at the outset and hand it to a spectator as you explain what you're about to attempt. You then permit another spectator to shuffle the deck and to select any card she wishes, allowing her to change her mind as often as she wants until she finally commits herself to a choice. Finally, you review the odds against success before having the first spectator read the prediction. In this case, the audience has been made aware from the outset of the seemingly insurmountable odds you are facing in your effort to predict the card. In this way considerable conflict-uncertainty suspense can be developed.

“Out of this World” and any version of “Seven Keys to Baldpate” are other good examples of where the apparent odds against success offer potential for building suspense. Indeed all the effects discussed under Risk in Situational Meaning can be considered conflict–uncertainty effects as regards suspense. In each of those cases the performer was attempting to overcome natural obstacles to his success and even offering to risk something on the outcome of the conflict.

Indeed in every effect one performs he must overcome some obstacles to success—must run some risk of failure—but audiences are not really likely to fully appreciate that in a smooth-running performance where each effect seems to be executed effortlessly. It's only when something goes wrong that they're reminded of the risks the performer is continually taking. That is why the Failure effects discussed under Situational Meaning may also be exploited for suspense. In fact, all effects possessing strong situational meaning also possess potential for developing conflict-uncertainty suspense.

In Failure effects, the uncertainty arises from the question of whether the performer will be able to overcome his problem. It is the few moments before that question is answered that can be exploited for suspense.

Consider Dai Vernon's “Cutting the Aces.” The effect ends with the performer attempting to cut to the final ace and arriving instead at a spot card. The performer uses the number of spots on the card to

indicate how many cards he should count down. If the card is a six, he counts down to the sixth card from the top of the deck and arrives at the final ace. This is a classic Failure situation. When the audience sees the six they think the performer has failed. However, he soon turns that apparent failure into an impressive success.

To milk this situation, when you cut the last time, turn the card toward the audience and proclaim it to be the ace without looking at it. All this time that the audience is aware of your failure and you're not, the suspense is building. They're thinking, "How will he take it when he finds out he messed up?" When you finally look at the card, pause for a few moments as if stunned and unsure how to proceed. This provides more time for the uncertainty suspense to build. Finally, the suspense is resolved when you count down to the ace.

The technique of making the audience aware of the menace before the protagonist becomes aware has been employed in some of the most suspenseful scenes in film history. In *The Cat and the Canary*, the audience sees the claw-like hand reaching out from behind the sliding panel in the wall and groping toward the heroine long before she does. In the shower scene from *Psycho*, the audience sees the menacing silhouette behind the shower curtain while the heroine is still blithely unaware of her danger.

In *The Phantom of the Opera*, when the heroine unmask the phantom, his face is turned away from her but toward the camera. Even as they are horrified by his disfigured face, the audience has time to wonder how the heroine will react when he turns around to face her. Once again we see that the dramatic elements that work in magic are the same that work in any narrative art.

Tension–Anticipation

When you start something, an audience expects you to finish it. If you don't finish it right away, a certain amount of tension will be created until you do so as the audience anticipates the conclusion they've been led to expect. It's like the proverbial case of waiting for the other shoe to drop. That is what the third form of suspense is all about. In the words of Rust Hills, "The most obvious way to create it, is by simply saying something is going to happen, then putting it off."

The most basic application of this idea in magic is the old gag where the magician announces that something magical will happen on the count of three. He begins to count slowly. Then, just before the count of three he stops to deliver some gag or on some other pretext, after which he begins the count all over again.

The Second-Shoe Technique: There are, however, far more sophisticated and potent examples of tension-anticipation suspense in magic. Consider “McDonald's Aces.” The performer deals four packets, each containing one ace and three other cards. One of the packets is placed under a spectator's hand. The performer then announces that he will make the other three aces change places with the indifferent cards in the spectator's packet. One-by-one, each ace is seen to change into an indifferent card.

Apparently the performer is keeping his promise. However, only one half of the miracle is shown each time. They see that the ace has changed into an indifferent card but they do not get to see whether an indifferent card under the spectator's hand has changed to an ace. (And, after all, that is the most amazing aspect of the transposition.)

Leaving each transposition unfinished creates more and more tension and consequently more and more anticipation for the final revelation in which the cards under the spectator's hand are all shown to be aces. This is why “McDonald's Aces” offers potential for a tremendous suspense buildup that cannot be attained in a “slow-motion ace assembly” in which the arrival of each ace in the leader packet is shown each time before proceeding to the next ace.

The suspense of “McDonald's Aces” is not of the mystery- curiosity variety; the audience knows from the outset how the effect is supposed to end. It's not of the conflict-uncertainty variety; there is no conflict and, if you've preceded the effect with other strong magic there should be no uncertainty in the audience's mind about whether you'll succeed. In fact, in my presentation, after the packet has been placed under the spectator's hand I explain to the spectator what is going to happen and ask her, “Do you think I can do it?” Almost invariably she laughs and says, “Yes.” But that doesn't mean she doesn't want to see it happen.

“McDonald's Aces” is strong partly because each ace vanish is itself

powerful, visual magic. But it's also strong because each ace vanish acts as a tease to increase anticipation for the climax in which the missing aces are revealed under the spectator's hand. The term "tease" has a sexual connotation and in this case it's an apt allusion. You've started something and the audience expects you to finish it. But the longer you can hold it off—the more tension you can build up—the better it will feel when it finally happens. I guess that's why they call it a climax.

The formula used in "McDonald's Aces", which I've labeled the second-shoe technique, can be applied to most multiple-phase effects of transition or transposition. What sets effects of transition (an object travels from one place to another) and transposition (two objects change places) apart is the effect may be revealed in two steps. In a transition, you can first show that the object has vanished from its original location, then that it's arrived at a new location. In a transposition, you can first show that object A has changed to object B, then that object B has changed to object A. Therefore, in a multiple phase transition or transposition effect, you can often (depending on the method) execute step A of every phase before revealing step B.

An example should make this clearer. In John Ramsay's "Cylinder and Coins," most performers make no reference to where the vanishing coins are going. When they lift the cylinder at the end to reveal the four coins it packs a surprise punch. Instead, the performer can show the cylinder empty, place it aside and then announce that he will make each coin travel invisibly to within the cylinder. Then each time a coin vanishes it creates audience anticipation for the performer to lift up the cylinder, something he doesn't do until all four coins have vanished.

Either approach may be made effective. However, this indicates how suspense and surprise are often at odds. Frequently, in routining a trick, you'll have to decide which of these two dramatic effects you want to achieve. If, in audience-testing an effect, you find that you need to strengthen the trick's ability to hold the audience's interest until the end, suspense is the technique to use.

An excellent example of how tension-anticipation can be built into an effect that doesn't already possess it is provided by Jon

Racherbaumer's handling of Brother Hamman's "Underground Transposition." Like "McDonald's Aces", this trick involves a series of transpositions. Although Jon's version of this trick, published in *The Hierophant*, differs from the original in several ways I'll deal only with the aspect relevant here.

In the original, four kings in one packet change places one at a time with four aces in another packet. Each time a transposition occurs both packets are shown. Jon came up with the idea of showing only one packet until just before the climax. In other words, he would perform a magical gesture and show that the king packet now contained three kings and an ace. He would not, however, spread the ace packet. He would perform another magical gesture and show that the king packet now contained two aces and only two kings. Another magical gesture and the king packet was now shown to consist of three aces and only one king.

All this time the ace packet lay untouched on the table. Each time an ace appeared in the king packet the audience wondered about the ace packet. Did it really contain one less ace? Were the kings really appearing within the ace packet? They wanted to see that ace packet, and with each transposition they wanted to see it more.

It was not until just before the last transposition that Jon picked up the ace packet and showed that it did indeed contain three kings and only one ace at that point just as it should. The effect on the audience was strong. Finally, the effect climaxed with the last transposition, the one packet now shown to contain all aces and the other all kings.

From a technical standpoint, Jon could have just as easily shown both packets after each transposition; in fact, that's the standard handling of this effect. Instead, he made them wait for the other shoe to drop. By deliberately holding back, putting off showing half the effect, he kept the audience in *an unfulfilled state* and thereby guaranteed their continued interest. When he finally satisfied their curiosity, he provided the effect with an emotional high point normally missing from repetitive effects of this kind. Overall, he achieved more impact with less work.

The Unavoidable Delay Technique: Here is an alternative to the

second shoe technique for generating anticipation suspense. You announce that you've achieved a certain effect but then you make the audience wait before they can find out if your claim is true. However, the wait must appear to be an unavoidable one created by the nature of the effect; otherwise the audience will realize they're being manipulated and resent it.

A perfect example of the right approach is the "Nest of Boxes." The performer borrows a coin and has it marked by a spectator. He places the coin in his hand. With his other hand he reaches into his pocket and removes a small plastic box and hands it to the spectator from whom he borrowed the coin. He then makes a mystic pass over his closed hand and causes the coin to vanish. Turning to the spectator holding the box he announces that the coin is inside. When the spectator opens the box he finds, not the coin, but a smaller box. Within that box he finds a still smaller box. He continues opening progressively smaller boxes until he finally finds the marked coin.

The fact that the coin is found inside several boxes rather than just one strengthens the effect due to the more stringent conditions, but it also strengthens it by creating tension-anticipation. You've made the claim that the coin is inside the plastic box. The audience wants to see the proof of this amazing claim. However, they have to wait, not because you're a mean guy who forces them to wait, but because it takes time to open all those boxes. All that time the tension is building within the audience, guaranteeing a stronger reaction when the fulfillment finally arrives.

Telegraphing the Climax: the audience has to know in advance that the coin is supposed to ultimately be found inside. Otherwise the opening of all those boxes merely becomes tedious. It may not be necessary to actually announce what the climax will be. Audiences are intelligent and realize that, the coin having vanished, the next logical step is to find it. When you direct the spectator to open the box they will probably expect the coin to be inside. But, one way or the other, it's imperative that they do foresee the climax; if you find that they're not catching on on their own, by all means *tell them* that the coin is inside the box.

In fact, the more of a foretaste of the climax you give them in

advance the more anticipation you can build. A beautiful example of this kind of thinking is a Ron Wilson idea I mentioned earlier, that of using a window envelope for the Card in Envelope Wallet. You remove the envelope from your wallet and announce that the card is inside. This builds anticipation. You turn the envelope over and point out the back of a playing card visible through the glassine window. This, you assert, is the signed, selected card. This peek-a-boo tease builds anticipation further. They want you to rip the envelope open and show the card.

Instead you turn the envelope over and point out how thoroughly sealed it is. You stress that the flap is glued down. You point to the wax seal and point out your stamped initial. All this time the audience continues to simmer, wanting more and more to see the card inside that envelope. Finally, you tear the envelope open and reveal the selected card within, providing a release for the tension you've built up.

Another good example of the need to telegraph the ending in order to achieve anticipation suspense occurs in the final phase of Vernon's "Cutting the Aces." As already described, this consists of the performer cutting to a spot card, then using the number of spots on the card to count down to the final ace. If you simply start dealing and counting as soon as you see the spot card the audience won't understand what is going on until you arrive at the ace.

Suppose, instead, you explain that you've deliberately cut to a certain spot card because that card indicates the position of the ace. Point out that the card you cut to is a six, then slowly start to deal and count aloud. The audience will immediately realize that the ace is supposed to turn up on the count of six. Even in the few moments it takes to count six cards you can build considerable audience anticipation.

The Dramatic Pause: Of the three different forms of suspense, tension-anticipation is easily the one you'll be able to exploit most often in your magic. In fact, almost any trick that has a strong climax can be given a little more impact simply by incorporating a dramatic pause to build suspense just before revealing the climax.

Even something as simple as a pick-a-card location can, and should,

be built up this way. Instead of immediately turning the card over, hold it back toward the audience. Ask the spectator who selected it to name his card, then *slowly* turn it face toward the audience. If you're not already using this approach, try it and see how much this small dramatic buildup can add to any pick-a-card trick.

This is why the “Ultra-Mental” deck is dramatically superior to the “Brainwave” deck. In the “Brainwave” deck, the prediction card appears face up in the face-down deck. One moment it's not visible; the next moment it is. There is no opportunity for any anticipation to build up. In the “Ultra-Mental” deck, the prediction card appears face down in the face-up deck. This gives you a chance to build suspense for a few moments before turning the card face outward to show that the prediction is correct.

What I've just described is analogous to the practice of some poker players who “slow roll” their hand at the showdown, spreading it slowly or turning it over card by card rather than all at once. In fact, if you do any poker deals you should definitely use this approach yourself to milk the hand for maximum suspense.

Of course, the more amazing the trick itself, the more effective this dramatic pause technique will be. A favorite card trick of mine is Larry Jennings' “Homing Card”; an ace of spades placed aside continually returns to a red packet in the performer's hand. Although the packet keeps diminishing in size as card after card is placed aside, the ace is always found in the packet. When I'm finally down to only one card in my hand, this card is cleanly shown to be a red card, then turned back toward the audience.

With only one card in my hand there simply appears to be no possibility for manipulation, yet the audience knows from the pattern already established that this card is going to change to the ace of spades. The expected climax is so amazing that the dramatic pause in this case is very potent. Some spectators will shake their heads while others will actually yell out, “No way!” or, “If that card is the ace of spades, I'll [fill in the blank]!” When the change is finally revealed it hits with the impact of a sledge hammer. But the pause is imperative to achieve that impact. Why let them off the hook right away? Let them sweat a little.

Milking Suspense

Of course, the first step toward creating suspense is recognizing those effects that have strong potential for suspense. This has been the focus of our discussion so far. However, no matter how strong an effect's suspense potential, you must know how to exploit that potential. There are several key elements you have to provide in order to successfully generate suspense.

First, as the definition I gave at the outset indicated, suspense requires time. Remember Darwin's Suspense Formula: make them care, then make them *wait*. It's impossible to create a high order of suspense in a quickie effect. Since suspense takes time, you may have to deliberately routine an effect so as to create time delays if you want to generate suspense. This is technically known as “milking” the suspense.

A beginner performing the “Endless Chain” will simply have the spectator place his finger in one of the loops then rapidly jerk the chain away to show that it has not caught. A more experienced performer might proceed as follows. He instructs the spectator to place one forefinger into each of the two loops. He then pulls the chain until it's taut against both fingers. Now he tells the spectator to study the chain and decide which finger he thinks will catch. He then has him remove one of his fingers. Finally, the performer pulls the chain away with agonizing slowness until finally it becomes apparent that it's not going to catch. This latter presentation will take twice as long but will be more than twice as effective because of the suspense buildup.

Here's a very simple but valid application of the milking concept. I've seen magicians perform the countdown ending to “Cutting the Aces” with a three-spot. Such a countdown simply doesn't last long enough to allow for suspense. If instead you make sure to use at least a five- or six-spot, a good deal of anticipation can be built up.

Often the time necessary to build suspense can be created by a means that appears to be an unavoidable part of the routine. For example, when John Scarne performed the “Card to Wallet,” the wallet he removed from his pocket had rubber bands wrapped around it lengthwise and widthwise. This feature added a new

condition to the effect, but it also accomplished something more important. The performer now had to take the time to remove each of the rubber bands before the audience could find out if the selected card was really inside. During this unavoidable delay the suspense built to a level unachievable in standard Card to Wallet effects which get to the point faster.

The most extreme example of deliberately creating a time delay in order to build suspense is that of Houdini's stage escapes. Most of these escapes were performed behind a screen. Often Houdini would succeed in escaping within moments. He would then patiently wait behind the screen while the audience sweated. From time to time he would peek from behind the screen to check on the audience. When he finally determined that the suspense had reached the proper fever pitch, he would muss up his hair and emerge from behind the screen panting and looking drawn. Keep in mind that he would often keep his audience waiting twenty or thirty minutes or even more before emerging triumphant. The usual audience response after this interminable wait was a standing ovation.

There are many self-styled experts (the kind who perform only for the bedroom mirror or their long-suffering wives) who'll tell you that such a strategy would never work today: audiences today are far more sophisticated than in Houdini's more innocent times. They'll tell you that television has given audiences far shorter attention spans. No one brought up on *Miami Vice* and MTV would sit still watching nothing and doing nothing for a half hour.

In response to these sages I offer the following instructive contemporary example. The Amazing Kreskin, the most successful mentalist of this generation and one of the most highly paid magical performers today, always closes his act the same way. Before the show a representative of the client hides Kreskin's paycheck somewhere in the theater. At the conclusion of the performance Kreskin takes the hand of an audience member who knows where the check is hidden and attempts to locate the paycheck by means of contact mindreading. This is done with the understanding that if he fails to locate the check he will forfeit his fee for the engagement.

By actual clocking in two different performances it took Kreskin

over thirty minutes each time to find his check. For over a half hour the audience watched a man walk up and down the aisles aimlessly. Attention never flagged, no one spoke, and no one left the theater. In both cases, when Kreskin finally succeeded in finding the check he was greeted by an audience response that would have surprised the aforementioned “experts” but would have come as no surprise to Houdini. Both audiences gave Kreskin a rousing standing ovation.

Kreskin uses this ending not only when performing for general audiences but also in his college shows. College students would presumably represent the ultimate example of the MTV mentality; however, they also invariably reward Kreskin with standing ovations.

Those who think that the audience was watching nothing for a half hour in these examples miss the point. What they were watching was a man in the midst of what they perceived to be a vital struggle with a great deal riding on the outcome. In the case of Kreskin, his walking haltingly along the aisles was the outward manifestation of that struggle. In the case of Houdini, the struggle took place only in the audience's mind as they imagined what might be going on behind that screen. In each case, it was strong enough entertainment to hold the audience spellbound.

Because suspense builds over time, an effective suspense- building technique is what I term the pre-climactic stall. I've already made reference to the old bit of dramatically starting to count to three, but stopping to deliver some gag just before the count of three. In Michael Ammar's timed presentation of “Roll-Over Aces” he has the spectator stop the stopwatch a couple of seconds before the climax. He then has the spectator announce how many seconds are left and he recaps how much he must yet accomplish in those few seconds. This pause is technically unnecessary but dramatically very powerful since it provides time for the situation to hit home with the audience and the suspense to build. It's simply a more sophisticated version of the one-two-three gag.

When a performer who is doing “The Seven Keys to Baldpate” stops just before the last spectator tries his key and offers to let him exchange his key for the single remaining one he is dramatizing the conditions of the effect, but he is also creating a pre-climactic stall

to heighten suspense.

In addition to manufacturing a stall in order to build suspense, it is sometimes possible to take a truly unavoidable time lag and turn it from a liability into an asset by using it to generate suspense. Few magicians would dispute that “Out of this World” is one of the strongest effects in card magic, but it does take a long time to reach the climax. During the first three-quarters of the effect, the audience is just watching someone slowly deal cards into two face-down piles. This time can be used to generate suspense for the climax.

An effective ploy Paul Curry suggested in the original instructions was to correct a spectator's “error” at one point. Since you know what color card the spectator is dealing at any given point, at some point when she places a card on the wrong pile, point out her mistake. Show the face of the card and place it on the correct pile.

When I perform the effect I use this idea as well as another of my own devising. I perform the impromptu version of the effect in which the performer removes cards from the fanned deck during the first half, allowing the spectator to indicate in which pile the card should be placed. At one point, I remove two cards and mix them face down on the table as I explain that one of these cards is red and one is black. (Actually, both are the same color; let's assume they're black.) I ask the spectator to point to the one she believes is red. I then drop that card on the red pile. Finally, I drop the other card on the black pile. However, as I do so, I casually turn it over to show its face. The fact that it's black seems to prove that the spectator guessed correctly.

Both these bits will get a good audience reaction. More importantly, they will change the audience's entire attitude toward the dealing process. By giving them a foretaste of the climax through these two ploys you start the audience wondering if perhaps the impossible really will happen and the spectator will succeed in separating the colors. The time required to deal out the cards now becomes a period of expectancy rather than one of tedium.

There are in fact a number of very strong card effects that involve long dealing procedures before reaching the climax. In *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I have an effect called “The Ultimate Card

Shark.” It's a gambling routine that ends with the dealing out of four perfect bridge hands. This is an extremely strong climax. However, the process of dealing out the entire deck into four hands takes time even when performed briskly.

Rather than allow this to become dead time, I use the dealing time to build tension-anticipation. As I deal out the hands I talk about what constitutes a perfect hand at bridge and what the astronomical odds against receiving such a hand are. The audience quickly realizes that I intend to deal a perfect hand and begins to anticipate the climax. The time required to complete the deal then becomes a period of building suspense rather than a drag on the effect. Furthermore, the climax still retains an element of surprise since the audience has been led to expect one perfect bridge hand and is surprised when all four hands turn out to be perfect.

Still another example of exploiting a long dealing procedure in a card trick for suspense is the Paul Curry plot “The Open Prediction.” In this case the suspense is of the conflict-uncertainty type as the performer bucks seemingly incredible odds. The performer begins by openly announcing that he believes the spectator will select the ten of spades. He then hands the deck to the spectator and tells him to deal through it face up, looking for the ten of spades. However, sometime during the deal, the spectator must place aside, sight unseen, any card he wishes.

As the deal proceeds further and further down in the deck without turning up the ten of spades it starts to dawn on the audience that the card placed aside must indeed be the predicted card. As the deal nears the end, the tension mounts as the audience waits to see if the predicted card will turn up among the last few. Of course, it doesn't, and the performer climaxes the effect by turning over the selected card to reveal the ten of spades. (The well-known “Premonition” effect is another prediction trick that can be built up this way.)

This example also illustrates the need for providing the audience with foreknowledge of the performer's goal if suspense is to be created. (The one exception is in mystery-curiosity suspense of the “strange behavior” type.) If the above effect were done with a *closed* prediction which was not revealed until after the dealing process was finished, the entire procedure would be monumentally boring.

Let's take one last example of using an unavoidably long procedure to build suspense. Many versions of the “Eyeless Vision” stage effect involve an intricate and time-consuming process of blindfolding the eyes. Coins are taped over the eyes. Dough is kneaded and pressed over the coins. A blindfold or hood is placed over the head. If the audience doesn't know what the performer intends to do, this procedure may seem tedious.

However, if the performer has announced in advance that, as soon as he is blindfolded, he intends, for example, to shoot an apple off a spectator's head, the blindfolding procedure becomes suspenseful rather than boring. The more impossible conditions that are piled on during the blindfolding procedure, the more the audience wonders how the performer could possibly hope to succeed and what the result will be when the fateful shot is fired.

Another point made in our definition is that suspense always revolves around a desired result. If the audience doesn't care whether or not the card is in the wallet, all the rubber bands in the world won't create suspense; they will only increase the boredom. Suspense is no substitute for substantive or situational meaning. Rather, if an effect already possesses meaning, suspense can make an already powerful effect more powerful and riveting. Remember Darwin's Suspense Formula: Make them *care*, then make them wait.

Combining Suspense Elements

One final point to note is that a single effect may provide more than one *source* of suspense or more than one *form* of suspense. These different suspense elements may work simultaneously or sequentially.

The strategy of using different suspense hooks sequentially is the very essence of the successful suspense novel or action film. The interest of the reader or viewer is held by one suspenseful scene. He wants to know how it will end. Yet, no sooner is that suspense element resolved than a new one arises to capture his interest. In this way he is propelled from scene to scene as if grabbed by the collar and transferred along from one hand to another along a gauntlet, never being released until the climax. If you want to see what I mean, watch *Raiders of the Lost Ark* or read any James Bond

novel.

Of course, a magic effect can never hope to match the complexity of a film or novel. Nevertheless, this strategy can work on a smaller scale in certain effects.

We've already seen how the final phase of "Cutting the Aces" creates uncertainty suspense when the performer apparently misses, cutting instead to a spot card, and how that suspense immediately shifts to anticipation suspense when the performer begins to count down to the selected card. A more complex illustration is provided by Paul Harris' "Reflex," an effect which is potentially one of the most suspenseful in close-up magic. While there is nothing revolutionary about my own presentation of this effect, I'll detail it for the sake of having a specific scenario to analyze.

First, I explain the premise: I will put my sleight-of-hand speed to the test in a contest against the spectator—a contest in which the spectator has all the advantages. The spectator shuffles the deck and removes any seven cards. She then merely thinks of any one of these cards. The seven cards are shuffled and dropped back on top of the deck.

I now explain the ground rules for the contest. I will show each card to the spectator, then drop it face down on the table. As soon as her card hits the table she is to slam her hand on it. The moment her hand begins to move, that will be my signal to try to snatch the card away before she can get to it. As I say in my patter, "She has a slight advantage; she knows what card she's thinking of and I don't. I have a slight advantage; I practice an awful lot."

The contest then begins. Each time I drop a card on the table I tense as if ready to spring. The spectator invariably takes the matter very seriously. Her tenseness communicates itself to the audience. Some spectators will throw in an occasional feint which serves to keep the audience even more on the edge of their seats. It's a classic conflict situation. The uncertainty of the conflict's outcome holds the audience riveted as much as any performer could wish.

Eventually the spectator slams her hand down on a card. This invariably triggers laughter from the audience—an emotional release for the pressure that has built up. In their eyes, the suspense

situation has been resolved; the spectator has won.

For a moment I act surprised and crestfallen as if beaten. Then I announce confidently that the spectator wasn't fast enough. I instruct her to look under her hand to see that I have gotten the card. Immediately the audience is pulled up short by my claim. Hardly have they caught their breath from the first suspense issue when they are faced with a new one.

Now they're curious to find out if my claim is true. Every eye is glued on the spectator's hand as she lifts it and turns over the card underneath. So absorbed are they by this issue that most don't even notice me removing my wallet from my pocket and dropping it on the table. They're too busy reacting to the fact that the thought-of card is not under the spectator's hand. The second suspense issue has been resolved. My claim was true; her card is gone.

However, as soon as this fact sinks in, I change the focus. I have the spectator turn over the other cards under her hand in search of her card. I deal off the top several cards of the deck face up. I spread the deck face up on the table. The thought-of card is nowhere to be seen. Tongue in cheek, I pull at the spectator's sleeve and even lift up the corner of the close-up mat in search of the missing card. All these actions serve to heighten the question in the audience's mind, "If the card wasn't under her hand, where on earth is it?" Need I point out that this question provides the third suspense phase?

Finally, I announce, "The hard part wasn't getting the card out from under Jennifer's hand. The hard part was placing Jennifer's card in a safe place." As I deliver the last line I pick up my wallet. Immediately they understand what I mean. The card is in the wallet! It can't be, but it must be. That's the answer to the third suspense phase.

They already believe it, but they want to *see* it. As I continue to patter I turn the wallet over and over in my hand. I open it. I point to the zippered compartment. Slowly I pull the zipper down. I ask the spectator to name her card. All this time the audience's anticipation is building. Finally I remove the card from the wallet and toss it to the table with a spin. The last and most powerful suspense phase has been resolved.

In one effect the audience is drawn through four suspense experiences, each subsequent one starting almost the moment the previous one is resolved. First, there is the question of who will win the contest between performer and spectator (conflict-uncertainty). Next, there is the question of whether or not the card is really under her hand (mystery-curiosity). Then there is the mystery of where the missing card is to be found (mystery-curiosity). Finally, there is the desire to see the miracle—to actually see the card come out of the wallet (tension-anticipation). I grab them by the collar at the outset and never let go until the climax. John Le Carré eat your heart out.

4. The Climax

There are few things as important—and tricky—in a magic performance as properly handling the climax of each effect. It's quite amazing how you can do everything perfectly in a trick, yet ruin it all in a matter of seconds by hobbling the climax. In fact, you'll see just that happen in most typical close-up magic performances. By contrast, structuring the climax properly can literally double the impact of an effect. Here are some principles to guide you in the right direction.

End On The Climax

In *The Elements of Screenwriting*, Irwin Blacker writes: “After the conflict is resolved in the climax, the film should end as quickly as possible.” He cites as an ideal example *A Man for All Seasons* where the second the executioner's ax falls on Thomas More the screen fades to black. In his book on comedy *The Light Touch*, Malcolm Kushner stresses this basic rule: “Put the punchline at the end,” He goes so far as to criticize the phrasing of one joke because there are two words after the key word of the punchline.

Here are two widely separated fields, movies and jokes; yet the same principle is being stressed in both. This is because it's such a fundamental principle of dramatic structure that it's equally valid in any dramatic medium—including magic tricks. The principle is that, once the climax is reached, anything that follows will only tend to weaken what you've already accomplished. In other words, once you

hit the climax, shut up and fade to black.

In order to do this, you must tie up all loose ends and resolve all doubts *before* the climax. You must also resist the temptation to throw in an anti-climax.

Unresolved Suspicions

A common example of the problem of lingering doubts comes up in some effects where a card travels from the deck to your pocket, your wallet, or some other impossible place. If the card has been signed, then the production of the card from the impossible location perfectly climaxes the trick. Unfortunately, sometimes you can't have the card signed, either because you're using a duplicate or because the card has merely been thought of rather than selected. If the card hasn't been signed, the audience will immediately suspect that the card in the wallet is not the same one that a moment ago was in the deck. This suspicion will usually be voiced by saying, "Can I see the deck?"

Naturally, you've anticipated that response and have ensured that, even if you did use a duplicate, the spectator won't find the card he's looking for in the deck. He'll spread through the cards, not find the one he's searching for, and finally accept that the card you had pulled from your wallet really is the same one that had been in the deck. He will then be duly impressed by the trick.

The problem is that the effect climaxed a minute-and-a-half ago, and he's only now coming to accept that an impossibility has occurred. For this person, the trick really ended when he looked through the deck and didn't find a duplicate, not when you pulled the card out of your wallet. The realization he's just come to should have occurred at the moment you removed the card from your wallet. If it had, the emotional impact would have been much stronger.

Here's a much better way to handle the same situation. You hand the spectator the deck and tell him to count the cards out loud, dealing them face-up on the table as he does so. Also, tell him that the moment he sees his card he is to place it aside and continue counting. When he's counted twenty cards, remind him that he is to

place his card aside as soon as he sees it. After another ten cards, remind him again. At this point, the audience will start to suspect that the card has vanished. This makes the counting of the remaining cards very suspenseful as the audience waits to see whether or not the card will turn up.

When the spectator finishes going through the deck, he'll have counted only fifty-one cards and his card will not have shown. Everyone will be wondering where the card is. Now is the time to pull out your wallet and remove the card for a strong climax unmarred by lingering doubts. No one will be thinking, "That's not the same card he chose. It's just a duplicate. I bet his card is still in the deck."

Card-to-impossible-place effects are not the only kind of trick where this issue can arise. Be sensitive to comments or questions from spectators after the climax of an effect that suggest they have some unresolved suspicions. Typical examples are: "Can I look in your pocket?" "What's inside the box?" "Can I see those cards over there?"

When a certain effect elicits the same type of doubt again and again, you have to do something about it. If you can't let them look in your pocket, see inside the box, or check the deck, you've simply got a bad trick you should consider dropping. However, if you *can* resolve their doubts, do a little creative reroutining so that their question is answered before they have a chance to think of it and, most importantly, before you reach the climax of the effect.

Although it can sometimes require ingenuity for you to follow it, the rule itself is simple enough: Resolve all doubts before the climax.

Extended Climaxes

Certain tricks present a special problem because the climax does not occur in one dramatic instant but drags on over a period of time. One example is a two-card transposition. It's not enough to show that the king is now an ace; you must also show that the ace is now a king. Both parts constitute the climax.

"Out of this World" is another example. The spectator has to deal all the cards face up so everyone can see that the reds are all together

and the blacks are all together. The climax really extends from the turning up of the first red card to the turning up of the last black card.

Yet another example is Vernon's "Travellers" where you remove the four aces from four different pockets. The climax of the trick is not the removal of the last ace; the climax is the removal of all four aces.

There is really nothing difficult about handling such effects as long as you follow one simple policy: Once you start the climax don't stop and don't allow anything to interrupt the flow of the climax. Don't remove two of the aces from your pockets, pause to tell a joke, and then remove the other two aces.

Just watch Martin Nash when he does his trick in which all the cards in the deck end up paired with their mates. Once he starts turning up those pairs, nothing is going to stop him until he's turned over the last one. Juan Tamariz does a similar trick and he handles the climax in the same full-steam-ahead, non-stop manner. Both men realize that any interruption will kill the climax.

Don't ask me why this is so; that's just the nature of climaxes of all kinds. If you think about other aspects of your life, you'll realize that you can't just take a break in the middle of a climax, then come back and pick up where you left off.

Anti-Climaxes

The term "anti-climax" comes up from time to time in magical writings and the way it's used makes it clear that most of these writers don't understand what the word means. So let's start with a definition: An anti-climax is something *following* the climax that is disappointing due to its triviality *in comparison with the climax*. Thus, the term anti-climax does not mean a second climax per se. although as we saw in the discussion on surprise, a second climax may indeed be anti-climactic if it's not as strong as the climax it follows.

We've already seen how this can be a problem with kickers. Now I want to talk about something somewhat different, the tendency of magicians to throw in an additional magical tidbit for the wrong reasons: because it helps clean up the trick, because they feel it

would be wasteful not to do it, or just because of poor routining.

The “Clean-Up” Anti-Climax: This situation is particularly common in card magic. For example, the magician learns an “All Backs routine,” the kind of trick where the faces disappear from the deck, each card now having a back on both sides. At the end, he makes the faces reappear. The magician notes that at the end of the trick he is left with a card secretly reversed in the deck. Eventually, he has a bright idea. He will start by having a card selected and returned to the deck. At the end of the “All Backs” trick, he will reveal the reversed card and disclose that it is the previously selected card.

On the surface, this seems like very clever thinking; take a liability and turn it into an asset. Not only does he openly clean up his reversed card, but he also gets a magical bonus in the form of locating a selected card. The problem is that it isn't a magical bonus, it's a magical blunder because it constitutes an anti-climax. The printing of faces on the deck is a very strong climax. The revelation of the selected card is a weak item by comparison. That means it's an anti-climax and that means it will only serve to undermine the overall impact of the trick.

This is not an isolated example. Practically every time a trick comes along that leaves you with a secretly reversed card, someone comes up with the “brilliant” idea of making that card a selected card. If the trick leaves you with two reversed cards, someone will figure out a way of having a selected card appear face down between them. If a packet trick leaves you with an extra card secretly in the packet, someone will decide to reveal the presence of that card and show that it is a previously selected card.

All this misguided creativity stems from the beginner's horror of not ending clean. The novice always fears that the instant the trick is over the audience will rip the cards out of his hands and discover that all is not as it's supposed to be.

With experience you start to realize that, if the effect is convincing and the climax is strong, the audience is too stunned to do anything at the end of the trick. You've got all the opportunity in the world to clean up casually after the trick is over while the audience is still recovering.

Look at the contortions magicians go through at the end of Paul Harris' "Reset" in order to be able to show that the packet on the table that's supposed to consist of four kings really does consist of four kings. I'll tell you a secret: The way to clean up at the end of "Reset" is to pick up all the cards and stick them in the middle of the deck. If you've done the trick convincingly, no one will have any reason to doubt that the king packet is what it's supposed to be.

The "No-Waste" Anti-Climax: In addition to this "clean-up fever," another major cause of anti-climaxes comes from the magician not wanting to waste any opportunity in a trick. This type of performer is like a cook who hates to waste food, so he scrapes together every scrap left over from preparing the main dish and tries to figure out something to use it for.

The magician notices that at the end of the trick in which the aces have changed to kings, the aces are secretly on top of the deck, so he can't resist producing them in some fancy way. Or, he finds that at the end of the trick in which the selected card vanishes, it's really on the bottom of the deck, so he can't resist palming it off and producing it from his pocket.

If doing so really provides a climax stronger than the one that came before, it may be worth doing. Too often, however, this sort of thing only provides a disappointing anti-climax. The fact that you happen to be in a position where you can throw in an additional scrap of magic doesn't mean you ought to.

The strongest impact doesn't come from producing the most magical events any more than the best meal comes from providing the most food. It comes from producing a magical event, or events, in the most dramatically effective form. Better to throw those leftover scraps in the garbage than to serve them after a magnificent meal and risk giving everyone heartburn.

The "Poor Sequencing" Anti-Climax: By "sequencing," I mean *the order in which the magical events in an effect are revealed to the audience*. Sometimes these events are not presented in the dramatically strongest order simply because the performer hasn't given the matter any thought or because he has a poor grasp of dramatic structure. A few examples should make clear the kinds of

situations in which these problems arise and how to solve them.

Larry Jennings' "Transmutation" is one of the best of all color-changing deck effects because it's one of the most convincing. But in its original form it's poorly sequenced. Three spectators select cards from a blue-backed deck and the cards are returned to the deck. The blue-backed deck is then changed to red and is spread on the table. There are three blue cards in the spread. They are removed and shown to be the three selected cards.

The transformation of the deck from blue to red is very powerful. But then comes the rather time-consuming task of removing each of the three blue cards, having the spectator name his selection, then showing that the blue card is indeed his card. The fact that the three selections didn't change colors is impressive and certainly relevant since the trick is, after all, a pick-a-card trick. But documenting all this after the deck has changed color is anti-climactic.

John Mendoza sequences the trick in a different way that solves the problem. After the three selections have been returned to the deck, the performer explains that the deck is marked and that this will help him find the three cards. He spreads through the deck, faces toward the audience, as he carefully studies the backs. Eventually, he upjogs a card as he says that he can tell from the marks on the back that this is one of the selections. The spectator verifies that it is and it's placed face down on the table. This is repeated with the second and third selections.

Finally, the performer comments that perhaps the audience can detect the marks themselves. He spreads the deck face down and everyone sees that the cards are now red-backed. The three selections are already face down on the table, so everyone can see that they are the only blue-backed cards in the deck. By means of a little creative thinking, the effect has been sequenced so that the grand climax of the deck turning red is revealed at the very end where it belongs.

Another trick with an anti-climax problem is Herbert Milton's "Sympathetic Clubs." The performer puts the thirteen club cards in numerical order and places them aside. He then takes the thirteen spades and shuffles them. Finally, a spectator is allowed to select

any spade card and it is reversed in the middle of the spade packet.

The spade packet and the club packet are now placed side by side face up. Using both hands, the performer deals through the two packets and it is seen that the club packet has rearranged itself into the same order as the shuffled spade packet. In fact, when the face-down card is reached in the spade packet, a face-down card also turns up at the same point in the club packet. The performer turns over these two cards and they match also; for example, if the selected card is the four of spades, the four of clubs is found reversed at the same point in the club packet. He then continues dealing to show that the remaining cards all match.

Incidentally, this trick is an example of an extended climax. The problem is that the high point comes in the *middle* of the extended climax. The most impressive part occurs when the reversed spade card is seen to be matched by a reversed club card of the same value. This happens half-way through the dealing process and makes the remaining matches anti-climactic.

Ron Zollweig published a version of the trick that solves the problem by simply changing the sequencing. When he deals through the two packets and comes to the two face-down cards, he places them aside without comment and continues without pause to deal through the remaining face-up cards. Only *after finishing the dealing process* does he return to the two face-down cards, turning them over dramatically to finish the trick on its highest note.

Recently I read a trick in which the performer has a card selected and placed aside face down. He then introduces three blank cards and magically prints faces on them. All three cards are the same value, for example, the nine of clubs, the nine of hearts, and the nine of spades. The spectator then turns over her selected card to reveal the fourth card of the same value—in our example, the nine of diamonds.

The fact that the three newly-printed cards match the selection is impressive. But the most impressive thing is that you were able to print any faces at all on three blank cards. The fact that those faces happen to match the selected card is anti-climactic.

A more effective sequencing would be to introduce the three blank

cards, then have the spectator select a card from the deck and reveal it to everyone. Now you print faces on the blanks to match the selection. The strongest part, the magical printing, comes last as it should.

As these illustrations show, some sequencing problems, like the color-changing deck example, require a good deal of thinking to solve. Others, like the printing trick, are easy to solve once you recognize the problem. But the critical first step must always be to detect when you have an anti-climax due to poor sequencing.

Whenever you have an effect with more than one magical event, rank those events in your mind in order of magical impact.

Most of the time, common sense will tell you the proper order. But, if in doubt, audience-test the effect until you're clear on what plays strongest and what plays weakest. Then, check to see if those magical events are revealed to the audience in sequence from weakest to strongest. If not, find a way to rearrange them. In magic, as in any narrative art form, it's not just what you do that matters, it's also what order you do it in.

Simultaneous Climaxes

In discussing surprise we dealt with effects that have sequential climaxes. A different situation is posed by effects containing what I call (with apologies to the writers of sex manuals) simultaneous climaxes. These are tricks where two separate effects occur at once. A classic example is the “Torn Card in Orange.” After a selected card is torn up and the pieces vanished, the restored card is found inside an orange. The appearance of the card in the orange and the fact that it has been restored are both revealed at the same time.

Another example is Vernon's “Triumph.” After a selected card is lost in the deck, the cards are shuffled face up and face down. When the deck is spread, all the cards are now face down except for the selected card. The righting of the deck and the location of the selection are revealed to the audience simultaneously. An analogous situation is found in Color Changing Deck effects where the back of every card changes except for one card which proves to be the selection. You found the selection and you changed the color of the

deck; both effects occur at once.

Such effects may prove confusing to an audience; then again they may not. This is something that must be judged on an individual basis, evaluating the audience's reaction in each case. However, as a guideline I suggest that two factors determine whether simultaneous climaxes will work in a trick: (1) Whether or not the two climaxes are conceptually related; tricks where two essentially unrelated climaxes occur at once seldom work. (2) How demanding it is for the audience to absorb the information in each climax. If a trick with simultaneous climaxes has a problem in either of these two areas it's usually wiser to either make the climaxes sequential rather than simultaneous or to simply do the effect as two separate tricks.

The problem of unrelated simultaneous climaxes occurs in the "Torn Card in Orange." The restoration of the card and its appearance inside the orange have nothing to do with each other. Therefore, it's disorienting for an audience to be hit with both at once. Like a person sitting in front of two TV sets, each tuned to a different program, the spectator is watching two different tricks being performed at the same time.

It would be much better to perform them as different tricks— do a Torn and Restored Card followed by the "Card in Orange" or vice versa. The only reason magicians do both as one effect is that both involve switching a torn corner, so they figure they may as well get double service from one corner switch. This is the attitude I've condemned before: making things easy for the performer rather than for the audience.

By contrast, let's consider another example of an effect that combines translocation and restoration in one climax. The magician performs "Matrix" with four broken pieces of a cigarette. As the pieces travel to one corner of the table they also restore until, at the end, the performer has one whole cigarette. This trick is also sometimes performed with the four quarters of a torn playing card. Unlike the previous example, this effect can be presented without confusing the audience. I think this is partly because breaking the translocation/restoration process into three phases makes the information easier for the audience to absorb.

More importantly, this step-by-step approach allows the audience to perceive the vanishing of each piece from its corner as simply the means you choose to employ in making the cigarette whole again. This nexus between the two magical effects can even be underscored in your patter: “Would you be amazed if I could put this cigarette back together? Well, I’ll do it the hard way—long distance. Watch!” (This is a good example of conceptualizing the effect for your audience through your patter.) Of course, you could break this into two different tricks, first making the pieces gather together, then restoring them into a whole cigarette. But in this case I don’t feel it’s necessary.

The second factor that must be considered in simultaneous climax effects is how difficult it is for the audience to grasp the information in each climax. Let’s again contrast two examples that are similar but different: “Triumph” vs. the “Color-Changing Deck.” In “Triumph,” you have two climaxes that any audience can easily absorb at the same time. Noting that the cards are now all face down and that the only exception is the selected card is hardly likely to overload the mental powers of anyone of average intelligence.

Furthermore, the two climaxes are conceptually intertwined. Your goal in “Triumph” is to find the selected card. You mix face-up cards with face-down cards in order to make it more difficult to do so. The way you then find the selected card is by making all the other cards turn face down. Straightening the deck is the means you employ to locate the selection.

Nevertheless, some magicians do separate the two climaxes. First the deck straightens out; all the cards are face down. A moment later the cards are spread out again and the selection is face up in the middle. To my mind this approach is misguided because it makes the “Triumph” feature appear irrelevant to the main goal of the effect which is finding the selected card. It appears that you have thrown in an unrelated preliminary effect for no reason.

This approach also creates a more serious problem. We saw in the discussion of surprise that in a multi-climax trick each climax should be stronger than the one that precedes it. Making the selected card turn face up can hardly be considered stronger than the magical righting of the entire deck which preceded it.

Once again I must stress that only audience testing combined with a consideration of the two factors mentioned earlier, whether the two climaxes are conceptually related and whether they are easily absorbed, will tell you whether or not simultaneous climaxes will work in a particular trick. Sometimes it does work beautifully.

If it doesn't, analyze the effect to determine which of the two problems we analyzed is the cause. If the problem is a lack of conceptual connection between the two climaxes, do the effect as two different tricks. If the problem is information overload from the double-barreled climax, see if you can structure the effect so as to make the climaxes sequential, always remembering that the stronger climax must come last.

Underselling The Climax

Ironically, sometimes the most effective way to present the climax of an effect is not to sell it for all it's worth, but to treat it as a matter of no importance. Contrast is a strong theatrical technique for drawing attention to something. That's why underselling can be particularly useful in the case of effects where the climax is not all that strong.

Suppose you have a trick which is good but not great; the climax is surprising but not earthshaking. If you give the trick a tremendous buildup, the contrast between the climax and the super buildup makes it seem like less than it really is. If, instead, you undersell the climax, the contrast between the surprising climax and your blasé attitude toward it makes it seem like more than it really is.

Underselling Weaker Effects: A perfect example of effective underselling in such a situation is Al Koran's presentation of the "Note Under Cup" as heard on the Al Koran audio tape. This is the well-known effect where a spectator hides a crumpled bill under one of three cups while the performer's back is turned and mixes the cups about. The performer then turns around and reveals the location of the bill.

The effect is puzzling; however, since the mixing of the cups is not completely free but occurs under the performer's direction, it's hardly a miracle. A big buildup before the revelation would only

serve to highlight the shortcomings of the trick. Instead, Koran would turn around and ask the spectator if he knew the location of the bill after all the mixing. Often the spectator would respond that he did not. (This would beautifully dramatize the conditions of the effect. How could the performer keep track of the bill if the spectator himself could not?) In this case, Koran would smile and say, "Well I do," as he lifted the cup covering the bill. If the spectator answered that he did know where the bill was, Koran would smile and say, "So do I," as he lifted the correct cup.

This soft-sell approach helped make a minor puzzle seem like a major mystery. That Koran was fully aware that underselling is important to the dramatic success of this effect is indicated in his book *Professional Presentations*. In it, he concludes his description of the "Note Under Cup" by saying, "Never put this across as a gigantic mystery. Just do it a couple of times and let it go."

Underselling Incidental Effects: One area where underselling is a must is in the use of what might be termed incidental magic effects. This is the kind of small effect that one does offhandedly in the course of performing another trick. You're going to set fire to a borrowed bill so you make a lighted match appear at your fingertips. You're going to perform a trick with a cigarette so you make the cigarette rise from the pack rather than just pulling it out. You're going to perform a trick with the four aces so, instead of looking through the deck for the aces, you cut to them in rapid-fire succession. Any such effect should be performed with little or no comment. Let the audience take note of the impossibility on their own.

A good illustration of this approach is a clever idea used by Paul Gertner. At the start of a four-ace trick, Paul will spread through the deck removing the aces. After finding three of the aces he observes that apparently the deck is not complete; the fourth ace seems to be missing. He turns to a spectator and spreads the deck, telling her to select any card to represent the fourth ace in the trick. When she turns over her selection it proves to be the missing ace. In true underselling fashion, Paul's only comment is, "That's a good choice."

By their very nature, incidental effects are minor compared to the

fullfledged effects they're part of. To play them up too much would make them appear trivial; treating them as trivial makes them all the more effective. However, in this kind of situation there is another important reason for underplaying. The subtextual message you want to convey with incidental effects is that such impossibilities are second nature to you; they happen so often you hardly take any notice.

In my “Nine-Card Location” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I use an idea of Eddie Fechter's. Before revealing each selection I have the spectator name his card. At one point I will turn to the next spectator and say, “Your card was the seven of what?” When the spectator tells me that it was the seven of clubs my only comment is, “That's the one I always forget.” The implication is that I actually knew the names of all nine selections all along. If I made a big deal about revealing my knowledge of the spectator's card, that implication would be lost.

Underselling Sucker Effects: A situation where underselling is particularly valuable is in effects that contain a “sucker” element. You can remove any potential sting from the climax of such an effect by underplaying. This allows the audience to enjoy the magical surprise without feeling that they're having their noses rubbed in the fact that they were suckered in.

One example should make the point. In “Darwin's Three-Card Monte” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*, I conclude with the bent-corner ploy. Apparently unbeknown to me, the winning card has a bent corner. When the spectator points to this card, I appear to notice the bend. My only comment is, “This card is bent!” In the act of casually removing the bend from the corner of the card I, quite incidentally, expose the face of the card to the audience. When they see that it's now one of the losing cards, the reaction is always tremendous. A more emphatic handling of this revelation might convey a sense of gloating; this would detract from the audience completely enjoying the amazing thing that has just happened.

Underselling is definitely not the approach to use in all, or even most, of your tricks. But in the right place it can be very effective. Experiment with the idea of underplaying the climax and I'm sure you'll find a number of spots in your magic where you can use it to

good advantage.

Part Two: The Character

“Little as I knew about movies, I knew that nothing transcended personality.”

Charlie Chaplin

CHAPTER SEVEN: THE FUNCTIONS OF CHARACTER

“The basic reason that people go to the movies, watch television, and read: People.”

Gary Provost, *Make Your Words Work*

Character vs. Magic

When it comes to character and personality in magic, there are two schools of thought. The first has been labeled by Michael Close as the “look at me” school. The second I would describe as the self-effacement school. Close makes the case for the self-effacement school in this passage from his book *Workers: Number 1*:

My own preference is to consider the magician in the same way you would consider a motion picture screen: the screen is the medium by which we are able to view the movie. If you have ever been to a movie theater when the screen is stained or dirty you know how distracting it is. You become aware of the screen and focus less on the movie. Likewise the magician is the medium by which the spectators are able to see impossible happenings. This is also the function of the classical musician; his function is to transmit the music from the mind of the composer to the mind of the listener. If the performance draws undue attention to the performer, the impact of the music (or the magic) is lessened.

I want to make it clear that I strongly disagree with this view. However, Michael Close so lucidly states the opposition case that it makes it easier for me to explain why I disagree. I've often emerged from a movie theater highly enthusiastic about the film I've just

seen, but I've never come out singing the praises of the screen. I don't recall ever thinking, "The next time I see a movie I want to be sure to see it on that particular screen!" By contrast, I do want my clients to think, "The next time I hire an entertainer I want to be sure it's Darwin Ortiz!" I just haven't encountered many memorable movie screens. If you want to be a memorable performer, self-effacement is not the way to go.

It's become a cliché in magic to say that the magician's job is to sell himself. This is one cliché I agree with wholeheartedly. As a performer, I don't see myself as a medium for conveying the magic. Rather, the magic is a medium for selling my personality. The magic should not transcend the performer; the performer should transcend the magic. As Gary Kurtz has written, "Our magic should be strong and memorable—but we, as performers, need to be even stronger and more memorable." In his book *Magic by Gosh*, Al Goshman put it more bluntly: "I'm selling ME."

Instead of classical music, I suggest that a more profitable model is a field that pays much better, standup comedy. Look at the most successful comics. Do you think Jay Leno sees himself as merely a medium for transmitting the jokes from the mind of the comedy writer to the minds of the audience? Jay Leno is there to sell Jay Leno and the jokes are the way he does it. The jokes exist to serve him; he doesn't exist to serve the jokes.

Comedians like Jay Leno, Steven Wright, George Carlin, and all the most successful comics today have reached the top because they've each succeeded in creating a style, attitude, and persona so memorable, unique, and appealing that it is indelibly stamped on the minds of the audience. To do that, they carefully set out to fashion a performing personality, then chose material that conveys that personality to the audience. They do everything possible to draw attention to themselves, that is, to spotlight their unique view of the world.

The result is that audiences seek out those comedians rather than other comedians who might well be telling very similar jokes. When people walk out of one of their concerts, they may well remember some of the jokes they just heard, but most of all they remember the performer.

When you're performing, the spotlight should be on *you* every minute. Even when the focus is on an assisting spectator, the audience's concern should be with how that spectator reacts to *you*. Ultimately, *you* are the subject of the performance. The entire performance should be an unfolding of your personality to the audience's view—hopefully, to their continually increasing intrigue and enjoyment.

Will this approach, as Michael Close suggests, lessen the impact of the magic? On the contrary, it will increase the impact of the magic assuming that you carefully select effects and presentations that play off the persona you've created. Steven Wright's borderline-psycho persona enriches his gags, making them much funnier than if the same words were coming out of another comic's mouth. In the same way, your persona should enrich your magic, making it more memorable.

Character And Effect

In the chapter on Suggestion we saw how expectation molds an audience's perception of an effect. One of the most important elements creating expectation is what kind of person the audience believes the performer is—their perception of his character—at the point when he starts the effect. In the Suggestion chapter we analyzed this phenomenon strictly from the point of view of prestige. But there are other aspects of your persona besides prestige that can affect an audience's expectations and therefore their perceptions of your magic.

I'll give you a graphic example of this factor at work. When I was in law school I worked as an instructor in the Harry Lorayne Memory School. Half the lessons in each course were taught by Harry and half were taught by me. Consequently I had many opportunities to see Harry Lorayne perform memory demonstrations for the students.

One stunt he sometimes did was to memorize a deck of cards. Only, he didn't memorize it. He would classic force a card on a student and tell him to place it in his pocket without looking at it. He would then rapidly spread through the deck, pretending to memorize it, and finally name the forced card.

I'm not telling tales out of (memory) school. In his card books, Harry has admitted that he sometimes passes off card tricks as memory demonstrations and he has even published a couple of these pseudo-memory stunts. In any case, there is no doubt that Harry could have performed the demonstration legitimately if he'd had to, but he didn't have to so he didn't.

In my gambling exposé lecture I put the memory skills I learned from Harry Lorayne to good use. The last effect I perform is one in which I memorize a deck of cards, relating the demonstration to the card memory required in games like bridge and gin rummy and also to card counting at blackjack. Unlike Harry, I perform the stunt legitimately, using real memory. Is this because I'm too ethical to cheat? Absolutely not. It's because I could never get away with using the method Harry does.

When Harry performed for his memory students, they had no idea he was one of the country's leading card magicians. He never did card tricks for them or referred to his magical prowess. In their minds, when he spread the deck and asked them to take a card, this was a layman handling the deck. They no more thought him capable of influencing their choice than they themselves could have influenced another person's choice of a card. They therefore guilelessly reached for the most convenient card in the spread, the force card.

By contrast, when I do the card memorization, it comes immediately after the audience has just seen me do fifty-five minutes of non-stop sleight of hand with cards. Under such circumstances it would be much harder for me to successfully classic force a card. Furthermore, even if I did allow a free choice of a card and then performed the effect through real memory, many of the people in the audience would still assume that I had controlled the spectator's choice and the presentation would be discredited. In other words, if I did exactly the same thing Harry Lorayne does, the effect on the audience would be totally different. They would think, "It's just a card trick."

In order for the effect to have its proper impact, I have to use a procedure whereby the spectators handle the deck from beginning to end. Only then can I make them accept it as real memory. The

only way I can achieve the necessary “hands off” approach is to actually do it through real memory.

The fact that Harry's students perceive him, quite correctly, as a memory expert means that, when he does a card memory stunt, they expect him to do it through real memory; therefore he can get away with using sleight of hand.

The fact that my audiences perceive me, quite correctly, as a sleight-of-hand expert means that, when I do a card memory stunt, they expect me to use sleight of hand; therefore I have to use real memory so I can stress the stringent conditions under which the demonstration is performed. Because of the audience's perceptions of our characters, the memory expert can use sleight of hand, but the sleight-of-hand expert has to use memory.

I once saw James Randi on a TV show where he was attempting to expose the trickery of a previous guest on the show, Uri Geller. Although Randi did a good job of duplicating Geller's phenomena, the host was totally unimpressed. He kept pointing out that Randi's demonstrations were just tricks. Yet he had not made similar comments to Geller on the previous show.

Why did the host respond so differently to the same tricks on two different occasions? Because they were performed by two different people. The TV host knew that Geller was a “genuine psychic” who had been tested by scientists. Therefore, he saw his demonstrations as genuine psychic phenomena. He also knew that Randi was a magician. Therefore, he saw his demonstrations as magic tricks. Because your persona will affect your audience's expectations it will affect what they see when you perform a trick.

Character And Audience Interest

Finally, we come to the single most important reason why developing a performing character will be worth every minute you devote to it. When you perform for an audience, you want them to pay attention. You want them to be interested. Remember what Fitzkee said? “People are more interested in people than in any other single thing.” You are the person at the center of every performance you give. If you want them to care about your

performance, you've got to get them to care about you.

It's often said in magic that if they like you, they'll like your magic. I think this notion is far too simple-minded. (After all, it isn't true in any other facet of life. How many times have you heard someone describe another by saying, "He's a nice guy but he doesn't know what he's doing"?) It is true, however, that if they are interested in you they will be interested in your performance. If they find you boring as a person, you'll find it very difficult to get them to work up any interest in what you're doing.

CHAPTER EIGHT: CREATING THE CHARACTER

“It is not enough for the performer to 'be yourself' in performance . . . You have to be yourself playing a part appropriate to the work in hand.”

Anthony Rooley, Performance

“No good performer is ever completely natural; he just seems that way. He tries to conceal his faults and make the most of his assets. He stresses characteristics which make his presentation more vivid and minimizes those which tell against it.”

Henning Nelms, Magic and Showmanship

Why You Need A Character

The usual advice found in magic books on developing a persona consists of the platitude, “Be yourself.” Frankly, this advice is extremely simple-minded.

It ignores the fact that each of us is really many different “selves.” We show different faces to different people in our lives. The way our coworkers see us is not the same way our friends see us, and neither is it the way our spouse sees us. We accent different aspects of ourselves in different situations.

The challenge the performer faces is what aspects of himself to accent in his performances for best audience response. Al Goshman once described his own performing character as “an overweight, middle-aged leech.” Was Goshman a leech off-stage? Frankly, I don't know, but if he was, I'm sure he didn't display it as openly. He found that, when he performed, leechery played well for him. By contrast, a good friend of mine, a professional magician and a great cardman,

is also one of the biggest lechers in the world. Yet he doesn't display this quality when he performs. Presumably, he has found that lechery contributes nothing to the success of his performances so he suppresses this characteristic when he is “on.”

Despite the impression you may get from some magical writings, the search for a persona is not some sort of mystical quest. It's a very pragmatic matter. What aspects of yourself will work best in the context of the kind of magic you want to do? What aspects of yourself will most appeal to an audience? What aspects of yourself will add the most conviction to your magic? What aspects of yourself will best produce the kind of reactions you want to elicit from an audience?

Finding Your Character

Very little has been written in magic about developing a performing character or persona. What little there is tends to make it sound like the issue has to be settled before you ever perform your first effect for lay people. First you create your character, then you start doing magic. This is the most convenient way to discuss the matter for analytical purposes. That's why much of my later discussion of the subject will take the same approach. But this is only a convenient fiction. You don't create a persona, you *evolve* a persona over time. It's like painting a picture. You start with broad strokes and get more and more detailed as you go along.

Although developing a persona takes time, that doesn't mean it will happen automatically if you just wait long enough. Just go to any magic meeting and look at all the magicians who've been in magic fifteen, twenty, or twenty-five years, and still have no more distinctive an identity when they perform than they did when they performed their first trick. Your persona will evolve with time only if you work at making it happen.

Aldous Huxley once said, “Experience isn't what happens to you, it's what you do with what happens to you.” If you do nothing with your performing experiences, that's what you'll end up with. What you need to do is to analyze, question, experiment and, most of all, think. Here are some of the most useful things to think about when asking yourself the question, “Just who am I when I'm performing magic?”

Role vs. Raw Material: More than anything else, your persona should grow out of the interaction between your role and the raw materials you as a person bring to that role.

First, it's important to understand the difference between the role and the character. The Amazing Kreskin and Max Maven both perform as men who are gifted with psychic powers and are demonstrating their powers for your entertainment; the role is the same. But, if you've ever seen them perform, you know that the two characters could not be further apart. One is a boy-next-door type who just happens to be able to read minds and doesn't completely understand how himself. The other is an exotic character whose powers have led him to explore and dwell in a world very different from the one you and I do. They play identical roles but very different characters.

An exercise I heartily recommend is to watch various films and TV shows and consider how different actors interpret similar roles. Compare Telly Savalas as Kojak and Clint Eastwood as Dirty Harry. Both are homicide detectives, but the two are very different characters with very different traits. Or consider how two different actors play private detectives: Humphrey Bogart in *The Maltese Falcon* and James Garner in *The Rockford Files*.

Even actors playing the same part can paint very different pictures. Bela Lugosi, Christopher Lee, and Frank Langella were all very different Draculas. The role was the same, the characters quite different. The point is that a role makes certain demands and imposes certain restrictions, yet any given role can be filled by numerous personality types.

In magic, your role is defined by the kinds of effects you perform. Mental effects, gambling routines, comedic magic, occult effects, and other types of magic each define a role. So a good place for you to start in your quest for a persona is to think about the kinds of tricks you most like to perform and what those tricks suggest about the kind of person who would perform them.

At the other end of our equation we have the raw materials you bring to the role. These include your gender, body type (short or tall, skinny, fat, or muscular), your facial appearance, (handsome or

homely, refined or coarse, WASP or ethnic) speech pattern (formal or informal, academic or down-to-earth, any regional accent or speech impediment), personality traits (mercurial, phlegmatic, etc.), your interests, and most everything else that makes you who you are.

Pay particular attention to your assets: what people like most about you. Maybe you're very articulate or have an appealingly offbeat sense of humor, or a sunny disposition that everyone warms to quickly. It only makes sense to try to capitalize on these things as you fashion your persona.

No matter what anyone tells you, none of the traits mentioned above need bar you from playing a particular role. Virtually any magician can effectively play virtually any role. But it may take some creativity on your part to figure out how to make it work.

When Peter Falk was asked to play a homicide detective in *Colombo* he didn't say, "I can't do it because I'm not a tall, silent, tough guy like Clint Eastwood. I'm a short, rumped, rambling, ethnic sort." But he also didn't make the mistake of trying to play Colombo the same way Eastwood played Dirty Harry Callahan. Instead, he found a way to create a character that could credibly be both a homicide detective and a person with Peter Falk's physical and personality traits.

Of course, Falk had the advantage of professional writers who could fashion the part to fit his characteristics. Often in casting a film, the makers will go after a particular big-name actor because of his box-office value. If the part isn't really suited to that actor's attributes, they just rewrite the part. As a magician, you have to be your own script writer. Look at the kind of effects you like to perform and look at the kind of person you are. Think of these elements as two lines on a graph. The point at which the two lines intersect is where you'll find your persona.

Audience Input: Channing Pollock has been quoted as saying, "We must look into the mirror and, with the utmost objectivity and honesty, search for a character we can make believable and come to life on stage." This is good advice, but we should not take the reference to a mirror too literally. Looking in the mirror will only tell you what kind of physical type you are. That certainly has a

bearing on the type of character you can play, but it's only the beginning.

For the performer, there is a mirror that is much more important than the one on the wall—the mirror of audience reaction. Audience reaction reflects the way the audience perceives you. If only you'll pay attention to it, audience reaction will allow you to achieve one of the most difficult things in the world, to see yourself as others see you.

Here are three ways in which audience reaction will guide you to the persona that works best for you. First, consider the effects that get the best audience reaction when you perform them. You'll probably detect a pattern. Do these tend to be long effects or short effects, serious, light-hearted, or fantasy-oriented, story tricks, or what might be termed genre effects (gambling routines, mental effects, bizarre magic, comedy magic)?

Whatever types of effects play best for you, it's probably because audiences sense something in your personality that resonates to these effects. Simply considering why certain effects play better for you than others will give you some insight into what kind of person audiences see you as being. In most cases, you would be wise to develop a persona that leans in that direction.

Second, consider what kind of humor plays best for you. Do audiences tend to respond best when you are doing physical humor, sarcastic humor, silly humor, off-the-wall humor? Here again they are giving you a clue as to what qualities they see and respond to in you.

Finally, think about the kinds of comments and questions you tend to get from audiences. The most off-handed comment may give you a major insight into how they perceive you. If, after a performance, they ask you about your background, the way they slant their questions can give you an idea of what kind of background they imagine you to have. Even tongue-in-cheek comments (in fact, particularly tongue-in-cheek comments) can be very revealing.

Remember your goal in all this. It's to use the audience's perceptions as a mirror to determine what kind of character you can most effectively portray when you perform. If you're sensitive to

such feedback, you'll find the audience will virtually write your character for you.

The Character Profile

I recommend that you start to put together a *character profile* on paper. This should include all information that you consider relevant to the character you're developing. This includes adjectives describing personality and character traits, relevant anecdotes, and personal history. It doesn't matter that the items of personal history may simply be episodes from your own past. They should still be listed to distinguish them from those episodes of your past that are not relevant to your performing persona.

I said, “start to put together,” because this is not a one–time thing. Your character profile is something you will return to again and again throughout your performing career to study it, to add items, and to delete items. Over time, what may start as a vague, or even clichéd, picture will come into sharper and sharper focus as you develop an ever clearer idea of what works best for you, how audiences perceive you, and thus who you want to be when you get up to perform in front of an audience.

Reconciling Character And Daily Life

Finally, if you don't do magic for a living, there is one more factor you have to consider in developing a characterization: the relationship between your on-stage persona and your off-stage personality. When Johnny Thompson is on stage, he is the great Tomsoni, a bumbling magician who is thoroughly clueless. But in his private life he doesn't have to maintain this characterization because he's not constantly interacting with audience members.

But, if you're a non-professional, your friends and relatives are also your magic audience. If your performing persona is completely inconsistent with the way you behave the rest of the time it won't have much credibility for these people. That's a good reason why your persona should grow out of your true personality. In developing that persona, you'll emphasize some elements of your personality and downplay others. But as long as it's all based on your own characteristics it will ring true even to those who know

you best.

CHAPTER NINE: CONVEYING THE CHARACTER

"I'm selling Me. I'm selling an image. An image of an overweight, middle-aged leech. That's the image I'm trying to sell and I never get off the basic theme."

Albert Goshman

"Fully explain your characters through dialog, behavior, and appearance."

Nash & Oakey, *The Screenwriter's Handbook*

So you're at the point where you have your persona clearly defined in your mind. With experience that character has become both concrete and detailed, and the portrait has been committed to paper in your character profile. The only problem is that your audience doesn't know that you've decided you're magic's answer to Agent 007, James Bond. Now you have to transmit that image from your mind to the *audience's* mind.

Simply telling them won't do the job. You have to follow the writers' time-honored dictum, "Don't tell; show." You have to let the audience figure out for themselves what your character is. At least, you've got to make them think they're figuring it out for themselves. Naturally, you helpfully lay out a series of clues to guide them.

The key to conveying a unique, clearly-defined character is *consistency*. The hallmark of hack fiction is the character who suddenly acts completely out-of-character in order to solve some plot problem for the author. Magicians often make the same mistake, breaking character to gain an easy laugh, to simplify some handling or presentational problem, or simply because they haven't given the matter very much thought.

In the following pages we'll consider how to make sure that everything you say, do, wear, and touch is in character—how to use every detail of your performance to sell your personality to the audience. If you think that some of the points I bring up are hairsplitting, consider the lengths top celebrities go to in order to protect their “images” (another way of saying persona).

Top movie stars will avoid film roles that might undermine the image they've built up. (You'll never see Chuck Norris playing a shy schoolteacher.) They will only endorse products that fit their images. They hire press agents to plant stories in the media that promote their images, and even insist on veto power over photographs accompanying articles about them, lest a picture appear that sends a message contrary to their image. In your own smaller way, you must be just as conscientious about selling your character through your every action and word—even your appearance.

What You Wear

“Rabbit-in-the-hat tie clips or cuff links are not to be worn. The 'M' ring should be similarly eschewed. I cannot bring myself to comment upon ties with patterns portraying playing cards or bunnies. Certainly it is not necessary to caution the true cardman against false moustaches or capes.”

David Bendix

Many books on magical showmanship are loaded with fashion, grooming, and personal hygiene tips. There's no denying those things matter. But you can go into any bookstore and find plenty of good books on those subjects written by experts, so why should I pretend to be a fashion consultant? Instead I want to concern myself with how your appearance affects how people see your character and, therefore, how they see your magic.

In the heyday of the big con in this country, professional con men would often meet some wealthy businessman and, within a couple of hours, succeed in convincing him, without any collateral, to turn over large sums of money to them. These well educated and highly intelligent businessmen were willing to put their trust in complete strangers in large part because the con men were able to convince

their victims, purely through their dress, grooming, and demeanor that they were the same type of men as themselves and therefore trustworthy. These con men knew that all of us draw firm conclusions about others based purely on what we see.

When a person first lays eyes on you he'll often draw conclusions about whether you're conservative or extravagant, shy or outgoing, about your financial status, ethnic background, social class, idiosyncrasies, and other qualities before you've uttered a word. Consequently, your appearance is your first opportunity to start to convey your character to your audience. That means your costume must reflect your persona.

Did the word “costume” surprise you? Most close-up magicians think that costume is something that only stage magicians have to worry about. If you're one of them, you probably think that you never perform in costume. Think again. Unless you perform in the nude—and, come to think of it, even if you do—you perform in costume.

A costume is simply attire selected by a performer to make a particular impression on his audience. However, whatever you're wearing when you perform will make an impression on an audience, regardless of whether or not you chose it with that thought in mind. Therefore, whatever you're wearing when you perform is your costume.

It's important that your attire not send messages that undermine the image you're trying to project. This means you've got to ask yourself, what kind of clothes, jewelry, and accessories would my character be likely to wear? Then start to put together a wardrobe along those lines.

In this connection, I think a word of warning is in order. Your appearance has to convey your character. But as with everything we discuss in this chapter, a key consideration is credibility. There is a danger in being too theatrical in your attire. Wearing a turban and flowing robes is not the best way to convey the character of an occult magician just as dressing like a nineteenth-century riverboat dandy is not the best way to convey the character of a gambler. Such tactics will only convince your audience that you're a clichéd

imitation rather than the genuine article.

To successfully put together a wardrobe that reflects your persona, you have to develop a sense for how our reactions to others is molded by appearance. A good exercise is to watch other performers and ask yourself what messages their appearance is sending to the audience. If you commute to work on the train, observe other passengers and play Sherlock Holmes. Try to deduce everything you can about them from their attire and grooming.

It doesn't matter whether your conclusions are right or wrong. The deductions you draw consciously in these exercises are the same kinds of conclusions your audiences will draw unconsciously when they look at *you*. Indeed, they're the kind of conclusions you're already drawing unconsciously every day as you interact with others. What these exercises will do is help you raise the matter to a conscious level so you can start using these insights to influence your audiences.

I also recommend you pick up a copy of John Molloy's classic book *Dress for Success* and study it carefully. I'm not suggesting you automatically adopt every suggestion he makes, but rather that you study his thinking. Molloy's recommendations are designed to make you look like a WASP corporate executive. Unless that's the type of persona you want to convey (and it may be, if you want to specialize in trade show work), there's no reason to do everything he suggests. There are any number of "power dressing" books that will tell you how to look like corporate VP material. The unique value of Molloy's book is how deeply he understands the way attire and grooming can be used to psychologically manipulate people, much like the old- time con men did. That's the lesson you want to learn and apply to your magic.

Of course, if you don't do magic for a living, your costume is usually just whatever you happen to be wearing whenever you have the opportunity to do a couple of tricks. That doesn't change the fact that it's still a costume. It simply means that you should go over your whole wardrobe to make sure it's consistent with your persona.

That shouldn't mean that you'll have to burn everything in your closet and put together such a radically new wardrobe that none of

your friends will recognize you. If it does, you've settled on a character too radically removed from your true self to really work. It should mean instead that you start making your clothes-buying decisions to reflect fully those aspects of your personality that you want to emphasize when you perform magic.

What You Say

The Script: In this section we're going to talk about how to fashion what you say during an effect in such a way as to convey your persona to the audience as effectively as possible. You can't do that if you say something different every time you perform the same effect. It's imperative for conveying your character effectively (and for other reasons we'll be discussing) that you have “set” patter for each effect. The underlying premise I'm working from is the belief that, whatever you have to say at any point in an effect, there is always one way of saying it that is clearer, more dramatically effective, and more in character than any other way. If that's the case, then you should determine what that way is, and always say it that way. That means your patter should be written out.

I realize there are some people in magic who strongly oppose scripted patter. The usual argument is that scripted patter sounds memorized. In response I would point out first that *all* the best professional close-up magicians work from scripts. Not all work from *written* scripts. But if you were to see any really good pro perform the same effect on three different occasions for three different audiences you would find that there wouldn't be more than a half-dozen words difference in the three performances. Indeed, amateur magicians are often shocked to discover that's the case when they have the chance to see a magician do the same act repeatedly, for example, in a trade show or if they follow the same performer from station to station at a magic convention close-up show. It's a revelation to them to discover that all those clever adlibs aren't adlibbed.

Some pros just evolve their patter through repeated performances. Over time it settles into a set patter which, through constant repetition in performance, is committed to memory. There is no written script, but there is a *memorized* script. Many other

professionals do script their patter on paper. Either way, if the performer is good, the presentation won't sound memorized when it is performed.

The notion that scripted patter must sound memorized is disproved every night on Broadway. All those actors on stage are working from scripts they've committed to memory. Yet, every night they make the words come alive and deliver their lines as if they're saying them for the first time.

Ironically, the biggest reason why a magician's memorized patter may sound memorized is that the performer hasn't memorized it well enough. He's continually struggling to remember what comes next. The audience senses that and realizes that he isn't speaking spontaneously; he's reciting memorized lines. That problem is easily avoided. Really memorize your patter. Memorize it to the point where you could virtually recite it in your sleep, to the point where you could recite it while thinking of something completely unrelated; (Occasionally, you'll have to do just that. Something will go wrong with an effect and you'll have to deliver your patter "on automatic pilot" while you concentrate on figuring out a way of solving the technical problem.)

Once you can deliver your patter without thinking about it, don't. Instead make sure that when you perform you are thinking about what you're saying. Concentrate on *communicating* what you have to say to your audience. In other words, you do the same thing you do whenever you talk to people. The only difference is that you won't have to decide how you're going to phrase it. The specific words will come automatically because you've already committed them to memory.

And you won't run the risk that after the performance, you'll realize you could have expressed your thought in a way that was clearer or more dramatic or more entertaining. You'll have done all that thinking beforehand. You'll already have found the best way to say it, written that way down, and memorized it.

In addition to the "sounds memorized" argument, the other common objection raised against scripted patter is that if your patter is memorized you won't be able to adapt to unexpected

occurrences. This is a silly argument used by people who are too lazy to script their patter and are trying to justify that laziness. Anyone who memorizes his patter (and really *memorizes* it) knows that memorized patter makes it easier to respond to unforeseen events.

Of course, you have to deviate from the script but, as soon as you've dealt with the unexpected development, you can smoothly pick up the thread of the prepared patter at the appropriate point. Consequently, you're in a much better position to deal with the unexpected than the magician who is always making it up as he goes along because your mind is free to improvise when necessary. As the great mentalist Chet Miller once said, "When I'm performing, I've got more important things to think about than what I'm going to say next."

Although I strongly believe that written scripts are the most effective approach to patter for both professional and amateur magicians, I think it's particularly important that the amateur magician use this approach if he's to reach his full potential as a performer. The professional has the luxury of countless performances of the same trick, during which he can refine his patter and commit it to memory virtually without trying. The amateur doesn't have that advantage. The best way to compensate for that is to invest as much thought as possible into the patter before the performance. For that, a written script is an absolute necessity.

Before you let one of your magic club friends convince you that written scripts are a bad idea, ask yourself just how good an entertainer the person offering the advice is. I can only tell you that I believe the use of prepared scripts is one of the most important steps in becoming a strong performer. One of the greatest secrets that all the pros know but that is almost unknown among amateurs is this: *Always say the same thing at the same point in each trick you do.*

Terminology: One of the ways we reveal ourselves to the world is by our choice of words. Almost every word in the English language has one or more synonyms. These words all convey essentially the same meaning, but they convey different messages about the person using

the word. Some are more likely to be used by a well-educated person, others by an uneducated person. Some are more likely to be used by an informal, friendly person, others by a formal, reserved person. Some are more likely to be used by someone in a particular profession or with a particular field of interest or a particular way of looking at things.

As someone who makes a specialty of gambling routines, one of my pet peeves is magicians who pose as gambling experts yet use all the wrong terminology in their gambling patter. Gamblers have a language of their own; one of the best ways of projecting the persona of a gambler (or someone who has spent a good part of his life around gambling) is to learn that language and use it.

Even beyond the matter of technical terms, a gambler is likely to use certain phrases that a non-gambler wouldn't. Thus, if your persona is that of a gambler, it should affect even your patter for non-gambling tricks. Consider the classic pick-a-card plot. A magician might say, "Do you want to exchange that card for a different one or do you want to stick with your original choice?" A gambler might say, "Do you want to exchange that card for a different one or do you want to stand pat?" A magician might say, "I guarantee it's the right card." A gambler might say, "I'll lay you odds it's the right card."

Both a psychic and an occultist might perform a mental effect. But they're two different personas and therefore should use different terminology. They might both do a blindfold trick, but the psychic might call it a demonstration in "remote viewing" while the occultist calls it a test of "second sight." They might both do a prediction trick, but the psychic might refer to the phenomenon as "precognition" while the occultist calls it "the gift of prophesy."

Now that you have all your patter scripted, you should go through those scripts searching for every opportunity to sell your character through your choice of words and phrases. Just as important, check to make sure that you're not using any words or phrases that clash with your character, things that character just wouldn't say.

Anecdotal Patter: Whenever a magazine does a profile on a celebrity or other interesting person they always rely primarily on

one tool for giving the reader a picture of what kind of person he is: the anecdote. Every profile piece is loaded with them. Anecdotes reveal character by showing how a person reacts in a particular situation. That's why anecdotes can be a very effective way for you to reveal your character to an audience.

We magicians often use anecdotes as patter themes for our effects, but we don't call them anecdotes; we call them story patter. We've already analyzed story patter in depth as a technique for imbuing an effect with meaning. In that section I recommended that, whenever possible, you fashion your story patter so as to make yourself the protagonist of the tale. Whenever you do that, you've got a great opportunity to sell your character to the audience.

Ask yourself the same question every novelist, playwright and screenwriter continually asks himself: "How would my character react in this situation?" If you really understand your persona, it will be easy to answer that question. Once you've got the answer, make sure that's the way you respond in your patter story. You don't want to look like a coward or a buffoon in your patter story unless you're trying to project the character of a coward or buffoon.

If your patter story doesn't portray you the way you want to come across, change the story, change the effect, or come up with a nonstory presentation. If nothing else works, drop the effect from your repertoire. No one trick is important enough to justify undermining everything you're trying to accomplish in your performance.

I realize some readers will object that, at least with some patter stories, the audience realizes the performer is telling a fanciful tale; it isn't really true. Nevertheless, if you're the protagonist of the tale, your behavior in the story will color the way people look at you. Story patter and background stories are among the most potent tools you have for selling your character to the audience—if you have to use them intelligently.

Character Lines: By character lines, I don't mean those little wrinkles around the corners of your eyes. I'm referring to *patter lines that help define your character for the audience*. These are lines that reveal the way you think, the unique slant you have on

life..

Here is a character line I use in one of my gambling routines: “I'm going to teach you how to win at blackjack. And the fastest way to win at blackjack . . . is to cheat.” This line always gets a laugh from the audience. What's important to us now is why it gets a laugh. The punchline is funny because it's unexpected. It's unexpected because most people don't think that way. The fact that I do, as indicated by that line, reveals something about my character to the audience.

Character lines are often humorous because they reveal an offbeat way of looking at the world. Indeed, every joke and every humorous line springs out of a particular world view. For that reason, you should go through every laugh line in your patter and ask yourself what it says about you. Ruthlessly eliminate any line that implies a sensibility foreign to the one you're trying to project. At the same time you should treasure every line that helps project your image and convey your unique turn of mind to the audience. Such lines are not easy to come by; they're worth their weight in gold.

A character line doesn't have to be humorous; it may be serious or even dramatic. When René Lavand introduces an effect by saying that it's one he often performs alone for himself because it helps preserve his own sense of wonder he is revealing a great deal about his character to the audience.

The point you must appreciate is that people tend to take us on our own terms. They are usually ready to assume that we are as we claim we are. Of course, it helps if we can back up our claims.

René Lavand's performances are a brilliant example of this. Virtually every description I've ever heard or read of his work has described him as a true artist. There's no question that Lavand is an artist but so, in my opinion, is Del Ray, to pick one example. I've heard magicians describe Del Ray as brilliant, amazing, wonderfully entertaining, but I've never heard him described as an artist. One of the reasons René Lavand is described as an artist and Del Ray isn't is that Del Ray doesn't try to project such an image while Lavand works very hard and very consciously to project the image of an artist.

His patter is loaded with “character lines” designed to convey that

notion. To take just one example, in Lavand's effect "Perhaps, Some Day," he first explicitly compares himself to Johann Sebastian Bach. (The exact character line is, "But if Johann Sebastian Bach was capable of composing this marvelous music with just seven notes, perhaps I can humbly present you with a little illusion with just four cards.") He then specifically refers to himself as an artist. (He describes the effect he's striving for as, "A little utopian perhaps, just the dream of an artist.")

Don't misconstrue these observations as a criticism of Lavand's artistry. Nothing could be further from the truth. On the contrary, I mean it as an admiring analysis of some of the technique underlying that artistry, an example we can all learn from. Once you're clear on your persona, look for every opportunity to sell that persona through patter lines as subtle and clever as those I've just cited.

Patter and the Non-Professional: Having read this far into the book you probably realize that I believe strongly in the value of precisely defining one's terms. Yet, I've discussed patter this long without defining what I mean by the term patter. That probably hasn't surprised you. All magicians know what patter is, don't they? Patter is what you say while you perform a trick. Actually, I don't happen to agree with that definition, but I haven't offered my own definition yet because it brings up an issue I wanted to put off discussing until now.

I believe that patter is everything you say that influences the audience's perception of your magic. In talking about suggestion and the connection between character and effect we've seen that the audience's expectations before you even begin your performance can influence the way they perceive an effect. Therefore, it follows that something you say before starting the performance can influence their perception of the effect. In fact, something you say after the performance can lead them to re-evaluate what they think of a particular effect or the entire performance. That's why I maintain that *every single word you say to a spectator or within the hearing of a spectator before, during, or after the performance constitutes patter.*

Most professionals realize this and for that reason always stay in character as long as they're in the presence of the audience, not just

while actually doing tricks. They're used to people coming up after a performance and peppering them with questions. They know that answering those questions is part of the performance. What they say then is patter just as much as what they said during the tricks.

Of course, this is much easier for professionals because they're only dealing with the audience when they're working. Johnny Thompson doesn't have to be "The Wizard of Warsaw" with his next-door neighbor. A professional mentalist doesn't have to play the psychic while hanging out with his best friend. But for the amateur, his next-door neighbor and his best friend are his audience.

That's why it's particularly important for the amateur to develop a persona that is an aspect of his true personality. That way, they're won't be a glaring clash between his "on-stage" behavior and his "off-stage" behavior. Having said that, I feel it's still important to stress that things you say casually to friends when not performing can influence the way they perceive your performances. It's something you simply always have to be conscious of.

What You Do

Although we've seen how important patter is in revealing character, we shouldn't forget the adage that actions speak louder than words. In *The Elements of Screenwriting*, Irwin Blacker writes, "A character is revealed by what he does." This is a simple but profound statement. First and foremost, the audience will decide what kind of person you are by what they see you do.

As a magician what you do is magic tricks. Therefore, the single most important tool you have in conveying your character to the audience is the kinds of effects you choose to perform. The characteristics of the effects you do that will particularly mold audience perceptions about you are theme and tone.

Themes: By themes I mean sources of substantive meaning of the kind I discussed earlier. Effects dealing with topics such as poltergeists, Voodoo, gambling, or con games, for example, all have inherent meaning for an audience, but they also all carry messages about the performer doing them. The fact that you have a special interest in poltergeist phenomena, know how to perform Voodoo

rituals, or know how card cheats or con men operate is very character revealing because the average person doesn't.

But do you really want to be thought of as the kind of person each of those things suggests? That depends on what kind of persona you've evolved for yourself. The point is that you must choose effect themes, not only for the interest they hold for the audience but also for how well they mesh with your character. The ones that fit your persona will play particularly well for you. The ones that don't will not play so well. That's the truth underlying the oft-stated observation that a trick that works for one performer won't necessarily work for another.

Furthermore—and this is the vital point—an effect that fits your character well will tend to strengthen the entire performance. By bringing your persona into sharper focus it gives you something for the other effects to play off. By contrast, an effect that clashes with your persona will only tend to confuse your audience and weaken the entire performance as, on some subconscious level, people are left wondering, “Who is this guy?”

Of course, the theme of an effect is largely a function of the presentation. As our earlier discussion of substantive meaning showed, the same effect can be presented in vastly different ways. So when we talk about themes we're not talking about effects so much as effect/presentation combinations. However, to say that the same effect can be cloaked with different presentations is not the same as saying that any effect can be sold under any theme. Remember the central importance of credibility in your presentations.

Tone: Closely related to theme is the matter of tone. In *Make Your Words Work*, Gary Provost defines tone as “a consistent attitude about the material.” That definition works well for magic. An effect may have a solemn tone, a lighthearted tone, a tongue-in-cheek tone, or a farcical tone, to name a few possibilities. Many of René Lavand's effects have a romantic tone. I don't mean romantic in the Valentine's Day sense, but rather that they reflect a romantic view of the world.

As with theme, the same effect can be presented with different tones.

Compare Masklyn ye Mage's presentation of the "Needle Through Arm" with Harry Anderson's—same effect but vastly different tones. This means that once again we're really talking about the effect–presentation package. As with themes, however, there is a limit to how far you can change the nature of an effect through presentation. You'll never be able to successfully give a solemn tone to the "Hippity–Hop Rabbits."

It's certainly not necessary for every effect you do to have the same tone. However, some tones are simply incompatible with certain personas. It would be as out of character for René Lavand to perform an effect with a farcical tone as for Harry Anderson to perform an effect with a romantic tone. Anderson's character is a cynical con man. You can't be both a cynic and a romantic.

Your persona should not limit you to one tone, but will limit the range of tones you can effectively adopt in your presentations. If you deeply understand your persona you'll know what that range is.

Selecting Effects: All of this leads us to an important truth: the fact that an effect is a great trick doesn't mean that it's a great trick *for you*. The fact that you like a trick is not enough reason to perform it.

This is a lesson very few amateur magicians ever learn. They see someone else do a great trick, so they have to start doing it themselves. This exemplifies the amateur's self-indulgent approach to magic. The professional realizes there are many great tricks that he'll have to admire from afar without ever performing them because they're not right for him. This approach takes discipline, but it's the only path to strong magic.

By contrast, from time to time you'll find a trick that works for you brilliantly. Most often this will be because the theme and tone of the effect actually allow you to develop the character more fully for the audience. It displays aspects of your persona that haven't been developed before. Such character–defining tricks are worth their weight in gold.

Your goal should be to make sure that, at minimum, every effect you do is consistent with your character. The very best ones actually help develop the character so that, by the end of the trick, the audience has a better idea of who you are than they did when you

started.

What You Use

In the Molloy book I mentioned earlier, *Dress for Success*, he spends considerable time discussing how accessories such as jewelry, wallets, pens, and handkerchiefs affect other people's perceptions of you. A magician's props are his accessories. (Indeed, jewelry, wallets, pens, and handkerchiefs are often used as magic props.)

Suppose you're going to perform a trick with a pen. If you want to come across like an average Joe, you might pull a plastic Bic pen out of your pocket. If you want to be perceived as affluent and upper class you might take out a Mont Blanc pen. If you're persona is that of a comedic tightwad in the Jack Benny mold, you might take out a pen of the kind found in banks and post offices with the security chain still attached to it.

I've seen several magicians perform the Bruno Hennig/Fred Kaps effect of revealing a signed, selected card folded up inside a small container that's been in full view since before the trick began. I've seen the card produced from inside a ringbox, a candy tin, a shoe polish tin, a small Godiva chocolates box, and a tin container painted to look like a clown. In each case, the effect was the same, but the message that the prop conveyed about the performer was different.

What did each of these props tell the audience about what kind of person the performer was? You can easily figure that out for yourself just by asking yourself what kind of person you associate with each of those props.

Suppose you saw someone perform the Cups and Balls with polished brass cups, or paper cups, or china teacups, or the plastic cups that come with McDonald's "Happy Meals" promoting Steven Spielberg's latest movie? How would your perception of that person change? Suppose he did a bill trick with a one-dollar bill? Or a two-dollar bill? A hundred-dollar bill? A French five-franc note? A Malaysian twenty-ringet bill? A Confederate bill? Monopoly money? Yes, the more unusual examples I gave might have to be justified by

the presentation. But, quite aside from the presentation, the prop itself carries a message about the person.

David Bendix once wrote, tongue-in-cheek, “Card cases made of leather must not be used, as they suggest that the cards contained therein are the only ones the performer ever owned, leading to natural suspicion. Once, incredibly, I saw a card performer remove from his pocket a pack encircled with a rubber band! Use only the case supplied by the manufacturer, as God intended.” There's truth behind Bendix's humor. A deck in a leather card case, or encircled by a rubber band, or in the original case all carry different messages to the audience, not only about the cards themselves, but also about the person who owns them.

Look at every prop you employ in your magic and ask yourself what that prop says about you. You may know a couple of great linking rubber band effects, but does bringing those rubber bands out of your pocket label you as a white-collar office nerd in the eyes of the audience? In the real world, those are the only people who normally carry rubber bands on them. Similarly, what does doing tricks with thimbles say about you? Is it what you want your magic to say about you?

If you ask yourself, what does this prop say about me, and you don't like the answer you come up with, there are several things you can do. One is to see if you can substitute a different prop. The worst possible reason for using a particular prop is the fact that it's the one that came with the trick when you bought it. You can always substitute something else, even if it means having someone custom-make it for you.

If all else fails, you have one more option. Drop the trick from your repertoire. It's worth repeating: the fact that an effect is a great trick doesn't mean that it's a great trick *for you*. If the props involved tend to undermine the image you're trying so hard to create, it will do more harm than good, no matter how great a trick it is.

I once heard Eugene Burger mention that he had stopped performing the Sponge Balls because he didn't want to be perceived as the kind of person who carried clown noses in his pocket. He observed that, “Breaking the sponge-ball habit was harder than

quitting cigarettes.” But he knew it was the right decision for him and he made it.

Avoiding those props that convey an undesired message about you is only half the task. The other is to use your props as a *positive* tool for selling your character. Strive to incorporate into your performances those props that project the image you want to create. Make a list of the items and accessories you associate with the type of character you're trying to convey. What are the kinds of things he'd be likely to carry in his pocket, have in his home, come into frequent contact with, collect as a hobby? Review your list from time to time and always be on the lookout for opportunities to incorporate those items into your magic.

Exercises

“Generally speaking, men judge more by appearances than by realities.”

Machiavelli, *The Prince*

Throughout this chapter I've suggested concrete steps you can take to make these techniques work for you in selling your persona. I'd like to finish by offering some final exercises for ensuring that you get the most out of the ideas in this chapter.

There are two lists you should make that can be of immeasurable help to you in conveying your persona to the audience. We'll call these *character material lists*. The first should start with the character profile you made in the previous chapter. Under it make five columns. They should be headed: dress, terminology, character lines, effects, props.

Under “dress” list items you frequently wear when performing that you feel are particularly helpful in conveying your character. This may include a particular shirt, tie, or jacket that's important because of its style, design, or quality. It may also include jewelry or other accessories. Under terminology list words and phrases in your patter that work for the reasons we discussed earlier. Under “character lines” list patter lines of the type we discussed in that section. Under “effects” list those tricks in your repertoire whose themes are particularly fitting for your persona or which are

specifically character-defining. Under “props” list any props you use in an effect that particularly tie into your character.

Now study the results. This list will help you spot what areas you may be weak in, areas you should be exploiting more fully to convey your character.

The second list is structured exactly like the first. However, in this case you don't list under the five headings things you're presently wearing, saying, doing, or using. Rather, you list any items you can think of that you could wear, say, do, or use to help communicate your character.

You might list accessories that you may want to buy whenever you can track down the right one or can afford the price, technical terms you might use if an effect comes along that would call for them, character lines you would like to work in if you can find the right situation for them, props you'd like to use if you can find an effect that would justify them.

Under “effects” don't list specific effects, but rather themes or subject matter that might some day form the basis for an effect. If you're a mentalist, you might list “psychokinetic combustion.” If you're an occultist, you might list “Santeria.” If you're a gambling expert, you might list “cheating at baccarat.” If your persona is that of a con man, you might list “shortchanging.”

Review this second set of lists regularly. It will help you stay on the lookout for new material that will work especially well for you. Without such a list, you can easily overlook effects that are tailor-made for you or ways of tailoring effects to your character. Also, update the lists regularly as new ideas occur to you.

I also suggest you study some good books on impression management. Impression management is the term that psychologists use to describe techniques for controlling how others perceive us. In addition to *Dress for Success*, other books in this field I particularly recommend are *The Secret Language of Success* by David Lewis and *Powertalk!* by Eisen and Farley. (This last work is excellent for increasing your awareness of how phrasing and choice of words can subtly affect people's perception of your character.) Books on power dressing, body language, and other non-

verbal communication can help sensitize you to the way we draw conclusions about other people.

In this connection, an excellent exercise is to watch other performers, whether they be magicians, comics, singers, or musicians, and afterwards think about what kind of people you feel they are. Then backtrack and try to figure out what factors led you to those conclusions. After all, you don't really know these people; you just drew these conclusions on the basis of watching them for a few minutes. You can do the same thing with people you meet socially. This exercise will help bring to a conscious level the kinds of reactions we all have unconsciously to subtle signals sent out by other people. This in turn will help you use such signals to control how other people view you.

CHAPTER TEN: STYLE

“One of the most persistent concepts involved in the various definitions of style is the idea that style is closely linked to the personality of the artist.”

F. Cowles Strickland, *The Technique of Acting*

“Style, of course, is ultimately tied to the psyche.”

William Zinsser, *On Writing Well*

“Style is character.”

Norman Mailer

The Elements Of Style

This is a good time to talk about performing style because style is a subtle but very important tool in conveying the performer's character to the audience. One of the few magical writers who has been brave enough to tackle the subject of style in print is Eugene Burger. He spends almost half his book, *The Craft of Magic*, on the topic; yet he begins the discussion by saying, “I'm not sure that I could tell you—in words—exactly what style ‘is.’” This difficulty in defining style is not limited to the field of magic. It arises in virtually every art.

I think that what makes it so difficult to pinpoint what constitutes a magician's style is that *every element* in a performance contributes to style. However, while major elements such as characterization and choice of material may be analyzed separately, style also encompasses elements which are individually so minute that they defy separate analysis. It's the cumulative effect of all these elements, particularly the infinitesimally small ones, that we usually

have in mind when we speak of a performer's style.

As a starting point for our discussion, the Webster's *Dictionary* definition of style will do fine: "The way in which something is said or done as distinguished from its substance."

Suppose you must have a card selected and returned to the deck. You may spread the cards between your hands and ask that one be removed. You may thumb the cards into a symmetrically perfect fan, then hold it out for the removal of a card. You may hold the deck squared in your hand and ask the spectator to pull up one corner and peek at a card. You may spread the cards on the table rather than hold them in your hand. If you do, you may spread them in a perfect crescent, or in a precise straight line, or in a sloppy, uneven row. You may instead leave the deck squared on the table as you instruct the spectator to reach in and remove any card he wishes. Or you may tell him to think of any card then look through the deck and remove that card.

Similarly, if you wish to introduce four half dollars for an effect, you may spill them out on the table from a purse, or place them out in a neat row, or produce them in a coin star between your fingers.

In each case you've been faced with an array of choices and the effect hasn't even begun yet. To the unthinking performer the differences between the various approaches may seem trivial. Actually, each choice conveys a slightly different message about the performer and his magic: that he is precise or casual, calculating or spontaneous, concerned with aesthetic considerations or not, that he must clutch his props in order to control them or not.

These examples should make clear how very many small choices and decisions a performer has to make in routining an effect. It's from these decisions that style emerges. Each small piece of the mosaic can contribute to the overall picture that is a performer's style, but only if each is pointing in the same direction. This leads to a fundamental truth about style: style is a function of *consistency* in the countless minute elements of a performance.

But suppose the various elements point in different directions? Here we come to the most common problem most magicians have with style; not that they have a bad style or a good style but that

they have no style at all. If you perform “Coins Through the Table” like Slydini, “Matrix” like Al Schneider, “Spellbound” like the guy who taught it to you at the last club meeting, and “Copper/Silver” exactly as it was described in the book, there will be no consistent guiding intelligence behind the countless small decisions comprising your performance.

Even the above example gives the average magician too much credit since it assumes he is stylistically consistent at least within each individual effect. Magic writers are continually exhorting the reader to adapt each trick to his own style. Since the average magician simply doesn't have any style of his own, how is he supposed to follow this advice?

I've seen many magicians jokingly imitate Tony Slydini or Harry Lorayne. If you ever saw them perform you can probably do a decent parody of either one yourself, one that would be instantly recognized by most magicians. But try imitating one of your magician friends from your local magic club. Chances are you wouldn't even know where to begin. It would be like trying to paint a picture of the invisible man.

Slydini and Lorayne are so easy to caricature because they're both superlative stylists with unique approaches. It's the same in every field. It's easy to lampoon Ernest Hemingway's writing style but difficult to do the same to the average back writer of potboiler paperbacks because there is nothing to lampoon.

Developing A Style

How do you achieve the consistency of approach in minute details that's the key to style in magic (or any other art)? Magical style is the product of a strong philosophy of magic, a strong aesthetic theory, a strong individual vision of what good magic should be. When you have such a vision, it provides the touchstone for determining the correct choice (for you) from among the many different approaches that can be taken at virtually every point in an effect.

I've spoken before about the prevalence of prejudices among magicians, the belief that their approach is the only right one. In the

realm of style we find the one legitimate place for such prejudices. By way of illustration I'll discuss some of my own prejudices, not to advocate them, but only to suggest how one's own (well-thought out) biases can provide a foundation for a personal style.

I specialize in card magic and there are a number of things I don't like to see in card magic. I dislike tricks in which playing cards are used merely as counters, such as certain "Cards Across" routines or effects where the performer keeps counting a packet of cards, always getting the wrong number.

There are two things that make playing cards fascinating and unique as a prop. The first is the many ways they can be categorized: into two colors, four suits, thirteen values, and fifty—two unique identities, as well as distinguishing between faces and backs. The second is the association that playing cards have with games and gambling. I believe a card trick ought to make use of these elements. Otherwise, why bother using cards? Use pennies, or matchsticks, or dollar bills.

That's why I think the Edward Victor "Eleven-Card Trick" is a better trick when done with dollar bills, as Gene Gordon originated and Fred Kaps popularized, than when done with cards. The same is true of Tom Bowyer's bill version of the "Six-Card Repeat." Which cards you have is normally as important in a card game as how many. By contrast, with money, quantity is usually the main concern. In his "Jackpot Coins," Al Koran took a boring self-working card trick of the kind that uses cards as counters ("I have as many cards as you, plus seven, plus enough to make your cards fifteen") and turned it into a strong effect, in part by using money instead of cards.

I also dislike tricks in which playing cards are personified. Don't tell me that the king rises to the top because he's ambitious or that the selected card turned red because it got embarrassed and blushed. Playing cards don't get married; and I'll never believe that the jack of spades is a famous private eye who is going to find the stolen (ten of) diamonds. To me, such patter is childish and embarrassing. Playing cards are not little, flat people. Playing cards are just playing cards and that's all they should be called upon to be in an effect.

For this same reason, allegorical card tricks are my idea of torture (“The king of diamonds will represent Jean Val Jean and the jack of spades will represent Inspector Javer. That's right, the J in the corner stands for Javer. I'll bury them in the deck which represents the sewers of Paris.”) I also dislike tricks in which cards are torn and folded in elaborate ways. Playing cards were not intended for origami.

Underlying all I've just said is the conviction that the prop being employed should bear a logical correlation to the effect being performed. In painting and sculpture, an artist may work in more than one medium, but he always tries to exploit the strengths of that medium rather than go against them. In magic, it sometimes seems as if some magicians really dislike cards, so they treat them as if they were something else rather than use a different prop.

In fact, taking a plot originally devised for one prop and arbitrarily applying it to another has become an easy route to instant creativity in close-up magic. Linking bracelets, finger rings, or safety pins makes sense to me; their very shape immediately suggests the idea of linking. Linking playing cards does not make sense to me; you can't even do it without first fiddling with the cards for ten minutes to tear holes in them.

For the same reason, the “Color-Changing Knives” has always struck me as a strange notion. If I really had the ability to magically make things change color, would a pocket knife be the prop I'd be likely to select to demonstrate that ability? Knives are for cutting and stabbing; any trick with a knife ought to relate to that reality. Otherwise, why use a knife? Playing cards were invented for playing games and gambling. Any effect with cards ought to evidence some awareness of that fact on the part of the performer.

That's why I also dislike using extraneous props in a card effect. I won't employ rubber bands, ribbons, handkerchiefs or other incongruous items in a card effect any more than I would in a card game. By contrast, money, poker chips, or a wallet may be appropriately employed because such items are often used in conjunction with cards in real life. In sum, I'm attracted to playing cards because of their mystique; consequently, I won't perform any effect that ignores or subverts that mystique.

I also think there ought to be some point to why you're doing the trick in the first place. Tearing a playing card to pieces just to restore it again a moment later doesn't make sense to me. If you wanted it in one piece, why did you tear it up? If you wanted it torn up, why did you restore it? It took me six years to come up with a good presentational answer to that question, but until I did, the effect stayed out of my repertoire.

Now that I've gotten that off my chest, I hasten to add that I know full well that for every statement I've made there is at least one really great card effect that contradicts it. Eddie Fechter could slay audiences with his counting trick in which he always had the wrong number of cards. Brother Hamman's "The Twins" is a wonderful effect in which kings and queens become romantically involved. "The Card in Orange" can be a great trick even though, in the real world, playing cards and fruit are seldom mentioned in the same sentence. And "Card Warp" may involve folding and tearing cards but it's a modern classic and I do it myself. (Note, however, that "Card Warp" does deal with an essential characteristic of playing cards, their faces and backs, which is more than can be said of card linking tricks.)

However, the prejudices I've described above are right for *me*. Following these biases has helped give my performances a distinctive and consistent look, one in which playing cards are used and handled in familiar ways in a familiar context (all derived from the card table) to produce extremely unfamiliar results.

I didn't go into the above arguments about card magic to win you over to my way of thinking. That might result in your copying my style, which would do neither of us any good. I've offered these opinions only as examples of the kind of conclusions a performer will eventually arrive at if he gives enough thought to what he is doing.

The more you think about your magic, the more concretely you'll develop a mental image of what you feel is magical and desirable in a performance and what is not. The stronger a magical performing philosophy you develop, the more distinctive a style you'll evolve as even the smallest elements in your performances are fashioned to reflect that philosophy. Style reflects your attitude toward magic;

therefore, you must think about magic in order to develop an attitude to reflect.

Because effective style always reflects thought and understanding, imitating other performers never works. In almost every art, including magic, beginners often find themselves attracted to the work of a particular practitioner and respond by imitating his style. This is a stage many performers go through and it can serve a useful purpose in an artist's development. As the artist starts to find his own voice he may end up incorporating some of his model's values. Every successful artist and performer has been influenced by the work of others.

However, the performer who becomes fixed at the imitative stage is doomed to mediocrity. He may try to do exactly what his model does, but because he doesn't understand *why* he does what he does, the performance rings hollow. Since there is no underlying intelligence animating the imitator's performance it will always be easy to tell the original from the copy.

Much has been said about the immorality of copying another performer's work. Experience has shown that morality doesn't carry much weight with most magicians. So just remember this, ethical questions aside, stealing and copying just don't work.

When you develop a strong style, it will show not only in the magic you perform but even in the magic you create. Dai Vernon and Ed Mario are undoubtedly the towering figures of twentieth century card magic. The one great difference between them is that Vernon's magic sprang from a strong philosophical base; Marlo's didn't.

That's why people speak of “the Vernon touch” but never make similar comments about Marlo. That's why an effect by another magician may strike you as being very “Vernonesque.” By contrast, if you were to read two effects published by Marlo in different publications without seeing the byline you might well think they were the creations of two different men—unless you recognized the similarities in *writing* style.

None of this is meant to diminish the contributions of either man, but only to indicate the differences in the nature of those contributions. Vernon's quest for “naturalness” in everything he did

gave his work a unity not found in the work of Marlo who was, by contrast, concerned with exploring every possible methodological avenue with cards. If you want to attain a deeper understanding of the role of style in magic, you would do well to study the differences between these two giants of card magic.

Working At Your Style

I'm going to suggest an exercise to start you on the road to developing a personal style. Get a pen and a piece of paper. Select any effect from your repertoire and run through it, noting every point where you might reasonably have chosen to follow a different approach to the one you do follow and note that point on the paper. Remember, we're speaking here not only of questions of method such as whether to do a double lift or a second deal, but are considering every feature that affects the visual picture created by the effect. Should you keep the deck in your hand during this phase of the effect or place it on the table? Should you hold it in the left hand or the right hand?

We will call these the crossroad stages of the effect. When you're finished, if you don't have a list of at least a dozen items you're just not thinking hard enough. Some of the possibilities will probably not even occur to you, but if you end up with a dozen or more crossroad stages that's good enough for now.

Take each of these crossroad stages and list every single alternative approach you could follow at that point, including the one you've chosen to follow. If you're performing a false shuffle to keep four aces on top of the deck, your list might include these choices: (1) false overhand shuffle; (2) false riffle shuffle; (3) false cut; (4) all of the above; (5) none of the above (i.e., skip the shuffling altogether).

Since you'll end up with numerous choices for each of the dozen or more stages of the effect you've listed, you should have quite a long list. Now comes the hardest (and most important) part. Study each option and determine in your mind what advantages and disadvantages each one offers. These may involve matters of deceptiveness, psychology, aesthetics, naturalness, pacing or any other considerations that seem relevant to you.

Finally, select the option for each crossroad stage that you feel is, on balance, the best. This will all take a lot of time and thought. In some cases, you may conclude that it doesn't make any difference which of two possibilities you choose. That's fine. It may be that you've not yet become sensitive enough to detect the subtle differences in the message given off by two different approaches or it may be that it really doesn't matter. That does sometimes happen.

When you've finished, you may well end up deciding that you don't want to change a single thing about the way you do the effect. But you'll still have learned something of value from the exercise. You'll have a better understanding of why you do what you do. You'll have come closer to developing a strong performing philosophy and you'll be better able to make stylistically consistent decisions in routining any subsequent effects you may add to your repertoire.

You may not wish to go through this exercise with every effect you do (although the more you do it, the more you'll benefit), but I urge you to try it with at least one effect if you want to really understand what style is all about.

Style As A Conscious Act

Some may feel that the kind of work suggested above is really unnecessary. There is a common belief that artistic style is something that just evolves automatically with time—that it just happens or that it just comes naturally. The more successful the artist, the more likely that his work will foster this notion.

Ernest Hemingway was one of the great stylists of modern literature. His exceptionally clean, spare writing style appears so simple that readers are inclined to think it was his natural means of expression, perhaps even the result of a limited education or limited vocabulary. Actually, literary scholars know that it took a great deal of hard work and deliberate effort for Hemingway to develop the extreme simplicity and apparent artlessness that mark his unique style.

The French author Gustav Flaubert is said to have tried whenever possible to avoid using the same word twice on any one page. You can be sure this stylistic feature required a great deal of work on Flaubert's part. In every art you will find that a tremendous amount

of thought and plain hard work goes into achieving what the public assumes just comes naturally.

Consider an example from the field of magic. René Lavand has written, “I have spent three months, not just to create a routine, but just to find the right words for the climax, and another three months trying to find the correct tone of voice for each of the words.” Does that sound to you like someone whose style has just evolved unconsciously?

I consider Tony Slydini and Harry Lorayne to be great magical stylists in much the same way that Hemingway was a great stylist of mainstream fiction and Lord Dunsany, Clark Ashton Smith, and Raymond Chandler were great stylists of genre fiction. Neither one's style is the result of accident.

Slydini's highly refined and analytical theories of magic are well-known. Lorayne, having a much more naturalistic style, is more likely to be dismissed as a purely instinctive performer. However, anyone who has ever discussed magic with Harry knows that he has strong convictions about what constitutes good magic—convictions born of a great deal of experience and also a great deal of thought. These convictions are clearly reflected in his style.

Let me put it this way. You may well evolve a personal style over time without much conscious thought or effort, but it's doubtful that it will be a style that will appeal to your audiences and enhance your magic.

This is not to say that every one of the countless minute decisions that go into the performance of a magic effect need be the result of conscious thought. In the work of a real artist a great many more of them are conscious than most magicians suspect. Nevertheless, in time, as your style grows you'll develop instincts that will automatically guide you on many points.

For example, in addition to the topics discussed earlier, another consideration that plays an important role in my own magic is economy of motion. In their classic book *The Elements of Style*, Strunk and White admonish, “Omit needless words.” I feel this advice is just as valid in magic if rephrased, “Omit needless actions.” At this point I find that in working on a new effect I instinctively

evolve the handling that involves the least wasted motion. I no longer need go through a great deal of conscious analysis on this point. However, a great deal of conscious analysis of other effects, moves, and handlings went into developing that instinct.

Considerations Affecting Style

Since style should be a very personal thing—the most personal aspect of your magic—the considerations that guide you in developing your style should simply be the ones that seem most important to you. However, here are some points to keep in mind. First, style should be an extension of your performing character. Consequently, stylistic decisions should be consistent with your character. Would your character be more likely to overhand shuffle or riffle shuffle the cards?

Style should also support substance. The hardboiled writing style of Dashiell Hammett would be as inappropriate in a fantasy set in an imaginary kingdom as the extremely ornate style of Clark Ashton Smith would be in a private eye novel. (Indeed, a standard technique of literary lampoons is to apply an author's style to content for which it's totally inappropriate. The result is invariably humorous.)

Similarly, your style should suit the effects you choose to perform. The effect and the manner in which you perform it should support each other, not undermine each other. Since your effects should also suit your performing character, you should encounter no conflicts in suiting style to both the effects and the character.

Finally, some of the examples we used earlier have already suggested how style and method interact in an effect. We spoke of deciding whether to have a card chosen by spreading the deck between the hands, ribbon-spreading the deck on the table, or having a card peeked at. The approach you choose may well be determined by how you intend to control the card. Alternatively, what method of control you use may depend on how you prefer, from a stylistic standpoint, to have the card chosen.

The more your individual style develops, the more demands and limitations it will place on the moves and methods you can use. This

is the truth behind the quite valid cliché that a method that is right for one performer is not necessarily right for another. It also gives the lie to the equally popular cliché that one method is as good as another or that the easiest method is always the best.

Naturalness In Style

I can't leave the subject of style in magic without addressing a topic that always comes up when magicians discuss the topic. In such cases you can always count on someone to say solemnly, "The important thing is to be natural." They always utter this comment as if it should put an end to the discussion.

To say that naturalness is an important aspect of style is a profound statement. But it shouldn't end the discussion; it should start another one. That's because praising naturalness only raises the knotty question of what is natural. How can we determine if a move or action is natural?

Some magicians seem to think the question should be settled by a vote. At a session, one magician will say, "I don't think that looks natural." Another will say, "I think it does." Everyone offers an opinion and the majority wins.

Many other magicians think that being natural means acting like a layperson. They will say, "That's not natural. No layman would ever do that." One problem is that close-up magic generally, and card magic particularly, requires you to perform many tasks that laypeople are never called on to do. Consequently, the question of how a layperson would do it is of only limited help in deciding what is natural.

A more important problem is that most magicians don't understand the difference between a natural style and a naturalistic style. Dai Vernon popularized the naturalistic style in close-up magic. By naturalistic, I mean a style that attempts to mimic nature, in this case to mimic the way laypeople do things.

It's a style that offers certain benefits. However, there are other masters of magic—Ascanio and Slydini, to name two—who have taken very different approaches with equal success. Their styles are anything but naturalistic. That is, they make no effort to handle

their props the way a layperson would. Yet, nothing about their actions appears unnatural. If they did, their magic wouldn't have the power it does.

This suggests that there must be some other test of naturalness than whether a layperson would do it that way. And, indeed, there is. People make the judgment that something looks natural or unnatural on an instinctive level. Often they couldn't tell you why something strikes them as unnatural. (Indeed, this is the source of all the confusion on the subject that I've already pointed to.) But the fact that the spectator himself couldn't tell you the reason he feels something looks unnatural doesn't mean he doesn't have a reason.

I suggest there are two tests that are the true measure of naturalness. The first is *motivation*. Any time you perform any action, however small, without having a good reason for doing it, a reason that is immediately apparent to everyone watching, that action will appear unnatural. There is nothing more suspicious to an audience than an unmotivated action.

Of course, most any time you do something in an effect you'll have a good reason. But often that reason is related to the method; you have to do it or the trick won't work. Since the audience isn't (or at least shouldn't be) aware of the method, that motivation isn't enough to make the action look natural.

Whatever your real reason for doing something, there has to appear to the audience to be a good reason for doing it within the context of the *effect* (as opposed to the method). Otherwise, it will look unnatural. Like a good actor, you should always be asking yourself, "What's my motivation here?"

The second test of naturalness is *economy of motion*. People instinctively understand that the natural way to do something is the way that expends the least energy. This is why you can perform an action that the audience has never seen anyone do before and yet it may look perfectly natural to them.

A good example of this can be seen in any gambling casino at the blackjack tables. People see the dealer shuffle, cut, and deal the cards, and handle the chips, in ways they've never done themselves and may never have seen anyone else do. Yet no one feels the

actions are unnatural. It all looks perfectly natural because it's clearly the most efficient way to do those things. People sense that this is probably the way they would do it themselves if they had performed these actions thousands of times and thus evolved the most economical ways of accomplishing them.

This is also why some of the most unnatural-looking actions I've ever seen in magic have occurred when a layperson who is unused to handling cards is asked to shuffle, cut, deal or perform some other action with cards. He hasn't done these things often enough to have evolved a natural way of doing them, a way that avoids wasted motion.

There are two lessons to be learned from all this. The first is that naturalness doesn't come naturally. You'll have to devote a great deal of thought to figuring out how to perform the necessary actions in your effects in a natural way, always applying the two tests of motivation and economy of motion.

The second is that a *naturalistic* style is just one possible approach. As an artist, you'll have to decide whether or not this is the kind of style you want to develop. However, *naturalness* in style is not merely an option. It is a must if you're to avoid arousing suspicion in your performances. And avoiding arousing suspicion is a lot easier than quelling suspicion once you've aroused it.

Part Three:

The Act

“It doesn't matter how good an effect is if it doesn't really fit into the act.”

T.A. Waters

CHAPTER ELEVEN: STRUCTURE

Proper construction of your close-up act is probably second only to characterization in its importance in determining how much impact your magic will have. Some professional performers, like Al Goshman, succeed in making a good living with only a single act while others have several acts. In my own case, I have seven different close-up card magic acts in addition to my one-hour gambling exposé act. How many acts you should eventually develop is partly a function of the circumstances and frequency of your performing and partly a matter of personal preference. I could easily make do with only half as much material as I have, but eight different acts satisfies my own desire for variety and helps keep my interest in magic at a high pitch. Fortunately, although I don't really need eight acts, I do perform frequently enough to get full use out of that many.

Even if you never perform professionally, you'll find it very valuable to organize the material in your repertoire into preset acts. Thinking of your material in terms of acts will give structure to your informal performances even though you may add, subtract, or substitute effects on the spur of the moment during an impromptu performance.

Furthermore, with a sound understanding of the principles of act construction, you can formulate an effective act as you go along even in totally improvised performances where you're completely "playing it by ear." Even if you're doing only three tricks off the cuff for a couple of friends, the performance will be far stronger if you choose those three tricks in accordance with the principles of proper act construction.

It's a precept of public speaking that your most important sentences

are your first and your last. The first sentence is the one that determines whether the audience will bother listening to the rest of the speech. Your last sentence is the one they'll remember best. For the same reasons, in a magic performance, your most important effects are your opener and your closer.

The Opener

Your opening effect must achieve two very important goals. First, it has to win over the audience. Second, it should set the tone for the rest of the act. When I talk about winning over the audience I mean that when you start to perform you are on trial. The audience has not yet committed to watching your performance. If you're performing in a professional situation where people are walking by, you may notice that many of them are hanging back, standing at some distance. They're ready to move in close if the performance captivates, but just as ready to move on if it doesn't. Even in a non-professional setting such as a party where you have something closer to a captive audience, the situation is psychologically the same. When you start performing, the audience is waiting to make a decision whether to pay attention for the rest of the performance or tune you out and daydream about more interesting activities.

What you must realize is that, not only are you on trial, but the verdict is going to be handed in very soon. The audience is not going to give you much time to establish that you're worth watching. Consequently, your first effect must not only make the case that you're worth watching, it must make that case pretty fast or it'll be too late.

This will usually mean that your first effect should be shorter than most of the other effects in the act, perhaps the shortest one in the act. However, the really critical point is not how short the effect is, but how much time elapses before something magical happens. A four-minute trick in which the first magical climax is reached in the first forty-five seconds will make a better opener than a three-minute trick in which nothing magical happens until the very end. "The Ambitious Card" is a good example of the former approach. The routine may be moderately long but, once the card is selected and signed, it's non-stop magic.

My own rule of thumb is that I want something magical to happen within two minutes of the start of any close-up act I do.

However, this is only a rule of thumb. In some settings, like restaurant magic for example, where there are numerous distractions and where the performer's prestige at the outset is usually low, even two minutes may be too long.

Alternatively, if you can intrigue the audience at the very outset with an interest catcher of the kind we discussed earlier, you may have a little more time. The important thing is to hook them into the performance fast—get them psychologically committed to watching the rest of your act. Then you'll have the freedom to get into some of your more elaborate mysteries.

The second thing your opener should do is to set the tone for the performance. Whatever you do at the outset, the audience will expect that the rest of the performance will be in the same vein. If it isn't, they'll spend the rest of the act confused. If you open with a mental effect, they'll expect mentalism to play a major role in the entire performance. If you open with a broad comedy effect, they'll expect the rest of the act to follow suit.

Your opening effect should epitomize your style and your slant on magic. It should give them a taste of your persona and start to develop the atmosphere you want to generate throughout the act. I realize that's a tall order. That's why you may find you'll have to search long and hard for ideal opening material. Personally, I have found it much harder to find good openers than good closers or good middle-of-the-act material.

The key is to give serious thought to the kind of style, tone, persona, and atmosphere you want to create, as we've already discussed. If you do, you'll be light-years ahead of most magicians and you'll readily recognize the kind of opener that will work for you when you encounter it.

On this same point of setting the tone, you should consider the possibility of introducing yourself with an appropriate tagline. Al Goshman used to start by saying, “Hi, my name is Al and I'm going to 'magish' for you.” In one sentence he had already communicated that his approach was informal (“Al”), and lighthearted and tongue-

in-cheek (“magish”).

I start all my formal performances by saying, “My name is Darwin Ortiz and for the next few minutes I'd like to show you why you should never play cards with strangers.” This immediately establishes that they're going to see a “card” act and that the subjects of gambling and cheating will play major roles. It also suggests that I know more about those subjects (cards, gambling, and cheating) than the average person.

While delivering this line I “absentmindedly” give the deck an impressive flourish cut. Immediately, they know I have skill with cards—that I won't be subjecting them to the “Twenty-One Card Trick.” The line and the flourish distinguish me from their Uncle Joe who does card tricks. They intrigue the audience, suggest that I'll probably be worth watching, give them some idea of what I'm like, and set the tone for the rest of the act. These are just the things you want to do at the start of any performance.

Build

In order to properly do its job, your opening effect should be a strong one, as should every effect you do. But it shouldn't be too strong. In fact, it's vitally important that it be the least strong effect in the act.

In discussing progression in individual effects I quoted F. Cowles Strickland to the effect that, “That which follows must always be made to seem more important and more interesting than that which has preceded. . . Even an attempt to maintain the same level of interest will not satisfy an audience.” This is just as true about the entire act as it is about each individual trick in the act.

In *Magic and Showmanship*, Henning Nelms speaks of the “interest curve.” The notion is that one can, in effect, graph the audience's increasing or decreasing interest at each moment. This is a very useful way of thinking about the concept. Proper build means that the interest curve rises continually from start to finish.

As Nelms points out, the interest curve for an individual effect is (or at least should be) shaped like a wave with the peak coining at the very end. Therefore, it isn't really possible for a series of effects to

achieve a smoothly rising curve. They will be a series of waves. But—and this is vital—in an effective act, the crest of each wave must be higher than the one before. If you were to draw a line connecting all the crests, that line would form a smoothly rising curve.

Some effects have more than one climax. As we've seen, in such cases, each subsequent climax should be stronger than the one before so the interest curve keeps rising throughout the effect and we avoid a deadly anti-climax. When a multi-climax trick is placed within the context of an act, even the first of the multiple climaxes should be stronger than the last climax of the previous trick. But the last of the multiple climaxes should still be less than the climax of the next trick. Just remember the image of that connect-the-dots line stringing together all the climaxes of the act and remember that this line must always rise. Any downward dip is fatal.

This means that *when you put together an act you must order the tricks from weakest to strongest*. Each one should be more impossible than the one before. Yes, I know that logically something is either possible or impossible. You can't speak of one impossibility being more impossible than another. That's logically true but emotionally false. Intuitively we all feel that some things are more impossible than others. In magic, the degree of impossibility will generally be determined by the degree of conviction you achieve and the scope of the effect. (Making a whole deck change color is more impossible than making one card in the deck change color.)

Experience in performing the various effects in your repertoire will give you a good sense of their relative strengths. It would seem, then, that it would be easy to select several effects and perform them in ascending order of strength. In practice, you'll encounter many problems. One card trick sets you up beautifully for another. Unfortunately, the first one is the stronger of the two. Another card trick is the strongest of all, but it requires a setup so it would be easier to use it as an opener.

Working things out so that the various effects are in order of ascending impact will require ingenuity; it will mean solving countless practical problems. As usual, you have to decide whether you want to follow the easiest path or the most effective.

I've heard some magicians argue that the best way to organize an act is with “peaks and valleys.” They advocate mixing stronger tricks and weaker tricks more or less randomly. The problem with the peaks-and-valleys approach is that when you hit a valley, the audience doesn't know there is another peak around the corner. They're likely to assume that you've passed the high point of the performance and that it's all downhill from here. Consequently, they'll start to lose interest, if not actually walk away. Believe me, once you've lost them it can be very hard to win them back.

The notion that what comes after must always be stronger than what came before is one of the most fundamental of all dramatic rules. You'll find it stressed in books on theater, standup comedy, public speaking, and playwrighting. Furthermore, every professional magician has discovered it from hard experience. Leave the peaks-and-valleys to the non-performing advice-givers. If you want your act to have maximum impact, the only approach is build, BUILD, **BUILD**.

The Closer

By now you realize that your closing effect should be the strongest trick in the act. You want that closer to trigger a tremendous burst of applause. I've found that two kinds of effects achieve that particularly well. The first is a trick with a very strong suspense buildup. Suspense creates pressure in the audience. When you push that pressure to the limit then release it with a strong climax you usually get just the kind of explosive applause you want at the end of your act.

The other kind of effect that works particularly well as a closer is a multiple-climax trick. If the climax of the trick is stronger than any previous trick in the act, then on top of that you can quickly pile one or two more climaxes, each stronger than the one before, you create a sharply escalating interest curve right at the end of the performance that will drive the audience to a strong response.

Something else I've found useful is to announce just before the closer that it will be the last trick. All it takes is a casual comment like, “Let me show you one last one,” or, “For my last trick I'm going to need your help.” This alerts the audience to the fact that if they've

got any applause they've been holding back, this next one is the time to give it to you. They should show their appreciation, not only for this particular trick, but for the entire performance.

CHAPTER TWELVE: UNITY

“The skillful writer has not fashioned his thoughts to accommodate his incidents, but having deliberately conceived a certain single effect to be wrought, he then invents such incidents, he then combines such events, and discusses them in such a tone as may best serve him in establishing this preconceived effect.”

Edgar Allan Poe

“To my mind, unity is as good a criterion as any for determining what is art and what is not.”

Gary Provost, *Make Your Words Work*

Of the many elements that go into creating a strong act the most important are constant build and a balance between unity and variety. The first matter we discussed in the last chapter. The second we'll discuss in the next two chapters.

The point of putting together an act is that, whenever you perform more than one trick, the cumulative impact of the effects should be more than can be accounted for by the individual impact of each trick; the whole should be more than the sum of its parts. To achieve this, the performance must come across as a unified whole rather than just a string of unrelated tricks. Let's look at the four major elements you can employ to impart unity to your act.

Amazingly, many magicians fail to achieve even this element of unity in their performances, not because each trick is performed by a different person, but because each trick is performed by a different “persona.”

You can't perform your first effect as a serious mentalist, your next effect as a corny practical joker, and your last effect as a smooth-as-

silk cardshark and expect the performance to register with your audience as a unified whole. Yet, if you've perfected a detailed, credible, and appealing performing persona it can tie together even a performance of otherwise unrelated material.

The most striking example of this I've ever seen is in the act of Irv Weiner. In Irv's college concert show, he performs mime bits, gambling exposé material, Hindu fakir effects such as the "Needle Through Arm" and stopping his pulse, straight magic such as "Spongeballs" and "Cut-And-Restored Rope," and mentalism such as a "Headline Prediction."

A lesser performer could never make this *mélange* of disparate material work. It would be like watching a pathological multiple personality perform. People would ask, "Who is this guy? Is he a card cheat, a magician, a Hindu fakir, or a mindreader?" The magic would undercut the credibility of the mentalism, the gambling material would undercut the credibility of the Hindu effects, and so on. Furthermore, this grab bag of unrelated material would never register as a unified act. The whole would be much less than the sum of its parts.

However, Irv has achieved the difficult task of creating a character that makes all this material work together. That character might be described as follows: an older man with an exotic past who has spent a large part of his life traveling the world experiencing things and delving into mysteries that the rest of us only read about.

Like Marco Polo regaling Europeans with spellbinding tales of what he saw in his travels, Irv has come here tonight to share with you some of the arcane arts and knowledge he has gathered from far-flung corners of the world. Viewed in this light, it becomes apparent that the wide variety of material he presents is necessary to develop his character. (Remember that we learned earlier that choice of effects is one of the most basic tools for conveying your character to an audience.) Paradoxically, because of the performer's stage persona, a wide variety of material is actually essential to imparting unity to this particular act.

The moral is that a strong and consistent character is the only absolutely essential ingredient in creating a unified act. However,

this doesn't mean that you can perform any tricks you want. Rather, it means that your act must consist only of effects that your character might be expected to do, performed in the way that your character would be expected to perform them.

Props

An act may be tied together by the practice of employing the same prop or type of prop in every effect. In all my acts, playing cards are the central prop in each effect. This is also true in the performances of Martin Nash, Eddie Tullock, and probably other performers as well. David Roth performs only effects with coins in his formal table act.

There are many other props that are adaptable to this approach. One could put together an act composed entirely of effects with currency (for example, the “Blank Paper to Bills” trick, the “Torn and Restored Bill,” and the “Floating Dollar Bill”) or an act consisting only of effects with dice (for example, Dr. Sak's “Spotted Sorcery,” Irv Weiner's “Soft Dice,” “Matrix” done with dice, and Dice Stacking). This is a concept that's been explored far more fully in stage magic where performers have successfully used acts employing only cards, doves, parakeets, phonograph records, light bulbs, or jewels.

Theme

The theme is the underlying message of the performance. Another way of putting it is that the theme is the ostensible reason for performing the act. Just as we spoke of an effect having substantive meaning, an entire act may have one substantive meaning; that meaning is the theme of the act.

Many acts don't have any single underlying message or any rationale other than entertaining the audience. There is certainly nothing wrong with that. As José Carroll has observed, ultimately every magic act has at least one theme, the theme of magic. As he has written, “A spectator who watches that act will identify it and separate it from any other kind of artistic manifestation because that act is . . . 'magical.' “

However, an act that also contains a more specific and distinctive theme can achieve a degree of unity that is difficult to attain in any other way. Every effect is tied to every other effect because they are all being performed for the same reason, toward the same end.

If theme is to an act what meaning is to an effect, it shouldn't be surprising that many of the sources of substantive meaning we discussed in connection with individual effects may also be employed as the theme of an entire act. In my gambling lecture my only real concern is to entertain the audience; however, my ostensible purpose is to make the audience more aware of the many ways in which they can be cheated when gambling. That is the theme of the act.

Similarly, a mentalist appears before his audience to expand their understanding of the hidden powers of the mind. This theme ties together everything he does in his performance. We have already discussed the developing field of bizarre magick in which the performer enacts what appear to be authentic occult rituals. A performer who specializes in this field has as the theme of his act the exploration of the supernatural.

Acts that revolve entirely around one kind of prop are often referred to as "theme acts." However, such sloppy terminology only serves to obscure an understanding of the different elements that contribute to the success of a performance. To illuminate the distinction between props and theme, let's consider how we might structure an all-dice act. Under Props we saw that an act might be comprised entirely of effects with dice such as Dr. Sak's "Spotted Sorcery," Irv Weiner's "Soft Dice," "Matrix" done with dice, and Dice Stacking. These are all quite unrelated magic effects whose only common bond is the use of the same kind of prop.

Suppose, however, that I begin my performance by explaining to the audience how I used to be a fanatical dice player. Recently, I swore off the game for good after a series of mishaps. I had been told that to be certain a pair of dice is fair you should check to make sure they add up to fourteen on opposite sides. But, in the first crap game I checked, the spots kept changing. ["Spotted Sorcery"] When I went to play craps at a friend's house where I knew I wouldn't be cheated, his downstairs neighbor kept complaining about the noise of the

dice rolling across the floor. [“Soft Dice”] After I gave up on craps, I dropped into the neighborhood bar. Even there temptation was put in my path. A couple of guys were playing poker dice with four dice and a cup. When I tried my hand, I couldn't even roll a pair; the dice just kept piling up. [Dice Stacking routine]

With a little thought, several other dice effects could be added to the act, all presented as examples of misadventures that occurred to a hapless, would-be dice player. While all the effects would employ dice, the theme would not be “dice,” but rather “why I quit playing dice.” In our first example, the decision to use only dice was an aesthetic one. In the second example, it is a conceptual one.

If we change the theme slightly to “why I quit gambling,” we can add card effects and other gambling-related routines that don't use dice. While all these effects would be performed from the perspective of a former habitual gambler who was cured by the series of mishaps and bizarre events he experienced in his quest for action. This modification of the theme offers greater versatility, but slightly less unity since a variety of props are used.

We can have an all–dice act without the why-I-quit-gambling theme, or we can have a why-I-quit-gambling act without limiting ourselves only to dice, or we can have an act that is unified both by the why-I–quit-gambling theme and also by an all-dice props approach. Since consistency and unity are essential qualities in all effective magic acts—and in all art—it should not be surprising that a change in any one element, theme, props, or character, may entail changes in the others. However, that shouldn't blind us to the fact that each is a different element with different functions.

Every presentational technique entails limitations as well as advantages. In the case of employing a theme, the limitation is that the performer must bypass any effect that cannot be made to serve the theme. Any digression from the main point will weaken the impact of, not only that effect, but the entire performance. You may love “Coins Through the Table,” but don't do it in the middle of a gambling act.

Keep in mind that the thematic relevance of each effect must have credibility for the audience. Some performers seem to feel that any

flimsy patter link is enough to allow them to drag in whatever effect they want. Such an approach is doubly harmful. The irrelevant effect hurts the act and the transparently contrived patter connection only serves to highlight how inappropriate the effect really is. With theme as with characterization, consistency is the keynote. Ideally, every effect should not only be compatible with the theme but should help to develop the theme in some way.

So far, we have limited our examples of theme acts to well- explored territory. However, the possibilities for effective themes around which to build a strong close-up act are limited only by one's imagination. Here is an idea for a close-up theme act I had several years ago but never used. (I've been told the idea has been independently thought of by others.) Anyone who cares to use it has my permission to do so. For the rest of you, it will at least serve to further illustrate the concept of theme in magic.

The performer comes out holding a child's magic set under his arm. He explains that he received it as a birthday present last week. After all, the box says on the side, "For ages seven and older." He's older than seven so his friends figured he qualified. Having practiced diligently for the past three days, he feels ready for his first performance. He opens the cardboard box and takes out some small plastic prop of the kind usually found in these sets and proceeds to perform a mindboggling miracle with it.

The act continues in this vein. The performing props all consist of cheap plastic slum items of the kind found in children's magic sets. The effects all consist of powerful, entertaining magic. The premise consists of the claim that these are really the tricks that came in his "Official Junior Magician" set and are taught in the instructions; the performer learned them in a couple of days. The power of the performance would stem from the contrast between the unassuming toy props and the miraculous magic the performer produces with them. Needless to say, this incongruity could also generate a great deal of humor.

There are a good many effects to choose from in constructing such an act. A number of top close-up workers have at some time worked selling slum magic in novelty shops and developed sophisticated routines for these tricks in order to maintain their sanity. The best-

known example is Michael Skinner's great routine for the Ball and Vase trick.

Also, many sophisticated effects have been reproduced in cheap knockoff versions. A few years ago there was a children's magic set on the market that actually contained an Okito coin box made out of plastic. If you could track down one of these, you could perform the David Roth coin box routine with it. Why not perform the Vernon Cups and Balls with one of the cheap, small plastic cups and balls sets they sell in slum shops?

You could also use some of those ingenious Tenyo effects which are invariably produced in plastic. In this case, the cheap appearance of the props would be an asset rather than a drawback.

If anyone does decide to develop this idea, I recommend that he check out an effect of Jack Chanin's in *Phoenix* No. 194 called "Jap Jape." It is a wonderful "Bill in Cigarette" effect using, of all things, two of the plastic drawer boxes sold in novelty shops that every child has owned at some time. The sponge rabbits is another effect that would work well in such an act. Remember, the props you use don't actually have to come from a children's magic set; they just have to look as if they do.

As with most themes, this one has implications for the character portrayed by the performer. He must not come across as a magician, but as a layman who has just learned a couple of tricks. Flourishes would be out of the question as would any blatant signs of professionalism. (In reality, it would take considerable professional ability to perform such an act with the apparent artlessness required.)

A nice touch might be to appear stumped at one point in a trick, take out the instruction booklet that comes with the set, glance through it, then resume the effect successfully. If the performer does his job right, the audience will recognize the talent underlying the self-effacing performance and give him the applause and acclaim he deserves.

Motifs

A motif should not be confused with a theme. When a theme is

employed, it should run through every effect performed. It is the thread that ties all the individual components together. If even a single effect is performed that is not consistent with the theme, the whole act will suffer. A motif is not something that runs through the entire act; rather it recurs periodically throughout the act. The performer may do one or even several effects that do not involve the motif, but he will strike the motif often enough throughout the act to give the performance a sense of continuity and a consistency of vision.

One of the most famous motifs in close-up magic is the production of coins under objects in Albert Goshman's act. The "Coins Under Salt Shakers" is not merely one of the feature effects of Goshman's act, it is a note that he returns to again and again throughout the act, sometimes varying it by producing coins from under some of the other props used in certain effects. As with most great artistic touches in magic, the use of this effect as a motif is a conscious strategy on Goshman's part, as will be seen by reading *Magic by Gosh* where he discusses the subject at length.

Another classic close-up magic act that relies heavily on motifs is that of Del Ray. One motif is the challenge offer of a fifty dollar bill if an effect should fail. This ploy, which is used by many performers in a single trick, is employed by Del Ray as a continuing source of humor and a continuing means of underscoring the impossibility of what he is doing. He will play a game of poker with the spectators, offering a fifty dollar bill to the winner. Later he will play blackjack with them, again offering the fifty to the best hand. The same offer is made when he plays dice with the audience.

Not content with limiting the offer to gambling situations, Del Ray turns virtually every situation into a (sure-thing) gamble by introducing the fifty dollar offer in card locations, prediction effects, and even transpositions (his presentation of "Vernon's Challenge"). At one point he varies the concept slightly by offering to give away his mechanical bird if an effect should fail.

Del Ray doesn't make the offer in every effect; he is wise enough to realize that the impact could diminish from overuse. Similarly, the offer is certainly not in any sense his rationale for presenting the act. Therefore, it is not a theme but rather a true motif, which together

with Del Ray's unique and appealing character serves to make his act a unified, and very memorable, experience.

An important difference between themes and motifs is that while an act can only have one theme it may have several motifs. Here again, Del Ray's act provides an example. In addition to the offer of a cash reward, his act contains a second major motif, that of toy animals that act alive. The act opens with a rabbit that jumps to attention and closes with a mouse that locates a selected card. In between we meet a frog that does somersaults and a mechanical bird that predicts the future. Throughout, Del Ray relates to these as if they were living creatures, and their behavior seems to justify his attitude. Toy animals don't turn up in every effect in Del Ray's act. Rather they recur from time to time, thus providing a unifying motif.

My own work provides a perfect illustration of the difference between a theme and a motif. As I explained, in my gambling exposé act crooked gambling is the theme. However, in my close-up card acts, gambling is not a theme since straight card magic predominates and the audience realizes that the only rationale for the performance is to entertain them, not to educate them as in the gambling expose. However, in these close-up magic performances I do exploit gambling as a motif. Gambling routines are interspersed among the straight magic effects. Gambling terminology and gambling references abound.

Even several of the straight card magic effects employ presentations that touch on gambling-related topics. For instance, here are two examples from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. "Darwin's Wild Card" is performed with deuces and presented as an explanation of why deuces are considered wild in poker. "The Lucky Deck" is an effect in which faces are printed onto a blank-faced deck. The deck is introduced as having belonged to my grandfather, a big-time gambler. Feeling that these cards brought him luck, he played cards with them so much he eventually wore the faces off. Thus, in these various ways the primary function of playing cards as gambling tools is repeatedly underscored, providing a motif that imparts a unifying element to the performance.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN: VARIETY

While unity is vital to any successful performance, it's important not to confuse unity with sameness. Unity creates artistic impact; sameness creates boredom. Others have commented on the importance of a magic act having variety. Achieving variety in a magic act is easy. Achieving variety without sacrificing unity is another matter.

One of the great challenges in putting together an effective act is to balance unity and variety. It's important to do so because the tension between unity and variety is one of the sources of strength of a good act. Actually, within each of the unifying factors we've discussed, there is considerable room for variety. Let's consider some examples.

Theme

Even if the theme of your act is mentalism, for example, there are many possibilities to explore. You may do an effect in which you receive a thought from someone, another effect in which you transmit a thought to someone, an effect of precognition, and an effect of remote viewing. Years ago Uri Geller did mentalists a great favor by introducing to the public the notion of physical phenomena as a manifestation of mental powers. Thus, today a mentalist can add considerable variety to his act by demonstrating his ability to move or physically alter objects through the power of his mind. Each of these may be considered a sub-theme that flows logically from the larger theme of the act.

Many magicians, when they put together a gambling act, end up with just a string of poker deals. There is a lot more to the theme of crooked gambling than that. You can do one effect on cheating at

poker, another on cheating at blackjack, another on cheating at gin rummy or bridge, all popular games. You can show people how hustlers can cheat using false deals, using crooked shuffles, and by palming and switching cards. You can do a three-card monte demonstration, a demonstration of cutting to the aces, and a routine in which you actually play cards with one or more spectators and repeatedly win under impossible conditions.

Another way to achieve variety is to engage in shifts in tone that are consistent with your theme. In recent years mentalists have shown greater interest in effects with humorous overtones. Similarly, in a gambling act you can do a deadly serious demonstration of some “closely guarded” secret cheating technique. Yet your next effect may be a three-shell game routine with strong comedy elements.

Props

David Roth performs an act built entirely around coins—indeed, entirely around half-dollars and English pennies. Yet, by introducing a wide range of subsidiary props, he creates tremendous variety and disguises the fact that the audiences is not only watching magic with the same prop over and over again, but also watching the same few effects (vanishes, productions, and transpositions) over and over again. The use of a purse frame, a cloth hole, a tuning fork, a glass, a brass coin box, a plastic rainbow, and pot of gold give the act great variety while the central prop of coins gives it great unity.

In an all-cards act you may do one effect using the full deck, another effect using only a small packet, another in which cards are laid out in a pattern on the table (such as “Wild Card” or an ace assembly), a trick like “Card Warp” which uses only two cards, and one or more effects in which the deck itself is transformed (such as a version of “The Color Changing Deck,” “All Backs,” “Micro Macro” or my own effect “The Lucky Deck” in which faces are printed on a blank deck). Once again you have great visual variety without abandoning the “one prop” concept.

Dramatic Structure

Here is perhaps the most important area in which to inject variety.

Something as simple as doing tricks of different lengths is very helpful. Combine one or two long tricks, one or two short tricks, and one or two of intermediate length and you'll give the audience a refreshing sense of variety.

I talked earlier of the danger of doing too many tricks that rely on surprise for their impact. Instead, you can achieve variety by combining some tricks that create strong surprise with some that create strong suspense. Similarly, you can combine some effects that have a single climax with others that have multiple climaxes.

In these various ways you can inject considerable variation into even the most strongly unified act. Just what methods you choose to create variety, like what methods you choose to achieve unity, are artistic decisions only you can make. Achieving the balance between the two elements is a must. Understanding the many ways possible for doing so is a matter of technique. Deciding just how you're going to do it is a matter of your artistic vision and will result in an act that is uniquely yours.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN: THE INFORMAL PERFORMANCE

“Most magicians when they perform close-up magic simply improvise as they go along. One trick follows another as they think of it. Sometimes the intimate show builds to a climax. More usually the last trick is the least impressive of all, and is the last because it happens to be the last trick the performer thinks of.”

Milbourne Christopher

If you don't do magic for a living, you might feel that most of what you've read so far about constructing an act is of little use to you. You don't perform a formal act; you just do a few tricks for your friends now and then. If you want those informal performances to be as powerful as possible, you have to make sure they follow all the principles of routining we've discussed so far. Even the most improvised performance must be structured as an act to be really effective.

The biggest difference between formal and informal performance is that, in the informal performance, you don't know just how long it's going to last. Usually, you decide from the reaction you're getting and the interest people are showing just how long you should keep going.

In such a case, the first thing to do is to settle in your mind what effect you're going to use as your opener and what effect you're going to use as your closer. I suggest you go through your repertoire right now and classify certain effects as openers and others as closers. Naturally, these selections will be based on how well the effects meet the criteria for openers and closers that we've discussed. All the remaining effects, of course, become “middle tricks.”

Now when you're faced with the prospect of doing an off-the- cuff

performance you can immediately mentally run through your openers and select one, then mentally run through your closers and select one. Once you've settled on those, you can play it by ear in selecting the middle effects. Of, course, as you go along you should strive to pick ever stronger tricks throughout the middle section. Once you've decided it's time to wrap things up, cut right to your closer. You'll find this a much more effective approach than the completely unstructured approach derided by Milbourne Christopher in the quotation above.

As I mentioned last chapter, I also think it's a good idea to organize the material in your repertoire into acts even if you never perform the effects in this way. It's an exercise that will help you better understand proper act construction. It will also help you better understand what slot each of the effects in your repertoire is best suited for. You'll find these insights very helpful when deciding what to do next during an informal performance.

The fact is that most informal performances are not completely unforeseen. You usually realize in advance when you're going somewhere that you may be asked to perform. In such cases, you should construct an act in your mind of the length you think you'll want to perform if you're asked. Also identify one or two of the middle effects that you can jettison if, when the time comes, you decide you should shorten things. This gives you the combination of flexibility and structure you need in such cases.

Finally, you may want to put together a short act—I suggest three tricks in length—that you can perform anytime, anywhere. This is for those occasions when you're unexpectedly asked to perform and your mind goes blank. Naturally, you construct this short act along the principles we've discussed. The first trick is one that works well as an opener. The last trick is one that works well as a closer. And the middle trick is one that ensures proper build from the opener to the closer.

One thing that is far more likely to happen in an informal performance than a formal one is that, after you've finished, you may be asked to do one more. This may, for example, be for the benefit of someone who has just joined the group. Or you may simply decide yourself that one more effect is called for.

This can create a problem with build. After you've just done an effect that you specifically chose as a closer because it's impossible to follow, how do you do an encore without it coming off as anti-climactic?

One solution is to decide in advance on a possible encore item. At the same time that you settle on your opener and closer, decide on another effect, at least as strong as the closer, that you'll use as an encore if the situation calls for it.

Another solution is to follow this rule: the way to follow an unfollowable effect (whether it was performed by you or by another magician) is to perform a trick so different from the previous one that it defies comparison. Suppose, for example, that your closer was a really strong gambling routine or other display of skill. A good encore item might be a completely hands-off trick like "Out of this World." Not only is this a very strong trick, but it's so different that the audience can't compare the two. They have to take each on its own merits. For this reason, the opposite would work just as well; a really strong gambling routine can follow "Out of this World."

Every performance of more than one trick is an act and has to be structured as such if it's to play as strongly as possible. Even if you never hope to perform at The Magic Castle, you should study the principles of proper act construction. Understanding them will help you in every performance.

Part Four: The Audience

“I always take the audience into account.”

Alfred Hitchcock

CHAPTER FIFTEEN: AUDIENCE-TESTING

“The first principle is that you must not fool yourself—and you are the easiest person to fool.”

Richard Feynman

Magicians And Consensus Reality

I vividly recall a card effect I saw as a teenager one of the first times I ever visited Tannen's Magic Shop. The effect was that a spectator selected one of six cards dealt in a row and the performer showed that he had successfully predicted the card. I was singled out as the spectator to make the selection.

The demonstrator asked me to name a number from one to six. I chose six. He then spelled the word “six,” pointing to one card on each letter, and pushed the third card toward me. “Amazing,” I thought “How could he possibly have known that the reason I said six was that I really wanted the third card? Of course, if I had actually wanted the sixth card I would have said, 'e-l-e-v-e-n.' “

“Consensus reality” is a term used by some political scientists to refer to a situation in which every member of a culture subscribes to a belief. Because there is no one in the culture to question the belief it's accepted as reality even though it may not reflect objective reality at all. One's beliefs are never put to the test; rather, they are continually reinforced by the fact that everyone else one comes into contact with also shares the belief. Consensus reality is, in effect, a shared psychosis.

The world of the amateur magician is a world ruled by consensus reality. In this Alice-in-Wonderland world everyone accepts unquestioningly that two cards held together in anything even

remotely resembling alignment will always be accepted as one card and that a block of four cards is indistinguishable from a single card. Similarly, all believe that if you perform a Hindu shuffle until a spectator says “stop” then show him the bottom card of the deck, he will believe that he has had a free choice.

The Blind Leading The Blind

The source of this consensus reality problem is the fact that magicians rely primarily on other magicians for guidance on what constitutes strong magic. The fact is that when another magician gives you his opinion about whether a trick you've just done for him would be strong for laypeople he is really just telling you whether he personally liked the trick. I need hardly point out that this is less than useless in determining whether laypeople will like it.

There is a great deal of interesting literature about the psychological mechanisms people use to rationalize their prejudices when faced with contrary evidence. The way magicians cling to their preconceived notions of what constitutes effective showmanship could provide an interesting case study in this field.

A striking example can be found on the Al Koran “Magicassette.” The tape consists primarily of soundtracks of Koran performing various effects on television. But it also contains an introduction by Goodliffe. In it, Goodliffe observes more than once that Al Koran lacked showmanship. Apparently, this is based on Goodliffe's judgment that Koran wasn't as bombastic as he feels a mentalist should be. My own feeling is that the performances that follow Goodliffe's preamble evidence outstanding showmanship.

However, my goal here is not to contrast my opinion with Goodliffe's. What matters is that, on the tape, one can clearly hear Koran receiving very strong audience reactions—gasps, applause, laughter—to his effects. Yet this fact did not lead Goodliffe to consider revising his opinions about what constitutes effective showmanship. In his view, Koran wasn't a strong mentalist because he didn't present mentalism the way Goodliffe happened to believe it should be presented, and the audience's reaction be damned.

Even magicians who are themselves strong showmen often have

unfounded prejudices about what constitutes good showmanship. The problem is that they know what works for them, but often can't recognize that a very different approach could work for someone else.

The moral is: when it comes to showmanship, don't listen to magicians; listen to your audiences. Don't even listen to this book—at least, not uncritically. Test the concepts discussed in it before lay audiences and evaluate the results. In the language of pop psychology, this is called reality testing. If more magicians would reality-test what they *think* they know about showmanship, it could put an end to magical consensus reality.

Commercial Sense

It would seem to follow that all you really have to do to determine what effects will play strongly for you is to try everything out in front of real audiences of laypeople and just forget about all this theory stuff. And, if you had unlimited amounts of time available for performing and for readying new material for performance, and also had unlimited access to eager audiences, this would be the answer.

Of course, none of us, not even professional performers, have the time to audience-test every trick that could conceivably prove to be an effective item for us. When you buy a new magic book you just can't try out every trick in the book on an audience to determine which ones they like.

That's why the single most important quality you must develop as a performer is what I call commercial sense. Gambling cheats and con men use the term “grift sense” to mean the instinct that every good hustler has for recognizing moneymaking opportunities, knowing what scams will be most effective, and how to best work a particular con. In the same way, every successful magical performer eventually develops an instinct for what effects, methods, and presentations will work best for him.

A good Broadway producer has a strong commercial sense in that he can watch a new play alone in a theater and predict whether it will be a hit. Over time, he has developed that insight into what the

public likes. The only difference between that kind of commercial sense and the kind you have to develop is that you need an insight, not only into what kinds of things audiences like, but particularly what kinds of things audiences like when *you* perform them. Thus, as a magician, your commercial sense must be a combination of insights into the nature of audiences and insights into your own strengths and weaknesses.

In large part, commercial sense is merely a matter of developing objectivity. You must be able to separate your own reactions to an effect from the audience's reaction. This is something most magicians seem incapable of doing (witness the Goodliffe example). As soon as you start to realize that the fact that you like an effect doesn't necessarily mean you should add it to your repertoire, you'll have taken a big step in the right direction. As soon as you start to realize that the fact that a trick fooled you doesn't necessarily mean it's a good trick and the fact that a trick didn't fool you doesn't necessarily mean it's a bad trick, you'll have taken a big step in the right direction.

Feedback

The key to developing a commercial sense is learning from audience reactions. In order to learn from audience reaction you must first notice that reaction and, secondly, properly interpret its significance.

The first step, noticing that the audience has reacted in some way, would seem easy enough, but many magicians seem incapable of it. I remember once sitting in a bar with a magician who started telling me how much “fun” he'd been having performing Vernon's “Trick that Fooled Houdini.” This is the Ambitious Card performed with a double-backed card. Since this version doesn't offer any advantage over pure sleight-of-hand versions, I expressed some surprise. He then offered to show me what a strong trick it was.

In standard amateur-magician fashion, he turned to the strangers sitting next to him, a man and woman, intruded on their conversation, pulled out a deck of cards, and started doing the trick. He had the woman select a card. He then placed it under the top card of the deck (the double-backer), and did a double turnover to show that the card had jumped to the top. The woman reacted well.

However, when he repeated the process, she pointed to the double-backer and asked to see what it was. (No doubt, she didn't suspect that it was a double-backer, but did suspect that it was a duplicate of the ambitious card.)

The magician brushed aside her request with some double-talk and continued with the trick. From that moment on, the woman lost all interest in the effect. Her face became a stony mask and she barely paid any attention as the magician made the card rise to the top another half-dozen times. When he finally finished she turned away without comment and resumed her conversation with her companion.

I expected that the magician would now hit me with a barrage of excuses for why the trick had fallen flat. Instead, he turned to me with a broad smile and said, "See, it kills them every time!"

To this day it baffles me how he could have failed to see the boredom written on the woman's face and the fact that she barely tolerated the performance once he refused her request to see the top card. Presumably, he was having too much "fun" performing the trick to notice that no one else was having any.

In fact, many magicians seem to perform only for their own amusement. They probably wouldn't notice if their audience stood up and left half-way through the trick. Many other magicians have to struggle so much with the mechanics of the effect that they can't spare any attention for the audience. In both cases, the performer is too absorbed with what he is doing to notice audience reaction.

Therefore, the first step to developing commercial sense is to rehearse and master both the mechanics and the presentation of your effects so totally that you can largely ignore them during performance and concentrate instead on how your audience is reacting to what you're doing.

There are also a number of things you can do to help sensitize yourself to audience feedback. I strongly recommend that you study books on non-verbal communication, commonly known as body language. This will help you pick up subtle, unconscious cues from your audiences. (Most magicians would be particularly well-advised to memorize the non-verbal signals for boredom.)

I also recommend you get into the habit of paying particular attention to people's eyes. There is no greater clue to what people are thinking. A glance in a certain direction at a particular moment can reveal volumes about what is going through a person's mind if you are sensitive to it. (Of course, your own eyes can reveal a great deal to others about what you're thinking, which is why the performer's eyes play such an important role in misdirection.) Watching people's eyes can be particularly useful in helping you determine whether people are really fooled and what unvoiced suspicions they may be harboring.

Debriefing

I recommend that every time you perform for laypeople you followup with a debriefing session. Quite simply, this means reviewing the performance in your mind to see what you can learn from it. At the first opportunity you have to be alone after the performance, mentally replay the entire performance. See the whole thing in your mind's eye. Note every bit of audience feedback you received. Recall every reaction you got or failed to get at every point in every trick.

Pay particular attention to the reactions (or lack of reactions) that surprised or puzzled you. You may even want to note them on a piece of paper. It is these unexpected events that offer the best learning opportunities. When an audience reacts exactly the way you expected, it's gratifying and reassuring. But it's when they don't do the expected that you have a chance to learn. Psychologists call such experiences "expectation failure." Every time you experience expectation failure during a performance you should seize it as an opportunity to increase your insights into audience psychology.

These "surprising" audience reactions may consist simply of an effect playing more strongly than expected, or less strongly than expected, or a laugh coming at point where you didn't expect a laugh, or of the audience's reaction of amazement coming at a different point in the effect than you expected, or of a spectator making a comment during or after a trick that wasn't at all the kind of comment you expected, perhaps a comment that didn't even make any sense to you.

Having noted *how* the audience reacted, you must now strive to understand *why* they reacted that way. Understanding why is vital to developing a commercial sense. Just noting how people reacted to the tricks you performed is of some value. It will help you know what to expect the next time you perform those same tricks. But your goal should be much greater. You not only want to know how people react to the tricks you perform, you want to be able to predict with a high degree of accuracy how they would react to a given effect that you've never performed if you were to do it. It's that predictive ability that is the essence of commercial sense. And that comes from understanding why you get the reactions you get.

In reviewing any unexpected reactions, try to put yourself in the audience's place. What were they thinking that might have provoked such a reaction? Like a good psychiatrist, you should always be asking yourself, "Hmm, what did he really mean by that?"

Your starting premise in this psychological detective work should be that the audience always has a good reason for anything they say or do, although that reason may not be immediately clear to you. If someone offers an explanation for one of your tricks that obviously couldn't be correct, you have to recognize that it's not obvious *to him*. You may want to think about altering the presentation to underscore more forcefully that the trick couldn't be done in the way suggested.

Having said all that, I must admit that once in a great while you'll encounter a strange comment from a spectator who is simply exceptionally stupid or pigheaded. You can't drive yourself crazy over such things. My own rule of thumb is that if I get a truly unfathomable comment from a spectator I mentally file it away without worrying about it. However, if at any time in the future I receive the same comment about the same trick from someone else, I know I have to deal with the problem. If two people make a particular observation about your magic, you can be sure others in the audience are thinking the same thing although they may not come up to you and say it.

Performing Experience

You can't engage in audience-testing without an audience. This

poses a problem for most amateur magicians. The average non-professional simply doesn't have an outlet for his performing needs. Consequently, he drives his poor wife crazy making her watch each new trick and performs for his fellow amateurs at the magic club, neither of which will make him a better entertainer. (Indeed, spending too much time performing for other magicians can be very harmful. They'll give you plenty of feedback but it will be very different from what you would receive from laypeople. As such it will only hamper your efforts to develop a strong commercial sense.)

This leads me to the most important advice I can give you in this book. If you're serious about your magic, find a place where you can perform regularly for laypeople. Do volunteer work, entertaining at hospitals. Or find a local tavern, become a regular, and get known for your magic. Before long, every time you enter the bar someone will ask you to do a trick.

Many amateur magicians have been successful in finding a restaurant where the management will pay them a modest fee to do table-to-table magic one or two nights a week. Offer to do it for free if you have to. (Some professional restaurant magicians will hate me for saying that, but you won't be a threat to any really capable professionals. Besides, how do you think *they* became professional restaurant magicians in the first place?)

A number of years ago, my friend Bob Elliott realized he needed more experience performing for laypeople. He offered to work behind the counter at Tannen's Magic Shop one day a week for free just for the experience. Between pitches, he would do some of his own tricks for customers. (No matter what anyone tells you, most magic shop customers are laypeople.) Within months, the improvement in his performing abilities was dramatic. It may not be easy but, if you're serious about your magic, you will succeed in finding a forum where you can regularly perform for laypeople.

Because of the problem of limited performing opportunities, I think the debriefing exercise I described earlier, with its analysis of expectation failures, is of particular value to the amateur. A professional gets so many chances to perform that he is bound to get better almost in spite of himself. After a few hundred

performances, it has to become obvious to even the densest performer that one approach is playing better than another, that this trick is strong and that one is dying, that people react well whenever he does this or says that.

If you're an amateur magician with limited performing opportunities, you have to be a fast learner. You have to extract more insights out of fewer performances if you're going to improve. I believe that study on your part combined with the advice I'm providing in this book can make your limited performing opportunities more educational.

As Aldous Huxley said, "Experience is not what happens to you; it is what you do with what happens to you." No book by itself can make you a better showman. But performing experience combined with a good book can teach you faster than experience alone. You've got the book in your hands; find yourself a performing forum and get to work.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN: THE TIME ELEMENT

One factor that may not seem very important when first rehearsing a new effect or act but that hits home very fast as soon as you start performing the material for audiences is the importance of *time*. Exactly when something happens, how long it takes, and how fast it occurs, all have a tremendous effect on how an audience will react to it. In theater, these elements are called timing, pacing, and tempo.

1. Timing

“There is correct timing and incorrect timing, effective timing and ineffective timing, obvious timing and timing which is performed with such skill and ease that only the most trained observers are aware of it; but there is always timing.”

F. Cowles Strickland, *The Technique of Acting*

What Is Timing?

Timing is one of the most important subjects in magic. Judging from the magic literature it would also appear to be one of the most mysterious. How many times have you read that a certain move “depends on timing” only to find that the writer immediately drops the subject just when you were looking for more guidance? Most magic writers treat timing as if it were too elusive and ephemeral a subject to permit explanation. While timing can be very difficult to learn, it's quite easy to understand. As with most matters of technique, the better you understand it, the faster you'll learn it.

Lets start with a definition: *Timing is the time relationship between, two different things*. Sounds simple, doesn't it? Yet this simple definition is the key to understanding the entire subject. Once you

grasp that timing is always a matter of the time relationship between two things, every timing problem in magic is easily analyzed. It becomes simply a matter of identifying the two elements involved and experimenting with every possible time relationship between them: performing A and B at the same time, performing A before B, performing B before A, and varying the length of time that elapses between A and B.

Timing is so central to magic that it touches almost every aspect of a performance: sleights, misdirection, and patter. Let's take some examples from each category to see how our definition applies.

Timing In Sleight Of Hand

There are many sleights which depend to a greater or lesser degree on timing to achieve the proper illusion. In sleight of hand, timing almost always means the time relationship between an action performed by the left hand and another action performed by the right hand. A few examples should clarify this.

Consider the “toss vanish” of a coin popularized by Al Goshman. The right hand pretends to toss its coin into the left hand. Actually, nothing really happens. The coin is retained in the right hand; the hands only mime the action of tossing and catching.

From a strictly technical standpoint, nothing could be easier. Yet, the move does take practice to master. The reason is provided by Goshman on his videotape *Magic by Gosh*, where he teaches the move, describing it as “a timing thing.” Although he doesn't elaborate, he is almost certainly referring to the time relationship between the tossing motion of the right hand and the catching motion of the left hand.

In this case there is no question of which action should come first; the toss must precede the catch. Yet the beginner, fearful of being caught, is likely to rush through the move, performing both actions simultaneously. Unless people are willing to believe that the coin can travel at the speed of light, this approach will lack conviction. Conversely, if too much time elapses between the throwing action and the catching action it will be apparent to the audience that nothing traveled from hand to hand.

The goal here is to allow a time lapse between the throw and the catch that exactly matches the length of time it would really take a coin to travel from one hand to the other. That can be determined by really tossing a coin from one hand to the other.

The shuttle pass popularized by David Roth is another coin move dependent on timing. In this case, the right hand pretends to transfer a coin to the left. Actually the coin is retained in the right hand while the left hand brings into view a different coin previously palmed there. The action of the two hands must be coordinated so that the second coin is brought into view neither too soon nor too late. If the time relationship between the actions of the two hands is just right, the original coin almost seems never to have gone out of sight.

The retention vanish of a coin is yet another good example of the need for split-second timing in the relationship between right-hand action and left-hand action. In this case, the right hand starts to place a coin in the left hand but secretly withdraws the coin just as the left fingers close. The critical time relationship here is between the closing of the left fingers and the retraction of the coin by the right fingers. If the right-hand retraction begins before the left fingers are adequately closed, the withdrawal of the coin will be visible. If the right-hand retraction starts too long after the left fingers close, the visual retention illusion is lost.

Almost every card magician has heard that the strike second deal is dependent on timing to achieve the right illusion. I doubt if one in a hundred understands what that means. Yet, the concept is really very simple. You have to coordinate the time relationship between the actions of the two thumbs, the left thumb in pushing over the top card and the right thumb in striking the second card.

The common error is to push the top card over too long before the striking action. Actually, the left thumb should not push over the top card until the merest instant before the right thumb contacts the deck. In this way, the push-over action is invisible to the viewer (hidden behind the right thumb) and it appears that the top card is the only one the right thumb could have contacted. Of course, if you wait too long before starting the push-off, you'll end up really dealing the top card.

The second deal provides an example of where the timing goal is very easy to understand but very difficult to achieve. However, if you don't first understand the timing concept involved you'll never achieve the desired illusion no matter how many years you practice.

The classic force provides a very unusual example of timing in sleight of hand because it does not involve the time relationship between right-hand action and left-hand action, but rather the time relationship between the action of the spectator's hand and those of the performer's hands.

You begin to spread the deck and the spectator reaches for a card. Just as the spectator's fingers are about to close on a card, you spread the deck further, leaving the force card invitingly just under her fingers. If your spreading action is performed too late (while the spectator's hand is too close to the deck), it will be apparent that you shoved a particular card into her hand when she was already reaching for a different card. If, instead, your spreading move to position the force card is performed too soon (while the spectator's hand is too far from the deck), it will provide her with time to change direction and reach for a different card.

Understanding these things doesn't mean you'll get it right the first time you try. But understanding how timing works in sleight of hand will make it easier for you to solve timing problems and to experiment with different timing approaches until you hit on the one that works best. After that, it's just a matter of practice.

Timing In Misdirection

In cases of misdirection it's easy to identify the two elements that have be coordinated. They are the misdirective action designed to draw the audience's attention and the secret action intended to go unnoticed. This often involves the time relationship between right-hand action and left-hand action, as when one hand openly removes a card from the pocket as the other hand performs a one- hand palm of the top card of the deck. Another example is when one hand holds up a visible coin as the other hand laps a palmed coin.

However, misdirection may instead involve coordinating an action of a spectator with an action of the performer. When a spectator is

directed to do something, his activity usually holds not only his own attention but also that of the other spectators. Therefore, you may choose to use an action of the spectator as misdirection to cover your own secret action.

An interesting aspect of timing in misdirection is that of staggered motion which we will analyze in the Attention Control chapter.

Timing In Patter

Timing in presentation means timing your patter for maximum emotional impact. We've already learned that timing always involves the time relationship between two things. In patter delivery, timing always means either the time relationship between a patter line and an accompanying action or the time relationship between two patter lines.

Patter and Action: Correct timing between a patter line and an action is often important either because the action provides humorous commentary on the patter line or because it provides a comedic or ironic punctuation to the patter line.

Here is an example of the first situation. Suppose you say, "Gee, I've never played cards before," and at the same time you perform a fancy one-handed shuffle. This will get a chuckle, or at least a smile, from the audience because the fancy shuffle throws an ironic light on your statement. Yet, if you perform the shuffle a few moments after delivering the line, the effect won't be as strong. And if you perform the shuffle a few moments *before* the delivering the line, the entire effect will be lost.

Let's look at the principle involved in this example. Incongruity is one of the keys to comedy. In magic, sometimes that incongruity comes from the contrast between what you're saying and what you're doing, for example, a protestation of naiveté combined with a display of skillful card handling. But the two have to be coordinated so as to throw the incongruity into sharp focus.

Now I'll give you an example from my own repertoire of an action acting as comedic punctuation to a patter line. In one effect I cut to an ace and then cut to a second ace. I then give the deck a couple of shuffles. As I do so I say, "That should make it almost impossible for

anyone to know where the third ace is.” I then continue, “I’m not saying it’s *totally* impossible, but it’s almost impossible.” On the word “totally” I do a slip cut and the third ace appears face up on top of the deck. This always gets a laugh from the audience.

I know from experience that if I produce the ace a second before or a second after the word “totally” the effect won’t be as strong. The action punctuates the statement. It has to occur exactly on the key word in the statement to achieve the desired result.

What these examples make clear is that you can’t count on the audience to automatically see a connection between what you’re saying and what you’re doing. They will see the connection only if the two things are coordinated in such a way as to make the connection obvious. *Your goal in timing actions and patter is to make these connections for the audience.*

No number of examples will automatically lead you to correct timing in your own work. You’ll still have to experiment to find the timing that gives you the best results in any given case. But experimentation combined with an understanding of the principles involved will give you results faster than blind experimentation alone. And appreciating the importance of timing will certainly produce results faster than proceeding blithely unaware that the issue even matters (which is the situation most magicians find themselves in).

Patter and Patter: For that reason, I also want to take a look at the considerations that underlie properly timing patter lines with one another. There are two variations of this issue that you’ll have to deal with. The first is timing a patter line you deliver with the patter line that preceded it. The second is timing a patter line of yours with a comment made by a spectator.

When it comes to timing patter, there is no issue of which line should come first; this will usually be obvious. You also don’t have to consider whether the two lines should be delivered simultaneously. The only question is how much time should elapse between one line and another.

If you haven’t had much performing experience, you might not think that such a small matter could make much difference. But

every seasoned performer knows that, particularly when you're going for a laugh, the presence or absence of a pause, or the length of a pause before delivering a punchline, can make the difference between hearty laughter and stony looks.

Here are some of the factors involved. First, audiences take a certain amount of time to absorb information. If the success of line B is dependent on the audience having fully absorbed the implications of line A, you'd better make sure they've had enough time to do so before you deliver line B.

Second, when you pause, it may imply that you're thinking during that pause, or that a certain thought has taken some time to strike you. That implication may or may not be desirable for the impact of the next line you're going to deliver.

Finally, timing humorous patter relates to the issue of killing a laugh. You say something funny and the audience laughs. In the normal course of events, they'll laugh until they've gotten it out of their system. But if you start talking while they're still laughing, they'll stop laughing in order to hear what you've got to say. Therefore, through poor timing you can deprive yourself of laughs you've earned.

However, it's strange but true that if you allow an audience to laugh until they're completely satisfied, you'll find it a little tougher to get them to laugh again a moment later. If you cut off the laughs just before they're finished, you leave the audience slightly unfulfilled and you'll find it a little easier to trigger laughter a moment later. That's why generally the best approach is to wait until the laughter has passed its peak, then kill it by starting to talk just before the laughter would have ended of its own accord. This is one of the secrets good comedians use to “get on a roll.”

Learning Timing

It's certainly true that you can only learn timing through actual performing experience. This is because you need audience feedback and constant reinforcement to perfect your timing. (That's also why timing is the first thing to get rusty when you take a layoff from performing.)

You'll find larger audiences are particularly good for perfecting timing. Because of the larger size, all the audience reactions are amplified, making it easier for you to detect nuances in reaction or lack of reaction which you can use to fine-tune your timing.

It's also true that you won't automatically learn timing from experience alone. The fastest and surest way to learn is by combining experience with an understanding of the underlying dynamics of timing. This will allow you to experiment with different timing approaches and also to more quickly recognize when you have a timing problem or when you've accidentally hit upon a particularly good hit of timing. Helping you achieve that understanding is what this subchapter has been all about.

2. Pacing

"In life you can be boring; on stage you cannot afford to be boring even for an instant."

Stella Adler

What Is Pacing?

Pacing is by far the most important aspect of time in a performance because pace is the way the audience actually experiences time in their minds during the show. And as we've seen again and again, all that really matters is what happens in the audience's mind.

Here is my definition of pace: *the audience's perception of the speed of the performance—their subjective perception of the passage of time during the performance*. A fast-paced show is one in which the time seems to pass quickly; a slow-paced show is one in which the time seems to drag.

The word “seems” in the above statement is very important. We're talking here of how time seems to the audience, not how time is measured on a clock. As F. Cowles Strickland has pointed out in *The Technique of Acting*: “The duration of a minute seems to vary according to what one is experiencing during that minute. The last minute of a closely matched football game may seem unendurably long to the rooters on one side of the field, but unimaginably short

to the rooters on the other side.”

If you doubt whether pacing is really an important factor in your performances, consider this. *Fast pacing is the single quality that most distinguishes professional magicians from amateur magicians.* Almost without exception, even the most accomplished and highly respected amateurs in close-up magic work at a pace too slow for professional performance. Almost without exception, even the worst professional magicians at least know enough to keep things moving fast enough to hold the audience's attention.

Amateurs can get away with slow pacing for several reasons. First, they're most often performing for friends who are more indulgent than strangers would be, or even worse, for other magicians who seem willing to sit through anything to see if they can catch the move.

Second, amateurs are also, more often than not, performing for a captive audience. In most professional close-up performing situations, the magician is competing with other diversions that the spectator is only too quick to turn to if his attention is not being held every instant.

Finally, because audiences don't expect professional caliber entertainment from amateurs, they'll often be more tolerant of slow pacing from them. But, make no mistake; whether you're a pro or an amateur, you'll garner much stronger audience reactions if you perform at a professional pace.

Pacing In Magic

Because pacing concerns the audience's subjective experience of time, pacing is not about talking fast or moving fast; pacing is about being interesting. Earlier we talked about how a magic effect can be divided into two parts, the expository phase and the magical phase. Pacing in magic is almost entirely concerned with keeping the expository phase interesting.

Magicians often speak of a trick being too long. Yet the length of a trick, in itself, has nothing to do with its entertainment value. It's not the actual length that's a problem, but rather the pacing. Almost invariably when magicians speak of a trick being too long they mean

that the expository phase drags.

Thus, an Ambitious Card routine may take twice as long as an ace assembly yet be much faster paced. A good Ambitious Card effect is almost non-stop magic. By contrast, an ace assembly may require a long process of laying out the cards before the ten seconds of magic occurs as the assembly is revealed. This doesn't mean that ace assemblies can't be strong magic. It does mean that an ace assembly will only be strong magic if you can keep the expository phase from dragging.

Another way of looking at pacing is the concept of dead time. Whenever what is happening holds no interest for the audience you have dead time. Pacing is about going over your performance to locate every second of dead time and ruthlessly eliminating it, like weeding a garden. Here are the most common causes of dead time and what you can do about them.

Pacing And Patter

“In your performance be sparing with words.”

J.N. Ponsin, *Nouvelle Magie Blanche Devoilee*

“Omit needless words.”

Strunk & White, *The Elements of Style*

Now we come to one of the most important pieces of advice on presentation I can give you: Don't talk too much! Given all the things you must strive to accomplish with your patter—clarify the effect, plant suggestions, create atmosphere, delineate character—you might understandably conclude that you're going to have to do a lot of talking. Nothing could be further from the truth, but it's an easy trap to fall into. Just as many films have been ruined by excessive reliance on dialogue at the expense of action, many magic effects are ruined by excessive reliance on patter at the expense of the magic

This is a failing you'll often see in cases of what might be termed new converts to showmanship. A magician who had previously concentrated solely on the sleight-of-hand aspects of magic decides

he is going to try to develop his presentational ability to match his digital skill. Before long, this formerly monosyllabic performer is talking up a storm. A trick that used to take him three minutes to perform now takes six minutes and may, in consequence, be even more boring. Some of the most prominent sleight-of-hand men in magic have fallen victim to this pitfall.

There are also those magicians who seem to have gotten into magic just as a means of trapping hapless spectators into listening to their endless rambling. The worst example of this kind of offender I ever encountered was an older gentleman, now deceased, who was a regular on the New York magic scene when I first discovered it at about the age of twenty.

The one trick he was most infamous for was the Houdini Card Trick. This was a two-card transposition between a king placed inside the card case and a queen outside the case. (At least, I think that's what the effect was.) His presentation concerned Harry and Bess Houdini performing the Substitution Trunk illusion. Whether this kind of patter theme really adds anything to a trick is open to question. However, in the case of this gentleman, the patter took on a life all its own that made the whole issue academic.

He would start by removing the king of spades from the deck and handing it out for examination. While the spectators were looking at the card he would begin to patter in a grave voice: "Harry Houdini, born Erich Weiss, grew up in the small town of Appleton, Wisconsin where young Erich had a normal childhood. His favorite sports were baseball and ice hockey . . ."

After about five minutes of this, he would remove the queen of spades from the deck, hand it out for examination, and launch into an equally riveting account of the early life of Bess Houdini. Twelve minutes into the trick the audience was no closer to seeing any magic. But, any spectator who had not yet lapsed into a coma would have absorbed enough information about Harry and Bess to write a biography rivaling Carl Sandburg's *The Life of Abraham Lincoln*.

It was one of my ambitions in magic in those days to eventually succeed in sticking it through to see just what the effect of this card trick was, but I confess I never did. My resolve would always give

out at about the point where Harry performed his famous elephant vanish at the old Hippodrome Theater in New York. Fortunately, the performer was always too absorbed in reciting Houdini's financial records to notice me slinking away. Thus, I never did see the conclusion of the Houdini Card Trick or, as I like to think of it, "The Trick That Cannot Be Endured."

How much patter is too much patter is partly a function of each individual performer's personality. It's important to remember, however, that people can tire very quickly of just listening to someone talk. Verbal diarrhea can completely destroy pacing.

Narrative vs. Background: At one time it was common practice for a novelist to take a break in the middle of his story to devote several pages to a philosophical discourse, a detailed description of a character, or even just a description of a house, room, or other physical setting. This approach is no longer in fashion. Today a writer is expected to develop any other concerns on his mind at the same time that he advances the plot. You should follow the same policy in your magic.

I stated at the outset that magic is a narrative art: every magic effect is a story. All information in storytelling falls into one of two categories, narrative and background. (Another word for background information is "exposition." However, since I'm using the term expository phase in this book to mean something else, I'll avoid it here to prevent confusion.) Anything that carries the story forward is narrative: any information that is necessary to properly understand the story is background.

If the hero kills an assailant with his bare hands in one scene, that is narrative. However, in order to prepare you for that scene the author may have had to mention beforehand that the hero is an ex-green beret whose training made him capable of killing a man with his bare hands. This information is background. Physical descriptions, information about the setting of the story, biographical data on the characters, and descriptions of events that occurred before the story began all constitute background. In general, *fast pacing means concentrating on narrative and keeping background to a minimum*. This applies to magic as much as to any other narrative form.

Any explanations you have to provide in order for the audience to appreciate the effect constitute background. Such background information can often enhance the impact of an effect. It may, for example, create atmosphere or help develop your character. A certain amount of background may even be essential to the success of a particular effect. However, if the presentation becomes top-heavy with background, it will almost certainly bore the audience.

You may have a great Bridge Deal and experience may show that it's more effective if you explain to the audience a couple of basic facts about the game of bridge. However, if you find that the only way they can appreciate the effect is if you first give them a five-minute lesson in how to play bridge, you're better off forgetting about the effect except when performing for bridge experts.

A good example of a trick that required a tremendous amount of background information for an audience to appreciate it is one I witnessed years ago in a magic convention close-up contest. The effect consisted of the performer demonstrating a box filled with wires that constituted an electrical circuit that apparently defied the laws of physics. Of course, most people are a little fuzzy on the laws of physics as they apply to electrical circuits. Therefore, before the magician performed his trick he gave the audience an in-depth lecture on how electrical circuits work. (I, for one, kept hoping the recess bell would ring so we could go out and play before class resumed.)

This was an absolutely hopeless magic effect. Without the background, it was incomprehensible. With the background it became intensely boring. To make matters worse, the audience just assumed that the magician was simply lying to them about how electrical circuits work so he could fool them with his trick. If an effect requires a great deal of background before an audience can understand it, you should probably forget the effect.

The more common problem is not an effect that requires a great deal of background, but the performer who feels compelled to provide tons of background, whether needed or not. A common example is the mentalist who can't do a trick with ESP cards without recounting to the audience the entire history of parapsychology research in the twentieth century. Similarly, some

magicians can't do a trick on an astrology theme without first giving the audience a ten-minute lecture on astrology.

I once witnessed a particularly memorable example of this problem when a verbose magician performing at a magic convention made the mistake of asking Howie Schwarzman to assist him in a trick. (Personally, I think this in itself evidenced a latent death wish on the performer's part.) I'll provide a slightly censored description of what happened.

The performer began by launching into a lengthy monologue about his close-up mat! (I swear I'm not making this up. I think it was supposed to be amusing.) After three or four minutes of this palaver, he performed his first magical effect: he produced a thimble. After the audience had recovered from this miracle, he launched into a discourse on the difference between logic and magic. (This was also, I suspect, intended to be amusing. I will admit that it was every bit as amusing as the monologue about his close-up mat.)

A mere two minutes or so more elapsed before the second magical effect: he vanished the thimble. Back he went to his sermon on logic vs. magic. He provided countless tongue-in-cheek examples of this distinction, every so often punctuating his filibuster by turning to Schwarzman and saying, "You know what I mean, Howie?"

Through it all, Schwarzman maintained a bored but long-suffering countenance. About ten minutes into the performance, without any more magic having occurred, the magician made the mistake of asking one time too many, "You know what I mean, Howie?" With a pained expression, Schwarzman looked at him and said, "Where's the f*****g thimble?"

Of course, how much background you can get away with depends in part on how interesting you can make it. Cy Endfield once did "Card Warp" for me. He prefaced it with a long explanation of the concept of the fourth dimension. He began by theorizing about what it would be like to live in a two-dimensional world of only length and width. This he illustrated by sliding cards around on the tabletop. He went on to explain how, if the flat inhabitants of such a world were to witness movement in the third dimension of depth, it would appear miraculous to them. They would be completely incapable of

comprehending what they were seeing, although to us it would be an everyday event. He illustrated this with a couple of hypothetical examples.

He then went on to talk about our three-dimensional world and explained what movement in the fourth dimension would appear like to us. I can sincerely say that I found all of this captivating. I was so fascinated that when he started to go into “Card Warp” I felt like saying, “Never mind that; tell me more about this multiple-dimension stuff.”

This performance inspired me to invoke the fourth dimension in my own version of “Card Warp.” Since I don't have Cy Endfield's skills as a science popularizer, the background in my presentation is somewhat briefer. Halfway through the trick I look up at the audience and say, “It has something to do with the fourth dimension; I don't know what exactly.”

The point to understand is not that background is bad. It isn't. But, rather, that allowing an imbalance to develop of background over narrative is bad. The audience must feel that the performance is constantly moving forward. If they feel that you're allowing things to grind to a halt while you give them a lecture, they'll quickly become bored.

A good guiding principle to remember is that an audience needs both something to listen to and something to watch at all times. With the exception of occasional brief introductory comments to set up the premise of a trick, you should seldom have cause to stop the action of an effect just to patter. Such a break in the action invariably means too much background. Talk and action should coincide. If you find that you are continually having to halt the progress of your performance to allow the patter to catch up with the trick, you're talking too much.

Patter is unquestionably your most important presentational tool, but it must be used artfully. To the list of all the other qualities your patter should possess, add *economy*. Like a good short story writer, you must make every word count. Every sentence and every phrase must be selected to accomplish the most in the least time.

Pacing And Business

Pacing can be hurt by actions as well as words. In theater, any actions performed on stage are referred to as business. Here we're concerned with actions that are time consuming and not very interesting to watch. This may include such activities as borrowing objects from the audience, having something signed by a spectator, having the deck shuffled by a spectator, counting a group of cards, or having a card selected by means of some lengthy procedure. When you find that some procedure in an effect is causing a lag in interest, you should do one of three things: eliminate the activity, shorten it, or make it interesting.

Eliminate: The first question to ask yourself about any such time-consuming activity is, "Is this really necessary?" The answer will usually concern the matter of conditions. Much time is wasted in close-up performances on activities that impose conditions on an effect that simply don't matter to the audience.

Before you take the time to borrow a handkerchief, ask yourself whether this particular trick would be any less effective if you saved time by using your own handkerchief. Before you take the time to have a playing card signed, ask yourself if this particular trick is really the kind in which the audience would be likely to suspect a duplicate if the card weren't signed. Before you have a spectator shuffle the deck at the start of a trick, ask yourself if this particular trick is one in which the audience would be inclined to suspect a setup if the deck weren't shuffled. Our earlier discussion on conditions, which ones matter to audiences and which don't, should help you answer these questions.

A particularly curious case of slow pacing you often see in close-up magic is the performer who insists on bringing the action of the effect to a dead stop so that he can engage in some "amusing" byplay that only he finds entertaining. A perfect example is the case I described earlier of the magician performing "Coins Through the Table" who insisted on preceding each penetration by forcing the spectators to join him in a protracted search for the elusive soft spot in the table.

Anyone who watches much close-up will encounter similar

situations where the performer forces a spectator to recite some nonsense or perform some silly ritual that embarrasses the spectator, bores the rest of the audience, and amuses only the performer himself. This is the “business” equivalent of the performer who gives the audience a long “whimsical” lecture on the difference between logic and magic when all they want to know is where the f*****g thimble is.

One word of caution, however. Pacing is very important, but it's not the only important element in your magic. Some magicians, in an effort to maximize pacing, will cut the expository phase of each effect to the bone. There is a danger in taking this approach too far. They've got to be totally convinced it's an apple before you change it into an orange.

Of all the important factors determining how strong your magic will be, the most important one is conviction. Generally speaking, what determines how strong the conviction will be is the expository phase. This does not at all mean that the *longer* the expository phase is the stronger the conviction will be. It does mean that cutting the expository phase too far can hurt conviction. Breakneck pacing at all costs risks producing trivial magic.

Shorten: As just indicated, sometimes the answer to the question, “Is this time-consuming activity really necessary?” is *yea*. In that case, the next step is to ask yourself, “Can I do it faster?” The answer to this question is almost always yes.

The key here is planning. Every step in an effect should be completely choreographed to eliminate wasted motion and, consequently, wasted time. You should know in advance exactly what procedure you're going to follow in putting away the previous effect's props and taking out the next effect's props in the most efficient manner possible. If you're planning to have a dollar bill signed, you should know in which pocket you have your pen so you don't have to waste the audience's time looking for it. If you don't plan even the smallest matters out in advance, you can be sure that the way you end up doing it in performance won't be the fastest and most efficient way possible.

Often a little thought in advance can save a lot of time during

performance. In one effect I do, I need to have the four queens signed. I have found that, rather than having one spectator sign all four queens I can save a little time by handing the red queens to one spectator and the black queens to another, having each one sign two queens. Of course, this means that I must make sure I'm carrying two pens and that I know exactly which pocket they're in.

Make It Interesting: If you find you can't shorten the activity, and sometimes even if you can, the final question to ask is, "Can I make it more interesting?" I made the point earlier that too much background can kill pacing and almost always results in boredom. However, a limited amount of interesting background definitely has its place in magic.

Many excellent effects have a certain amount of unavoidable dead time. The audience has to wait while a spectator shuffles the deck, counts off some cards, or signs his dollar bill. Such points are the best times for background. Giving the audience something interesting or humorous to listen to during such lulls in the action can help hold their interest and actually increase the pacing. The procedure may take just as long but the time will *seem* shorter to the audience.

Many close-up effects have a lag at the beginning as needed cards are culled from the deck or necessary props are brought out and arranged. This is the perfect time for interest-catching patter (intriguing statements, questions, inverted questions) of the kind discussed earlier.

You'll find humor extremely useful here. One or two funny lines or bits of business can go a long way toward covering a time lag. As long as the audience is laughing, you can be sure they're not bored.

In another effect where I need to have a spectator sign four of a kind I take a different approach to increasing the pacing. Instead of shortening the process by splitting the work between two spectators, I rely on humor. As the spectator starts to sign the cards, I point out that I've studied handwriting analysis. By the time I've finished saying this, she has finished signing the first card.

I pick up this card and make a couple of humorous remarks about what her signature supposedly reveals about her character. By the

time the audience has finished laughing (or at least smiling) the spectator has finished signing the rest of the cards. The process takes just as long but seems shorter to the audience.

Another effect I do is the “Nine–Card Location” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. The revelation of the nine selections is very strong for the audience. However, before the cards can be revealed, they first have to be selected and that takes a bit of time. To pick up the pacing I have a different humorous line I deliver as each card is noted. This patter actually makes the selection process slightly longer but also much more interesting.

A similar situation arises in the demonstration where I memorize a deck of cards. I close my eyes and have a spectator call out the name of each card as he deals through the deck. I could get through this part of the effect slightly faster if I myself dealt through the cards silently. But I've found that having a spectator call out the cards gives the audience something more interesting to watch, particularly since I get the rest of the audience involved by asking them to make sure the spectator doesn't make a mistake in calling out the cards. Because in pacing you're dealing with the audience's subjective perception of time, sometimes you have to make something a little longer in order to make it seem shorter.

Instead of humor, another technique you can sometimes use to make dead time interesting is suspense. Since I've already dealt with this at length, I won't go into detail here. I'll just refer you to the example I discussed in that section of using mystery-curiosity suspense to hold the audience's interest during the lengthy cutting process in “The Lazy Man's Card Trick.”

Finally, there is one last technique you can use to make a procedure interesting if you have enough strength of personality. Quite simply, treat the procedure as if it is very important. The audience takes its cue from you, the performer. They're often willing to assume that if you feel something is important it must be important. (That's why effects that involve more setting up should be saved for later in the performance. That way, the prestige you've built up during earlier miracles can help to convince the audience that the next miracle is worth waiting for.)

If something is time-consuming but essential, treat it as of vital significance. There is a good chance the audience will pay attention when they realize they must be watching something terribly important, even if they're not quite sure why.

A good example can be seen in the blindfold routine many mentalists perform. Often the expository phase (application of the blindfold) takes forever—layers of dough on top of coins covered with cotton taped down and wrapped with bandages covered with a sack. Yet a good mentalist can make this long process interesting to his audience just by treating each detail of the procedure as if it were a matter of life and death.

There you have the tools for keeping “business” from hurting the pacing of your performance. Eliminate it, shorten it, or make it more interesting through background information, humor, or suspense. If all else fails, make the audience pay attention through the sheer force of your personality. If you treat it as important, you have a good chance of getting them to see it as important.

Finally, remember that the key to pacing is planning. You have to map out everything in advance with a view toward keeping things moving. If you leave things to chance or play it by ear, you can be certain the performance will drag.

Pacing And Audience Participation

“When you work with people, you must be in control. If you cannot control, you do not belong on the stage.”

Al Koran, Lecture Notes of Fantastic Koran

In addition to what you say and do, there is one other factor that can affect the pacing of your performance, that is, what the spectator assisting you does and how long he or she takes to do it. Many performers when they ask a spectator to do something, whether it is to volunteer, shuffle the deck, select a card, or any other action, immediately abdicate control of the performance to the spectator until that action is completed. You can't expect laypeople to be sensitive to the demands of show business; therefore, you can expect the pacing of the performance to suffer whenever it's in their hands. When you perform, you must be in control every

second, even when the action shifts to someone else.

Having a spectator do something will almost always take longer than doing it yourself. Magicians often justify having spectators perform various inconsequential tasks on the grounds that it increases audience participation. Audience participation can be a very good thing, but I believe the only kind of participation that matters to an audience is having them do things that seem important. Having a spectator perform some menial task that you could have done yourself in half the time accomplishes nothing other than to deaden the pace of the effect.

Therefore, the first question to ask yourself is whether you really need to have a spectator perform this action. This in turn depends on whether having a spectator perform the action will *increase conviction*.

Suppose you're going to perform an ace assembly using the four aces and twelve indifferent cards. Audiences seldom suspect the use of extra indifferent cards in an ace assembly, so having the spectator count out the twelve cards is a waste of time. Do it yourself and things will move faster. However, if you are going to do a "Cards Across" effect, the fact that there are exactly twelve cards in each packet is crucial. In this case, having the spectators count out the twelve cards increases conviction.

If you decide it is necessary to have the spectator do something, you then have to figure out how to control the spectator's actions so that he or she does it the way you want him to at the speed you want him to do it. This is another matter that will require analysis, experimentation, and creativity on your part. But if you don't solve this problem in every spectator participation situation, your magic will suffer.

One effect I've seen ruined in this way almost every time I've seen it performed is the "Card on the Forehead." The performer palms the spectator's card and hands her the deck, telling her to remove her selection. While she is looking through the deck, he licks the card and sticks it to his forehead. The rest of the audience sees him do this and chuckles. They anticipate with glee the spectator's shocked reaction when she sees the card on his forehead.

The spectator finishes looking through the deck and doesn't find her card. Concluding that she must have bypassed it, she starts spreading through the cards again. At this point the audience's anticipation starts to wane and they just want her to see the card so that the magician will go on to something else.

At the end of the second run-through, the spectator still hasn't seen her card and is starting to feel a little embarrassed about her failure. She starts to spread through the deck a third time, this time quite slowly, determined not to miss her card again. By now, the rest of the spectators couldn't care less about the whole matter and are starting to talk among themselves. When eventually the assistant finally does look up and sees her card on the performer's forehead, what should have been a funny climax dies because of poor pacing.

The only performer I've ever seen satisfactorily solve this problem is Chicago's great bar magician, the late Heba Haba Al. As soon as the rest of the audience had a chance to see the card on his forehead, he would turn to the spectator who was searching through the deck for her card and say, "I think you passed it." Naturally, she does what people usually do when you talk to them; she looks up at the performer and, of course, sees her card. With one well-chosen patter line, Heba Haba Al completely controlled the timing of the trick's climax rather than leaving it in the spectator's uncertain hands.

Another good example is "Out of This World." It's a great trick, but sometimes you run into a spectator who wants to agonize for five minutes over every single card before dealing it in the red pile or black pile. This kills the pacing for any other spectators watching. I solve the problem with a simple patter line. When I see a spectator with this tendency, I say, "Your first impression is most likely to be right. Don't second-guess yourself out of the right decision. Go with your first impulse." In extreme cases, I might have to admonish her at some later point again to go with her first impulse. This always solves the problem and keeps the effect moving at a reasonable pace.

Striking A Balance

In this discussion, I've tried to make it clear that pacing is vitally important, but it's not the only important consideration. In fact,

that's what makes achieving good pacing such a challenge. Pacing is often in conflict with other important elements such as subtlety, conviction, characterization, and atmosphere. (For example, fantasy author Clark Ashton Smith once complained, “The problem is to develop adequate atmosphere in connection with fairly rapid action.”)

Indeed, pacing is one of the issues at the heart of the conflict between art and commercialism. Compare the pacing of an Ingmar Bergman film to the pacing of a Steven Spielberg film or the pacing of a Dostoyevsky novel to the pacing of a Robert Ludlum novel. Whatever you may think of them, you have to admit that Spielberg and Ludlum have much bigger audiences.

Throughout your career as a magical performer, you'll continually have to struggle to balance conflicting considerations: humor vs. mystery, suspense vs. emotional memory, pacing vs. everything else (and, of course, the one conflict that the hack magician worries about most, audience impact vs. ease of execution). When the conflict involves the issue of pacing, just remember this. You can't accomplish anything else if you don't have their attention. And you won't have their attention for long if your pacing is too slow.

3. Tempo

While timing concerns time coordination and pace involves the audience's subjective perception of time, tempo simply means how fast you actually work: how fast you move and how fast you talk. It's a very simple concept—so simple it's easy to overlook how much impact it can have on the effectiveness of your performance.

I vividly remember reading quite a few years ago the following statement in Al Goshman's lecture notes: “When struggling with a trick that doesn't seem to go over, try speeding it up or slowing it down, see if the change in tempo doesn't make it more effective.” At the time, I was still a law student and my interest in magic revolved mainly around methods. I'd had very little experience investigating the potentials of presentation.

Goshman's statement was a revelation to me. That something as seemingly irrelevant as the speed with which you performed a trick

could actually affect the audience's reaction to the trick seemed a radical idea. I decided to give it a try. Sure enough, I found that, in several cases. I could make a trick play better by performing it faster or slower than I usually did.

Almost twenty years later, I still find the exact reasons for this elusive. There is no doubt, however, that it's the case. I suspect that two factors are involved. One concerns the speed with which an audience can absorb information and experiences. The other concerns dramatic elements such as generating excitement or building mounting suspense.

Your natural tempo, the rate at which you normally tend to work, is an expression of your personal style. However, it's wise to vary this tempo from time to time both to provide the audience with variety and to derive maximum impact from a particular effect. This may involve changing your tempo from one effect to another or within a given effect.

The tempo should always be slow enough for people to understand what's going on. I remember seeing a well-known close-up magician perform "Spellbound" so fast that I literally could not focus on the coin long enough to tell when it was silver and when it was copper. If I hadn't already been familiar with the trick I wouldn't have realized that any magic had occurred. You should never perform faster than the audience can absorb it visually or intellectually.

It is sometimes effective, however, to perform faster than the audience can absorb it *emotionally*. I find that in effects that involve nonstop visual magic, it can be very effective to emotionally overwhelm the audience by performing rapidly.

In "Darwin's Aces" from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* the four aces vanish in a very direct, visual manner, one right after the other. I perform these vanishes with almost no pause between them. Just as the audience is starting to wonder where the first ace went to, they're hit with the fact that a second one has vanished also. Before they can recover from that vanish, they have to cope with the fact that the third ace has also disappeared. No sooner has this begun to register than the fourth ace evaporates.

The entire sequence keeps the audience off-balance from beginning

to end. It's like a good boxer keeping his opponent on the ropes with a series of punches. The trick is to land each new blow before he has completely recovered from the previous one.

In certain other visual effects I've found it very effective to start slowly and build up speed with each new phase. I use this in the first phase of "Jumping Gemini" from the same book. This first phase is an Ambitious Card sequence with a small packet of cards. Each time the card jumps to the top I speed up a little until the audience is overwhelmed by it all. (This is also an example of something we talked about earlier, accelerating tempo to create a sense of progression.)

In both of these tricks I've also found it very effective to slow down, practically coming to a dead stop, just before the grand climax. You can practically hear the audience catching its breath when the roller coaster finally comes to a halt. But like on a real roller coaster, the pause comes just before the biggest drop. Or, to go back to our boxing metaphor, the flurry of blows stops just before the knockout punch.

While these examples show the way tempo can affect an audience's reaction to the magic, they don't offer any ironclad rules. There are other effects, superficially similar to the two above, where I've found that working almost in slow motion gets the best response. The only real answer is to experiment with different tempos for different effects, gauging the audience's reaction each time.

In the end, Goshman's words are still the best advice: "When struggling with a trick that doesn't seem to go over, try speeding it up or slowing it down, see if the change in tempo doesn't make it more effective." The first step is appreciating the fact that a change in tempo can make a big difference in audience reaction.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN: IMMEDIACY

Planned Spontaneity

“Spontaneity is not a kind of easy, spur-of-the-moment facility that an actor has, but rather is a state of possibility engendered by comprehensive preparation.”

Brian Bates, *The Way of the Actor*

The essence of successful close-up magic and indeed of all live entertainment is the feeling that you are experiencing something now that you would not experience if you had come to the performance yesterday or if you came tomorrow—that you are experiencing something that has never happened before and will never happen again, at least not in exactly this way, and something that you are lucky to be a part of. This is a very difficult quality to pinpoint, but there is no doubt that all the greatest live entertainers succeed in imparting this feeling to their audiences.

I once read a revealing profile of Las Vegas entertainer Wayne Newton in *Atlantic City* magazine. The writer pointed out that every time he had seen his show, Newton said to the audience part way through the performance that the show was running overtime, “But you're such a great audience that I'll do one more number.” He would then do two or three more numbers. Then he would glance at his watch and make some comment about how the showroom manager must be having a fit because the show was going so overtime. Then he would do one or two more songs. Again, he would look at his watch and say in mock horror, “Ooooh boy. You know we are so far overtime that . . . IT JUST DOESN'T MATTER ANYMORE!”

By now, the audience would be going wild, cheering for this wonderful man who was willing to defy the powers-that-be to give them an extra measure of entertainment. Each of them was no doubt thinking how lucky he was to be there on the one night that Wayne Newton decided to go all out.

The writer of this piece went on to state, “And yet each of the twelve shows I saw started and ended at the exact same time *on the dot*.” Furthermore, the “adlib” comments about running overtime came at exactly the same point in each show. Newton's show actually ran like clockwork and every audience got exactly the same performance. But every audience left feeling they had gotten something no other audience got. The fact that Wayne Newton is one of the most successful entertainers in the history of Las Vegas might just mean that he's onto something here.

Since each of your audiences will, in fact, be getting essentially the same show, how do you make them feel that this performance is something special? A former student of mine has a cute patter line. Whenever some minor mishap occurs such as accidentally dropping a card, he says, “That's just an example of planned spontaneity.” This oxymoronic phrase is actually the key to making every performance special for the audience. There must be a certain sense of spontaneity in the performance. However, to ensure that the performance is a success, it must be *planned* spontaneity. As the Wayne Newton example makes clear, it may even be carefully calculated, precisely engineered spontaneity.

Induced Responses

Recently, I saw a TV special by one of the world's leading illusionists. When he came out at the start of the show he spotted a young lady sitting in the first row with a large pair of binoculars. The performer called the young lady over, borrowed the binoculars, and engaged in some amusing, off-the-cuff byplay before sending her back to her seat. Friends who've seen this illusionist's touring show in various cities assure me that this little exchange occurs at the start of each performance. It is, in fact, the ultimate example of planned spontaneity, the use of a stooge to create a special moment for the audience.

In Nate Leipzig's act, there was a point where he would hold his hand as if it contained a palmed card. One of the members of the committee on stage would grab his hand as if suspicious. Leipzig would then turn the hand over with a smile to show it empty. I have no doubt that this bit of byplay always got a laugh. The obviously unrehearsed, spontaneous nature of the moment would have to prove irresistible to any audience. The curious thing is that the same thing happened at every performance.

The explanation was not a stooge, but rather audience cueing. It's a technique often used by the best stage magicians when performing audience-participation routines. Cueing consists of the performer secretly whispering instructions to the assisting spectator. These instructions have nothing to do with the methodology of the effect. Rather, they're aimed at eliciting laughs from the audience.

The performer instructs the spectator to do or say something that will be funny to the audience. The audience finds the action funny because they think it's a spontaneous act. They don't realize the spectator has been prompted to perform the action.

Cueing has probably been around as long as stage magic has, but it's reached new levels of subtlety in recent years with the introduction of wireless microphones. Today, the performer can have a hidden switch that allows him to turn his mike on and off at will. Now he can speak in his normal voice and the entire audience can hear what he is saying. Yet a moment later he can secretly turn his mike off and quickly cue the spectator. He then turns the mike back on and the audience again hears his voice, completely unaware that a crucial comment has been edited out.

I don't rule out the possibility that some ingenious close-up worker may some day figure out a way of incorporating cueing into a close-up performance. Perhaps he might use the kind of secret written instructions that are sometimes employed in impromptu stooge effects. Nevertheless, I fear that audience cueing will always remain basically the province of stage magicians.

There is, however, something the close-up worker can do to engineer humorous situations along the lines of those that stage magicians manufacture through cueing. I call this technique

induced response. The concept is somewhat analogous to doing a psychological force. You create a set of circumstances that subtly but compellingly coaxes the spectator to do something he or she thinks is her own idea. In other words, you manipulate the spectator into doing something without his realizing he's been manipulated. Most restaurant magicians give a lot of thought to ways of inducing customers to tip them while making them think it was their own idea. The same concept can be used for less mercenary reasons.

Eddie Fechter had a great quickie effect called "I've Got a Surprise For You." He would have a card selected and lost in the deck. Then he would show an indifferent card and ask if this was the selection. When told that it wasn't, he would toss it on the table with the comment, "Then I've got a surprise for you."

He then reached into his pocket and pulled out a card. Naturally, the audience assumed that this was the selected card. Yet, when Fechter turned it over, it proved to be the indifferent card he had just tossed on the table a moment earlier. Invariably, someone would grab the tabled card and turn it over, only to find himself staring at the selected card. At that point Fechter would observe, "That's the surprise."

No doubt, the spectator who pounced on the tabled card thought that this action was his own idea. But, as Fechter's tag line brought home, the spectator had actually been manipulated into performing the action by a set of circumstances that made the audience's desire to see the tabled card irresistible.

Of course, Fechter might have staged the effect in a different manner that called for he himself to turn over the card. In a theoretical sense, the effect would have been the same, but the impact on the audience would never have been the same without the emotional thrill of that seemingly spontaneous moment when the spectator lunged for the tabled card.

In *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table* I have a very commercial effect called "The Lucky Deck." In it, I show a blank-faced deck and claim that the faces were worn away through use. I state that each card still has a faint impression on it of what the face used to be.

At one point, I identify one of the blank cards as the joker. I say,

“This shouldn't even be in the deck,” as I casually slip the card in my breast pocket. In so doing, I leave the card jutting out of the pocket for about an inch. At the climax of the effect, I print faces on all the cards in the deck.

Almost invariably, after the applause has stopped, someone will say, “What about the one in your pocket?” When that happens, I casually remove the card from my pocket and hand it to a spectator, at which point everyone sees that the previously blank card is now a joker.

This sequence plays all out of proportion to the magic involved simply because it happens spontaneously in response to a spectator's unexpected challenge. Of course, I not only expected the challenge, I induced it. I know that, with the card sticking so tantalizingly out of my pocket, someone is bound to take the bait and ask about it. If I hadn't wanted it to happen I would have pushed the card all the way into my pocket where it would have been out of sight and out of mind. There you have the essence of induced response: you set out the bait, then wait for the spectator to take it.

Another good example of the kind of thing I'm talking about can be found in Michael Ammar's presentation for the “Hundred Dollar Bill Switch.” You'll have to check out Ammar's book for the details. The essence of it is, however, that he borrows a one-dollar bill, then *induces* a spectator to ask him to change it to a hundred. The spectator thinks that the plot of the trick is his idea! Naturally, the effect becomes much stronger because it seems to be spontaneous, in response to an unexpected request. As Michael Ammar says, “You have to act genuinely surprised at their clever remark.”

How do you go about developing situations like this? Most of the time they simply evolve in much the same way that I suspect most audience cueing situations evolve for stage magicians. I doubt that stage magicians spend much time trying to originate bits that can be created by cueing. I suspect that what usually happens is that, during an audience participation routine, a spectator does something that gets a big laugh from the audience. The magician says to himself, “That was great!” It would be terrific if it happened every time.” He then decides to make it happen every time by cueing the spectator.

Your close-up magic can benefit from the same kind of thinking. The next time a humorous or powerful spontaneous moment develops in a performance because of something a spectator says or does, ask yourself, “Can I encourage this to happen more often—maybe even at every performance—by manipulating the spectator into a situation where he’ll naturally react that way?” Sometimes, unfortunately, the answer will be no. But you’ll be surprised how often, with a little thought, you’ll find the answer is yes.

One final point, always be prepared with a contingency plan. You must know what you’ll do to still bring the effect to a successful conclusion if the spectator doesn’t take the bait. Usually, this is a simple matter. In the Fechter trick, if no one grabs the tabled card, you can always turn it over yourself with the comment, “That’s the surprise.”

Special Effects

A very effective method of giving the audience a feeling that they’ve received something special, something most of your audiences don’t get, is to offer to perform a special trick just for them. The classic example of this in live entertainment is the encore. The performer decides that this audience is so special they deserve something extra. In close-up magic the concept can be applied in many imaginative ways beyond just encores.

In his excellent book *The Other Side of the Coin*, Jay Evans mentions that he has a beautiful set of Indian Cups and Balls that he uses only on rare occasions because he is afraid they would get damaged if used constantly. From time to time he brings them to the restaurant where he works and does the trick. The important point, from the standpoint of this discussion, is that Evans always makes it very clear to whatever party he does the trick for that they are seeing something special, something he doesn’t do at every table. This is precisely the sort of thing that makes a performance memorable for an audience.

In *Magic From the Soul*, René Lavand discusses how he uses his “Color-Changing Knives” routine in much the same way. He perfectly conveys the strength of this ploy when he speaks of “the fervent desire of any audience” to enjoy “the privilege of THE

CHOSEN FEW.”

Once again, Wayne Newton carries this concept to the ultimate. He will say, “You know, I don't often do this next song; it requires a special kind of group, a special kind of mood. So let's do it.” He will then launch into an elaborate production number involving such extensive stage special effects that it couldn't possibly be done on the spur of the moment.

A twist on this approach that I sometimes use is to explain that the next effect I'm going to do is one I've been working on for several years, but that this will be the first time I perform it before an audience. Naturally, the audience in question will feel privileged to be in on the unveiling.

Here's another ploy I often use. During a performance, I'll mention that before the show someone came up to me and mentioned a trick they had seen me do on the Dick Cavett Show (or whatever my most recent TV appearance may be at that time) and they insisted that it must have been done by camera trickery. Therefore, although I hadn't planned on doing it, I'm going to perform that trick tonight to prove it's not trick photography. (I trust that by now I don't have to explain that I don't actually wait for someone to make such a comment before I'll use this gambit and that it doesn't really matter whether the trick I do is one I've performed on TV or not.)

There is a gambling routine I use when I work hospitality suites. I always introduce it by saying, “People often ask me what is the most difficult thing I do with cards.” (This is, of course, an inverted question opening. Remember?) “Well I'll show you the most difficult thing I do. It's so difficult that I don't do it very often. I only attempt it if I feel in particularly good form. But everything's been going so well that I'm going to give it a try. We'll find out together if it works.”

Actually, the trick is one of the easier ones I do, but it's amazing enough to make the claim credible. Also, I perform the trick quite often. But, because of the patter, whomever I perform it for feels they've received a special privilege. Actually, I wasn't planning to share that last little secret with you, but you've been such great readers I just couldn't resist. (Wow, are we overtime! Better move

on to the next topic.)

Audience Interaction

The single most potent and generally most accessible technique for giving your performance a sense of spontaneity is to spontaneously interact with the audience. You'll find that most of the biggest laughs you'll get in performance will come from comments you adlib. Realizing that your comment couldn't have been planned because it came in response to an unplanned occurrence, the audience will be that much more appreciative.

Prepared Adlibs: The great secret is that adlibs *can* be planned to a great extent. If you perform with any regularity you'll quickly discover that you tend to get the same comments and responses from people, performance after performance. Often these comments and responses will tend to come at the same points in the performance.

Some of these comments are so common that almost every magician is familiar with them. Every restaurant magician has had the experience countless times of introducing himself at a table only to hear, "Can you make my check disappear?" Everyone who does card magic has heard, "I'd hate to play cards with you." Anyone who does gambling routines has heard, "Why don't you and I go to Las Vegas next week?" And we've all been subjected to, "Can you make my wife disappear?"

Other comments may be ones that only you draw because of your persona. Still others are elicited only by specific effects you perform. As I said, such comments tend to always occur at the same point in the effect. Often they occur in response to a certain question you always ask or instruction you always give at a certain point in a particular effect. Sometimes it's not something a spectator says but something he or she does that tends to happen performance after performance. Let's label all these experiences "recurring situations."

The interesting thing about these recurring situations is that the person involved always seems to think that he or she is the first one who ever said or did this to you. (In fact, the most irritating thing about the "make my wife disappear" witticism is that everyone who

says it thinks he's the first one.) Even more important, the rest of the audience also thinks it's the first time it's happened to you.

This means that if you've prepared a witty response or clever comeback, the audience will interpret it as a great adlib. They feel they've witnessed something that is unique to the particular performance they're seeing, which is just what we want.

I recommend that you put together an adlib list. This is a list of one-liners that you have found effective in recurring situations. (Yes, it's another example of planned spontaneity.) Most of these clever lines will occur spontaneously in a performance. When you debrief yourself after the performance, write the line down. Add it to your adlib list or you'll forget it. Over time you'll accumulate quite a list of such lines. My own list contains almost a hundred lines.

In debriefing it's just as important for you to note a recurring situation that you feel you're not handling as well as you might. Give it some thought and try to come up with an adlibbed line or action to deal with it, because *if it's happened before, it'll happen again*. (If the recurring situation is one that you can't exploit—one that's creating a problem for you—you may just have to restructure the handling or presentation to prevent it from happening again.)

Don't overlook the audience as a source of great adlibs. Many of the funniest lines in your performances will be ones uttered by audience members. Some of these are only funny when they come from the audience. However, many others would be just as funny if you had said them. When you hear one of these, add it to your adlib list so that next time you will.

The problem with the kinds of recurring situations we're talking about is that while they happen often, they don't happen every time. That's why it's vital that you review your adlib list from time to time. These lines have to be on the tip of your tongue at all times. Otherwise, you'll miss a lot of great opportunities to make a performance special for the audience.

One reason magicians resist the kind of approach I'm recommending here is that they're fooled by great entertainers into thinking that a talented performer ought to be able to just go out and wing it, improvising a great performance. Let me tell you a

couple of stories to introduce you to the reality of entertaining.

We've all seen Robin Williams while being interviewed on a TV talk show go out of control and do eight or ten minutes of crazy, improvisational comedy. Obviously, he's a wild man who never knows what he's going to do next. A reporter who was doing a piece on Williams once accompanied him to one of these TV appearances. In the green room before the show, Williams meticulously listed on paper what bits he planned to do and in what order. When he went on he did not deviate from this outline in any way.

One of the greatest improvisational comics of all time was Lenny Bruce. He virtually invented the concept. Yet, I once read an article by an associate who had studied his performances and his approach. This person had seen Bruce perform night after night. He observed that out of every one-hour performance Bruce gave, about five-minutes worth was improvised. The rest was prepared and never changed from night to night.

After each performance, Bruce would go over the five-minutes of improvised material. On a good night, he might find that perhaps thirty-seconds out of the five minutes was strong enough to keep. He would then add that thirty seconds to the next night's performance. If it continued to get a good response, those thirty seconds would become part of the prepared show. If a legendary improvisational comic like Lenny Bruce, one of the greatest comedy talents of all time, relied mainly on "prepared adlibs," shouldn't you also?

Real Adlibs: With all this talk about planning, I don't want you to think I'm against real spontaneity. Some of the funniest lines you'll ever utter in performance will be totally unplanned. The trick is to recognize the opportunities when they come along and know how to take advantage of them. The key to being able to do that is— you guessed it—preparation.

You need to be so totally in control of your performance that your antennae can be out and attuned to what's going on around you and your mind can be open to inspirations. If you're struggling to remember what you should say next, or trying to extemporize, or worrying about whether you'll screw up the next move, or trying to

remember what the next move is, you'll never come up with a good adlib or creatively exploit a promising situation.

The key to spontaneous wit is an unburdened mind. Only when you're relaxed and in control throughout the performance will those wonderful, inspired gags pop into your head. You must have your patter memorized to the point where you could say it in your sleep. You must have your technique perfected to the point where every move is second nature. You must have rehearsed each effect to the point where every part of it is effortless.

We've all seen the opposite situation too many times. A magician is so engrossed in what he's doing, so in danger of being overwhelmed by the trick he is trying to perform, that he's oblivious to everything going on around him. The audience doesn't exist for him. His attention is totally consumed by the wrestling match between himself and his props.

Only when you don't have to be preoccupied with the demands of what you're doing will you be able to take advantage of unforeseen opportunities. When you reach that stage you'll probably surprise yourself at just how funny you can be on the spur of the moment. One of the paradoxes of performing is that it's only when your patter is prepared and memorized to the ultimate degree that you can readily depart from it to really effectively adlib when the situation calls for it. It's paradoxical but true: in a magic performance, preparation is the key to spontaneity.

Incidentally, when you do come up with one of those great adlibs, don't throw it away. If it relates to a situation that has come up before, or that you think is likely to come up again, add the line to your adlib list. Follow Lenny Bruce's example and turn the real adlib into a prepared adlib. Good lines are too rare to waste on just one performance.

Situational Meaning

Since I've already explored this subject at great length, I won't go into detail here. I'll only point out that one of the great strengths of situational meaning is the feeling the audience gets that on this particular occasion the situation might turn out differently. This

time the spectator might win the conflict instead of the performer. This time the performer might lose the hundred-dollar bill. In the case of the magician-in-trouble gambit, clearly something has happened in this performance that doesn't normally happen. Therefore, creating a sense of immediacy is one more good reason for exploiting situational meaning whenever possible.

In this connection, there is one great ploy you can often use to create immediacy. That is to suggest the possibility of failure. Of course, any time you perform there is some risk, however small, that you may screw up the trick. But if you're a smooth, polished performer the audience won't realize that. It's a good idea to remind them from time to time. Mention how difficult a particular trick is. Comment that the trick is brand-new, so you can't guarantee the results. Exhibit some uncertainty once in a while, perhaps some visible relief when the trick does work.

Harry Lorayne is a master at this. Almost every time he picks up a deck of cards he starts by mentioning that he hasn't done this trick in ages, so it probably won't work. It always does, but it seems that much more special because of the element of uncertainty.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN: ATTENTION CONTROL

“Lead the audience by the nose to the thought.”

Laurence Olivier

Magicians talk a great deal about misdirection. This is understandable since misdirection is one of the cornerstones of effective magic. However, all this talk about misdirection can have one drawback. It leads magicians to think that misdirection is something you create in a vacuum. Let the audience look where they may and pay attention to whatever they wish until the move comes. At that point, use some “misdirection.”

Anyone who takes this approach is going to find that his misdirection doesn't work. Here is the biggest secret to effective misdirection: *Misdirection is only an aspect of the larger subject of attention control.* You must be controlling the audience's attention every moment of the performance. If you don't, they won't be able to follow the thread of the effect. If you do, when the time comes to misdirect them from a secret move, you'll find it an easy matter to do so.

There are two aspects to attention control: holding attention and directing attention. Most of the topics we've discussed until now—substantive meaning, situational meaning, dramatic structure, pacing—will help you hold attention. Now I want to talk about directing attention in such a way as to tell your story the way you want to tell it.

Mapping The Route

Other writers have made the point that in order for misdirection to work the performer must control the audience's attention all the

time, not just when the move comes up. What has not been stressed enough in the past is that attention control is important quite apart from the issue of misdirection. A stage director doesn't have to worry about hiding sleight-of-hand moves, yet he will be careful to stage every scene in such a way that the audience's attention is focused where he wants it.

Similarly, a film director will choose each shot very carefully to ensure that the audience takes note of what he wants them to. He will also compose each frame so that the audience focuses on the information within the frame that he considers most important. Otherwise, they might miss a fact that is vital in order for them to understand the story.

As I've said before, magic is a narrative art. Every effect is a story told in dramatic form. All dramatic art forms, whether the stage, film, or novel, work essentially the same way. The viewer is shown pieces of information. The way these pieces of information relate to each other and the order in which they are revealed add up to a story. But it's not enough to put a fact in front of a spectator. You have to make him notice it, understand it, and remember it.

They say you can lead a horse to water but you can't make him drink. But if you want to be a good showman, you've got to learn how to make the audience drink. One of the keys to that is attention control.

Magic on television provides a powerful example of the importance of proper attention control. A TV director has total power to direct the audience's attention since they can only look at what he chooses to put on the screen at any given moment. Think of a case where you saw some magic on television where the director chose his camera angles poorly or cut to, or away from, a shot at the wrong time. I know such errors sometimes inadvertently expose the secret of an effect, but that brings us back to the matter of misdirection which I want to put aside for the moment. Think instead of those cases where such poor direction simply made it difficult for the audience to follow the effect. Unfortunately, this is all too common when magic is shown on TV.

You want the audience to understand what happens and appreciate how impossible it is. Your first step is to study the effect in question

to decide what facts and what conditions the audience must absorb in order to understand and appreciate it. Your second step is to go through the effect and decide what piece of information each step is designed to convey. If there are any steps that serve no function in conveying information or any key piece of information that is not highlighted in any of the steps, the effect is poorly structured and needs to be reworked. Pinpoint the element in each step that conveys the information you desire. This is what Henning Nelms calls the “source of information.”

Your goal is to act as a tour guide, ushering your audience smoothly from one source of information to the next until you reach the climax of the effect. At every point you must be clear in your own mind where you want the audience to be looking and why. There must be no gaps. This is vital. If there is one moment in the effect where you fail to hold and direct the audience's attention they will, in that moment, wander away like little children in a busy department store. And you will have to fight very hard to get them back. This is a situation you must avoid; never let go of the audience's hand.

Tools Of Attention Control

Once you're clear in your own mind where you want the audience focused at every moment, you must select the tools to make it happen. In *Magic and Showmanship*, Nelms observes, “The source of information is what we want the audience to watch. The *center of interest* is what the audience itself wants to watch. In an ideal presentation, they coincide, but this does not happen automatically.” This statement frames the performer's task with beautiful simplicity. To turn the source of information into the center of interest you must use one or more of the following tools:

(1) The Performer's Interest. *They look where you look.* The audience will consider important whatever you treat as important. You are the audience's guide through the effect. Consequently, they will look to you for guidance as to what to pay attention to. As John Ramsay used to say, “If you want the audience to look at something, look at it yourself.”

The one variant of the fundamental rule that the audience will look

wherever you look occurs when you look at the audience. Naturally, they cannot look at themselves. Instead, when you look at them, they will look at you. Needless, to say this can be very useful for misdirection.

(2) Pointing. *They look where you point.* Sounds simple, doesn't it? It is simple, but also powerful. This seems to be one of the things that separates people from animals. If you try to point something out to a dog or a cat, it will just stare intently at the tip of your finger. Fortunately, people aren't that way. They can't help at least glancing at whatever you point to. This is a characteristic you can constantly exploit in your magic.

Keep in mind that you can point, not only with your finger, but with your head or virtually any other part of your body, or with your entire body. Even turning your back on something is a form of pointing. Since you are obviously not turning your body toward something but rather away from something, your body will actually serve to focus attention on whatever you've turned away from.

(3) Patter. *They look where you tell them to look.* Another simple but important point to remember. This works best when combined with techniques (1) and/or (2).

(4) Movement. *They look at anything that is moving.* The tendency of the eye to follow motion must be one of the most ingrained of all human reflexes. No doubt it's an ancient survival mechanism. For primitive man anything that moved in his field of vision was likely to be either something that he might want to catch and eat or something that might want to catch and eat him. Either way, following the moving object with his eyes was likely to improve his chances of survival.

(5) Sound. *They look at anything that is making noise.* This is probably another primal mechanism designed to help us survive in a dangerous world. The great thing about both movement and sound for controlling attention is that these reflexes are beyond people's control. We have no choice but to look.

(6) Contrast. *They look at anything that's different from its surroundings.* The only face-up card in a face-down spread will immediately draw the eye. So will the only red card in a spread of

black cards or the only English penny in a group of half-dollars.

(7) Newness. *They look at whatever has arrived last.* The longer something is in view, the less interesting it becomes to the audience. But whenever a new prop is introduced it will initially draw the audience's interest.

(8) Inherent Interest. This is the one place where source of information and center of interest will automatically coincide. If you create suspense around a certain object, the audience will automatically look at it when that suspense is released. If you arouse curiosity about a box, they will look at the box when you open it. If you arouse uncertainty as to whether you've found the selected card, they will look at the card when you turn it over. If you arouse anticipation concerning the number of sponge balls in a spectator's hand, they will look at her hand when she opens it. Inherent interest is particularly potent for misdirection.

Once you've determined how you want to tell your story, you must structure your presentation to exploit each of these eight tools to lead the audience to each point in turn that you want them to notice, look at, absorb. In other words, make the center of interest and the source of information one and the same.

Directional Misdirection

The term misdirection is used in magic to mean two very different things, often without making it clear that they are two different concepts. One meaning is what we might term physical misdirection: preventing the audience from seeing what you've done. The other meaning is what is sometimes termed psychological misdirection: preventing the audience from figuring out what you've done. Psychological misdirection is nothing less than the psychology of deception. This entire book deals with the psychology of deception. Here I want to discuss only physical misdirection, not controlling the audience's thinking, just controlling their attention to cover a secret move.

Since I've already noted that misdirection is only an aspect of the larger subject of attention control, it follows that, if you've absorbed the information about tools for controlling attention, you already

know most of what you need to know about misdirection.

Remember, it's impossible to direct attention *away* from something; you can only direct attention *toward* something. So, in misdirection, the first step is to determine what you want to direct the audience's attention toward. This should not be something arbitrary. Ideally, it should be something that is logically the source of information at that point in the effect anyway. In other words, it should be something you would want them to look at in that moment even if you weren't going to do a move just then. Having determined what you want them to look at, you then use the tools of attention control to make them look at it.

For example, suppose you're working on a “Chop Cup” routine and need misdirection for loading the giant ball at the end. As you lift the cup to reveal the small ball for the last time, give the ball a slight tap with the back rim of the cup. This will cause it to roll forward a few inches as the cup is lifted. This motion will irresistibly draw all eyes, providing you with the necessary misdirection for loading the large ball.

Inherent Interest as Misdirection: The strongest source of misdirection comes from exploiting inherent interest. This is analogous to judo. In judo you use your opponent's own momentum to defeat him. Here you use the audience's own natural curiosity to deceive it. In both cases, you don't fight against the other's natural tendency; you augment it and use it toward your own ends. You let the spectator look exactly where he wants to look anyway and use that as cover for the move.

For example, in Vernon's “Travellers” as you remove the first ace from one pocket with your left hand you perform a one-hand top palm of the second ace with your right hand. The misdirection is perfect since everyone wants to see whether the first ace has arrived in your pocket; it is a point of inherent interest.

In the section on suspense we discussed Paul Harris' “Reflex.” Most magicians I've seen perform this effect try to palm the top card of the deck when the spectator slaps her hand onto the tabled card. Since you don't know when she is going to do so, it's virtually impossible to coordinate your action with hers. The correct time to

execute the palm is when the spectator looks under her hand to see whether her selection is there. Everyone is curious to see whether she got the card. The inherent interest in her action is so strong you couldn't hope for better misdirection.

In a pick-a-card trick, the strongest moment of inherent interest is always when you reveal the selected card. I exploit this for misdirection in my “Nine-Card Location.” I spin one of the selections out of the deck onto the table. It lands face down, so I ask the assisting spectator to show the card to the rest of the audience. As she does so, I perform a secret card fold of another selection.

The next strongest moment of inherent interest in a pick-a-card trick is when the spectator looks at the card she selected and shows it to the rest of the audience. In one effect I use this moment as misdirection for doing a half-pass. I've even used this moment as misdirection for a deck switch; it's that strong.

All these examples are only specific applications of the tools of attention control for misdirection. However, misdirection also raises some issues that go beyond these eight tools. Let's now look at these.

Staggered Movement: It's natural to think that the misdirective action and the secret action should occur simultaneously, but this is not always the case. Suppose I want to load a palmed card into my wallet as I remove the wallet from my inner jacket pocket. As my right hand with the palmed card goes to the wallet, my left hand places the deck on the table. My goal is to cause the audience's eyes to follow the hand placing the deck on the table rather than the hand with the palmed card going to the pocket.

We already know that the eye follows motion. But, a corollary of that very important rule is that, *when two objects move, the eye will follow the object that moves first*. If my left hand starts moving toward my pocket before my right hand starts to place the deck on the table I'll defeat my goal; the audience's eyes will follow the hand with the palmed card. If both hands start to move at the same time I'll have no control over which hand the spectators follow. In order to achieve my goal, the hand with the deck must start moving just an instant before the hand with the palmed card in order to draw

the audience's eyes.

However, the first hand must not start moving too much earlier than the second hand or it will finish its action before the second hand has finished its job and the spectators' attention will turn to the hand loading the wallet before I want it to.

Intensity Misdirection

When it comes to misdirection, attention control may involve not only the *direction* of the audience's attention but also the *intensity* of that attention. You can sometimes cover a move, not by directing the audience's attention toward something else, but simply by making the audience momentarily relax its attention.

Humor: One of the most effective ways of doing this is with humor. When people laugh they watch you less closely. Yet they themselves don't realize they've let their guard down. Imagine if whenever you wanted you could cause the audience to close its eyes for a moment without their realizing they had done so. A good gag accomplishes just that. Always be on the lookout for the laugh that can be used to cover a move.

Tension/Relaxation: Another way to cause an audience to relax its attention is for you yourself to relax. They will tend to mimic your attitude. This is particularly effective if you first create a moment of tension. If you study John Carney's close-up act on his videotape *Up Close and Far Away* you'll see him repeatedly use this technique.

In one coin effect John places a coin in his hand in such a way as to make the audience suspect that he didn't really put it there. This creates tension. Sensing the audience's suspicion, he opens his hand to show that the coin is really there. This action releases the tension. Carney himself relaxes. You can see all the tension drain out of his body. This reinforces the audience's own tendency to relax after the momentary peak of tension. It's at this instant that he steals the coin back into the other hand.

René Lavand also makes effective use of this technique, for example in his one-handed stripout shuffle. He shuffles the two halves together and holds the deck up high as he comments on the thoroughness of the shuffle. This is the moment of peak tension. He

then relaxes, dropping his hand to the table, and in that moment strips the two halves apart.

Tony Slydini was also a master of tension/relaxation for misdirection. A detailed discussion of the body language principles involved in this type of misdirection is beyond the scope of this book, but you'll find such discussion, along with numerous examples, in Slydini's books.

Beginnings and Conclusions: Two areas where the audience's attention naturally diminishes in intensity are before the effect begins and after it ends—that is, before they *think* it has begun or after they *think* it has ended. Occasionally this can be used to your advantage.

The classic example of exploiting the moments before the trick begins is the card man's notion of “toying with the deck.” Often you can set up cards openly yet unnoticed because the audience doesn't feel the trick has started yet. For an example of exploiting the moments after the trick has seemingly ended, check out “Darwin's Wild Card” in *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. In that effect I switch the gaffed cards for ungaffed duplicates in the moments of relaxed audience attention after the effect has ended.

The Limits of Misdirection: There are times when you don't want to misdirect from a move. Modern sleight of hand has come to rely more and more on *simulation moves* where you appear to do one thing when you actually do another, as opposed to classic-style sleight of hand where you do something while appearing to do nothing at all (as in the pass, most palms, and the top change). Examples of simulation moves are the Braue secret addition, the Elmsley count, and the retention vanish of a coin.

In the case of simulation moves, often the move is the source of information at that point in the effect. If you do an Elmsley count to show that you are holding four kings, you can't very well misdirect the audience from the move. If you do, they won't realize that you apparently have four kings and will miss the point of the effect. In such cases, perfect technique becomes particularly important to ensure that the simulated move looks exactly like the true move.

Distractions

“You want [the reader's] attention and to keep it you must avoid the distractions that will cause his attention to wander.”

Gary Provost, *Make Your Words Work*

Attention control has a positive aspect and a negative aspect. Once you decide where you want attention directed at each step in the effect, you employ the tools we've discussed to focus the audience's attention directed there. That's the positive aspect. However, you must also go through each effect and eliminate every element that might distract your audience, undermining what you're trying to accomplish through positive attention control techniques. Eliminating distractions is the negative aspect of attention control.

Audiences have an enormous capacity for being distracted. When faced with a choice between paying attention to what a performer is presenting to them and paying attention to a distraction, they will usually choose the distraction. That's why you have to make sure they never get that choice.

Distraction is the flip-side of misdirection. *Anything that can act as misdirection at the right moment can act as a distraction at the wrong moment.* That means that if you understand misdirection, you understand what you have to eliminate to avoid distractions.

Movement is a very strong attention-getting tool. It is also the most common source of distraction in magic performances. Often a performer will engage in unconscious fidgeting, usually as an outlet for nervousness. He may constantly shift his weight from foot to foot. He may engage in constant, meaningless riffling of the deck. These things can easily distract the audience from what you want them to focus on.

Since these actions are unconscious, they can be difficult for you to detect. If you ever have the opportunity to have yourself videotaped during a performance, take advantage of it to study the tape for any distracting movements you may make. You can also ask a friend to watch a performance specifically looking for distracting movements.

As you become more experienced as a performer you will become

more aware of every action you make. Here are the rules to follow: Make no move, however small, without a conscious reason. Use every move to help focus and direct audience attention. In general you should make only one movement at a time. The only exception is when using movement as misdirection, performing the hidden movement in the shadow of the open movement.

Always keep in mind that your first responsibility is to tell your story (the story of the effect) as clearly as possible. You must eliminate anything that distracts your audience from that goal, no matter how much you may like it. It may mean eliminating a favorite flourish or dropping a funny gag. This can be particularly difficult in the case of humor. Magicians often find it difficult to forego a laugh, even when that laugh may distract the audience from a key point of the effect. A good laugh at the right moment is a great thing. A good laugh at the wrong moment just isn't worth it—not if it jeopardizes the magical moment you've worked so hard to create.

CHAPTER NINETEEN: AUDIENCES

Those of us who do magic for a living have amateur magicians turn up in our audiences from time to time. Invariably, after the show, the amateur will come up to talk to the professional. Most professionals find this irritating for a variety of reasons. Here is one of my reasons. There is one comment that the hobbyist magician almost always makes to me after a show: “You had a really good audience.”

The implication seems to be that the fact that I got a lot of applause, lots of laughs, and generally a strong reaction has nothing to do with my skills. It was just the luck of the draw. I simply happened to get “a really good audience.” I suspect that if I had gone over poorly, these same magicians would have walked away thinking I was a lousy magician. They would not have chalked it up to my having had “a really bad audience.”

The only reason I bring up this minor pet peeve is that I suspect that most of these magicians use exactly the opposite criteria when evaluating themselves. If they go over well, it proves how great they are. If they go over poorly, it's because they had “a really bad audience.”

It is true that some audiences are more responsive than others and that some audiences come to the performance more ready to be entertained than others. Nevertheless, the differences from one audience to the next are the least important factor determining how well you will go over. The most important factor is how good an entertainer you are. The fact is that *the similarities among different kinds of audiences far outweigh the differences.*

That having been said, it must also be recognized that there are differences and the better you understand the different kinds of

audiences you'll encounter and how to handle them, the better entertainer you'll be. Let's consider the major variables you'll encounter from one audience to the other.

Attention Span

If you perform with any frequency, it won't take you long to notice that audiences can vary greatly in attention spans. Naturally, this will affect the success of your performances. You'll have to either adapt to each audience in this regard or suffer some disappointing experiences.

It's easy to assume that the matter of attention span is governed by some mysterious element—perhaps the phases of the moon—that is completely unpredictable. But that's not really the case. Once you understand what factors affect attention span you can usually predict in advance of a performance what kind of attention span you'll probably encounter. Therefore, you can plan your performance accordingly.

Environmental Distractions: The biggest factor affecting attention span is the working environment. The rule of thumb is simple. The more easily the audience can see and hear what you're doing, the easier you'll find it to hold their attention.

Unfortunately, close-up workers don't always get to perform under ideal conditions. Particularly in certain professional settings, there are sometimes environmental factors that can make it more difficult for an audience to see or hear you. If the room is rather dark, as is the case in many restaurants, they will have to work harder to see what you're doing. If there is loud music in the background, as is common in many receptions, they may have to work harder to hear you. Similarly, if there is a lot of background noise, as can happen in any crowded room, they may have to strain to hear you.

Audiences don't like to work. Consequently, anything that makes following your performance a chore will cut their attention spilt. Needless to say, if the room is very noisy you must speak louder and more forcefully to be heard over the din. But, even more important, you must cut your patter to an absolute minimum. Cut out any lines that aren't vital to following the effect.

It will pain you to leave out some sure-fire laugh lines and other patter that you know adds to the impact of the effect. And there is no denying that such patter pruning will hurt the performance. But the performance will suffer even more if the spectators start to tune you out from fatigue at having to strain to catch each word.

Similarly, if the room is very dark you should select shorter effects so the audience has to concentrate for shorter periods. You may also have to cut the length of the entire performance.

Of course, the ideal solution would be to avoid working such situations. But when you work for money you don't always have that choice. In such cases, you have to choose your material and your patter so as to make the least demands on the audience.

Alcohol Consumption: This one is simple. The more people drink, the shorter their attention span. They'll have greater difficulty concentrating, remembering, understanding, and paying attention.

If only moderate drinking is going on, it will have only a slight affect on attention span. You may, for example, find that people are somewhat more likely to forget what card they chose, or may have a problem following instructions unless you keep them very simple.

However, if you're going to work for a heavily drinking crowd, you have to almost relate to them like children. Keep the tricks short and very elementary in effect. Consider that favorite of bar magicians, the "Card under the Glass." Even someone who is semi-comatose can follow that, as long as you can get him to remember his card.

Physical Discomfort: This is the one that's difficult to foresee before the performance. Fortunately, this factor usually has only a slight impact on attention span. Nevertheless, you should keep in mind that if the room is too hot or too cold or the seats are uncomfortable, it will slightly reduce the audience's ability to pay attention.

Size

Audience size is a factor that should greatly affect how you play an audience. Yet, very few close-up magicians appreciate the major differences between performing for three people and performing for

thirty people. Some might argue that close-up magic was never designed to be performed for more than a few people at a time. This is, no doubt, true. However, the economics of the business are such that most professional close-up magicians often find themselves working for large groups.

Trade show magicians often attract crowds of thirty or forty or more. In my college shows I usually work for anywhere from thirty to eighty people at a time. I also find that in hospitality suites the audiences can get fairly large at times. Even restaurant workers sometimes have to work tables holding ten or twelve people. Close-up workers who work magic conventions also have to get used to large crowds. It's not unusual for a convention close-up audience to number seventy or more. Lecture audiences can be even larger. Similarly the close-up room at the Magic Castle holds over thirty people.

If you try to work groups like these the same way you would perform for three or four people, you're going to have problems. A good place to study the potential pitfalls of working large audiences is at magic conventions. It will sometimes happen that a certain close-up magician develops a great reputation. As a result, he is hired to work a magic convention. Expectations are high, yet everyone walks out of the close-up show disappointed. Often this is because the magician built his reputation in magic sessions of three or four people. Having no experience with large audiences, he works the crowd the same way he would have performed for three or four people. The result is a catastrophe.

The most obvious challenge that large groups pose for close-up magicians are audibility and visibility. The most important thing you must learn about working large groups is that *it's more important for people to hear you than to see you*. Given a choice between a performing situation where the audience can see me clearly but have trouble hearing me and one where everyone can hear me clearly but many people have trouble seeing what's happening, I'll unhesitatingly take the one where they can easily hear me.

This may surprise you since we tend to think of magic as a visual experience; nevertheless, it's true. It's amazing how large a group

you can hold as long as they can hear what you're saying, even if the ones at the back can hardly see anything. As long as people can hear you, they feel they're a part of the performance. Furthermore, they can easily follow what is happening just from listening. By contrast, it's very difficult to follow the plot of most close-up effects just from watching if you can't hear the patter.

The ideal solution to audibility problems with large audiences is to get a good portable sound system with either a clip-on or lavalier microphone, then learn how to work with it (How many times have you seen a close-up magician at a magic convention trip over his microphone or half-strangle himself because of inexperience working with a mike?)

Since a sound system isn't always practical, you should also learn how to project. This means increasing your volume by pushing your voice out with your diaphragm rather than straining your throat. This is a knack you can develop through experience, although taking some basic voice lessons is a better way.

While visibility is less important than audibility, you shouldn't neglect it. There are two simple rules you must follow in order to make close-up magic visible for large audiences. The first is to *hold* things up. Most close-up magicians just don't realize that, once your audience goes above a half-dozen or so, most of them can't clearly see a flat object lying on a table. This means that cards and coins almost disappear as soon as you put them down. This doesn't mean you can't put cards or coins down on the table. It just means that you have to make sure everyone gets a good look at them before you do.

Let's take a simple example. Suppose you're going to deal the top four cards of the deck face up on the table. You want everyone to see that these cards are the four kings. The usual way to do this is to deal the cards overhand, stud-style. This means that people see the back of each card as it is dealt onto the table. They only see the face once the card is lying on the table. But with a large audience, most of them won't be able to see the card clearly once it's on the table. Instead, deal the cards underhand so the face of each card is toward the audience for a moment before it hits the table. Also, deal slowly enough for them to get a good look at each face as the card is dealt.

Also, specifically when working with cards, remember that people are interested in seeing the faces and backs of the cards, not their edges. This leads to our second rule of visibility: *tilt the cards down so people can see them*. It helps if you're working standing up as it's quite awkward to tilt your hands down when you're sitting at a table.

When most close-up magicians do card tricks they seem to be performing for themselves. As long as they can see what's happening, that's all that matters to them. They will do a double turnover onto the deck and hold the deck in such a way that the audience sees only the front edge of the pack. They will do an Elmsley count in such a way that they see the faces of the four cards clearly while the audience sees only the edges.

I was once asked to judge the close-up contest at a national magic convention. One young magician did the “Modern Jazz Aces” from *Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table*. This trick involves Elmsley counts and other packet moves. Throughout the effect (which the magician performed seated) I could only see the edges of the cards, despite the fact that I was seated on high bleachers. If I hadn't created the routine myself I would have had no idea what the effect was. (I ranked him first in the contest anyway. His superb choice of material outweighed all other considerations.)

The problem is that magicians assume that if they can see something clearly, the audience can also. The opposite assumption can also cause problems. Particularly when working with a larger audience that is seated, you must be aware that the people further back have a lower angle of vision than normal. This means that they may be able to see under your hand or see the bottom of the deck unless you keep them tilted down.

I've often seen magicians control a selected card to the bottom of the deck, then hold the deck in such a way that most of the audience could clearly see the card on the face. Other times they will switch four aces for four kings, then hold the packet in such a way that people can see a king on the face of the packet. The performer assumes that since he can't see it, no one else can. As magicians, when we see such mistakes made by performers at lectures or magic conventions, we tend to turn a blind eye. Instead, watch these performances with a critical eye in order to learn what mistakes to

avoid.

In addition to audibility and visibility, another major concern when working large audiences is making contact with everyone. You must make everybody in the audience feel they're part of the performance or you'll lose them. They'll start to drift away, either physically or at least mentally. Magicians who aren't used to working large audiences will sometimes direct the entire performance to the two or three people closest and ignore everyone else. The rest of the audience feels like eavesdroppers rather than part of a shared experience.

Your most important tool in avoiding this problem is eye contact. You must continually look at different parts of the audience both close and distant. (I strongly recommend you study Juan Tamariz' advice in this regard in *The Five Points in Magic*.) Related to this, you must make sure you direct your patter to the audience as a whole. Don't talk only to the spectators who are assisting you in the trick. You must divide your attention between the assisting spectators and the rest of the crowd.

It's particularly important that you develop what I call *peripheral awareness*. When a large crowd gathers to watch a close-up performance, many people will stand off to the far sides. It's very easy to unwittingly ignore these people and direct all your attention to those directly in front of you. Remember, address some of your comments to those at the extreme sides and make eye contact with them also.

One requirement for working large groups that is difficult to describe is making the “size” of the performance a little larger. You must exaggerate things just the slightest bit. Your gestures should be a little broader, your comments a little more emphatic. Of course, for a small group you must bring the performance down again; otherwise, you'll seem too theatrical. Making the proper adjustment is a knack you'll develop with experience.

When working a larger audience in a formal setting you may want to bring up one or two assistants to help you. Handling this properly is a science in itself; we'll be devoting the next chapter to the subject.

Finally, the one other element that is important in working for large

audiences is good applause technique, something most close-up magicians don't give much thought to. This subject has been brilliantly covered by Henning Nelms in his lecture notes *Applause and How to Get It*. (This was also reprinted in the November 1978 *Genii*.) Rather than simply repeat what he has written I recommend you track down a copy of this excellent treatise.

Magicians

The best advice I can give you about working magician audiences is *don't*. At the very least, don't do it too often. If you do, it will only hamper your development as a lay-audience entertainer. Whenever you do perform for magicians, here are a couple of things to keep in mind.

First, novelty is very important to magicians. Magician audiences will respond more strongly to a bad trick that is very different than they will to a great trick that is similar to things they've seen often before. (That's one reason why performing for magicians can hurt your commercial sense.)

Second, most magicians are much easier to fool than laypeople. I know this is an unpopular opinion, but long experience and observation have convinced me it's true. I've often seen magicians fooled by tricks that would never fool a lay audience. You would think that their familiarity with magic methods and principles would make magicians far more able to reason out how an effect must have been done. In some cases, it does work that way. But with most magicians, it seems they're knowledge of magic serves only to ossify their thinking.

As long as a trick stays on the familiar path, they can follow it. But the moment it deviates in the slightest degree from what they're used to, their minds shut down. Their increased knowledge of magic only serves to limit their capacity to reason about magic. They can recognize a double lift when they see it (at least, if it's badly executed), but they can't put two and two together.

Laypeople are much more flexible in their thinking. Because they have no preconceived notions, and because they're not overly concerned with the exact details of methodology, laypeople can

more easily see the big picture, and often instinctively go directly to the correct solution.

Another thing you should realize is that the common belief that magicians don't respond to presentation is generally false. There are a few magicians who are so obsessed with technique or methodology that they're blind to everything else. For the most part, however, magician audiences respond to good presentational technique almost as well as laypeople do.

If you've ever seen Don Alan, Del Ray, Al Goshman, René Lavand, or any other great magician perform for other magicians, you've seen the proof of this. In fact, these performers don't change their acts in any way when working for magicians. They use exactly the same tricks, the same methods, the same patter, and the same bits of business when they work for magicians that they do when they work for laypeople. And they get the same enthusiastic response.

When you perform for magicians, just do the same material you normally do for laypeople and present it the same way. You'll want to leave out any very standard items that would be extremely familiar to them. But if your magic is good, well executed, and based on sound principles of showmanship, it will go over well. Best of all, you won't have expended a lot of energy developing "magicians only" material that will be useless with the audiences that really count, laypeople.

CHAPTER TWENTY:

ASSISTANTS

The Importance Of Assistants

When working for larger groups, it's very common for a performer to bring up one or two spectators to sit beside him and help during the various effects. These assistants play a vital role in the success of the performance. First, the assistant serves to confirm the deceptiveness of the magic for the rest of the audience. In a large group, someone sitting in the back may be completely amazed by an effect, yet wonder whether he might not have been able to figure it out if he had been sitting closer where he could “catch” you. When he sees that the assistants sitting right next to you are just as amazed, he realizes that distance has nothing to do with his being fooled.

Second, the assistant vicariously provides the rest of the audience with a sense of participation in the performance. The ideal would be to have every audience member take part in the performance at some point or other. When working for small groups, you can often achieve this ideal; however, with a large audience this is impractical. Here is where the assistant plays an important role. Since she came from the audience, they'll perceive her as their representative; they will identify with her and thereby get a sense of having participated in the performance.

Third, and this is very important, the assistant can act as a catalyst for audience reactions. Often a strong reaction from an assistant will provide an unconscious cue to the audience to react similarly. They will mirror the amazement or amusement they see on her face. (This is a specific application of the concept of suggestion we discussed earlier.) That's why it's so important to have an assistant who responds openly to the magic rather than an inhibited

spectator who keeps her reactions bottled in. As Dr. John Booth says in his book *Dramatic Magic*, “Emotion breeds emotion.”

Finally, the spectator's reactions to the various effects in themselves provide a source of entertainment for the audience. There is something compelling about watching spontaneous emotion. This is why we're captivated by viewing the emotional turmoil of the victims of tragedies on the television news, however much we may regret their suffering.

At the other end of the spectrum, the jumping, shouting, and carrying on of winners on TV game shows provides these programs with much of their entertainment value. Game show producers are so aware of the importance of this factor that many shows actually audition prospective contestants, looking for expressive types and rejecting withdrawn, unemotional ones. In addition, game show contestants are often prompted before the program to show excitement if they should win a prize.

Consider Slydini's “Paper Balls Over the Head” where almost all the entertainment value of the trick comes from watching the spectator's emotional reaction. I've seen this effect performed on occasions where the performer had the misfortune to draw an inexpressive assistant and can testify that the impact of the trick and the audience's reaction were greatly diminished.

Qualities Of A Good Assistant

Just what kind of assistants do you want? There are two critical qualities to look for: *expressiveness* and *cooperativeness*. The importance of expressiveness should be clear from what I've said so far. The value of cooperativeness should be self-evident. You don't want someone on your hands who is going to fight you at every turn. With experience, you'll reach a point where you can handle even the most recalcitrant assistant. However, this doesn't alter the fact that an assistant who is with you rather than against you will make for a much more enjoyable performance for both you and your audience. Furthermore, the two criteria are related. An uncooperative assistant is also an assistant who will do her best to show no reaction to your magic.

When I do my gambling lecture I always select two men to help me. I do this, first, because I'm trying to create an authentic-looking gambling situation; in our culture, men most often play cards with men and women with women. Second, since I'm going to continually beat these people in our mock card game, I don't want the audience to feel that I'm picking on a defenseless woman. Instead I choose two men who look like they can take care of themselves and don't need the audience's sympathy.

However, when I perform close-up magic I always select women to assist. First, a woman is less likely to take a competitive attitude toward a male performer. ("If you fool me I lose; if I catch you I win.") Second, a woman is much more likely to openly express admiration for the performer and his magic. (Note that both these points are from the perspective of a male performer. I can't speak from experience, but I realize that matters might be different if the performer is female.) Third, in our society a woman is much more likely to express her feelings freely and spontaneously. A man might be just as amazed as a woman if he opens his hand to find two spongeballs instead of one, but he is much less likely to let out a scream when it happens.

In selecting assistants I always look for attractive women since this is a legitimate consideration in adding to the aesthetic appeal of the performance. I want to stress, however, that physical attractiveness is not the most important consideration. Some magicians seem to be conducting a personal beauty contest when they select an assistant. Expressiveness and cooperativeness are far more important than beauty.

In fact, I believe that an assistant who is too spectacularly beautiful can be a handicap. On more than one occasion I've seen close-up performances where I was continually distracted from the magic by a beautiful assistant's looks or the amount of cleavage she was displaying. I figure that if it can happen to me as a spectator it could happen to members of my audience when I'm working. In a typical larger audience there will be numerous women sufficiently attractive to serve as assistants. This will allow you to choose from among them based on more important criteria.

One Assistant Or Two?

In a formal close-up show I recommend that you bring up two assistants to your table to help rather than just one. This offers several advantages. First, when you have only one person up there with you they will sometimes feel inhibited, thinking that everyone is staring at them and watching their every movement. This self-consciousness makes the person less expressive than they would normally be and consequently hurts your performance. As soon as a second person is involved, this seems to take the pressure off both of them. They're both more relaxed and therefore more likely to respond openly and spontaneously to your magic.

Second, when you have two spectators at the table with you, you'll often get amusing interaction between them. This usually consists of them exchanging astonished looks and quizzical expressions or one asking the other if she has any idea how these things are happening. Audiences find this very entertaining. It also helps underscore for the rest of the audience just how incredible what you're doing really is.

Third, when you have two assistants it gives you a fallback if one spectator proves extremely troublesome. You can use the other spectator in all the audience-participation effects and virtually ignore the troublemaker.

However, you should only bring up two spectators if you actually have enough for them to do to justify having two people. It's better to use just one assistant than to bring up two and leave one with nothing to do. In one of my seven close-up acts I do use only one spectator for just this reason. In this act I'm always particularly careful about whom I pick to help me.

Who Chooses?

In light of how important the choice of the right kind of assistant is to the success of a performance it's vital that you don't forfeit your right to make this decision. That is just what you'll be doing if you simply ask for a volunteer and take whoever comes up first. (In fact, as we'll see later, the kind of person most likely to volunteer is just the kind who is most likely to be unsuitable.)

That is also what you'll be doing if you give in to someone who comes up to you before the performance and asks you to pick his girlfriend or some other member of his party to help. He may assure you that she is “perfect” for the job but, since he has no idea what the job requirements are, his assurances mean nothing.

Sometimes you may be performing with all the spectators sitting around a large table. If you simply let them fill up all the seats before you get there, you'll be stuck with using as assistants whoever happens to take the seats next to you. Instead, place your briefcase or some props or other items on the chairs you want your assistants to occupy. Or hang “reserved” signs on them. (You can steal a couple of those multi-lingual “occupied” signs the airlines have.) When you come over to start your performance, remove the items from the chairs, pick out a couple of promising-looking spectators, and invite them to come over and join you.

Choosing An Assistant

I once saw a comedy juggler working a college show. At one point he brought an assistant up from the audience. When the assistant made a mistake in following directions, the juggler looked at the audience and said, “It's not his fault. It's my fault ... I picked him.” The clear implication was, “It's my fault for picking an idiot to help me.”

Although the line got a laugh, I don't recommend that kind of insult humor. Nevertheless, the juggler's line contained a profound truth that every magician should realize. Anything that goes wrong in your performance is your fault. That includes things that are caused by an assisting spectator's behavior. It's your fault because you picked him or her to help you. Here are some tips I've found useful in avoiding losers and troublemakers as assistants.

Just before I start a set I will scan the audience, specifically looking at the women spectators. While I do this very casually and without staring at anyone, I'm actually carefully auditioning assistants in my mind. I look for women who are smiling or have an expectant expression, like they're looking forward to the show. I immediately eliminate anyone who looks bored or is deeply absorbed in conversation. Needless to say, I also eliminate anyone who looks

like she has had too much to drink.

It will sometimes happen that I will catch the eye of one woman and she will smile at me. Whenever that happens, her berth as an assistant is secure. This has nothing to do with flirting or any ulterior motives. I can only say that in my experience these women always make perfect assistants. Anyway, it works for me.

In many of my shows I'm introduced by someone at the start of my performance. Not every close-up worker has this advantage. However, whenever this opportunity arises it offers you a great aid in selecting a good assistant. I will stand off to the side during the introduction and watch the audience. How closely people listen to the introduction is a good indication of how much they're looking forward to the show.

Often I will notice a woman glancing back and forth between the person introducing me and myself. What she is hearing about me has intrigued her enough to want to get a better look at me. Like the eye—contact-and-smile tipoff I mentioned earlier, I have found this a sure-fire indicator of an ideal assistant.

In many close-up situations you'll be called on to do more than one show in the course of the evening. This is almost always the case in my own work. This provides another great aid in selecting a good assistant. This is because you'll get many people who will come back to catch more than one show. (If you don't, reread the earlier portions of the book.)

When you see a woman in the audience that you remember seeing during a previous set, you know she likes what you're doing. Furthermore, since you had the opportunity to watch her during the previous performance, you know how expressive she is. A spectator who reacts strongly and comes back for more will also be a cooperative spectator. She'll be perfect to help you in the next set.

In some performing situations, you may do walk-around magic during the early part of the evening and a sit-down show at the end. The theory remains the same. The ones who reacted the best during the walk-around will make the best assistants during the formal show.

If you haven't had a lot of experience performing, you might think it unlikely that the faces of people in a large audience will stay in your mind from one set to the next. But any experienced close-up performer knows that the face of every person in the audience gets etched in your mind for the duration of the evening. (If that's not the case, it means you haven't mastered your material sufficiently. You're too absorbed in what you have to say or do next to relate to the audience.) Indeed, often during a performance I will notice a particularly responsive woman audience member and make a mental note to select her as an assistant if she comes back for a later show.

One final word about who to avoid choosing as a spectator. In addition to the obvious ones, the drunk, the stone-faced, the bored, and the compulsive talkers, avoid anyone who seems very eager to be selected as spectators. These people want to come up because they like being the center of attention. But during a show *you* have to be the center of attention. Don't make the mistake of confusing expressiveness with extroversion. Unless you want competition from out-of-control extroverts, avoid the ones who are dying to be chosen.

Getting Them Up

A few weeks ago I attended a magic lecture by one of the biggest names in close-up magic. Many of his tricks required help from the audience. Every time one of these effects came up, he would look out at the audience and ask, "Could I have the assistance of someone from the audience?"

Invariably, what happened is exactly what you can expect to happen most of the time when a performer makes such a request: nothing. Everyone sat silently and tensely as they waited for someone else to volunteer. During this interminable wait, the performer said and did nothing: he only stared out at the audience.

Eventually someone would decide that anything was better than this uncomfortable silence and would step forward. At the end of the effect the performer would dismiss the assistant. As soon as he wanted to do another audience-participation effect the ordeal would begin again. All told, this little exercise in tedium occurred about a

half-dozen times during the lecture.

The most obvious error this performer made was to keep sending the assistants back after each trick. Once you have a couple of good assistants up at the table with you *keep them there*. It doesn't matter if they don't have something to do in every trick. They can still watch and react. His second error we've already talked about. By simply asking for a volunteer, he was relinquishing the power to choose a promising assistant.

This episode also illustrates the larger point that if you don't know how to get a spectator up from the audience quickly it can kill the pacing of the show right at the outset. Once you've settled on a person you want to have assist you, look at her, point to her, and ask if she would be kind enough to come up and help. She may not immediately realize you're talking to her. If so, identify her with a comment such as, "The lady in the red dress, would you please come up and help?"

Occasionally, the person you ask may demur. She may shake her head and say. "Pick someone else." My advice, based on long experience is: don't pick someone else. Insist in a friendly and gracious but uncompromising way that she come up. She will and with very little stall. That's because there is tremendous pressure on her to do so. She realizes that everyone is waiting for her to come up so the show can go on. (Compare this with the case of the magic lecturer I cited. Everyone wanted the show to go on and everyone felt uncomfortable about the wait. But no one felt personally responsible for holding up the show, so no one moved.)

With a particularly reluctant spectator I will say. "I guarantee you'll have a good time. Just come up for a couple of minutes and. if you don't like it, you can go right back." I've never had anyone refuse after that and I've never had anyone ask to go back to their seat before the show was over. As long as you're firm, she'll come up. And, assuming you know your job, before long she'll be happy she did.

Since I realize some will question the advice I'm giving here, let me explain my reasons. First, you may think that if a spectator doesn't want to come up and help, she'll make a lousy assistant if she does

come up. Again I remind you, don't confuse expressive with extroverted. An extrovert will come running up but may give you trouble throughout the performance as she tries to get the audience to pay attention to her instead of you. A more reserved person may be reluctant to come up. But once she does come up, she'll be cooperative. And, if you chose well, and if you put her at ease immediately, she will be expressive. The assistants who are initially the most reluctant always seem to be the ones who have the best time once they're at the table with me. They're also always the ones who thank me most warmly after the show for letting them help.

Furthermore, consider the alternative. You ask a spectator to assist. She declines, so you ask another one. I guarantee that I can predict what will happen next. The second one you ask will also decline. And so will the next one you ask. As soon as the audience realizes that all they have to do to get off the hook is to say no, everyone will say no. Better to spend a few moments being firm with the first person you ask than spend a half-hour going from one person to another pleading for someone to come up.

With experience you will know who in the audience will make the best assistants. Once you've made that determination, don't take no for an answer. The only reason they're reluctant is that they don't know what a good time they're going to have once they're up there. You do know, so do them a favor and insist. It's for their own good.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE: HECKLERS

“When you work with people, you must be in control. If you cannot control, you do not belong on the stage.”

Al Koran, Lecture Notes of Fantastic Koran

The Psychology Of Heckling

The most difficult problem you'll face as a close-up performer is the heckler: the person who yells out taunts and insults, grabs your props, and “explains” all your tricks to the rest of the audience. While hecklers are a real problem, many close-up workers also misinterpret more innocent situations as heckling. For that reason, I think we should start with a definition: *A heckler is a spectator whose goal is to wreck your performance.* If you don't understand what makes a heckler tick, you'll find his behavior not only frustrating, but baffling.

The key to influencing people's behavior is understanding their motivations. What motivates the true heckler is jealousy. You have something he wants. That something is *attention*. The spotlight is on you and he wants it on him. Everything he does is designed to shift the spotlight from you to him.

That's why even the strongest insult humor won't discourage most hecklers. We've all read “heckler-stoppers” in books, gags that are supposed to make the heckler wilt in humiliation and give up his evil ways. Here is the way it usually goes in practice. The heckler throws some dumb insult at you. You throw a brilliant insult at him. He throws another dumb one at you and you throw another brilliant one at him. Your lines are getting much bigger laughs than his, yet he won't shut up.

You may find yourself wondering, “Why doesn't this guy realize that, in this battle of wits, he's outgunned.” What you don't realize is that he's not concerned with a battle of wits. He's concerned with the battle for the audience's attention, and that's a battle he's winning. Every time you throw a clever put-down his way, he scores another point. This pathetic clown is so desperate for attention that he finds even being insulted preferable to being ignored.

Every time you turn your attention to him, you encourage him to heckle you further. That's why your attempts to retaliate against his heckling will usually only get you more of the same.

The only way you can control this kind of individual is to deprive him of what he seeks. 99% of the time in close-up magic, the best way to handle a heckler is to ignore him. In Jay Evans' book *The Other Side of the Coin* he has a beautiful way of expressing this attitude. He calls it turning off your hearing aid.

When I have a difficult heckler I not only pretend not to hear what he says, I completely refuse to acknowledge his existence. I don't make eye contact with him. I literally act as if he doesn't exist.

In most cases, as soon as he realizes that his game isn't going to yield the results he is seeking, he starts to quiet down. If the performing situation is one where the person can walk away without attracting attention, the heckler will often leave before the performance is over. This is, of course, the best resolution of the matter I could possibly hope for.

At first you might find the approach I'm recommending difficult to put into practice. If so, it's because you're doing the one thing you must never do in such situations, letting your ego get involved. It's only natural to see a heckler's actions as a challenge to you and to feel you must rise to the challenge with a string of clever insults. You want to best him in a battle of wits.

However, this approach is filled with pitfalls. I've already stressed the most important one; it will only encourage the troublemaker. A second pitfall is that you risk alienating the rest of the audience. They may start to identify with the guy you're “picking on.” After all, he is one of them. He may even be a friend of some or all of them. When you ignore his wisecracks, you become the good guy. The

audience starts to resent this guy who is giving you a hard time when all you're trying to do is entertain them.

Indeed, the only heckler-stopper I ever use succeeds precisely because of this resentment. I only employ this line in the most extreme cases, ones where the heckler persists in disrupting the performance despite my ignoring him. I will look up at the rest of the audience and say, "You see what happens when cousins marry."

Invariably, this line gets a huge laugh, much larger than its inherent humor justifies. This is because the laugh is an outlet for the animosity that the audience has built up against this person. (And I never use the line until I can feel that a great deal of animosity has built up out there.)

What I particularly like about this line is that even as I insult the heckler I avoid acknowledging his existence. That's because, unlike most heckler-stoppers, this one isn't directed at the heckler; it's directed at the rest of the audience. I don't point to the heckler when I deliver the line; I don't look at him as I say it. I look at the rest of the audience. They know who I'm referring to. Thus, the heckler gets the most lethal combination, ridicule without recognition.

I'm not suggesting you should use this line. I only provide it as a further example of the philosophy I recommend when dealing with hecklers. Deny them the one thing they crave: attention.

Finally, the most serious pitfall of giving in to the temptation to trade insults with the heckler, is that you are betraying your responsibility to your audience. Even if your put-downs get laughs, the audience isn't being entertained *by magic*. That's your job, to entertain the audience with magic. To the extent that you allow a heckler to prevent you from doing that, you've lost the battle with him, even if you score some laughs at his expense.

Something to keep in mind as a last resort if dealing with an impossible spectator is that you don't *have to* perform. If working in a social situation, you can always apologize to the rest of the audience and stick the cards or coins back in your pocket. Even when performing professionally, you can always move on to the next table or the next group or take a break before resuming your

performance.

If you follow the advice I've given you, you will very, very seldom have to use this option. But it's always there. Indeed, if you refuse to stop performing even in a truly impossible situation it's only because you've fallen victim to the one thing I warned you against, allowing your ego to get involved in the matter.

Now let's take a look at some of the different ways heckling might manifest itself as well as some folks you might mistakenly classify as hecklers.

Theorizing

The theorizer is the kind of spectator who has to try to explain every trick you do to the rest of the group. He may do this while you're performing the effect or after the effect is over. He may be motivated by a sincere desire to settle in his own mind whether what he just saw qualifies as an impossibility. Or he may be motivated by personal insecurities. The latter is the type of person who feels compelled to prove in every situation that he is smarter than everyone else.

If a spectator starts theorizing while the effect is still in progress, just turn off your hearing aid and continue with the performance. If the trick is well constructed, the very progress of the effect will disprove his theory by the time the trick ends.

In fact, often a theorizer will start to explain a trick before he even knows what the effect is going to be. I remember one case where I performed "Roll-Over Aces." As soon as I rolled off the four ace packets, a spectator started to explain to the others how I had located the aces. When, a moment later, I produced the four royal flushes, he looked pretty silly. This was the real effect and, of course, he hadn't seen it coming. Therefore, instead of engaging in a debate with the spectator, let the effect do the talking for you. If it's a good one, it will provide an irrefutable rebuttal to his half-baked theories.

Whenever I have a spectator offer an explanation of a trick *after* I've finished it, I base my reaction on whether he addresses the explanation to me or to other audience members. If a spectator addresses me and offers an obviously false explanation I will usually

point out briefly why his theory can't be correct.

If he says that the card that came out of my wallet is only a duplicate of the selected one, I may point out that the card was signed by a spectator. If he says that the deck must have been in a special order, I may point out that it was shuffled by a spectator. If he says that the cards must be marked, I may point out that I never saw the back of the selected card. However, I won't pursue the matter beyond one comment. If he is sincere, he'll realize that my point is valid. If he just wants an argument, he'll have to look elsewhere.

If, instead, the spectator offers his explanation of how the trick was done to the other spectators, I completely ignore the comment. I let the spectators deal with the matter. Usually one of them will point out why the explanation can't be correct.

If it isn't immediately obvious to the other spectators that this person's theory must be wrong it indicates a weakness in the construction of the trick. It's your job not only to disguise the correct solution, but to eliminate *any possibility* of a solution. If anyone can come up with a plausible explanation, even if it's incorrect, the trick has failed. Ormond McGill in *Psychic Magic* expressed it this way: "The effects you perform must be such that the understanding of the observers will be so put to naught that no possible explanation remains to be sought; *only wonder on which to conjecture.*"

Challenging

A common form of heckling is the challenge. A spectator says to you, "You palmed the card," or, "Those aren't really the aces," or, "Show us the top card of the deck." Ninety percent of the time, these challenges are completely unfounded. You don't have a card palmed, the cards really are the aces, and there is nothing special about the top card of the deck. In fact, anyone with an ounce of intelligence would have to realize that the challenge is groundless.

Therefore, your natural tendency will be to accept the challenge. You turn over your hand to show it empty, you turn over the four cards to show they really are the aces, or you show the challenger the top card of the deck.

My advice to you is: don't do it. You figure that when you show the spectator that his challenge was unjustified, it will score a point for you. But, once again, you're scoring the wrong game. This game is not about being right or wrong. It's about control. The heckler loves the fact that every time he says, "Jump," you jump. You're the puppet and he's pulling the strings. That's the way he likes it; so as long as his strategy keeps working, he'll keep doing it.

Every time you give in to a challenge, you encourage more challenges from this spectator. Keep playing his game and before long you'll realize that you're never going to be able to finish this performance. The troublemaker will just keep firing off more and more challenges. No sooner do you respond to one than he hits you with another. He won't be discouraged by the fact that you prove him wrong each time. On the contrary, he'll be *encouraged* by the fact that every time he issues a challenge, no matter how ridiculous, you have to stop dead in your tracks to deal with it.

The smart way to deal with a challenge is to ignore it. Once again, just turn off your hearing aid. You don't have to prove anything because, if your effects are properly structured, the audience will be convinced of what they have to be convinced of without your having to take any unplanned detours. When a spectator issues a challenge, just pretend not to hear it, and continue with the performance. If he is so loud, persistent, and obnoxious in repeating the challenge that you simply can't ignore it, just turn to him, smile, and say, "No." Then continue with your performance as you would normally do it.

Consider the alternative. The spectator throws out challenge after challenge. You respond to each one, always proving him wrong. This encourages him to be even more aggressive. Sooner or later, one of his bullets will find its mark. Just by chance, he'll issue a challenge you can't meet. You won't be able to show him the top card, or let him shuffle the deck, or whatever it may be. Since on every other occasion you catered to him, when you don't give in this time, the whole audience will realize that he has finally caught you with your pants down.

If instead you just turn a deaf ear to challenges, you'll find that the challenger will eventually quiet down. If it's a situation where he can conveniently leave the group, he may eventually wander away.

(And won't that break your heart!) Don't let someone else turn you into their plaything. *Always maintain control.*

Of course, everything I've said is based on the premise that the challenger's real motivation is to make trouble; you can tell that by the absurdity of his challenges. It may occasionally happen that you get a challenge from a spectator who is sincerely motivated by a reasonable suspicion. These cases will fall into two categories, those in which you can respond to the challenge and those where you can't because he is right.

If you've received a reasonable challenge (i.e., expression of suspicion) that you can't meet, this tells you there is something wrong with the construction of the effect. (In such cases, you'll probably notice that the same challenge comes up in performance after performance at the same point in the effect.) You had better alter the effect to ensure that you allay the suspicion before it's aroused. If that's impossible, you should drop the effect from your repertoire.

Earlier I told the story of a magician doing "The Trick that Fooled Houdini." The spectator asked him if she could see the top card of the deck. This was a perfectly reasonable question since the construction of the effect suggested that this card might be a duplicate. The performer should have eliminated the problem before it arose by having the spectator sign the "ambitious card" at the outset.

Suppose you get a reasonable challenge to which you *can* respond. They ask to see the faces of the four aces and you're in a position to show them. Then do so. At the same time, make a mental note that this experience has identified a weakness in the construction of the effect. An effect that arouses suspicions, even unfounded suspicions, is a poorly structured effect. Alter it so that the audience's suspicious questions are answered even before they can think to ask them. This accomplishes two things. First, it eliminates interruptions. Second, it allays the suspicions of those spectators who might be wondering if those cards really are the aces but are too polite to ask.

Grabbing

One of the most dangerous types of heckler is the grabber. This is someone who grabs your props as soon as you put them on the table.

When you're doing the “Cups and Balls” he will lift up a cup to look underneath. When you're doing an ace assembly he will turn over one of the “aces” as soon as you deal it face down.

There are two factors that particularly affect how likely you are to run into grabbers. The first is prestige. Since grabbing your props is fundamentally a sign of disrespect to you, it will happen most when you're working from a position of low prestige. One of the best things you can do to discourage grabbers is to employ the techniques I discussed in the Suggestion chapter to build your prestige as much and as fast as possible in every performance.

The second factor that bears on the likelihood of encountering grabbers is territoriality. If you put a prop down on what people perceive as your territory, they're much less likely to grab it. If you put it down on what they perceive as their territory, you may be in for trouble. Thus, for example, if you're performing in a hospitality suite at a table that's been set up especially for your performance you're much less likely to encounter grabbing than if you're table hopping and working on what the spectators view as *their* table.

Because of territoriality a simple way to protect a “hot” prop from being grabbed is to put it down close to you. The closer it is to you, the more clearly it's within *your* territory; therefore, the less likely it is that anyone will reach for it.

Another effective way to discourage grabbing is to use a close-up mat. The close-up mat very clearly defines the boundaries of your territory. People are much less likely to grab a prop that's on a close-up mat because it so clearly involves crossing into your territory. I'm not necessarily recommending you use a close-up mat. That choice depends on a number of factors, including your persona, your style, and your performing venue. But you should be aware that close-up mats do have the advantage of discouraging grabbing.

The one performing venue where grabbing is most common is restaurant magic. That should come as no surprise when you

remember the two factors of territoriality and prestige. In a restaurant, you're always performing on *their* table. Furthermore, the typical restaurant worker is starting from a position of very low prestige when he approaches a table. The audience tends to relate to him like a servant. (All the other people who approach their table during the meal are servants!)

For these reasons, when doing restaurant work, it's vital that you routine all your material in such a way that you never put anything down on the table or only do so in situations where you can completely control it (for example, in a trick where the spectator is instructed to immediately cover the tabled object with her hand).

Whatever steps you take to discourage grabbing, you'll still run into the problem from time to time. When you do, it's imperative that you put a stop to it immediately. If you don't, you'll only encourage the spectator to do more of it. Sooner or later, he'll do it in a situation where it exposes the trick.

Recently I did a TV show in Buenos Aires, Argentina. I was planning to have a card signed in one trick, so I had a marking pan on the table. Before I began performing, the host of the show absent-mindedly picked up the pen. I gently took it from her and replaced it on the table. A moment later she picked up the empty cardcase and started toying with it. I smiled and took it from her, putting it back on the table. These actions on her part did no harm since I hadn't yet started performing and since the items she picked up were of no importance. However, if I hadn't acted immediately to put a stop to her wandering hands, she might well have ruined one of my tricks later by picking up something I couldn't afford to have picked up.

The way to put a stop to grabbing is to immediately retrieve the item and politely ask the spectator not to touch your props. While you should be pleasant, you should also be firm. You have to get the audience to understand that the issue has nothing to do with the trick; you simply won't stand for it as a personal intrusion. If the grabbing continues, I strongly suggest you stop performing for that group then and there. There are few situations, either social or professional, where you have to keep performing. Any situation where the audience refuses to respect you is one where you should

refuse to perform.

The Challenge Attitude

I should point out that there are some theorizers, challengers, and grabbers whose motivations are different from the ones we've discussed so far. This relates to the challenge attitude I discussed early in the book. If you find that you're getting more than your share of such spectators, you should consider whether your style of presentation may be inadvertently encouraging people to look at your performances as a contest between you and them.

It's also true, however, that no matter what you do, some people will look at your performance as a personal challenge to their intelligence, their masculinity, or whatever. These people will sometimes explain that they hate to be fooled. I suspect that what they mean is they hate to lose.

These are the same people who can't stand losing at any game, no matter how trivial, even if it's only *Monopoly*. You know the type, people whose entire week can be ruined because they lost a tennis match on Saturday.

Furthermore, they tend to see every interpersonal situation as a game where there must be a winner and a loser. It's the only way they know of relating to the world. Magic, to them means that, if you fool them, they lose and you win. If they catch you, they win and you lose. Such people are hopeless, and only a masochist would attempt to entertain them. When you encounter such a person, remember your responsibility to entertain the rest of the audience. To do that you'll have to neutralize the troublemaker by using the techniques I've suggested.

Interrupting

From time to time you'll encounter spectators who continually interrupt your performance with jokes, comments, or questions. These people, in most cases, are not true hecklers. That is, they're not trying to wreck your performance. They're just overly gregarious, either by nature or as a result of alcohol. Nevertheless, they can damage your performance if they carry their garrulousness too far.

With experience you'll find that you can control just how much kibitzing you get from an audience by how you respond to it. Most of the time it's best to answer the spectator's question or to respond to his jocular comment with a funny—or at least pleasant—response. As I've already noted, such adlibbing can add greatly to the entertainment value of a performance by enhancing its sense of immediacy.

At the same time, you have to realize that you can't continually engage in conversation while you're trying to present a trick or the performance will suffer. If you start to feel that the interruptions are in danger of getting out of hand and derailing the performance, you have to change your tactics. Start limiting your reactions to each interruption to a simple smile or just ignore it completely.

When you respond to an interruption, you give the audience permission to interrupt again. Before long, they may start to think that this kibitzing is supposed to be the point of the performance and focus less and less on the magic. When you politely limit your reaction to interruptions, you let the audience know, without offending anyone, that they should be focusing more on what you're showing them.

Your goal here should be to let the audience feel relaxed enough to engage in spontaneous interplay without allowing anarchy to overwhelm your performance. Your tool in achieving the right balance is the degree to which you acknowledge interruptions.

Getting Nailed

There is one misconception that many magicians have that I'd like to correct at this point. People who point out that you flashed or who succeed in figuring out how you did a trick are not hecklers. If people see a palmed card in your hand, there is no reason on earth why they shouldn't point it out. If one of your tricks doesn't fool them, there is no reason why they should pretend it did.

They're not being troublemakers; you're inviting trouble by performing sloppily or doing a trick that lacks deceptiveness. These people are doing you a favor by pointing out your failings (although that may not be their motivation). Learn from their comments and

use them to improve.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO: THE UNEXPECTED

The big difference between rehearsing in private and performing in public is that things will happen in performance that you never anticipated in rehearsal. Your success as a performer will depend in part on how well you handle these unforeseen situations. This in turn will depend on how well you've prepared for them. That may sound like a contradiction. How can you prepare for something you can't foresee? Well, institutions like the U.S. military do it all the time.

Practice And Rehearsal

The military knows that one of the keys to handling the unforeseen is proper training. For the same reason, you have to train yourself properly. Sometimes you will have things go wrong technically in a performance. Sometimes you will have to vary your patter so as to adapt to an unexpected situation. Sometimes you will have to fashion, on the spur of the moment, a strategy for dealing with some problem created by a spectator.

You must have your technique so well perfected that you can perform it with no conscious thought so your mind can focus, if necessary, on altering your patter to deal with an unexpected situation. You must have your patter so thoroughly memorized that you can recite it with no conscious thought so your mind can focus, if necessary, on figuring out how to get yourself out of a technical jam. You must have both your technique and your patter so well rehearsed that you can perform both of them “on automatic pilot” if necessary while your mind races to figure out how to deal with a problematic spectator or some major unforeseen distraction.

The key to achieving that is practice and rehearsal. Writers like

Eugene Burger, T.A. Waters, and others have stressed the distinction between practice and rehearsal, but the point is worth covering again. Practice is what you do to master the sleight of hand. Rehearsal is what you do to master the performance.

Practice: Practice involves repeatedly executing a given sleight. This should be done both in front of a mirror to monitor the illusion created and without a mirror to avoid becoming dependent on mirror feedback.

I don't want to give you the impression that practice is merely a matter of mechanical repetition. Practice should also be both an analytical and a creative process. However, the repetition element is important. It's the aspect that's most relevant to what we're now discussing. It's the repeated drilling on a move that will allow you to perform that move when the time comes with no effort and virtually no thought.

In effect, this drilling is a conditioning process. It's analogous to the combat training a soldier undergoes to condition him to react properly, and without conscious thought, in the high-stress situation of battle. Performing, however enjoyable it may be, also places you under a certain amount of stress. By conditioning yourself to respond automatically when it comes time to do the move, you avoid needlessly adding to that stress.

Here is a technique I've found extremely helpful. If there is a patter line that I always deliver in a particular trick as I perform a particular move, I will recite that line every time I execute the move in practice. I don't worry about delivering the line with the right inflection and so on. I just concern myself with coordinating the line and the move, in other words, the timing. If I use the same move in two different tricks, I practice it half the time while reciting one patter line and the other half the time while reciting the other patter line.

At first you may feel self-conscious about doing this. There is no denying that, if anyone were listening, you would sound pretty silly parroting the same line over and over. So just do it when no one is listening. You'll find this technique will help the whole performance run smoothly. You'll also find it will help keep you from getting lost

in the middle of a trick. The patter will remind you what move comes next and each move will remind you what patter comes next.

Rehearsal: While practice involves repeatedly performing a small part of a trick, rehearsal involves performing the entire trick from beginning to end exactly the way you intend to perform it. In fact, if you have a set act, you should rehearse the entire act from beginning to end without stopping. You should perform every action you intend to do in performance. You should utter every word you plan to say in performance. You should handle every prop exactly as you would in performance.

If you intend to have a card signed during a trick, actually take out the pen and mime handing it to someone. Pause appropriately to give your “ghost spectator” enough time to sign. Be conscious of making eye contact with your imaginary audience. You should be no more self-conscious about doing all this than an actor would be while rehearsing in private.

You must rehearse until you've committed your patter to memory so thoroughly that you could recite it in your sleep. This doesn't mean that you should deliver your patter as if you're asleep. It does mean that if a crisis develops you can deliver your patter without concentrating on it for the few moments it takes you to decide on a plan of action.

You may think you're clever and witty enough to decide what to say during your performance. But how witty do you think you can be while your mind is racing to figure out a way to relocate the selected card after you just accidentally dropped the break. The best way to make sure you sound witty and clever at all times is to script your patter, then commit it to memory.

One misconception many magicians have is that they think practice and rehearsal are something you do until you've mastered the move or trick in question. Practice and rehearsal are ongoing things. You must practice and rehearse your material even after you've mastered it.

This is for two reasons. First, you'll be amazed at how much both moves and effects can continue to improve even after you thought you had mastered them, if you just keep working on them. Second,

even if you perform constantly, performance just isn't enough to keep you in shape on either moves or presentation. You can practice a move more times in a half-hour than you would probably perform it in a year, even if you perform a great deal. If you don't review the material regularly your skills will deteriorate.

Indeed, most of your practice and rehearsal time should be spent on the material you've already mastered and are already using. Working on new material is a secondary matter you should do only in whatever time you have left over after your primary practice.

Screw-Ups

Recently I was talking to a card cheat friend of mine. In the course of conversation he observed, "Show me a card cheat who claims he's never been caught and I'll show you someone who's never cheated." In the same sense, I would say, "Show me a magician who claims he's never screwed up a trick and I'll show you a magician who never performs."

No matter how much you prepare, you will make mistakes. You will mess up tricks. Since you know it's going to happen, it's best to decide in advance how to respond when it does.

A good deal has been written about the use of "outs" in magic. Much of this suggests that a good magician should always be able to bring a trick to a successful conclusion, no matter what. I can't agree. If you're thoroughly familiar with your material, you will sometimes be able to save an effect even if something goes wrong. If you can, by all means do so. However, sometimes you just have to abandon a trick. There is nothing more embarrassing for an audience than to watch a magician desperately moving from one makeshift to another in a hopeless effort to save a trick that has gone bad beyond all hope. You've got to know when to bail out. If a trick can't be saved, apologize briefly to the audience, then move on to the next trick

When a trick goes bad, you're going to feel terrible. Your natural tendency is to want to dump some of that bad feeling on the audience. You'll want to go on and on about how sorry you are. You'll want to tell them you don't understand how this could have

happened. You'll want to explain to them that nothing like this has ever happened before. You'll want to give them a list of reasons why it's not your fault; it's just that it's humid, the deck is old, and you're going through a rough divorce.

You'll want to do all those things to make yourself feel better. *But your job is not to make yourself feel better; it's to make the audience feel better.* Telling them all these things only makes them feel worse. First of all, they don't care that it never happened before or that it's not your fault the magic dealer sold you a defective folding coin. They came to the show to forget their problems, not to hear about yours. Second of all, your behavior will embarrass them. People feel uncomfortable watching someone else in pain, particularly if that person wallows in his misfortune.

When something goes wrong in a performance, your job is to make the audience forget it as quickly as possible. Whining and self-indulgently dwelling on the matter will only impress the screw-up more strongly on their memory. If, instead, you treat the matter as of little importance, they will too.

Smile (even if you're dying inside) and brush the whole thing off with a comment such as, "Sorry folks, that didn't work out the way I planned. Let me show you something else. This next one is a better trick anyway." Now move on to your next trick and don't look back. Don't make another reference to the mistake for the rest of the performance. Remember, in this matter as in most others, the audience takes its cue as to how to behave and what to think from you.

What do you do if you screw up the last trick of the act? You don't have another trick to move on to. Come up with one real fast. It's a good idea to always have a trick in the back of your mind that you will use as an emergency backup if you should screw up your closer. The last thing you do in the performance is what the audience will remember best. For that reason, *you must never end on a screw-up.*

What if you screw up your closer and then screw up your emergency backup closer also? In that case, reread the subchapter on Practice and Rehearsal.

Debriefing

We've already discussed debriefing to analyze audience reaction as a way of developing commercial sense. However, your debriefing at the end of each performance should also serve another purpose. You should use it to review any errors, problems, or unexpected difficulties of any kind that arose during the performance, whether due to a mistake on your part, the behavior of a spectator, or just an unlucky break.

Whenever you note such an occurrence you must do one of two things. You may reroutine the effect to ensure that it never happens again. For example, if a spectator gave you a hard time about replacing a selected card where you told him to, you may decide to have the card peeked at from now on instead of having it removed from the deck. That way, all the cards stay under your control at all times. Alternatively, you may decide on a plan of action to follow the next time the situation arises that will prevent it from creating a problem. Either way, you must do something to ensure that whatever gave you a problem this time doesn't give you a problem in the future. As Chuck Berry once said, "Don't let the same dog bite you twice."

This brings me to one of Darwin's laws: when it comes to live performance, *if it happened before, it'll happen again*. No matter how freakish or unlikely an event that gave you a problem in a performance may be, sooner or later it will occur again if you don't take steps to ensure it doesn't. That fact leads to another of Darwin's laws: *leave nothing to chance*.

Unforeseen Distractions

In the chapter on attention control we discussed the importance of eliminating distractions. Not all distractions, however, are under your control. A door at the back of the room may suddenly slam. A group at the next table may start laughing raucously. A spectator may knock over his drink.

In such situations you must use your own attention as your primary means of controlling the audience's attention. If the distraction is one that can be ignored, ignore it. Remember, they look where you

look; they consider important what you consider important. *For you to pay attention to a distraction is to give the audience permission to pay attention to it.*

If a distraction is so disruptive that you can't ignore it, acknowledge it in a minimal way, then return to the thread of your effect. What you cannot allow is for you yourself to get distracted. There is all the difference in the world between acknowledging a major distraction with, for example, a humorous comment and allowing yourself to get rattled to the point where you have trouble getting back on track.

This is where preparation tells. When both your technique and your patter are totally mastered, very little can happen to shake you. Your mind is free to deal with any unforeseen disruption so you can bring the audience back to what you're showing them. The important thing is that you must always remain in control.

APPENDIX ONE: DARWIN'S LAWS

For purposes of quick review, meditation, or whatever, I've decided to distill some of the most important points I've made in this book into a series of “laws”:

1. The effect happens in the spectators' minds.
2. “There is no place for challenge in professional magic.” (Fred Kaps)
3. Method matters only in regard to how it affects the effect.
4. Make it easier for the audience to remember what you want them to remember than it would be to forget it.
5. Audiences are easily confused, but not easily fooled.
6. The better you are, the closer they watch.
7. If you're going to change an apple into an orange, minimize the time between their last glimpse of the apple and their first glimpse of the orange.
8. The audience should never be made to work.
9. Your job is to make things as easy as possible for the audience, not to make things as easy as possible for yourself.
10. Make the expository phase as convincing as possible.
11. How impressive a condition is depends on your audience's perceptions, not on the reality of the situation.
12. See the effect from the audience's point of view.
13. Audiences have contrary intelligence. They're dumb when you

want them to be smart (like when you want them to pick up on some subtlety) and smart when you want them to be dumb (like when you want them to overlook some discrepancy).

14. When telling a story, if possible, personalize it; make yourself the hero.

15. Darwin's Suspense Formula: make them care, then make them wait.

16. People tend to see what they expect to see.

17. People tend to experience what they want to experience.

18. "What we wish, that we readily believe." (Demosthenes)

19. Every single word you say to a spectator or within the hearing of a spectator before, during, or after the performance constitutes patter.

20. The presentation exists for the effect, not the other way around.

21. Method should conform to the demands of the effect, not the other way around.

22. The fact that you like a trick is not enough reason to perform it.

23. The fact that a trick fooled you is not enough reason to perform it.

24. The similarities among different kinds of audiences for outweigh the differences.

25. It's more important for people to hear you than to see you.

26. Tilt the cards down so people can see.

27. Any given effect can only support so much presentation and no more.

28. Anything that can act as misdirection at the right moment can act as a distraction at the wrong moment.

29. Resolve all doubts before the climax.

30. Always say the same thing at the same point in each trick.

31. The key to spontaneous wit is an unburdened mind.
32. When you respond to an interruption, you give the audience permission to interrupt again.
33. If it happened before, it'll happen again.
34. Never end on a screw-up.
35. Leave nothing to chance.
36. Always remain in control.

APPENDIX TWO: GLOSSARY

When I began writing this book, I quickly realized that most of the topics covered are so little discussed in magic that there wasn't even an adequate vocabulary with which to talk about them. I found I had to coin numerous terms. I've decided to include a glossary of the most important of these terms (along with a few coined by others) in the hope that it may be a start toward developing a language with which issues of magical presentation can be argued, debated, and discussed.

accidental convincer: A minor action, apparently performed unintentionally, that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that all is as it should be.

adlib list: A list of patter lines for use in situations that are unplanned but not unforeseen.

anti-climax: Any dramatic climax that is preceded by a more powerful climax.

anti-contrasting parenthesis: Any element in a presentation that distracts the audience from some feature of the effect that is central to its success, (coined by Arturo de Ascanio)

artificial progression: A sense of progression created through some theatrical device extrinsic to the effect.

audience testing: Performing material before an audience in order to determine the response—the magician's version of the psychological concept of reality testing.

the bizarre explanation formula: A presentational structure in which you offer a magical explanation to a common problem.

the bizarre solution formula: A presentational structure in which you offer a magical solution to a common problem.

character: The audience's perception of who the performer is; the same as persona.

character line: A line of patter that provides the audience with an insight into the personality of the performer.

character material lists: Listings of all the material (patter lines, props, themes, etc.) that you use, or hope someday to use, to convey your persona to the audience.

character profile: A listing of all character traits and personal history relevant to the persona you wish to convey to the audience.

commercial sense: An instinct, developed through experience, for predicting how well an effect will play for lay audiences.

condition: Any restriction under which the magic is performed that seems to preclude the possibility of trickery.

consensus reality: The untested myths shared by the magic community at large as to what is effective with lay audiences.

conservation: Deliberately withholding part of an effect's strength in the early phases so as to reveal it in the later phases and thus achieve progression.

convenience-driven effect: An effect that is primarily structured to require as little skill as possible rather than to have the strongest impact possible.

convincer: Any minor action that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that all is as it should be.

conviction: The degree of belief on the audience's part that all is as it should be.

conflict-uncertainty suspense: The kind of suspense that arises from doubt as to the outcome of some battle.

dead time: Any period during a performance where nothing of interest to the audience is happening.

debriefing: Mentally reviewing a performance in search of new insights and to identify areas that need improvement.

deteriorating conviction: The process whereby the very progress of an effect causes an audience to question the conclusions it formed during the expository phase.

directional misdirection: Causing an audience to turn its attention elsewhere as you perform a secret action.

emotional belief: A “gut-level” conviction, which may be strong and may move a person even when it contradicts his intellectual beliefs.

emotional memory: The “gut-level” impact of having seen something, which fades much faster than intellectual memory.

expectation failure: Any audience reaction that was different from what you anticipated.

expository phase: The part of the effect in which the performer establishes the situation prior to the magic.

Fitzkee's fallacy: The belief that magic has no inherent entertainment value and can therefore only be made entertaining by incorporating other entertainment arts such as comedy or music.

foreshadow: To prepare the audience for events that will happen later in the effect, often in ways that will not be fully understood by the audience until the effect is over. [to paraphrase Rust Hills]

incidental convincer: A minor action, apparently a byproduct of some more important action, that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that all is as it should be.

incidental magic: A minor magic effect performed casually in the course of performing the major effect.

induced response: The principle of manipulating a spectator into doing something while making him think it was his own idea.

intensity misdirection: Causing an audience to relax its attention as you perform a secret action.

interest curve: The continually changing level of audience interest

in a performance.

invasive magic: Magic that happens on the spectator's person.

inversion: An effect ending involving a role reversal of the props.

inverted question: A question which the performer poses to himself and then answers by means of an effect.

kicker ending: An effect ending that occurs after the one the audience was led to expect.

lead-in effect: A quick, simple effect used to introduce a longer, more elaborate effect.

the magical phase: The part of the effect in which the impossible occurs.

method-driven effect: An effect that is primarily structured to fit the methodology employed rather than to have the strongest impact possible.

meaning: Additional importance imparted to an effect by its presentation.

the must-believe test: The process of determining what false (or true) premises the audience must be totally convinced of in order for the effect to register as a miracle.

mystery-curiosity suspense: The kind of suspense that arises from wondering how or why something is happening or has happened.

the no-contact condition: In any effect where an object travels from point A to point B, ensuring that point A and point B never touch and nothing is openly transferred from point A to point B.

the occult formula: A presentational structure in which you introduce a prop, tell a supernatural story about the prop, then produce some magical phenomenon with the prop that seems to validate the story.

pacing: The audience's perception of the speed of the performance—their subjective perception of the passage of time during the performance.

peripheral awareness: When performing for large audiences, a continual awareness of the need to maintain contact with those spectators along the outer fringes of the audience.

persona: The audience's perception of who the performer is; the same as character.

picturization: The practice of arranging your props on the working surface in such a way as to convey the content of the effect.

plot-driven effect: An effect where the methodology is fashioned to meet the demands of the plot rather than the other way around.

pre-climactic stall: Any pause or delay just before the climax of an effect in order to build suspense.

prepared adlib: An apparently improvised response to an unplanned event that was actually prepared in anticipation of such an eventuality.

progression: The sense that each subsequent effect or phase is more interesting, impressive, or important than what preceded it.

recurring situation: An unplanned event that occurs with some frequency at a particular point in a performance and can, therefore, be anticipated and prepared for.

reverse one-eighty: An effect ending in which at the last moment the action of the effect makes a complete reversal.

the second-shoe technique: In a multiple-phase effect of transition or transposition, to perform all phases of the first part of the effect before revealing the second part.

sequencing: The order in which the magical events in an effect are revealed to the audience.

simulation move: A sleight-of-hand technique that mimics some completely different action (as opposed to one in which you apparently do nothing at all).

situational meaning: Additional importance imparted to an effect by the human context in which it occurs.

staggered movement: The action of coordinating a misdirective move and a secret move so that the first begins just before the second in order to catch the eye.

style: “The way something is said or done as distinguished from its substance.” [Webster's Dictionary]

substantive meaning: Additional importance imparted to an effect by the subject with which it deals.

subtext: Any implicit or unconscious message conveyed by an effect or presentation.

tempo: The speed at which you perform.

tension-anticipation suspense: The kind of suspense that arises from a desire to experience an expected result.

the theatrical fallacy: The belief that a magic effect should exist to validate a dramatic presentation rather than the presentation existing to enhance the effect.

thematic discrepancy: Any element of an effect that contradicts the presentational premise.

timing: The time relationship between two things, either words or actions, in a performance.

tone: The performer's attitude (serious, whimsical, tongue-in-cheek, ironic, etc.) toward the material he is performing.

twist ending: An effect ending that is different from the one the audience was led to expect.

undersell: To treat a magical climax as insignificant in order to indirectly underscore it.

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